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PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

Learning & Leisure at a "Blue Collar Hilton": ILGWU's Unity House, 1919–1990

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Abstract

In histories of travel and free time, emphasis is often lavished on wealthy travelers taking leave from their work and their homes to rejuvenate in exotic locales. In parallel, however, labor unions provided access to vacation time to their working-class members throughout the twentieth century. The International Ladies' Garment Workers Union (ILGWU), for example, operated a retreat known as Unity House in the Poconos region of Pennsylvania for most of the twentieth century—a key site for the union's educational ambitions as well as a restful retreat for workers and their families. A Victorian mansion sat at the center of the complex in the early years, but it burned in 1930 and was replaced by a campus of buildings designed by modernist William Lescaze in the mid-1930s. A recreation center was later added by architect Louis Kahn in the late 1940s, followed by a dormitory and other structures by the lesser-known Pennsylvania firm Rinker and Kiefer. Lescaze's main building (with its murals by Diego Rivera) burned in 1969 as the ILGWU's ambitions—and its members travel opportunities—had evolved, and an administrative building was added to the complex designed by Prentice & Chan, Ohlhausen—a late modern building of geometric form and large expanses of reflective glass. Tracing the evolution of architectures and landscapes at Unity House can reveal the evolving spatial needs and organizing priorities of the ILGWU as it grew to one of the largest labor unions in the United States with a membership of nearly half a million around mid-century, with roughly 75% of those members being women. Part of an ongoing research project into architecture and organized labor, this paper draws upon the archives of the ILGWU and its various architects to reveal the imbrication of space and solidarity in buildings by and for labor unions.

PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

A Dexterous Regime: Training the Hand between Workshop and Classroom

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Abstract

In the early twentieth century, the Ottoman Empire occupied a precarious position—internally anxious about its waning power vis-a-vis Europe, and externally driven by colonial ambitions for politico-economic expansion. To navigate these tensions, the Ottoman elite reconceptualized crafts as "useful" arts. Positioning crafts training at the heart of an imperial power struggle served multiple purposes: asserting an aesthetic heritage as a proxy to the Western Fine Arts tradition, responding to European market competition, and instilling diligence in the modern Ottoman subject. At the nexus of authenticity, utility, and social management, this paper examines the emergence of a dextrous regime, a moral and pedagogical order that elevated manual skill as a foundation of modern subject formation and a strategic conduit for recuperating the imperial economy.

To integrate production into schooling, Ottoman elites sought to organize labor through handicrafts education. Informal pedagogies of craft that had developed in manufacturing sites such as the Hereke Textile Factory were unevenly incorporated into girls' schools via carpet weaving programs. These localized practices were later sidelined in early twentieth-century pedagogical initiatives that systematized handicrafts education, most notably at the Teachers' Training School. Here, children were no longer conceived as immediate producers within the labor force but as future makers whose cognitive and manual capacities were to be cultivated. Drawing on contemporaneous discourse, instruments of design, and academic curricula, this paper examines late Ottoman institutions from the 1890s to the 1920s to analyze how handicrafts education constituted children as inherently productive bodies. As dexterity came to be valued less for its immediate economic yield and more as a creative capacity oriented toward future productivity, the tension between workshop and classroom was not resolved but redefined.

PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

From Foundations to the Roof: Black Building Labor in 1830s Havana

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Abstract

As the Havana suburb of El Cerro developed in the first decades of the nineteenth century, mansions with grand neoclassical porticos dotted the main road, which led through the town and to the sugar plantations of western Cuba. Like a microcosm of the Caribbean capital, the neighborhood combined spaces of leisure for wealthy planters and government officials with those of confinement and forced labor for the island's enslaved population. In fact, the stately mansions of El Cerro flanked the Depósito de Cimarrones (Deposit of Runaway Slaves), an institution run by Havana's Royal Consulate, which sought to promote economic improvement and urban beautification. This paper examines the nature of enslaved and forced labor used for both public works projects and private residential architecture through a microhistory of El Cerro.

In 1831, one of the neighborhood's original residents, don Francisco Betancourt—also the administrator of the Depósito de Cimarrones—was investigated for corruption. The ensuing trial and reams of sworn testimony offer rare windows into the textures of life and labor among superintendents, overseers, craftsmen, and enslaved laborers and craftsmen, with often blurring boundaries between their roles. These men labored on roads, bridges, quarries, and the opulent masonry homes that undergirded Cuba's expanding plantation system and facilitated Havana's elite social and political life. The story that emerges reveals how skilled building labor was deeply embedded in slave society, as the wealthy and powerful exploited the expertise of enslaved Africans and free people of color across a range of statuses for both public works and private gain. In tracing these connections, the mostly unexamined spaces of labor necessary to produce El Cerro—and, by extension, Havana—come into focus.

PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

Unfree Labor and the Colonial Invention of the "Javanese Village": The Case of Priangan's Family-Run Tea Plantations

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Abstract

Priangan's tea plantations were run successfully by some Dutch family enterprises (Van der Hucht c.s.) between the 1840s and 1940s. They were granted the land lease (*erpfacht*) of both unsuccessful plantations under the forced cultivation (*cultuurstelsel*) which had turned into "waste land" and forestland to refigure into their "plantation establishments". After the politico-economical liberalization of Netherland's Indies in 1870s, tea export from Java boomed and increased by 16-fold between 1883 and 1909. Underpinning that growth, tea laborers were recruited to perform various duties, such as tea harvesting, manufacturing work, carpentry for tea chest, delivery, and others – based on gender, age and lineal prestige difference. Since Priangan consisted largely of an isolated mountainous region, ensuring sustainable labor provision for the unattractive "frontier" necessitated various schemes of unfree labor arrangements, ranging from coolie contract, serfdom to penal forced labor, often brokered by village brokers and native officials (*inlands bestuur*). This study aims to contribute to the vast literature of labor and frontier history of Priangan and Java by offering a spatial and architectural historical perspective. Tapping from various historical photos, architectural plans, ego-documents of the said planters, and agricultural publications on tea (1840s–1940s), it strives to analyse the documented labor-related building typologies, ranging from simple shed, houses, mosque, to World's Fair's pavilions – some of which still stand until today. Micro-historical work on the planter's ego-documents is conducted to trace the material flow and discursive exchange which brought about the complete refiguration of a "Javanese" village (*desa* or *kampoeng*) as a material-cultural product of the global tea frontier's expansion. What is today familiar as the "traditional village" is, in fact, a colonial invention – deeply entangled with the spatial logics, techniques, and aesthetic exoticism rooted in colonialism.

PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

Labor, care, and architecture: The International Ladies Garment Workers Union Health Centers

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Abstract

In 1914, the International Ladies Garment Workers Union (ILGWU) established the Union Health Center in two rooms at 31 Union Square in New York City, furnished with several chairs and a used examination table covered with dish cloths. In its first iteration, a small team of 7 medical professionals examined workers for tuberculosis, 'the garment worker's disease.' In 1935, the ILGWU relocated the first Union Health Center to several floors of the Lefcourt Clothing Center, a 26-story Art Deco brick building at 275 Seventh Avenue designed by commercial architects Buchman and Kahn. By 1965, the ILGWU had 13 health centers in purpose-built or adapted facilities and six Mobile Health Centers that travelled to areas beyond their scope. Local divisions of the ILGWU established a network of Union Health Centers in the United States, Puerto Rico, and Canada that provided preventative ambulatory and primary care to garment workers and their families.

This abstract proposes to explore the everyday life of the ILGWU medical spaces and their material dimensions through episodic narratives of women who worked within this international network of welfare, encompassing agents of varying classes and backgrounds. Beginning in 1918, labor activist Pauline Newman directed the Union Health Center educational program, forming health education and outreach programs while working with medical professionals and public health experts. Women nurses, pictured in a 1940s triennial report, staffed the New York Center and cared for patients. The same brochure reports that women patients were less likely to access the clinic than men.

In a structure providing an early model of socialized medicine motivated by social unionism, how did the women of the ILGWU Health Centers - as leaders, volunteers, patients, and laborers - assert architectural agency?

PS01 Open Session: The Spaces of Labor(ers)

Session Chair: Juan Heredia, Portland State University, USA

Unweaving Andean Fabrics: Obrajes, struggle and memory in Otavalo

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Abstract

Museo Viviente Otavalango (Otavalo, Ecuador) has functioned since 2011 in the abandoned San Pedro textile factory, formerly an *obraje*. Obrajes –infrastructure for forced labor in textile manufacture– were established during the Spanish colony in America. Due to their weaving craftsmanship, communities like Otavalo in the Ecuadorian Andes were condemned to exploitation in obrajes since the sixteenth century. This paper will show how and why the Otavalango community cares about the material evidence and the place of a longue durée history of oppression. Otavalango community –members of the Kichwa-Otavalo nation– preserves an early nineteenth-century obraje to account for a history of modernization entangled with abuses that extended until the 1980s.

This paper will explore the history of anticolonial struggle of obraje labor, first recorded in the eighteenth century in Otavalo, and echoed in the San Pedro factory work union in the 1970s–the precursor of the Otavalango community. They fought against exploitation in a context of regional Indigenous demands for, and contestation against, rural development. Locally rejected projects, like the "Andean Indian programme" (by the United Nations and the International Labour Organization) that included attempts to industrialize handicraft textiles, dwelt in the paradoxes of mechanization encountering artisanal work: folklore became a developmental motif fueled by centuries of exploitation.

The dialectical counterpart of folkloric weaving –the historical trademark of Otavalo– materialized in the massive, obscure sheds that used to hold people incarcerated to weave. These spaces have been reclaimed with Indigenous rituals, oral accounts, and weaving objects from the Otavalango community. Following Silvia Rivera Cusicanqui's interpretation of the Aymara notion of history, this paper argues that the past of the Otavalango community has been brought to the fore as a guide to the present: identities forged in the abuse of their craftsmanship enact emancipatory potentials by preserving the material means of subjugation.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Accumulations of Coal Mining Waste: Slow Sacrifice and Imminent Danger

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Abstract

Coal transformed the British economy and everyday lives but what is less known are the spatial, social and environmental consequences of the abundant waste material that the coal mining industry left behind.Between 1913 and 1983, more than 14 billion metric tons of coal were extracted in Britain. Simultaneously, the mining industry generated more than 6.5 billion tons of waste. The ways in which this waste was handled and disposed of ties in with major urban developments in peculiar ways, revealing significant effects of this abundant resource on both the rural and urban geography of twentieth-century Britain.

This paper links waste deposition activities to the urban developments that they facilitated: from enormous waste tips at the heart of mining towns, to the New Towns and motorways constructed with foundations of colliery waste. In well-resourced council areas, waste deposits were reclaimed into expansive public parks, designed by the most renowned landscape architects of the 1950s and 60s.

However, despite its significant spatial reach and enduring physical presence, coal mining waste easily slips out of view for urban and architectural historians. One of the reasons for that is that before 1969, coal waste deposits were exempt from planning law, which means that there has never been a comprehensive record of them.

The environments shaped over time as a result of these various processes are here examined through the lens of what Ryan Juskus calls ‘slow sacrifice’ (2023, 3). It examines how material and cultural accumulations, formed over many decades, created a situation where fierce aversion to industrial dereliction was often met with strong emotional attachments to the material reality of coalfield areas. The paper also presents methods for using historic aerial photographs to research this waste stream and resource over time, drawing on the extensive archives of the National Collection of Aerial Photography.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Hollow Stones: A Carbon Counter-Genealogy

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Abstract

In response to the challenge that fossil fuels are "hidden in plain sight," this paper reassesses a canonical site of postwar modern architecture. Louis I. Kahn's Yale University Art Gallery (1953) has been hailed as the watershed project in Kahn's career, celebrated as the first modernist building at Yale, and cited as a crucial turning point in American post-WWII architecture. Reframing this project around questions of fossil fuels, this paper offers a different interpretation and genealogy. The tetrahedral braced beam ceiling developed for the gallery, which Kahn poetically named "hollow stone," crucially mediated the appearance and function of the ductwork for the new air conditioning system at the gallery. Such an interpretation asks that we reconceptualize the ceiling, taking its geometry not as a point of origin but as a mediating framework for an older and less visible history of fossil-fueled infrastructures. The YUAG ceiling was the last of three sets of environmental systems in Yale's galleries, the earliest of which were Street Hall's Egyptian revival steam radiators (the first at the university) installed in the 1870s. Second, the ductwork threaded through the tetrahedral ceiling was itself an outlet for energy and humidity generated at the university's district steam plant, physically mediating a fossil-fueled energy infrastructure initially developed for Yale's historicist colleges. Finally, the ceiling's "hard exposed structure" and "forceful geometry" mediated a far less tangible substance: the emerging principles that sought to standardize museum air in the post-WWII period. Kahn's ceiling was a crucial implement for an emerging regime that understood consistent temperature and humidity as the essential medium for the conservation of art works. These three historically layered mediations point to a different turning point: the emergence of systems for environmental control that currently make up the largest component of the museum's carbon footprint.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Material Norms, Energy Forms: Mapping Construction After 1948

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Abstract

In the decades following World War II, housing construction surged, driven by the tail end of fossil fuel availability. Cheap oil supported industrial expansion and mass housing agendas, making the energy-hungry materials of cement, steel, and glass central to development. In Israel, these forces converged with Zionist goals of territorial consolidation. Even before statehood, Zionist institutions had mobilized construction for population dispersion while relying on the British supply of energy resources through their Haifa Oil Refinery and regional oil networks. But following the 1948 War, construction ambitions quickly outpaced inherited energy capacities.

The young Israeli state faced the dual pressures of absorbing immigrants and meeting urgent housing demands, alongside constrained access to imported fuel and foreign currency. As construction demand accelerated, state policy turned to centralized institutions to stabilize material and energy flows. Within this framework, Solel Boneh, a construction firm established in 1924, became a key vehicle in this effort through its industrial arm, Koor. After 1948, Koor quickly expanded, primarily through the acquisition of privately owned enterprises, to become a construction conglomerate comprising quarries, cement and steel plants, oil exploration, and transport infrastructure. However, the underlying fossil fuel infrastructure that facilitated this growth remained obscure and seemingly unnoticeable compared to the widely publicized construction activities, despite the need to constantly expand energy availability to support state-scale construction.

Using Israel/Palestine as a case study, this project reconstructs postwar geographies of material production through multiscalar spatial analysis and mapping of corporate dependencies. It proposes a framework for understanding how energy-intensive construction consolidated territorial control while embedding fossil fuel reliance into building norms. By mapping how fuel and energy availability became embedded in this intricate network of construction infrastructure, the project also aims to develop a visual language for exposing the often hidden interdependence between construction and fuel economies.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Petrochemical Complexes: The Naturalization of Multi-Building Megadevelopments in the Saudi Building Boom of the 1970s

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Abstract

The aftermath of the 1973 OAPEC oil export embargo saw the government of Saudi Arabia reap unprecedented oil revenues which were subsequently channeled into three five-year construction and development plans. Under these plans, a series of massive multi-building projects were commissioned for academic campuses and other institutional programs, often with US architects at the helm. This paper focuses on the typology of these projects, multi-building "complexes." Treated as expandable and refinable but neatly packaged alchemical agglomerations composed of interrelated systems rather than as static objects, such “complexes” were significantly informed in their design by knowledge, practices, and organizational strategies drawn, operating as a vector for a translation of concerns with continuous processes into architectural design and design practice. Central to this history is the Houston-based architecture firm Caudill, Rowlett, Scott whose growth alongside the oil industry in Texas and Saudi Arabia from a small domestic operation designing secondary schools to an international concern leading the push for “complex” projects the world over also helped spur the company’s exploration of computer-based drafting. Tracing the impact of projects such as the College of Petroleum and Minerals in Dhahran and follow-on commissions on office practices, the paper further explores how the “complex” typology was used to create footholds for a subsequent translation of approaches from the oil industry into architecture practice in the "re-engineering" of design and operations. Re-engineering, in turn, is explored as it helped underwrite a second generation of multi-building complexes built in Europe and the United States, often with funding from Middle Eastern petrostates. Building out a world of practice from the “complex” typology, the paper reveals the role of petrochemical extraction and refinement in shaping a specific yet formative moment of late twentieth century architectural practice, not just through finance or material, but in form and organization.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Ahmedabad's Tarpaulin, a Construction Material of the Capitalocene

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Abstract

Fossil fuels are not only energy sources but also the constitutive ingredients of construction materials such as synthetic textiles, plastics, and composites. This paper critically investigates polyethylene tarpaulins, an omnipresent yet overlooked material that permeates the urban landscape of India. Manufactured from crude oil-derived polymers, the characteristic blue, orange, and yellow 'tarps' have steadily replaced organic thatch, jute, bamboo, and cotton canvas as key building materials for market stalls or temporary shelters since the 1970s, often built for and by marginalised and migratory communities.

Inspired by multimedia artist Marie Julia Bollansée's Tarpaulin Blue series (https://www.mariejuliabollansee.be/) and taking cues from recent interest in 'Construction Ecologies' (Moe), 'Reciprocal Landscapes' (Hutton), and Production Studies (Ferro), this paper centres the histories of labour, architectural precarity and social complexity associated with the production and architectural consumption of tarps.

Collaborative ethnographic fi eldwork conducted with the artist in the city of Ahmedabad, a hub for tarp production in India, entailed photographic and videographic documentation as well as oral histories and documentation through drawings. It allowed tracing the material and its associated human and ecological conditions from the factories to its construction labour camps and food markets, and resulted in Marie Julia Bollansée's Art fi lm "Tarpaulin blue people". Archival work, on the other hand, sheds light on the genealogy of the tarpaulin; its transformation from tarred cotton to polyethylene and the role of global concerns such as the Imperial Chemical Industries, Reliance and Sabic in this historical process.

Such a methodological approach allows for an expanded historiography, which casts the exploitation of 'cheap nature' and 'cheap labour' associated with architectural fossil fuel products in the Global South as a structural feature of the Capitalocene.

PS02 Mediating Fossil Fuels in Architectural History

Session Co-Chairs: Alex Bremner, University of Edinburgh, Scotland, and Jiat-Hwee Chang, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Boundary Objects: The London Coal Tax and its Limits

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Abstract

London became the planet's first fossil-fueled metropolis beginning in the early seventeenth century. From that time forward, coal transformed the city's environment: its hearths and factories, its polluted atmosphere, and its expanding fabric of bricks, mortar, glass, and iron were all linked to coal's surplus energy. In parallel to those pervasive consequences, however, appeared a stranger and indirect imbrication of coal and the metropolis: the City coal tax.

The Corporation of the City of London maintained an immemorial right to tax all commodities entering its jurisdiction, including coal. Following the Great Fire in 1666, the coal tax was increased to fund reconstruction—centrally, the resurrection of St. Paul's Cathedral. Over the next two centuries, this tax changed form and justification, but it was repeatedly renewed and helped fund buildings and public works: from the construction of bridges, to the renovation of streets, to the renovation of public institutions like Newgate Prison and the Royal Exchange. In short, this tax on fossil fuels generated not just revenue, but architecture.

Is it possible to narrate an architectural history of a tax? And was there any significance or meaning in this intersection of coal, regulation, and architecture? This paper will consider these questions by focusing on a nineteenth-century breaking point in this drawn-out history. Where coal shipments had long been regulated in the Port of London, the appearance of canals and railways began upending this spatial and commercial bottleneck. From the 1830s, the City erected "coal tax posts" at new entry points, little monuments to its increasingly tenuous attempts to regulate the coal trade. With the London coal tax, some remainder of the city's reliance on coal had been captured and siphoned off into more durable forms, but that control began to seem obsolete as the coal-fired metropolis continued burgeoning in all directions.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

Reforming Bodies, Reforming Space: The Haus der Frau (1914)

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Abstract

In 1914, Margarete Knüppelholz-Roeser's Haus der Frau (House of Woman) opened on the plaza of the Deutscher Werkbund Exhibition in Cologne, surrounded by buildings designed by leading male architects of the modern movement. This pavilion, which showcased women's contributions to design, craft, and the applied arts, marked a turning point for women's visibility and agency in architecture—not merely as a venue of inclusion, but as a spatial and ideological intervention into the democratic potentials of architectural representation.

Rather than reassert gendered stereotypes through ornate or sentimental design, the Haus der Frau embodied the ethical and aesthetic values of the Werkbund: rational planning, restraint in ornament, and material clarity. Its sober façade and clear structural expression resonated with contemporaneous dress reform movements led by figures like Else Oppler-Legband and Anna Muthesius, who sought to liberate women's bodies from restrictive fashion. These parallel reforms—of clothing and architecture—reveal a shared agenda: the democratization of form, function, and authorship.

This paper reconsiders the Haus der Frau not as a marginal or segregated space but as a deliberate act of architectural redefinition. By focusing on authorship, rather than gendered subject matter, the pavilion advanced a democratic model of exhibition in which design intellect—rather than identity—was foregrounded. At a time when women were largely excluded from architectural institutions and commissions, this building intervened in public space to assert women's professional and cultural agency. Situating Knüppelholz-Roeser's design within broader discourses of access, visibility, and reform, the paper argues for a more nuanced understanding of how architecture can challenge structural exclusions and articulate democratic values through form, authorship, and spatial practice.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

Geographies of Resistance: Ephemeral Democracy in Tehran's Public Spaces

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Abstract

This paper investigates how Tehran's public spaces—such as Daneshjoo Park and other informal queer gathering sites—operate as terrains of ephemeral democracy for queer individuals in Iran, particularly for gay men and gender-nonconforming people whose voices are systematically silenced in dominant political, cultural, and architectural discourses. In a context where heteronormative, authoritarian structures criminalize and erase non-normative identities, these spaces become rare outlets for presence, connection, and resistance. Among them, Daneshjoo Park stands out as a heterotopic anchor. Once home to a statue commemorating ideals of freedom and civic engagement, the park symbolized a modest vision of democratic space. The unexplained removal of the statue in recent years reveals the fragility of such symbolism under state surveillance and control. Yet for many, that statue once served as more than a monument—it was a spatial and social axis. Queer individuals would often initiate conversations around it, using it as a coded meeting point and as a discreet way to explore identity and belonging. Architecture and public space are often celebrated as manifestations of democratic values such as access, participation, and visibility. This paper challenges such framings by centering those who cannot safely appear within sanctioned democratic frameworks. Drawing from Michel Foucault's heterotopia, Sara Ahmed's queer phenomenology, and Doreen Massey's spatial multiplicity, the study reveals how public spaces across Tehran are reconfigured through coded behaviors, shared risks, and fleeting moments of solidarity. By amplifying the lived experiences of queer Iranians—long excluded from architectural histories—this paper redefines democratic space not as monumental or permanent, but as intimate, precarious, and enacted in secrecy, refusal, and shared survival.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

Profit over People: Debating Canary Wharf in the House of Commons

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Abstract

The late 20th century is generally regarded as a time when in many European democracies the power of the people was eclipsed by the interests of the market and private capital. In Britain, this shift was spurred by the rise to power of Margaret Thatcher, who in 1979 became Prime Minister. Under Thatcher, the country experienced tremendous change, which also affected its built environments: Following the doctrine of deregulation, the Greater London Council was abolished, council flats were sold off, and publicly owned lands were privatized to attract (foreign) investment. And yet, even if from the 1970s Britain's social democracy was dismantled, the country's democratic apparatus endured. Elections were held, checks and balances persisted, and government institutions continued to operate. One such government institution is the House of Commons. It gathers 650 Members of Parliament (MPs) elected by the people to represent corresponding UK constituencies.

This paper offers a close reading of the debates held in the British House of Commons regarding the development of Canary Wharf. Located in London's former docklands, Canary Wharf was a flagship neoliberal project. Realized during Thatcher's tenure, it was to become a new 'center for global finance' (Stevens 2020). The debates held in the House of Commons in the 1980s highlight how this project challenged Britain's democracy. In 1986, one MP, for instance, expressed his disbelief that 'because Canary Wharf lies within the Isle of Dogs enterprise zone […] the Secretary of State for the Environment [can] refuse to hold a public inquiry.' Focusing on these debates and relating them with contemporary discourses in popular media and architectural press, this paper examines how the architecture of the state – understood here as state institutions – defended and represented the interests of the people at a time when Britain's social democracy was sold off for private profit.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

The Design-Politics of Modernist Urbanism in Mexico City's Plaza de las Tres Culturas

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Abstract

Mexico City's Plaza de las Tres Culturas in Tlatelolco, inaugurated in 1964, is a stark modernist square surrounded by the reconstructed ruins of a temple destroyed by the conquering troops of Cortés in 1521 in their final battle, a Catholic church built by the colonizers using reclaimed stone from the temple, and a 12,000-unit mixed-income social housing project, the country's largest. Invented to celebrate the triple cultural mix of Mexica (Aztecs) and European colonizers that produced modern Mexico, the conjoined design-politics of this Plaza instead reveals the tensions behind such mestizo elision. This culminated in the infamous massacre of hundreds of protesting students (and others) who had assembled at the Plaza on October 2, 1968 to listen to speeches (delivered from a balcony made architecturally possible by neo-Corbusian skip-stop elevators). Military snipers instigated the violence by firing shots from the housing project in the general direction of the troops encircling the Plaza, thereby inducing a murderous response. Fleeing crowds tumbled over the edge of the plaza into the adjacent ruins, found no sanctuary in a locked church, and struggled to navigate their way into the warren of housing blocs. Drawing on a wide variety of Spanish and English sources that analyze the efforts of architect Mario Pani and archaeologist Francisco González Rul, the paper traces the contested high-minded ideological efforts to invent the Plaza as a democratic gathering place and reveals how the resultant architecture and urban design of the complex acted as a trap. The Plaza flagrantly faltered as both public space and public conscience: the military arm of the third culture, ignoring the religious tenets of the second, had forced the public to throw themselves onto the stones of the first.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

In the Absence of Democracy: The Case of the Palestinian Parliament in Jerusalem

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Abstract

In the early 1990s, the Palestinian-Israeli peace agreement led to the establishment of a new Palestinian government in the West Bank and Gaza, but not in Jerusalem, the city that the Palestinians perceive as their only national capital city. As a result, they were banned from establishing their government institutions in Jerusalem. To address the issue and to start building a Palestinian state, they decided to construct a brand-new parliament building on the edges of Jerusalem, in the village of Abu Dis, to create facts on the ground and claim the city as a Palestinian capital. A few years later, Israel noticed the national symbolism of the building as a Palestinian institution and halted its construction. Today, the parliament stands as a half-completed structure, symbolizing a crushed Palestinian presence in the capital city, hanging between a hopeful past and a suspended future.

This paper investigates Palestinian attempts to build a parliament under occupation. It focuses on the shifting symbolism of the Palestinian Parliament from a building that was expected to embody democracy to one that represents occupation and the failure of the peace agreement. The divergence between its intended use and harsh reality will be interrogated to raise questions about utilizing democracy in built form in state-building processes, especially during conflicts, extending the discussion to capital cities and their role in steering national ideals. The paper analyzes the architectural and urban features of the Parliament and the geo-political conditions under which it was conceived. It looks for democratic approaches – or lack thereof – in its design, perception by the public and decision-making processes to unpack the relationship between democracy, the nation and the regime on one hand, and democracy and complex political contexts on the other. It investigates how, in Palestine, the parliament embodies democracy and its absence in multiple ways.

PS03 Architecture & Democracy

Session Chair: Farzaneh Haghighi, The University of Auckland, New Zealand

City Hall for a Party Without an Avant-Garde

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Unicamp, Brazil

Abstract

This article analyzes the unbuilt design for a new São Paulo City Hall made in 1990 by architect Lina Bo Bardi, conceived during the first municipal administration of Brazil's Workers' Party (PT) in the city of São Paulo. The project marked an architectural shift aimed at fostering proximity between government and citizens during the country's re-democratization process. Bo Bardi proposed the conversion of a historic early 20th-century exhibition pavilion into the mayor's office, a daycare center, a public restaurant, and building a new modern annex for the state's bureaucratic functions. While the project is widely known as Bo Bardi's final work, little attention has been given to the political and historical circumstances that led the PT to prioritize it as an architectural statement of its popular vision of governance. Through a reconstruction of the decision-making process and a comparative analysis with projects by Oscar Niemeyer—who, during the redemocratization period, was embraced by the PT's political opponents on both the left and right of the ideological spectrum—this paper examines how Bo Bardi's approach reinterpreted modernist forms in dialogue with pre-existing historic buildings. The contrast between the two proposals highlights divergent visions of architecture for democracy in São Paulo, and reveals how modernist forms were in dispute to become the official design approach to the new State-led initiatives in Brazil in the New Republic.

PS04 Border Construct: Political Objects, Regional Imaginaries and Architectural Agency

Session Co-Chairs: Germán Pallares, Rhode Island School of Design, USA, and Albert José-Antonio López, University of New Mexico, USA

Playa del Rio: Utopia as a Border Construct in the 1980s

Luis Hernan

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Abstract

The paper considers Playa del Rio, a resort project developed in the 1980s for Boca Chica - the estuary where the Rio Grande meets the Gulf of Mexico in Texas. Drawing on Bolivar Echeverría's notion of racial modernity (2010), I read the project as a utopian construct of the borderlands. In doing so, I am interested in how architecture is complicit in the creation of ideal places along racial lines by the paradoxical but precise opening and closing of the border containing utopian spaces.

The 12,000-acre resort is representative of a shifting discourse around the Mexico-United State border in the twentieth century. With its proposed 71,000 rooms, convention centre and beach parkway the project operates as a mirror image of PRONAF, the development-oriented projects financed by the Mexican government in the 1960s to transform the border into a 'show window' (Pallares, 2020). Playa del Rio similarly relies on the creation of two new bridges into Mexico which were meant to create a tourist-centred district oriented to the Grande. The porous border, and its neoliberal logic of free flow of capital and services, prefigures the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) and catalysed local activist groups, most visibly in the figures of Mary Lou Campbell and Merriwood Ferguson, who imagined an alternative utopia of the borderlands, leading to the creation of the still existing (but under threat) ecological sanctuary in Boca Chica.

Read today, Playa del Río warns against the allure of racial utopias and architecture's complicity in them. The project is a preface to the current development on the site of Starbase, SpaceX's company town with a planned resort operating as a show window to the future of humanity in the stars, but one which requires a militarised border and the ordering of racialised bodies (Grosz, 2001).

PS04 Border Construct: Political Objects, Regional Imaginaries and Architectural Agency

Session Co-Chairs: Germán Pallares, Rhode Island School of Design, USA, and Albert José-Antonio López, University of New Mexico, USA

Border flows: infrastructural reciprocities in the Colorado River delta in the first half of the 20th century

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Abstract

In its natural course, the Colorado River meandered across the line that became the US-Mexico border. Traveling the region now known as the Imperial and Mexicali Valleys, environmentalist Aldo Leopold found a river that "divided and rejoined, twisted and turned, got lost and was glad of it."

Although bisected by a national border, the Colorado delta region was shaped by the shared ecological imaginary of a productive desert, whose aridity could be mastered through modern water management. Before 1942 - when the river was eventually channeled into separate "All-American" and "All-Mexican" canals - the natural patterns of water flows joined infrastructure and international politics in unexpected ways.

North of the border, the extraordinary development of Imperial Valley depended on water delivered by the Alamo Canal, an infrastructural complex built on Mexican soil and under Mexican control. America's legendary crops relied on water that had to come from Mexico.

South of the border, Mexicali Valley developed as a Cardenista counterproject to the Bureau of Reclamation's massive upstream interventions. The establishment and irrigation of the region's *ejidos* anchored the regime's rural development strategy in the late 1930s and 1940s, and asserted Mexico's claims to the river waters during the construction of the Hoover Dam and the Colorado River Aqueduct. American water projects shaped the migrations that built Mexicali.

The paper examines the hydrological entanglements between US and Mexico in the first half of the 20th century, in order to recover the material and ecological reciprocities that produced the environments of Imperial and Mexicali Valleys. By writing collaboratively between Mexico and the US, and by posing the river's natural ability to overflow its banks as a hopeful methodological model, we aim to work in ways that nurture relations across the border, alter national frameworks of knowledge production, and perform their own kind of productive desborde.

PS04 Border Construct: Political Objects, Regional Imaginaries and Architectural Agency

Session Co-Chairs: Germán Pallares, Rhode Island School of Design, USA, and Albert José-Antonio López, University of New Mexico, USA

Who's the Jefe? : Harnessing Labor Power and Configuring an Industrialized Border

Alan Alaniz

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Abstract

With the establishment of the Border Industrialization Program in 1965, Mexican state officials and American managerial consultants devised a framework to introduce industrial manufacturing along the Mexico-United States border, providing a stable engine for regional development while reintegrating the far-reaching extents of national territory into the country's economy. Emerging from the political rhetoric of the Good Neighbor Policy and catalyzed by the sunset of the Bracero Program in 1964, border industrialization leveraged the physical and economic ties spanning the international boundary to transform the image of border economies away from their associations with vice tourism into critical linkages in the global industrial supply chain. The ideal model that stood at the center of this transformation was the "twin plant," a coordinated manufacturing arrangement bridging facilities on either side of the border, capitalizing on plentiful yet inexpensive labor in Mexico and the growing technical capabilities of the American Southwest. To Mexican and American business interests, this form of development was perfectly suited to provide the jobs necessary in revitalizing the region's economy while also holding the potential to alter the social makeup of the borderlands as a whole.

This paper explores the development of the twin plant concept and its avatar, the binational corporate manager, evaluating how this building typology and its human agent complicate discrete notions of state, trade, and the international boundary. Rather than focus on the economic impact of border industrialization, this research evaluates border industrialization as a key object of design – carefully devised, produced, and maintained to lubricate the international mobility of expertise and capital at the expense of the laboring subject. By examining industrial archival documents and associated oral histories, this paper presents the genealogy of what later came to be known as the maquiladora industry, questioning the intentions behind this form and its influence on the configuration of border cities.

PS04 Border Construct: Political Objects, Regional Imaginaries and Architectural Agency

Session Co-Chairs: Germán Pallares, Rhode Island School of Design, USA, and Albert José-Antonio López, University of New Mexico, USA

Infrastructure manifestations of boom & bust cycles on the U.S.-MX border

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Abstract

This article traces how infrastructure has championed eras of colonization across the U.S.-Mexico Gulf Coast borderlands. The twin cities of Brownsville and Matamoros evolved into a north–south regional economic unit divided by the Rio Grande/Río Bravo, which became an international boundary. Since the establishment of the border in 1848, the region has experienced cycles of economic boom and bust that have shifted across the border, leveraging geopolitical differences and global and national markets for local resources, with significant impacts on urbanization. The patterns of the urban fabric bear witness to the developments, revealing the tensions and histories of resource and labor extraction shaped by the emergence of the political boundary.

We interrogate the complicity of urban planning, infrastructure, and architecture in processes of power and capital accumulation, focusing on the built environment's role in reinforcing or challenging the political, social, and economic dynamics of the border during the 20th and early 21st centuries. We chart periods of economic growth and decline and their dependence on the extraction of local resources, including soil, water, and labor. To understand the complicity and deployment of the built environment in border-making projects, we trace infrastructure development and analyze planning evidence embedded in the urban environment, showing how these elements have been mobilized to advance economic—often extractive—agendas in the region.

Throughout the history of the border, a recurring pattern emerges. Far from major urban centers, peripheral in the regulatory landscape, yet a significant geopolitical interface of contention and opportunity, the border has presented a sequence of opportunities for extraction and capital accumulation. Elites have formed coalitions, influenced regulatory environments, and financed infrastructure in order to extract resources, while using architecture as a marker of status. Governments have deployed architecture to advance state-building efforts.

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

Rebuilding the Church of the Holy Sepulcher: Ottoman Sovereignty, Greek Kalfas, and Orthodox Networks

Deniz Turker

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Abstract

This paper will be tightly structured around the rebuilding of the Church of the Holy Sepulcher after the devastating fire of 1808. It will closely examine the immediate call-to-action of the Greek Orthodox Brotherhood of the Holy Sepulcher, which conjoined Eastern Mediterranean diasporic networks stretching from Jerusalem to the Danubian Principalities. Helmed by the Ecumenical Patriarchate and the Patriarch of Jerusalem (residents of Ottoman Istanbul) a large troop of Greek Orthodox architects, builders, and craftsmen were assembled for the holy site's restoration. The architectural choices of these builders will be read in tandem with the efforts of the Ottoman state to control the final results to elucidate the complex prongs of heritage making at the turn of the nineteenth century. What did Ottoman decrees under Sultan Mahmud II stipulate about the rebuilding of non-Muslim ecclesiastical sites? To what extent were these Greek artists able to convey their artistic licenses? What of the voices of Armenian and Franciscan (Latin) communities with claims to segments of this holy site? The paper will also venture into a discussion of the Ottoman baroque, especially the layered meanings it accrued when its forms, associated deeply with an imperial idiom, were transposed into an unlikely architectural space: whose heritage did such architectural and decorative choices serve?

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

From Italian Imperialism to Cultural Sovereignty: The Birth of Antalya Museum in Türkiye

Pınar Aykaç

Middle East Technical University, Türkiye

Abstract

Following the Italo-Turkish War, Italy articulated a policy in 1912 to expand its influence into Anatolia through consulates, schools, and archaeological expeditions. As part of this policy, Roberto Paribeni, Director of the *Museo Nazionale Romano*, was commissioned to conduct archaeological surveys around Antalya, a southern port city with strong ancient Roman past. Although Paribeni's plans for excavations in the region was interrupted by the First World War, he continued to promote the region's Roman legacy through conferences and publications, reinforcing Italy's claims in the Mediterranean.

Following the Italian occupation of Antalya in 1919, archaeological surveys continued in the region together with conservation work, including at Hadrian's Gate. These efforts eventually culminated in the establishment of a museum within the Italian Consulate. The museum drew objections from local Ottoman officials over the unauthorised collection of antiquities by the Italians and the transfer of some items to Rhodes.

In response, Süleyman Fikri, a local teacher at the Ottoman *idadi* school appointed himself a voluntary antiquities officer. He rearranged the Bayraktar Masjid as a local museum depot in 1919. This depot formed the nucleus of the Antalya Museum, officially established in 1923 under the Turkish Republic. In its early years, the museum focused on incorporating antiquities collected by Italian authorities during the occupation into the national collection.

This paper examines how Italy mobilised archaeology and the ideology of *Romanità* to legitimise its political claims in southern Anatolia, and how these claims were contested both by local actors and Ottoman institutions. It argues that the establishment of the Antalya Museum was both an act of preservation and a claim to cultural sovereignty. By analysing the interplay between international, imperial, and local actors, the paper offers further insight into the contested processes of heritage-making during the transition from the Ottoman Empire to the Turkish Republic.

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

Resettler Nationalism and Alternative Visions Against Partitioned Heritages

Esra Akcan

Cornell University, Stanford University, USA

Abstract

This paper reflects on the impact of what the author calls resettler nationalism during the dissolution of the Ottoman Empire on the making of cultural heritage in successor nation-states. Resettler nationalism supported compulsory population transfers, and perpetuated partitions along perceived ethnic, religious, and racial lines to hinder cosmopolitan ethics as a prerequisite of perpetual peace. It was endorsed both by rulers on opposing sides of divides and international institutions, and fostered an irreversible division between Europe and Asia, and "West" and "Islam." Against the victors of history, the paper foregrounds alternative visions such as those of migrants who carried cultural artifacts and techniques from departure places and hybridized them in arrival places; builders who crossed the borders of partition; architects who used building materials to empower migrant economy and labor; or refugees who resisted the erasure of co-existence and solidarity memories. The paper treats architecture as the debris of erased peoples as a connector between those who stayed and those who were expelled. As exceptions to the dominant policy, the paper foregrounds people who collected, preserved, restored, referenced or revived enforced migrants' remainders as alternative visions against partitioned heritages, such as intellectuals Melpo Merlier, Mihri Belli, and particularly the "exchanged" architect Nikos Zoumboulidis. Through bottom-up memory practices, the paper reconceptualizes partitions as the rift between the rulers and the peoples, and not the rift between the two communities.

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

Smyrna's "Paradise": Heritage-Making in a Palimpsestic Landscape

Sibel Zandi-Sayek

William & Mary, USA

Abstract

The verdant valley once known locally as *Paradise* (also recorded as *Kızılçullu* in Ottoman and Turkish documents and today known as *Yeşildere*) was long a fertile and spiritually resonant landscape on the outskirts of Izmir/Smyrna. Watered by a gentle stream traditionally linked to the birth of the ancient poet Homer, the valley supported orchards, fields, and the rhythms of seasonal labor. It also carried deep devotional significance, becoming associated with St. Anne, venerated in Christian and Muslim traditions alike. Into the late Ottoman period, Paradise served as a favored site for religious and communal feasts, its flowing water drawing crowds through the season. The monumental aqueducts that crossed the valley, first built in Roman times and kept in use under Byzantine and Ottoman rule, functioned as the dominant feature of this richly layered landscape. Their weathered arches, together with the valley's picturesque appeal, made the area a recurring motif in travelogues, guidebooks, engravings, paintings, and early photographs.

Building on critical heritage studies, this paper examines how Paradise was recontextualized in the late Ottoman and early Republican periods through the rise of a nearby American missionary college (the International College of Smyrna). It argues that the relocation of the College to a large site by the valley on the eve of WWI catalyzed new interpretations, transforming Paradise from a vernacular agrarian landscape into an institutional one. Approaching heritage not as a fixed legacy but as a constructed relationship with the past—an ensemble of practices, framings, and ways of seeing—the paper traces how the valley's palimpsest of ruins, water, sanctity, and fertility became a canvas for missionaries, local communities, European antiquarians, and national actors. By charting these successive reinscriptions, the paper shows how Paradise became a terrain of fluid and ongoing heritage-making, shaped by shifting pedagogical, institutional, and political priorities.

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

Bringing the Baroque to Sinan: Architectural Renovation in the Late Ottoman Empire

Emily Neumeier

Temple University, USA

Abstract

Despite recent interventions in the field of art history, the imperial mosques designed by Mimar Sinan in the 16th century remain the quintessential representatives of Ottoman architectural heritage writ large. With textbooks and tourist guidebooks celebrating the austere "classical" aesthetic of these monuments, most contemporary visitors would be surprised to learn that the majority of these buildings were once decked out with elaborate Baroque painting programs featuring sinuous scrollwork, faux colored marble, and trompe l'oeil curtains. For it was in the late 18th and 19th centuries that, alongside new constructions announcing the triumphant arrival of the "Ottoman Baroque" style, the grand mosque complexes built by earlier sultans and their court also underwent extensive renovations and received updated decoration schemes. It is difficult today to comprehend just how prevalent the Baroque was in Ottoman architecture because much of these later decorations have now vanished, removed during 20th-century restoration campaigns after the establishment of the Turkish Republic. In this presentation, I propose to recover the lost Baroque interiors of some of Istanbul's most iconic mosques—including the Süleymaniye, Yavuz Sultan Selim, Rüstem Pasha, Kılıç Ali Pasha, and Mihrimah Sultan in Üsküdar—through historic photographs and archival documents. Building on this evidence for a systematic effort on behalf of Ottoman architects and patrons in the long 19th century to reimagine the appearance of Istanbul's architectural environment, I will also analyze archival records and contemporary accounts to evaluate whether these individuals understood these renovation practices as a departure from or a complementary enhancement to Sinan's 16th-century designs. Ultimately, the fact that the 19th-century interventions in these mosque interiors were largely removed in the 20th century points to the rapid shifts in heritage discourse in the modern Mediterranean, offering new perspectives on the formation of the Ottoman architectural canon.

PS05 Heritage Making in the Eastern Mediterranean

Session Chair: Belgin Turan Ozkaya, Middle East Technical University, Türkiye, and Nilay Özlü, Istanbul Technical University, Türkiye

Architectural Heritage, Selective Narratives, and National Identity Formation in Nineteenth-Century, Post-Ottoman Greece

Heather Grossman

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Abstract

This paper examines heritage making practices in nineteenth-century Athens, analyzing how classical, late antique, and Byzantine monuments were deployed to construct nascent Greek national identity as it emerged from the late Ottoman Empire. The architectural heritage of bygone political states was invoked in intellectual circles and through popular imaginaries to bolster the ideas of the contemporary polity and to provide legitimizing foundations upon which to build a national identity. In the years following Greece's establishment as an independent nation, Greek historians newly aligned Byzantium with classical Greece to create an imagined continuum toward a modern Hellenic identity, effectively bypassing four centuries of Ottoman rule. However, in the same period, many Byzantine churches in the new capital of Athens were destroyed and the Acropolis was largely cleansed of its later accretions to project an image of the city – and nation – as steeped in classical Hellenism. The paper teases out the role of architectural heritage in the tensions between the creation of a multi-period, multi-confessional, and continuous Hellenic identity and one based in a more constrained historical narrative. Both architectural monuments and nineteenth-century photographs of the city, particularly those of the Istanbul-based Sébah photographic firm as well as those of contemporary Greek photographers (as opposed to western European image-makers), are examined in the presentation. These demonstrate contemporary linkage between monuments, memory, and contemporary modernization. Lastly, the use of Athens' architectural heritage is briefly compared to the ways in which ancient, Byzantine, and classical Ottoman monuments in Istanbul were conjoined both physically and in images to modern buildings and new infrastructure, making a connection between past states and late Ottoman identity in a parallel mode of heritage creation.

PS06 Feminist Routes: Views and Voices from the Global South

Session Co-Chairs: Mrinalini Rajagopalan, University of Pittsburgh, USA, and Shundana Yusaf, University of Utah, USA

A Face in the Crowd: A Feminist Reading of Modernisation in Tehran at the Turn of the 20th Century

Sadaf Tabatabaei

Newcastle University, United Kingdom

Abstract

Working with (his)tories positioned outside the canon, has changed how I look. Over time, a habit formed, zooming into photographs, scanning the background, the shadows, for those the archive has failed to name. I often look for women; their black *chadors* and white face coverings make them strangely more visible in grainy images of Tehran from the turn of the century.

In one such search, I paused on a face. A woman rests on the ground at *Takyeh Dowlat*, a monumental site for religious performance, just before a show begins. Her veil is lifted, her hand tucked under her cheek. She is neither passive nor assertive. Her presence unsettles fixed ideas of visibility. She waits for the performance, but perhaps, also for recognition. Her presence carries *[a] story*. Not one preserved in the archive, but a (her)story pieced together through what remains.

This paper begins with her. The act of zooming becomes a point of entry—not just visual, but narrative—into a feminist method of historiography grounded in *storytelling*, and the search for what official histories omit. Set in Tehran at the turn of the 20th century, this research explores how women experienced the modernising city. They inhabited, resisted, and subtly reshaped its emerging spaces, often remaining outside the frame of architectural records.

This research use *storytelling* to read against and alongside the archive, to trace how women/others, rarely named and barely visible, claimed the space. Following Saidiya Hartman's method of critical fabulation, the aim is not to fill the gaps in the archive, but to remain critically aware of them. In this image of Takyeh Dowlat, the quiet presence of this unknown woman opens up a new reading of the space. Her story asks us to rethink what counts as evidence, agency, and spatial history.

PS06 Feminist Routes: Views and Voices from the Global South

Session Co-Chairs: Mrinalini Rajagopalan, University of Pittsburgh, USA, and Shundana Yusaf, University of Utah, USA

Work with care: feminist reflections on community research methods

Mariana Moura

University of Antwerp, Belgium

Abstract

This paper explores the role of care work within a research where community-oriented practices serve as a guiding principle. As part of an ongoing oral history project with women builders in self-building sites of Indigenous and Afro-Brazilian maroon communities in Brazil, these practices were designed to center women in the discussion, learn from their techniques for building with natural materials, and raise awareness of the relevance of their gendered construction know-how, challenging hegemonic historiographical claims that position women only as a minority or exception on the building site.

However, as the project unfolds, it confronts its own limitations, particularly regarding a preconceived model of engagement that demands continuous adaptation between our scholarly frameworks and the commitment to, in bell hooks' words, 'build community with strangers', a practice that requires care, responsibility, respect and a willingness to learn.

In this context, care work is framed as a methodological concern with a twofold dimension. On one hand, it refers to the often-invisible labour involved in conducting research grounded on feminist and decolonial principles, labour that takes time and is frequently undervalued within an increasingly neoliberal university system that privileges outcomes over processes. On the other hand, care is understood as an ethical practice essential to enabling socially engaged research with emancipatory potential.

In this article, I discuss the dialogical process of conducting this project, and the challenges and uncertainties of collaboratively building a research approach rooted in care. This includes, amongst other aspects of fieldwork activities, obtaining community consent and navigating institutional ethical clearance, each with its own set of contradictions. Reflecting on my experiences with these women and their communities, I argue that care work in research involves working *with* care: a process of negotiation and reciprocity that continually reshapes research questions, objectives, procedures and envisioned outcomes.

PS06 Feminist Routes: Views and Voices from the Global South

Session Co-Chairs: Mrinalini Rajagopalan, University of Pittsburgh, USA, and Shundana Yusaf, University of Utah, USA

Between Utopia and the Everyday: 'Other' Imaginaries in a Fractured Landscape

Ismat Hossain

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Abstract

The Bengal delta is a unique landform shaped by hundreds of winding waterways, shifting tidal plains and a transient landscape fractured by tides, wars and the remnants of colonial dictates. The history of Bengal is constructed largely through patriarchal narratives- both colonial and nationalistic. These histories are often violent and seperatical and suppress other voices or reconstitute them through the male gaze. This paper investigates two non-historical narratives, one from 1905 and the other from more recent times, in hope of understanding the 'other' imaginaries of Bengal that are absent in recognized historical texts. The first narrative is a futuristic utopia titled 'Sultana's Dream' that was written by a female Bengali writer Rokeya Shakhawat Hossain. The second, narrated in a film titled 'Are you Listening!' by Kamar Ahmed Simon, is the continuing story of everyday trials faced by people in the delta. Both narratives are seen through the female gaze, often contending patriarchal visions and providing alternate imaginaries of the built world. Separated by over a hundred years, both stories are intertwined within the larger narratives of state, power and marginalization but also torn by the devastations of war, man-made and climate disasters. Both the utopian world Sultana, the female protagonist, encounters in her dream and the precarious world Rakhi navigates in the delta necessarily attempt to subvert the existing power relations and re-imagine the built environment. Unlike Sultana, Kamar's female protagonist does not visit utopia in her dream. Her utopia is one that she works towards every day. Between the two narratives we see the possible becoming of alternate realities, imaginary worlds that emerge through constant negotiations of the everyday.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Kañaraqay and the Development of Inca Architectural Language

Georgi Kyorlenski

Denver Art Museum, USA

Abstract

Construction was an important expectation of the office of the Inca ruler called *Sapa Inca*. Rulers commissioned civic, military, and other projects, but their royal estates occupy a singular space as the sites that defined their patron's reign. These private complexes constitute a multipart site type that includes agricultural land, landscape modifications such as terracing, roads, storage facilities, shrines, public plazas, as well as the private quarters of the Inca rulers. Royal estates were an integral part of the royal economy that supported the ruling class that called themselves Inca. They were at once a home and the place where the *Sapa Inca* inscribed their political and ideological concerns into the sacred Andean landscape.

The four imperial *Sapa Inca*, as well as two of their predecessors, built such royal estates over the course of the Inca imperial period (1400-1533). This archaeologically short span of just over a century is often discussed as a monolith. However, detailed architectural studies of these most spectacular Inca sites allow us to trace a development of the imperial architectural language. From an emphasis on the relationship between the Inca state and the potent landscape in the context of initial expansion through concerns about succession and control over the nobility to aggrandizement of Inca monumental architecture, the royal estates paint a very different picture of the static imperial architecture of power. This presentation traces those developments and then adds the final piece of the puzzle. Kañaraqay, the royal estate of the final *Sapa Inca*, Huascar, transformed the royal estate type from a rural to an urban form, while its primary concern was alliance-building in the context of the Inca Civil War, the devastating conflict that paved the path to European invasion of the Andes.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Carved Connections: Maya Stone Monuments and the Mapping of Urban Space

Catherine Popovici

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Abstract

Several discussions of Mesoamerican urbanism focus on city centers composed of towering temples, radial pyramids, and nearby freestanding stone sculpture. However, sculpture was also strategically positioned just beyond the ceremonial core, suggesting that placement in relation to urban centers also held particular significance. An exploration of the positioning of sub-urban monuments reveals their spatial and aesthetic relationship to the built environment across the Classic Maya region. This study examines how encounters with monuments in transitional spaces between urban centers and surrounding landscapes shaped daily and ceremonial movement practices in these liminal zones. Drawing on recent studies of Mesoamerican urbanism and a series of case studies spanning the Maya region—from the Yucatán to Honduras—this paper considers the broader spatial context of these stone monuments and the various urban connections in their midst.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Reconsidering Chaco Canyon

Anne Lawrason Marshall

University of Idaho, USA

Abstract

Chaco Canyon is the location of a dozen monumental, multistory, Ancestral Pueblo buildings known as great houses. It is one of only two Ancestral Indigenous places north of Mexico that could be considered a metropolitan urban center. Built ca. 850-1150 CE in northwestern New Mexico, these buildings have been excavated and studied extensively since 1896, yet much is still unknown about them. This paper will recount unique attributes of Chaco and consider theoretical interpretations about what Chaco Canyon was. This paper is based on my own fieldwork, conversations with other researchers, and review of the extensive literature.

Chaco Canyon is a wide, shallow canyon in which the great houses are clustered along a 14 k stretch of the canyon, eight on the canyon floor along the canyon's vertical north face, and four on overlooking mesas. All face south or southeast, some are aligned astronomically, and the great house Pueblo Bonito is perfectly aligned with the cardinal directions (Marshall 2003). Radiating out from central Chaco Canyon is a series of engineered roads leading toward surrounding mountains and outlying Chaco-style great houses. Great house architecture is remarkable for its geometric plans and overengineered, finely-crafted walls of sandstone and mud-mortar veneer filled with a core of rubble stone and mud. Items such as turquoise, copper bells, macaw feathers, and cacao were found within Pueblo Bonito indicating wealth and long distance trade to turquoise mines and Mexico.

Based on the road system and outliers, alignment and formality of great houses, astronomical rock art, and intermittent deposition of broken pottery, Chaco Canyon has been interpreted as a ceremonial center (Lekson et al.1988, Malville 2001); population studies support this interpretation (Bernardini 1999; Marshall 2004). Recent research documenting vegetation degradation suggests a permanent resident population (Lentz et al. 2021), but this interpretation is not conclusive.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Mvskoke Spatial Sovereignty and the Limits of Settler Recognition

Jacob Boatman

Parsons School of Design, USA

Abstract

This paper challenges the settler-colonial foundations of "urbanism" by foregrounding the spatial and political significance of Muscogee (Mvskoke) towns - settlements central to the formation of Indigenous nationhood yet persistently excluded from architectural discourse. It asks: if these towns were not "urban," how could they have constituted a sovereign polity - one recognized, negotiated with, and ultimately targeted by the United States? Drawing on fieldwork at the *Ocmulgee Mounds* Historic Site in Georgia and *Abihka*, my ancestral village in Alabama, privately owned since Indian Removal, this research explores how Indigenous spatial formations have been overwritten by Euro-American frameworks of property, preservation, and urban growth. Ocmulgee, a ceremonial site and Muscogee political center, became the foundation for the city of Macon, anchored by a colonial-era trading post. It now functions as a federally managed historic site, where Indigenous sovereignty is narrativized into the past while settler heritage is foregrounded. Rooted in architectural history, legal theory, and Indigenous critique, this project traces how American Indian policy - from the treaty system to the Commerce Clause - transformed Indigenous nations into legal fictions. By imposing capitalist logics of exchange, territory, and identity, settler policy abstracted land into commodity, redefined Indigenous relations as "dependency," and spatialized colonial dominance through infrastructure, surveys, and eventually, monuments. This research argues that Muscogee towns, with their distributed governance, ritual centrality, and enduring place-based epistemologies, constitute a form of urbanism misrecognized by settler frameworks precisely because they threaten the myth of the frontier and the legitimacy of American expansion. In foregrounding these Indigenous geographies, the paper reframes urbanism not as density or permanence, but as a spatial expression of sovereignty, continuity, and resistance.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Relational Urbanism in the Chaco World: Movement, Geoaesthetics, and Landscapes of Power

Robert S Weiner

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Abstract

The prodigious architectural developments centered in and around Chaco Canyon in the North American Southwest have long stirred debates regarding the character of urbanism in the precolonial Indigenous Americas. Between AD 800-1200, ancestors of Pueblo and Diné (Navajo) people constructed hundreds of multistoried masonry Great Houses—temple-like structures designed with rigid geometric proportions and in alignment with astronomical cycles and prominent landforms— within a dense architectural complex at the heart of Chaco Canyon. Nine-meter-wide linear earthworks resembling roadways also crisscross the surrounding desert, connecting Chacoan Great Houses with powerful places in the landscape including springs, mountains, and uninhabited structures from the pre-Chaco past. Despite Chaco Canyon lying at the center of a 100,000 sq. km region through which its distinctive architectural style spread, the canyon appears to have supported only a modest population of religious elites. Along with its low resident population, Chaco also lacked other traditional trait-list "markers" of urbanism (e.g., writing) that are now widely understood to reproduce ethnocentric prejudices. In this paper, I revisit the question of urbanism as applied to the monumental architecture of Chaco Canyon and its larger world. I trace the relational character of Great Houses and roads whose placement within the landscape, orientations, materiality, geometries, symbolism, and use for ritual performance define a complexly layered *gesamtkunstwerk*. The Chaco Way, as I refer to this bundled architectural-land/skyscape-performance aesthetic complex, integrated the human-built with stone, water, mountains, and the sun and moon to evoke synaesthetic connections for those who moved through it. Overall, I develop an argument for the centrality of interconnected, inter-being relationships—monumentalized in the built environment—at the core of Chacoan urbanism.

PS07 Urbanisms of Ancestral Indigenous America: A Reconsideration

Session Chair: Trenton Barnes, Williams College, USA

Sculpted Friezes, Predatory Beings: Earthen Architecture Traditions in the Ancient Andes

Gabriella Wellons

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Abstract

In ancient Peru, the earliest earthen wall elaborations depict fanged and predatory aspects of caimans, felines, raptors, and arachnid divinities in temples within monumental architecture (huacas) at archaeological sites—Cerro Blanco, Punkurí, Huaca Partida, Caballo Muerto, and Huaca Garagay situated on the north and central coast of Peru between 1400 and 500 BCE. This paper assesses early urban settlements reconsidering recent field research on architectural sites belonging to the Cupisnique and Manchay cultures that preceded and coalesced with the highland center of Chavín de Huántar. In particular, the menacing fanged earthen pilaster from the temple atrium at Huaca Garagay. I detail the architectural construction of earthen sculpted friezes and monumental centers offering primary material evidence of a sophisticated sculpture tradition in an era far removed from ancient text and writing.

This paper examines the visuality of *in situ* earthen sculpture as a salient point of investigation into the earliest architectural developments in the central coast of Peru with attention to colossal ancestral predators sculpted onto facades and within atriums of coastal temples. Early examples include the pre-ceramic urban center, Caral, situated in the Supe valley of the north central coast of Peru, where material evidence demonstrates Caral's substantial urban settlement. It considers the persistent phenomenon of U-shaped architectural structures during the Initial through Early Formative Periods. Furthermore, this paper explores the social historical implication of how the investigation of the earliest autochthonous Andean civilization prompted multiple discourses on ancestral origins, socio-political organization, and the development of complex societies in the ancient Andes.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

Sister Nesta Fitzgerald-Lombard, Religious Agency and Alternative Routes to Architectural Practice

Alborz Dianat

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Abstract

While histories celebrate those who have fought their way into the architectural profession, this paper recognizes the importance of identifying agency in alternative and collaborative pathways to practice, explored through a case study on the Catholic nun and architect Sister Nesta Fitzgerald-Lombard (1916–2006). One of the first women to study architecture in Ireland, Sister Nesta did not break into the patriarchal profession. Instead, she avoided professional obstacles entirely by becoming a nun and designing buildings voluntarily for her convent. While foregrounding her agency in leading over fifty construction projects, this paper notes the difficulty ascribing a term presumed to denote individualism and resistance, with Sister Nesta working closely with her community on projects. Beyond the notice of architects and historians, her contributions built from precedents for the collaborative and anonymized work of Catholic women religious in construction. Rather than seeking individual recognition, those involved in such projects have reinforced their religious order's collective existence. Underappreciated pathways to architectural production can be brought to light by acknowledging intentionality in compliance as well as resistance, and in community-building as well as self-empowerment. Considering 'religious agency', Kelsey C. Burke and Laura M. Leming have emphasized women's actions in gender-traditional religions, while scholars including Jakeet Singh and Paola Rebughini have proposed the integration of an intersectional framework to identify both obstacles and opportunities through multiple intersecting social categories. Working from these perspectives to apply an expanded definition of agency, this paper identifies the potential for empowerment by evading rather than overcoming the architectural profession's patriarchal policing. Rather than merely adding names to the canon, expanding agency can therefore encourage recognition of these alternative routes to affect the built environment.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

Invisibility, Agency, and Transnational Justice: The Sans-Papiers at the Eiffel Tower

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Abstract

For the past few decades, the areas around the Eiffel Tower have inadvertently become a *mise-en-scène* of neoliberal world (dis)order and its grassroots lived experience: an intertwined narrative of migration politics, global capital flows, and the confounding agency of the human–architecture interface. The *sans-papiers*—as undocumented or irregular migrants are known in local parlance—have carved out a highly mobile, informal tourism market in the shadows of Gustave Eiffel's soaring tower, the world's tallest man-made structure when it was built in 1889 to commemorate the centennial of the French Revolution. Spread across the Champ de Mars, Place du Trocadéro, and Palais de Chaillot, these ubiquitous yet transient vendors—mostly from West Africa—primarily sell a single souvenir: miniature replicas of the Eiffel Tower, the quintessential Parisian keepsake that tourists expect to find everywhere. Herein lies a tripartite irony: the *sans-papiers*, whose most logical defence in a hostile environment would be to remain socially invisible, make a living by peddling the most visible, miniaturized trope of French cultural chauvinism, mass-produced in Chinese sweatshops. The state's jurisdictional regime tolerates the *sans-papiers* only insofar as they remain humanoid silhouettes—not fully recognized individuals with names and addresses—allowed to survive, but not to thrive, within what South African philosopher Achille Mbembe calls a state of "necropolitical" governance. At the mercy of shifting migration policies, they are the spectral protagonists of a world that is geographically open yet politically gated, revealing a counterintuitive ontology of invisibility as both a condition for life and a strategy for survival. This condition exposes the epistemological inadequacy of prevailing notions of agency and their aspirational corollaries: empowerment and inclusion. Drawing on years of field research in France and Senegal, this paper argues that agency must be reconceptualized as a problem of justice, one that warrants repositioning within what political theorist Nancy Fraser calls a transnational frame.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

The Submerged Floating City: Agency and Urban Marginality in Manaus

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Abstract

In response to the processes of marginalization produced by the modernization of Manaus, a true city of the excluded was built on water: the Floating City. Formed by clusters of houses erected on large wooden logs tied together and floating on the Rio Negro, this collective mode of dwelling experienced significant densification over time. Studies indicate that around 12,000 people lived in floating houses, a number that, combined with the significant presence of stilt houses, still lacking precise accounting, suggests that approximately 10% of Manaus' population lived on water in the 1960s, making the city a hybrid between land and water.

This process was directly linked to the expulsion of poor populations from the historic center and to the progressive occupation of riverbanks in neighborhoods such as Educandos and São Raimundo. As land-based areas became saturated, these populations expanded over the water, forming territories where the boundaries between urban and rural were fluid and where fishing, cultivation, commerce, and service activities coexisted. With increasing densification, floating houses became interconnected along the shoreline, forming an urban network structured by the dynamics of the river. In this context, riverine populations played a decisive role in shaping Manaus as a fluvial metropolis, producing circulation networks and urban life in spaces without formal infrastructure.

Today, the Floating City no longer exists. During the developmentalist and industrialization processes implemented under the Brazilian military dictatorship. In 1967, the floating city was submerged, and its inhabitants were forcibly displaced to distant and underserved peripheries. As Amazonian researcher Geraldo J. Tupinambá do Valle observes, "we did not erect an opera house, but we accomplished something just as complex: we built a city on the waters of the Rio Negro."

The history of the Floating City can thus be understood, on one hand, as a narrative of precarious living conditions and silencing under dominant territorial control; and on the other, as an active process of spatial production. In light of a reassessment of the concept of agency, this paper understands riverine agency as continuous spatial invention, grounded in everyday practices of circulation, labor, and adaptation to the river's dynamics, producing urban life beyond formal planning while remaining subject to delegitimization and erasure.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

Relational Agency in Asian Modernism: ARCASIA as a Structural Actor in Architectural Discourse

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Abstract

While agency has become central in recovering marginalized voices in architectural history, its binary framing overlooks the structural processes by which meaning is collectively produced. This paper reframes the Architects Regional Council Asia (ARCASIA) not simply as a forum of exchange, but as a transnational institution functioning as a structural agent of epistemic articulation and cultural positioning, reconfiguring the boundaries of modernist discourse from within postcolonial Asia.

Methodologically, the study applies qualitative methods, including the KJ method and the gradual structuring method to organize textual data into thematic clusters and analyze the archive of ARCASIA keynote speeches (1984–2021). Among the resulting categories, the paper focuses on "Reflection on Modernism," a recurring theme that reveals intellectual negotiation between Asian architects and global paradigms. The analysis reconstructs how Asian architects engaged with and domesticated the epistemic challenges posed by Western modernism—not as isolated individuals, but through a regionally embedded discursive network.

Findings indicate that ARCASIA architects did not reject modernism wholesale, but instead regarded it as a complex stimulus for critique and cultural reflection. In response, they developed two interconnected trajectories: one centered on reclaiming cultural identity, the other on critically renewing modernist principles. These responses, articulated through ideological, theoretical, empirical, and pragmatic modes, converged into a conceptual framework shaped by cultural-region and environmental-nature orientations within the Asian context. This framework encompasses a set of nine recurring themes: ethics, tradition, place, climate, environment, nature, urban, life, and technology. Rather than opposing modernism outright, ARCASIA architects reinterpreted it through locally grounded knowledge production, contributing to a renewed architectural worldview that repositions Asian perspectives within global discourse.

Overall, this study positions ARCASIA as a regionally embedded agent that enables the structural production of architectural meaning and contributes to repositioning non-Western institutions in global architectural historiography through a framework of regional discourse networks.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

From Make-shift to In-habit: Historicising Spatial Agency in Humanitarian Architecture, and its Discontents

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Abstract

Designated spaces of displacement are often being created as alienating environments of control and care. The rationalized design of their humanitarian architecture, in the form of the rigid grid of a refugee camp composed of repetitive prefabricated shelters, is designed for those who are seen as temporary unwanted guests.

Since the second half of the 20th century, however, humanitarian architecture has had a continuous engagement with participatory practices, recognising those perceived as "helpless refugees" as having active agency in the production of their spaces. Architect Frederick Cuny writes already in 1977 in 'Refugee Camps and Camp Planning' on how the term "victim" should be replaced with "participant," building on the ability of the refugees to engage with the process of appropriating their minimal camps and shelters. Today architects and architectural theorists such as Conti, Dabaj, and Pascucci reflecting on 'Participatory Humanitarian Architecture' (2020) also consider "refugees' agency" as core to co-design processes of humanitarian sites, including makeshift encampments where the displaced build their own spaces of refuge.

What are the implications of putting such an emphasis on refugees' agency in humanitarian spaces? What are the architectural imaginaries involved, and what is their meaning in the context of such exclusionary and restrictive refugee spaces, which are both internal and external to the national spatial order of things? This paper critically examines the history of architectural practice and theory on spatial agency in humanitarian architecture and refugee environments. It challenges the ethics and meaning of building on ideas of architectural participation and agency in such exclusionary and liminal spaces, where refugees have no real choice and autonomy on where they live and how. The paper suggests the alternative notion of inhabitation as a broader lens to engage with refugee and migratory spatial practices both within and beyond designated spaces of refuge.

PS08 Redefining Agency in Global Architectural Historiography

Session Co-Chairs: Sara Honarmand Ebrahimi, University of Exeter, United Kingdom, and Nokubekezela Mchunu, University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

Hospital, Corporation, or Sanctuary? The Multiple Faces of Agency as Read in Iranian Modern Domesticity (1910s–1940s)

Kamyar Salavati

University of Exeter, United Kingdom

Abstract

After the 1906 Iranian Constitutional Revolution—a grassroots, full-fledged movement to initiate modernization in the country—Iranian domesticity was redefined as well. Unlike pre-20th-century visions of the home, the modern home had to be run by women as its head and was expected to result in a carefully planned environment to raise healthy, educated citizens. The constitutionalists introduced their ideas through a redefinition of older house administration treatises. These new treatises were mostly written by women, now addressed to the emerging modern middle class (as opposed to the traditional middle-class). While the house was to become the 'sanctuary of men'—echoing Catharine Beecher's and Benjamin's notions of the Christian and modern home—the housewife was to act as both the head of a hospital and the director of a corporation. The new domesticity was centred around the kitchen as the core of the house, with bedrooms transformed into hospital rooms, and the other rooms as a carefully planned enterprise (as opposed to flexible rooms of the past). The housewife, whose main capital was her modern education (unlike traditional women), had to learn the skills of an accountant as well as a medic. These dual roles were to be merged through architecture. While this vision was materialized in a unique house plan—a 'sub-divided' home that also incorporated a hospital-ward layout-, in reality, the Iranian home evolved into a synthesis of a large central space (similar to traditional courtyards) with specialized rooms arranged around it. These transformations raise several concerns regarding agency. Multiple and competing forms of agency were at play, particularly between modern and traditional middle-class women. Also, the promotion of women to the role of masters of the house did not simply result in empowerment or subjugation. Rather, it produced a paradoxical form of agency—both constrained and enabled by the very structures that sought to shape it.

PS09 Open Session - Landscape

Session Chair: D. F. Ruggles, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Jurisdiction Drawn in Drifted Sand: Prison Labor, Land Law, and the Making of Maamoura on Egypt's Mediterranean Coast, 1944–60

Manar Moursi

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Abstract

This paper examines the making of Egypt's modernist coastal leisure through the case of Maamoura, a seaside district east of Alexandria developed after the 1952 revolution. Under the late monarchy, Maamoura's coastal terrain was reclaimed through prison labor, transforming sandy desert into traversable and developable ground. After 1952, this terrain was reclassified through land law as state-owned desert, rendering existing Bedouin land use legally invisible and enabling its transformation into a coastal leisure district. It was simultaneously reframed within a socialist developmental idiom that presented leisure as a collective entitlement and national achievement. In this process, prison labor was recast as rehabilitation and national service, rendering coercion legible as a contribution to national progress and modernity. Shifting attention from architectural form to the labor, law, and environmental transformations that make construction possible, the paper shows how processes that precede building shaped the conditions of modernist development. Reading architecture alongside labor, law, and administration, it argues that modernist form did not mark a postcolonial rupture but gave durable expression to earlier coercive processes, translating forced land-making into a landscape that appeared technical, progressive, and collective while leaving the relations that produced it intact.

PS09 Open Session - Landscape

Session Chair: D. F. Ruggles, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Beautifying India. Trees in nation-building, 1945–57

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Abstract

The construction of national identity in former colonies was a complex process that, among the different fields related to ideological and cultural production, involved open space design and entailed a new perception of indigenous vegetation. Considered identifying symbols, local plants played a crucial role in shaping a local image and were used to support narratives of the former colonies' cultural uniqueness.

The paper will focus on the role of Punjabi civil servant Mohinder Singh Randhawa (1909–86) in the development of a self-affirmation strategy for post-colonial India based on the relation between the new nation and its trees.

A skilled botanist and a high ranking official, Randhawa actively participated in the theoretical discourse on nation building and identity seeking that animated the country in the years surrounding independence and the Partition. Recognizing the challenge of finding common ground in a profoundly diverse and politically fragmented nation, he perceived trees as potential catalysts for shared cultural identity, emerging from a unified national landscape shaped by distinctive geographical and climatic conditions.

In 1945, Randhawa proposed a tree plantation plan as a national planning tool aimed at constructing a varied botanical network linking infrastructures, rural villages, and urban centers to foster territorial cohesion and a unique spatial aesthetic. The introduction of trees was based on principles of functional efficiency and spatial clarity and was tailored to the specific needs of different sites, to enhance their character: utility guided the selection of trees in rural areas, while beauty shaped urban areas.

By imagining a more efficient, and more beautiful Indian landscape, where trees would be carefully arranged, Randhawa revealed the agency of plants as stable elements in the construction of a new spatial order and visual aesthetic that reflected the idealistic construction of a better, more cohesive society the Nehruvian administration envisioned.

PS09 Open Session - Landscape

Session Chair: D. F. Ruggles, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Re-worlding the River and Its Dissonant Landscapes

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Abstract

In the South Asian context, top-down riverfront development discourse often reflects agendas of control—rationalizing, disciplining, and aestheticizing rivers through colonial and neoliberal planning frameworks. This paper focuses on the Ravi River in Lahore, Pakistan, to explore how such agendas threaten—and often erase—the embedded lives, memories, and practices of care enacted by the communities who inhabit and engage with the river's shifting ecologies. Historically framed as unruly and "dissonant," Ravi has been subject to repeated interventions that cast its uncertainty as a problem to be resolved—rendering its floodplains either as neglected wastelands or as sites for extractive development. Foregrounding oral histories, fieldwork, and archival material, this paper examines how marginalized communities residing along the river resist and re-narrate the Ravi through everyday entanglements—settlements, rituals, and adaptive practices—that counter dominant spatial imaginaries.

Drawing on Donna Haraway's concept of *re-worlding*, the paper reframes the river not as an object of control but as a living, relational landscape. These minor, often invisible practices of dwelling and remembering, constitute a vernacular politics of care—refusing erasure and reclaiming space through intimate, collective acts. By centering overlooked structures and local narratives, this paper contributes to a growing discourse on small spaces as sites of resistance and alternative world-making. It calls for a methodology that assembles fragmentary, embodied, and place-based knowledge—challenging inherited categories of nature, infrastructure, and architecture. Ultimately, this re-reading of River Ravi opens space for a decolonial perspective that reimagines rivers not as inert boundaries to be managed, but as dynamic thresholds between land and water—nurturing both human and more-than-human communities.

PS09 Open Session - Landscape

Session Chair: D. F. Ruggles, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Plants as Central Agents in the 'Wild Gardens' of Louis Le Roy

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Abstract

This paper takes a critical approach to the projects of the Dutch 'Wild Gardener' Louis Le Roy (1924-2012) who believed that the co-creation of green spaces by humans and other-than-humans would restore the culture-nature divide, and that a 'counterculture' of green spaces would combat the dominant monocultures that he considered, to be a symptom of technocratic, capitalist modes of space-production. Contrary to common (designer-led) practice, Le Roy's approach centered on plants and people as central agents. His projects for green spaces in residential areas were built by residents, creating topographies that allowed vegetation to develop independently after an initial collective planting and sowing effort. 'Gardening' thus became a collective action and a continuous process of interaction and negotiation between plants, soil and residents.

Our investigation into the agency of plants takes place on three different levels, with the aim of enriching existing methodologies for research into landscape design by taking the perspective of the plant. Firstly, through a combination of archival research and interviews, we trace the history of plant agency in the Lewenborg neighborhood of Groningen from its conception until today. In doing so, we expand existing modes of historical and ethnographic enquiry (focusing on the user, afterlives, etc.) into the realm of plants. Secondly, we trace how plants play a role in the reception of the work of Le Roy and discussions on landscape design. His 'letting things grow' approach and his tolerance of invasive species sparked debates and brought an explicit plant perspective to the 1960-70s' countercultures. Thirdly, we examine how Le Roy's ideas resonated internationally. He was a key figure in the ecological and participative turn in landscape design in Europe, inspiring projects that prioritized plants and people over experts in the design process. This approach made plants protagonists in challenging existing design and planning schemes.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

Smart City Data Catalogs and the Corporate Laminations of Territory

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Abstract

Smart city data catalogs suggest a novel form of deterritorialization. A burgeoning market sector, smart city data catalogs allow municipalities to share their metadata to a common repository that can be discovered, searched and filtered by a third party. For information to be brokered through these platforms, municipalities must engage with the somewhat difficult issue of user privacy, facilitating buy-in from smart city users to allow the sharing of their data.

When compared to the traditional notions of computational deterritorialization, smart city data catalogues frame a novel condition. While the flow of data across previously impervious boundaries reflect a traditional technoscape, there is a notable distinction regarding the questions of how the users of a smart city control these flows. The amount of control users have varies wildly, in many cases many are unaware their data is being shared and see little benefit in return. Smart city data catalogs suggest an increased interest in standardizing the monetization of these datasets, yet reflect little interest in standardizing data agency of users.

This paper leverages the work of Arjun Appadurai, Benjamin Bratton, Ash Amin, Nigel Thrift and Gilles Deleuze to frame computational deterritorialization, or technoscapes, and position smart city data catalogs relative to this framework. This paper ultimately argues that smart city data catalogs present a novel form of technoscape, one that should give municipalities pause before entering.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

Atmospheric Territories

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Abstract

This paper highlights how territorial reconfigurations attended the material transition of solid sulfur and liquid formaldehyde into insecticidal gases, following the expansion of U.S. interests in Cuba and Panama in the early decades of the 20th century. In the aftermath of the Spanish-American War in 1898, U.S. military personnel developed methods of fumigating buildings and landscapes in service of a colonial project that brought new epidemiological knowledge to bear on Latin American geographies. The discovery in 1901 of an exclusive vector for the transmission of yellow fever encouraged U.S. authorities in Cuba to pursue the systematic eradication of mosquitoes to protect people of European ancestry from tropical diseases. They then deployed fumigating technologies at scale in Panama, where insect-borne diseases had long frustrated construction of an isthmian canal. Drawing on maps, reports, and vital statistics, and employing Peter Sloterdijk's concept of "negative air-conditioning," I position fumigants as constituents of an anxious colonial enterprise and explore how they embedded wider territorial ambitions in urban, rural, and domestic spaces. Like the atmospheric weapons discussed by Sloterdijk, fumigants manipulate breathable air for destructive purposes, although in this case out of a paradoxical concern for the preservation of human health. Fumigants also acquire spatiality by virtue of their linked relationship to buildings. Like air conditioning, fumigants underline architecture's critical ability to envelop air, transforming its volume into a site for experimentation, and making architecture a tool with which to reassert control over tropical geographies and their people. Tracing the relationship of laboratory practices to invasive regimes of public health, I argue that fumigants operated as agents of colonization, allowing the reconfiguration of tropical territories through the medicalization of their topographies, landscapes, buildings, and people.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

Volcanoes and Imaginations of Territory in Central America, 1880s-1920s

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Abstract

The Central American Volcanic Arc is a chain of around fifty active volcanoes that extends for more than a thousand kilometers along the isthmus. While this volcanic chain has played a role in the history of cities, catastrophes and architectural adaptations in Central America, it has also shaped imaginations of territory in the region. In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the Guatemalan intellectual Antonio Batres Jáuregui produced a series of writings in which he recovered the natural and cultural history of Central America. Writing in a context marked by the global spread of nationalism, the imperial rise of the United States and by identity debates in Latin America, Batres Jáuregui sought, not only to trace the contours of Central America as a particular region within the American continent in geological, cultural and political terms, but also to highlight the significance of the region in terms of a broader universal history narrative. The volcanic chain played a key role in the imaginations of the Central American territory reflected in these writings. It informed Batres conceptions of Central America as a unit whose territory stretched between the continental masses of North and South America and between the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans because, thanks to changes in the geological knowledge of his time, he understood it to be the geological foundation of the isthmus and an actor in the formation of the continents, the oceans and the climate in general. Moreover, for Batres the volcanic chain was part of a patriotic imagination in which the isthmus was equated with the territory of the *patria*. Finally, Batres linked the volcanic chain not only to narratives about the past, but also to visions of the future in which the territory of Central America was expected to become a center of world trade.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

Islanding Empire: Architecture and Territorial Exception in Francoist Spain, 1962-1975

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Abstract

From the arrival in Hispaniola in 1492 to the relinquish of Cuba and the Philippines in 1898, islands have been the foundation of Spanish imperial rule: bounded, governable, and outpost of further extension. During the Francoist dictatorship (1939-1975), amid Cold War geopolitics and accelerating decolonization, the island reemerged not as geography but as architectural technique. This paper examines "islanding" as a strategy of territorial fragmentation facilitated by architecture that operated through material volumes, environmental control, and infrastructural density to create spaces of exception beyond conventional political boundaries in the rearticulation of a Spanish “minor empire:” an imperial enterprise without territorial expansion achieved through the spatial production of exception.. Between 1962 and 1975, the regime deployed islanding across the territory, this paper traces its deployment across four sites: the Bou Craa phosphate conveyor complex in Western Sahara (1962), modular settlements in Equatorial Guinea (1963), tourism infrastructure in the Canary Islands (1964), and Madrid's Casa de Campo Zoo (1972).

Islanding functioned through architecture's ability to mediate materiality and sovereignty: the concentrated tonnage of phosphate extraction, controlled densities of labor housing, atmospheric management of climate systems, and biological containment of species circulation. Through examination of unstudied drawings, engineering specifications, and administrative correspondence from AGA and INI collections, these sites constituted a coordinated network of spatial exceptions unified by common techniques of volumetric control. Drawing on Elden's volumetric approach and Billé's emphasis on the state's material presence (Elden 2013; Billé 2020), this investigation demonstrates how islanding enabled the regime to maintain imperial functions through architectural rather than territorial means. This analysis reveals imperial logics that would otherwise remain invisible, demonstrating how architectural operations mediated between imperial ambition and geopolitical constraint during decolonization, exposing the discipline's capacity to naturalize colonial relations within transformed material configurations and offering new insight into the spatial afterlives of empire.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

A Rarer Earth: Peat and the Politics of Legibility in Indonesia

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Abstract

In 1997–98, transboundary haze from a failed food estate project in Indonesia blanketed Southeast Asia, disrupting regional economies and releasing massive quantities of carbon into the atmosphere. Annual haze cycles have continued since, driving a shift in how tropical peatlands are valued and understood. The Indonesian government, along with international institutions such as the World Bank and the FAO, once framed tropical peatlands as agricultural frontiers and considered large-scale fires unlikely. Post-disaster, these same organizations have redefined peat in terms of its atmospheric toxicity. Technoscientific surveying technologies, including satellite imagery, LiDAR, GIS, and hydrological modeling, have rendered peatlands newly visible as carbon reservoirs and sites of environmental crisis.

This paper examines how these technologies have engaged with Indigenous knowledge, or "local knowledge," surrounding peat. Focusing on the Dayak Ngaju, it traces the shift from their term for peat, "sahep," to standardized categories of "peat" that operate within bureaucratic and scientific systems. After peatlands were mapped as digital models, new government regulations and rehabilitation programs followed, coordinating policy through these models. As global conservation frameworks positioned peatlands as sites requiring protection, they simultaneously displaced these existing communities' conceptions of peat and reshaped the conditions under which Indigenous communities could assert authority over land.

In contemporary Indonesia, "local knowledge" now circulates as a hybrid form of expertise, emerging through both perceptual awareness of the local surroundings and institutional teaching. Different Indigenous organizations have articulated divergent understandings of both "local knowledge" and "peat" since the disaster. Drawing on interviews with local scientists, farmers, and Indigenous activists, the paper challenges the notion of both "local knowledge" and "peat" as static, bounded concepts. Rather than treating Indigenous knowledge as a fixed repository of ecological wisdom, it argues that such knowledge is continually reconstituted through processes of classification and governance.

PS10 Territorial Reconfigurations: Volumes, Weights and States of Matter

Session Chair: Valeria Guzmán Verri, University of Costa Rica, Costa Rica

Volume of Land: Territorial Accounting in 19th-Century New South Wales

Samantha Rosner

University of Technology Sydney, Australia

Abstract

This paper will undertake a volumetric analysis of the Hunter River Valley in the British colony of New South Wales through a comparative study of two distinct types of landscape representation: the geologic section and the collector's chest. It aims to interrogate nineteenth-century systems of colonial-territorial accounting that exceeded the planar limits of the cadastral survey yet applied the same flattening effects to legitimize colonial claim to Indigenous Country. Both the geologic section and collector's chest adhered to the principles of natural history, understood as a colonial technique for the measurement, abstraction, and alienation of all dimensions of Indigenous land.

The late-eighteenth century witnessed the coincidence of the natural sciences and the invention of the steam engine. Both influenced the British invasion of the Hunter River Valley, which commenced in the 1790s following the accidental discovery of coal deposits on the river's floodplain. Core sampling, much like specimen collecting, aided in the generalization of territory and established a new, vertical dimension of vision that extends beyond the surface and sees into volumes of deep time. The resulting geologic section mapped subterranean coal seams and created a new, volumetric means of representing and evaluating the mineralogic potential of the Hunter River Valley. The collector's chest, an alluring container filled with brightly-coloured and painstakingly arranged specimens, also scoured Indigenous Country and replaced the relational with the categorical. As specimens were identified, their Indigenous names were overwritten, inducting the "exotic" into a system of epistemological domination to further secure the claim of Western scientific jurisdiction across the Australian territory

This paper explores volume through both its dimensional and epistemological meanings to ask how volumetric forms of mapping and categorizing land assisted in re-shaping the once dynamic Hunter River Valley—today home to the world's largest coal port—as an infrastructure for colonial desires.

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

Political Prisoners in the Revolutionary Republic

Diana J.S. Martinez

UC Berkeley, USA

Abstract

This paper analyzes and historically situates the *Carcel y Presidio,* a prison built by the Spanish Crown in Manila in 1865. Organized as a panopticon split into two — the *carcel* detained social offenders, while the *presidio* housed enemies of the state— separating a politically motivated population from a violent one.

Opening with a consideration of the social and political context that conditioned the prison's design, namely the unraveling of Spanish Empire and the liberal reforms associated with the rise of Spanish Republicanism, the paper turns to the building's spatial conversion during the US colonial period, beginning with the removal of the 4-meter-tall wall that separated the institution's two halves (following the release of the *presidio's* political prisoners by writ of *habeas corpus*). In the decade that followed the unification of the prison, re-christened by US colonizers as "Bilibid" (Tagalog for prison), it was transformed into a model industrial school and mustering site for a massive penal labor force employed to execute an ambitious, archipelago-wide public works program. I present the prison's unification not as an affirmation of due process, but rather as an attempt to supersede the legal and ideological contradictions of a revolutionary republic by treating political opposition as a trespass against common law. Insurrectionary 'behaviors,' W.H. Taft argued, could be corrected by imposing sentences of 10 years of hard labor to teach "the ignorant and easily led members of a community the difference between a political revolution and the crime of robbery."

I conclude by illustrating how the contradictions of a revolutionary republic are today projected onto territories of politicized jurisdiction (as demonstrated by the transportation of Mahmoud Khalil and Rumeysa Ozturk to Louisiana) and designed states of exception (as at Guantánamo where the US exercises "complete jurisdiction", or at CECOT where the US claims "zero jurisdiction").

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

Waqf and the Metaphysics of Jurisdiction

Yara Saqfalhait

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Abstract

Under Islamic law, *waqf* (Arabic for "to stop") is a category of non-alienable property that entails endowing rent-yielding land and/or roofed property to support the functioning of a pious or charitable beneficiary (schools, mosques, and hospitals to name a few). The endower of *waqf*, in principle, surrenders the ownership of the endowed assets to God in perpetuity. In the nineteenth-century Ottoman empire, the management of *waqfs* underwent a major transformation. Large scale sultanic endowments were gradually released from the eternal will of their founders to be administered according to the *İrades* (literally "will," used to denote imperial edicts) of the state.

This paper explores how architecture mediated this reconfiguration in *waqf* jurisdiction by focusing on the history of the *Hamidiye* endowment across the nineteenth century. Established by Sultan Abdulhamid I in 1781, the endowment consolidated properties dispersed across a massive geographic expanse. Its urban component comprised a building complex (*külliye*) constructed in Istanbul to provide subsistence, schooling, and edification to the pious. To finance the complex, the endowment consolidated farms, groves, vineyards, fisheries, and an ore mine – spread across multiple imperial provinces and local jurisdictions – under religious sanction. Following how jurisdictional conflicts between cultivators, state administrators, and endowment trustees unfolded spatially, I argue that incorporating *waqfs* into the uniform procedures of the administrative state did not amount to rationalizing their legal authority. Rather, as Ottoman administrators gradually evacuated God from property relations, the metaphysical aspect of *waqf* jurisdiction far from disappeared. Towards the end of the nineteenth-century, the inalienability of *waqf* properties was increasingly mobilized in a quest to secure Ottoman sovereignty against the incursions of various European state and private interests. This paper thus charts how theological notions of property got carried over to worldly, albeit metaphysical, notions of jurisdiction.

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

Para-Sovereignty: The Architecture of Australian Imperialism

Jasper Ludewig

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Abstract

This paper examines the role of the built environment in constructing Australian legal authority in the Pacific. It focuses on the shipping, logistics, and trading company, Burns Philp & Co.—known as "The Octopus of the North"—which established a sprawling infrastructural network in the Pacific Islands from the late 1800s on. Following the federation of the Australian nation-state in 1901, the company's Islands Department covertly operated as a proxy for the new national government, purchasing large swathes of plantation land in Melanesia and opening extensive industrial and trading facilities—funded by the state—to counter French and German influence in the region.

The paper argues that this close collaboration between a private company and the settler-colonial bureaucracy exemplifies the legal and political processes that sustained Australia's Pacific empire prior to World War One—a history long overlooked due to its legally diffuse, extraterritorial structure. The legal historian Cait Storr has argued that analysing such jurisdictional processes involves attending to the "thresholds across which the political becomes legal, and to the material forms those thresholds take" (2020: 16). As the case of Burns Philp & Co. reveals, in early-twentieth-century Melanesia, Australian jurisdiction was mediated by specific financial and legal instruments—the lease, the subsidy, and the share—that together secured para-sovereign control over Indigenous land and labour in lieu of formal colonisation or annexation.

The built environment also functioned as an important technology of legal presence in this context: the ferro-concrete wharves, prefabricated timber warehouses, and impressive regional headquarters erected by Burns Philp & Co. made legible an otherwise non-contiguous territory spread across Melanesia's myriad islands. The company's Australian architects, engineers, and building contractors were central to this endeavour, extending their professional authority into the Pacific and enacting the Australian Government's covert imperial jurisdiction in the process.

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

The Act and the Billboard: Land Acquisition in 1960s Nigeria

Ayala Levin

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Abstract

How does land become an object of possession, a territory with absolute boundaries? This paper explores the land acquisition process for the establishment of the International Institute of Tropical Agriculture (IITA) by the Rockefeller and Ford Foundations in Ibadan, Nigeria, in 1965-68. Historians have recently asserted that land does not precede architecture but is constituted by it through techniques such as surveying and enclosing (Allais 2023). As the case of the IITA demonstrates, however, these techniques were not immediately present as finite acts that established a before and after. Soon-to-be dispossessed villagers continuously contested and obstructed surveying and enclosing, either by organized resistance or relentless cultivation of crops on site.

At the IITA, like in many other recent histories of land grab in the global south, the transition from one form of jurisdiction (neo-costumery land tenure based on communal ownership) to another (state law based on western conceptions of land expropriation) was not clear-cut. It involved a heterogeneity of overlapping jurisdictions that the post-colonial state inherited from colonial rule's plural and fragmented jurisdiction. To counter villagers' resistance, the American foundations relied on a series of speech acts, starting with a Land Acquisition Act published in the federal Gazette, and followed by the erection of a fence and a billboard. The latter two were proposed by a Nigerian lawyer following local precedents as a provisional solution, with the recognition that the boundaries that they represent would be traversed perpetually, until buildings will be erected and crops planted as tangible proof of land use. In this paper, I will discuss the role the billboard played in respect to the Land Acquisition Act and the fence in relation to the various audiences they addressed, while highlighting the instability of these three media as markers of possession.

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

Illegal Architecture in He Sapa (Black Hills)

Jessica Garcia Fritz

University of Minnesota, USA

Abstract

The Architect, Contractor, Owner trifecta forms the contractual foundation of United States architectural practice. These relationships, standardized by the American Institute of Architects (AIA), trace to the 1888 Uniform Contract, which positioned the contractor as a builder on the owner's property under the architect's supervision. The contract emerged during rapid expansion of the U.S. nation-state in the nineteenth century, a period marked by land seizures, such as the 1877 Black Hills Act, which appropriated seven million acres of Oceti Sakowin Oyate (Sioux Nation) lands. In 1980, the U.S. Supreme Court deemed this act a theft, but no lands were returned. Financial compensation was refused by the Oyate and currently accumulates interests in a Bureau of Indian Affairs account. Despite the suspended and unresolved legal status of the land, construction in He Sapa (Black Hills) continues under an ownership model. The AIA's contracts continue to reflect this model, meaning the exceptional status of lands like He Sapa are not considered in the various document formats.

This paper analyzes AIA contract documents alongside the theft of He Sapa (Black Hills) and the Black Hills Sacred Landback Return Strategy to propose changes in the contract templates from transactional ownership toward indigenous stewardship models. The analysis primarily focuses on *AIA Document A201-2017 General Conditions of the Contract for Construction*, *AIA Document A503-2017-2019 Guide for Supplemental Conditions*, and *AIA Document A295-2008 General Conditions for Integrated Project Delivery*. All name a single entity as the owner of a project site. In contrast, the Oceti Sakowin Oyate (Sioux Nation), which includes Dakota, Lakota, and Nakota tiospayes (people) continues to challenge the notion of ownership in He Sapa (Black Hills) by collectively stewarding the lands. By aligning AIA contract documents with current Landback strategies, this paper strategizes new contract relations to support collective stewardship over transactional land ownership.

PS11 Architecture and Jurisdiction

Session Co-Chairs: Manuel Shvartzberg Carrió, University of California San Diego, USA, and Lisa Haber-Thomson, Mount Holyoke College, USA

Homes, Patents, and Modern Techniques of Counter-secularization: Architecture and Christian "Natural" Law

Maria Gonzalez Pendas

Cornell University, USA

Abstract

In December of 1933, architectural student Ricardo Vallespín and lawyer Josemaria Escrivá founded a private residence-academy to tutor university students. Secretive and set in an apartment in Madrid's city center, they named it *DYA*, for *Derecho y Arquitectura* (Architecture and the Law). Unofficially, they called it *Dios y Audacia* (God and Daring). Escrivá also happened to be a priest with visions to lead a Catholic revolution that would mean to the onwards march of secularization what the Jesuits had once meant to The Reformation. Only, as imagined at the *DYA*, this new global evangelization would be not in the hands of cross-yielding priests or sword-bearing crusaders but of suit-wearing experts—the architects, lawyers, but also scientists, engineers, and historians educated therein. The vision hinged on some radically conservative biopolitics and the severe, often bloody disciplining of these men's bodies, behaviors, and beliefs. In time, the *DYA* became *Opus Dei*, a conservative and controversial Catholic organization whose members, today, occupy some of the most influential posts of the ultra-right all over the world.

This paper historicizes the DYA in its foundation, arguing for the ways in which architecture and the law offered less a pool of students than the disciplinary confluence befitting its punishing regime of subjectivity; in a modern, secular version of monasticism a lot more religious and aesthetic than Michelle Foucault would later imagine. The paper will also wonder about the afterlife of the association between architecture, jurisprudence, and Christianity in the later work of one of the DYA's students, architect Miguel Fisac, who became renown in the 1950s and 1960s for his ingenious patents of concrete blocks, which he filed globally. How did Fisac's bone-looking, world-reaching patents—I will ask—tie architecture and Christian "natural" law? And how were they architectural legal alternatives to Opus Dei's evangelical agenda?

PS12 Women, Welfare, Labor: The Architecture of Philanthropy

Session Co-Chairs: Tara Bissett, University of Waterloo, Canada, and Maria Pía Montealegre Beach, Universidad de Chile, Chile

'And Thy Neighbor As Thyself': Atlanta's Neighborhood Union

Christina Crawford

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Abstract

In 1908, Lugenia Burns Hope and eight other prominent Black women on Atlanta's west side founded the Neighborhood Union (NU), a philanthropic social service organization that aimed to "co-operate with one another for the best interests of the community, city, and race" and which took at its motto "and thy neighbor as thyself."[1] This paper focuses on the NU's interventions into the built environment of Atlanta's Black neighborhoods, where they invoked a "politics of respectability" to educate and elevate African Americans on the lower rungs of the social hierarchy.[2] A taxonomy of NU programs includes playgrounds, health clinics, orphanages, and schools. Yet despite their philanthropic reach, the NU's architectural footprint was light: the Neighborhood House clinic, the Leonard Street Orphan Home, and the Chadwick Home and School all fitted into modest preexisting wooden structures that leave little trace. I argue, however, that the NU's early efforts to understand their constituents' programmatic and spatial needs enabled them to participate in architectural design discussions for University Homes, the first fully federally funded public housing for African Americans in the US built in their service area in 1937. Archival documentation reveals that in the years leading to the US New Deal the women of the NU surveyed their neighborhoods, established strict moral (often highly judgmental) standards for their community, and ultimately successfully advocated for dedicated socio-educational spaces in the US's first housing project for Black Americans. In the eyes of the housing architects, the women's local expertise trumped their gender.

[1] "Neighborhood Union Brochure, 1911". Neighborhood Union Collection. Atlanta University Center Robert W. Woodruff Library. http://hdl.handle.net/20.500.12322/auc.050:0210.

[2] Evelyn Brooks Higginbotham, *Righteous Discontent: The Women's Movement in the Black Baptist Church, 1880–1920* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1993), chap. 7.

PS12 Women, Welfare, Labor: The Architecture of Philanthropy

Session Co-Chairs: Tara Bissett, University of Waterloo, Canada, and Maria Pía Montealegre Beach, Universidad de Chile, Chile

Other Domesticities: Over-Amstel Penitentiary by Pot & Pot-Keegstra (1967–1978)

Elena Martínez-Millana

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Abstract

This paper explores other domesticities by critically examining the design of the Over-Amstel Penitentiary Institution in Amsterdam, commonly known as the 'Bijlmerbajes' (1967–1978). It was primarily designed by the Dutch architect Jacoba Froukje (Koos) Pot-Keegstra (1908–1997), who ran the Pot & Pot-Keegstra architectural firm together with her husband, Johan Willem Hindrik Cornelis (Jop) Pot (1909–1972). She entered the profession at a time when it was rare for women to do so, being the first woman to graduate from the Amsterdam Academy of Architecture (1936), and arguably, the first woman to design a prison.

From the beginning of their practice, Pot & Pot-Keegstra specialized in designing housing for 'target groups' of people who live alone in collective arrangements—such as single women, older adults, and youth—beyond the predominant 'nuclear families'. The design of housing for prisoners represented the culmination of their career-long focus on non-family collective living and reflected a broader debate about what housing is—the extent to which domestic services can be shared. This theme has not received sufficient attention in architectural historiography, and there remains a need to trace the evolution of the meaning and form of housing the 'other'.

The 'Bijlmerbajes' was designed when the Netherlands was at the forefront of rethinking how prisoners should be housed in more humane conditions, serving as an outstanding example of the implementation of postwar penitentiary policies. However, even before the opening of this high-rise prison—the largest by the Government Building Agency—it had faced criticism from both the public and specialists, as well as numerous protests. Its demolition (2020), except for the tower that housed women prisoners, comes as no surprise. This paper seeks to preserve its legacy by discussing key aspects of the design that shaped the lives of the prisoners.

PS12 Women, Welfare, Labor: The Architecture of Philanthropy

Session Co-Chairs: Tara Bissett, University of Waterloo, Canada, and Maria Pía Montealegre Beach, Universidad de Chile, Chile

Women Writing Welfare Architecture in 1940s Turkey

Ipek Mehmetoglu

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Abstract

This paper investigates women's philanthropic labor in shaping modern architecture in Turkish print culture. It interrogates how women philanthropists experienced and wrote about architecture within the political context of 1940s Turkey—a decade marked by the transition from a single-party rule to a multi-party democracy and continued state-led modernization on the one hand, and an alleged "invisibility" of women's movements on the other. It focuses on the feminist *Women's Newspaper*, one of the longest-running women's publications in the history of journalism in Turkey (1947-1979). In its search for gendered interpretations of modern architecture and its place in everyday life, "Women Writing Welfare Architecture" underlines the social and political nuances embedded in local stories. It highlights non-architect women's knowledge and legacy of social and spatial change in a situated way.

The *Newspaper* was a public platform where a knitted community of politicized women with a collective, yet diversified voice addressed topics from politics to culture to urbanism. In particular, the texts of Hasene Ilgaz and Iffet Halim Oruz reveal distinctive voices, engaging with the design and construction of various welfare projects as part of the country's modernization efforts. Drawing on the *Newspaper*, archival documents, photographs, and architectural plans, I argue that the modern architecture of the 1940s in Turkey relied on a wide range of gendered work that remains at the margins of architectural histories. Women's collective labor at the intersection of architecture, welfare, and journalism constituted a vital yet invisible infrastructure of modern life during the developmental phase of the Republic.

PS12 Women, Welfare, Labor: The Architecture of Philanthropy

Session Co-Chairs: Tara Bissett, University of Waterloo, Canada, and Maria Pía Montealegre Beach, Universidad de Chile, Chile

Marie Stopes' Architecture of Family Planning

Emma Cheatle

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Abstract

This paper explores the British 'family planning movement', offering a combinatory socio-architectural history of the buildings, spaces and urban networks instigated by activist Marie Stopes (1880–1958). In the first decades of the twentieth century—continuing the legacy of nineteenth-century women physicians such as Elizabeth Garrett Anderson, and intersecting the advocacy of Margaret Sanger in the US and Jeanne Humbert in France—British feminists developed community associations to focus on birth control and women's health. Their initiatives, ephemeral and fragmented, were ignored by the mainstream medical profession and media. In 1921, Stopes materially established the family planning movement by opening two Mothers' Clinics in Victorian houses in working class areas of London. The rooms had plain, 'homely' interiors to 'reassure' patients. In 1925, to reach areas of Britain that had little formal healthcare, Stopes redesigned two Romani caravans as 'Caravan Clinics', which from 1927–31 delivered local contraceptive services and education. Stopes, though, remains a problematic figure. Although fundamental to the global reproductive movement, her eugenicist beliefs included limiting procreation rates for certain demographics, opposition to abortion and support for enforced sterilisation. Stopes was instrumental to the British welfare state's adoption of family planning, yet influential in its embedded racism, ableism, and nuclear family structures.

The paper has several intersecting aims: to present a critical socio-architectural history of Stopes' birth control clinics as built forms, domestic interiors and urban networks; to unearth and narrate the experiences of women who used them; and to understand the ways in which Stopes' eugenicist philanthropy skewed reproductive politics and inflicted harm. In doing so, I re-evaluate the history of family planning to demonstrate the ways in which architecture, materiality and spatial design were not just integral to delivering reproductive rights but shaped its social and political outcomes.

PS12 Women, Welfare, Labor: The Architecture of Philanthropy

Session Co-Chairs: Tara Bissett, University of Waterloo, Canada, and Maria Pía Montealegre Beach, Universidad de Chile, Chile

Building Containment: Women's Welfare in the Spanish Colonies

Sol Pérez Martínez

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Abstract

Catholic nuns and religious laywomen played a central, yet overlooked, role in the urban development of the Spanish colonies in South America. Since their arrival in the Viceroyalty of Peru in 1538, female religious orders and their communities developed spaces that contained women who married God –becoming nuns– or those who failed to marry a man – falling outside of the two socially acceptable paths for Catholic women at the time. As historian Nancy Van Deusen explains, the religious concept of 'recogimiento' (containment) regulated the lives of women in the Spanish Empire between the 16th and 18th centuries, controlling their spiritual, physical and social lives (Van Deusen, 2007). Established by the priest Francisco de Osuna in the 1530s, the separation of women from the chaos of the world became a central catholic virtue in the same decade as the colonization of Peru (Osuna, 1531). In this paper, I trace how the transculturation (Ortiz, 1940) of the religious and gendered idea of women's containment shaped the built environment of South America by replicating the form of the cloister and adapting it to the convents, shelters and houses in the colonial territories. In this context, religious women provided a haven or enforced shelter to house widows, single women, repentants, and others who fell outside the categories of wife or nun. Using conventual and colonial archival records, I demonstrate how women actively participated in the foundation, construction and management of these architectures for the social care of women. This paper examines built examples of women's welfare in the Spanish colonies to argue that the concept of female containment is relevant to the histories of welfare and architecture. Sometimes forced and others voluntary, women enforced or subverted containment to build worlds of their own, creating cities of women within the cities of men.

PS13 Modern Interiors in Mexico and Beyond

Session Co-Chairs: Aldo Solano Rojas, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico

Transculturation in Colombian Modern Interiors

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Abstract

During the "golden years" of Colombian modernism (1950s), interior design was largely overlooked in architectural discourse and media. *Proa*, the leading architectural magazine founded in 1946, only began addressing interiors in 1952 through selective articles on furniture and design. It was not until the emergence of *Revista A* in the mid-1950s that a more sustained interest in interior design and modern furniture started to surface across the national editorial landscape. Even today, studies on Colombian interiors and furniture design remain fragmented, and the topic is generally underexplored. Nevertheless, the lack of an explicit discourse did not imply that interiors were disregarded by Colombian architects of the era.

This paper conducts a systematic study of upper-scale residential interiors featured in *Proa* and *Revista A* magazines between 1946 and 1963, along with the two editions of the books *Arquitectura en Colombia* (1951 and 1963), aiming to uncover the implicit discourse on modern living constructed by Colombian architects—many of whom were educated in the United States. By analyzing elements such as material choices for interior finishes, the incorporation of vegetation, and the selection of iconic imported or locally produced furniture, we explore how modern interiors reflected both global modernist aspirations and local conditions.

We argue that Colombian architects often created interiors that appeared decontextualized, eschewing overtly local references in favor of aligning with North American aesthetic models. Yet paradoxically, aspects such as spatial organization, light modulation, and the use of locally crafted furniture frequently revealed engagement with and adaptations to Colombian social habits, cultural conditions, local climates, and the availability of specific furniture pieces that re-contextualized these designs. These ambiguities, we contend, reflect processes of transculturation, in which international models were filtered and selectively adapted.

PS13 Modern Interiors in Mexico and Beyond

Session Co-Chairs: Aldo Solano Rojas, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico

Crafting Modern Interiors: Arquitectura [Mexico] Magazine (1938–1951)

Ana Marianela PORRAZ CASTILLO

ENSA-Versailles, France

Abstract

This lecture explores the role of architect Mario Pani Darqui and his professional network as cultural intermediaries among France, Europe, the United States of America, and Mexico. It highlights the editorial work of Arquitectura [Mexico] magazine during its first thirteen years (1938–1951), particularly focusing on the representation of interior spaces.

Founded in 1938, Arquitectura [Mexico] served as a platform for documenting and promoting modern architecture. Initially, the magazine emphasized international architectural trends but gradually shifted its focus to include a growing number of Mexican projects, reflecting the country's burgeoning architectural scene. This shift underscored the team editorial commitment to showcasing local talent and integrating Mexican architectural identity into the global modernist narrative.

The magazine featured modern interiors that were not merely functional spaces but also expressions of aesthetic innovation and cultural identity. It presented the projects of architects such as José Villagrán García, Vladimir Kaspé, Enrique de la Mora, and Luis Barragán, as well as interior designers like Clara Porset, Gaston Chaussat and Arturo Pani Jr. These contributions illustrated the diverse approaches to modern interior design in Mexico, blending international influences with local materials and techniques.

Through specific case studies from the magazine, this lecture demonstrates how interiors were crafted to construct modern representations for a Mexican audience. These images also reveal the cultural exchanges, translations, and adaptations of international trends within the Mexican context, reflecting the dynamic interplay between global modernism and local identity.

Arquitectura [Mexico] played a significant role in shaping the architectural discourse in Mexico, serving as a vital resource for architects, designers, artists and scholars. The magazine's documentation of modern interiors and its commitment to high-quality graphic content have made it a tool for understanding the evolution of Mexican architecture and design in the first half of the twentieth century.

PS13 Modern Interiors in Mexico and Beyond

Session Co-Chairs: Aldo Solano Rojas, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico

Designing for Bureaucracy: DM Nacional's Furniture for Mexico's Ministry of Communications and Public Works (SCOP, 1955) and Its Everyday Use

Francisco Esteban Alvarado Carrasco

El Colegio de México, Mexico

Abstract

On June 20, 1955, a questionnaire was distributed among directors and department heads of the Secretariat of Communications and Public Works (SCOP). This questionnaire, focused on the benefits of relocating to the new SCOP center, contained 15 questions concerning various aspects of daily life within the recently inaugurated architectural complex. Notably, department heads were asked to assess whether there were "improved working conditions in terms of equipment, furniture, and supply of materials." This inquiry was pertinent because, concurrently with the building's inauguration, new furniture—ranging from filing cabinets to drafting tables, desks, and chairs—had been provided.

This paper aims to reconstruct the ideas behind the conception of the SCOP's furniture, which was commissioned from the company DM Nacional. It will contrast these original design intentions with the testimonies of the secretariat's workers regarding their use of the furniture. The objective is to establish a dialogue about the everyday life of this furniture and its perceived success or failure. Furthermore, this research seeks to generate an open and constructive debate on the furniture's functionality, ergonomics, and adaptability to employees' needs—including a preliminary consideration of whether its design and distribution mirrored or reinforced hierarchical distinctions among personnel—offering a perspective that is not always predominant when discussing furniture: that of the end-user.

PS13 Modern Interiors in Mexico and Beyond

Session Co-Chairs: Aldo Solano Rojas, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico

Domestic Synthesis: Art in Modern Mexican Interiors

Rodrigo Torres Ramos

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Abstract

While monumental projects such as Ciudad Universitaria or Centro S.C.O.P. have long defined the canonical image of artistic integration in Mexican modernism, this paper turns to the domestic interior as an alternative site of experimentation. In contrast to state-sponsored initiatives shaped by ideological agendas, private residences allowed for greater flexibility in the collaboration between architects and artists, producing interiors where aesthetic ambition intersected with everyday life.

This study examines a selection of domestic projects developed between the 1940s and 1970s by four central figures of Mexican modern architecture: Mario Pani, Enrique Yáñez, Manuel Rossen, and Augusto H. Álvarez. Their residential commissions, executed for a variety of clients, incorporated murals, reliefs, built-in furnishings, and custom finishes created in partnership with artists such as Carlos Mérida, Xavier Guerrero, and Herbert Hoffman Ysenbourg. These collaborations, often underdocumented in the architectural record, reveal a sustained pursuit of the total work of art expressed within the intimate scale of the home.

Drawing on unpublished archival sources, architectural drawings, and photographs, the paper proposes a revision of the narrative surrounding *integración plástica* (synthesis of the arts) in Mexico. Rather than framing it exclusively as a monumental, state-oriented endeavor, the integration of the arts is reconsidered here as a practice grounded in aesthetic freedom, material experimentation, and personal expression. This reframing not only complicates the established narrative of modernism but also positions the domestic interior as a critical locus for negotiating and embodying modern ideals. In doing so, the paper contributes to a broader understanding of how art and architecture together shaped the lived experience of modernity in Mexico.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Geoarchitectures: "A Flicker in the Life-History of the Earth"

Clemens Finkelstein

Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich, Germany

Abstract

Once dismissed as an obstacle to precise scientific observation, vibration emerged in the late nineteenth century as a vital epistemic tool in modern geophysics. This paper explores how vibration, despite becoming more extreme and pervasive as an artificially engendered environmental phenomenon in industrialized societies at the turn of the twentieth century, evolved into a fundamental geoscientific instrument closely tied to architectural design. As geoscientists increasingly sought to uncover Earth's material composition, accurately measured intensities, frequencies, and temporal aspects of terrestrial quakes provided essential empirical insights. Geophysicists eventually leveraged the vibrational sensitivity of the ground and architecture into a globally networked system of seismic observatories, collectively striving toward a comprehensive "seismic survey of the world." This paper focuses on the Royal Observatories in Potsdam, Germany, where astronomer-cum-geophysicist Ernst von Rebeur-Paschwitz recorded the teleseismic aftermath of the 1889 Tokyo earthquake, which kickstarted the meteoric rise of imperial German geosciences. It examines the subsequent advent of specialized architectural techniques and forms designed to capture humanly imperceptible microseismic vibrations that traced the scale of invisible, inaccessible planetary space. Scale-making and space-making, thus, coalesced as tectonically mediated by instrumental architectures that enacted complex design techniques to differentiate obstructive from constructive vibrations, twinning epistemic space as linked interior planetary space and interior architectural space. Prussian geophysicist Oscar Hecker's innovative "earthquake house," conceived in 1896 as a modest, purpose-built hut, exemplifies an early materialization of architecture tailored to isolate, record, and analyze planetary vibrations. Drawing on original archival research, this study situates Potsdam's architectural innovations—from subterranean pendulum chambers at the Deep Well Observatory to hybrid natural-built twin structures nestled in the earthly ground—within broader narratives of epistemological and architectural evolution. Moving beyond conventional narratives of earthquake-resistant design, this paper illustrates architecture's formative role in shaping modern geoscientific inquiry.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Malcolm Wells' Underground: Building Downwards, Failing Upwards

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Abstract

In a letter to supporters in 2011, the Underground Art Gallery in Brewster, Massachusetts lamented that, "unfortunately, the gallery has developed some serious leaks," which they described as, "really just a detailing problem," failing to protect the structure from tree roots, termites, and ants. The gallery was designed by architect Malcolm Wells who, in 1964, began transitioning his successful practice designing and constructing above-ground buildings to one that advocated for what he called "underground architecture". Inspired in part by an emerging building science discourse, Wells spent the latter years of his career grappling with the real implications of going underground: vapor permeance and permeability, hydrostatic pressure, natural light, pest control and the slow creep of technological progress. Beyond the technical implications of building underground, Wells' decision came with a number of repercussions. His underground practice risked criticism from "some architects who, misunderstanding it, fear[ed] it will create a kind of nonarchitecture," negating one of the primary tasks of the architect: the creation of visible, well-articulated forms. More importantly, through the act of embedding structures within the earth, Wells challenged prevailing building culture, finding ways to produce, "the next architecture of America," while heeding the imperatives of an environmental age.

This paper will consider three of Wells' projects: his own Wells' Architectural Office (1975), an earth-sheltered building in the Philadelphia suburbs, the Cary Arboretum Plant Science Building (1977), an ambitious institutional work completed to varying degrees of success, and the still operational Underground Art Gallery (1988). These projects, and their documentation, illustrate Wells' ability to juggle hopes for an ethical practice and the realities of industry and material production. Through review of Wells' far-reaching correspondence, countless articles, drawings, and manifestos, this paper intends to situate Wells' development of an underground architecture as an open-source, public research project unafraid of failure.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Rockwork: Fabricating Landscapes in Nineteenth-Century Paris and Mexico City

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Abstract

In the late nineteenth century, monumental artificial rock formations—grottoes, cliffs, and cascades—became prominent features of public parks from France to Latin America. Though compared to mountain scenery and subterranean wonders, these structures were in fact hand-fabricated "rockwork"—assemblages of rubble, cement, and concrete superimposed onto existing topographies. Not merely ornamental, artificial rockwork was a medium for physically and symbolically reconfiguring ground in modernizing cities.

This paper focuses on two parks where rockwork played a significant role: Paris' Parc des Buttes-Chaumont (1867) and Mexico City's Bosque de Chapultepec (renovated 1895–1910). It argues that rockwork emerged not primarily from aesthetic concerns, but from technical ones. A byproduct of land surveys and infrastructure construction, its rubble armature was the detritus of volumetrically calculated earthworks, while its revetments were experimental applications of cement and concrete. In Paris, during Baron von Haussmann's extensive renovations, rockwork structures showcased the capacity of the authoritarian central government to spectacularly reshape exhausted terrains such as the former quarries of the Buttes-Chaumont. Decades later, in Mexico City, President Porfirio Diaz' technocratic advisors conspicuously implemented concrete rockwork at the Bosque de Chapultepec as they used the same materials in the capital's massive drainage project. Examining public responses to these rockwork landscapes, this paper resituates the transformation of modern urban space in the materiality, technics, and aesthetics of fabricated terrains.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Earthen Architectures of Power: Adobe and the Politics of Place at Huaca Colorada and Tecapa (Jequetepeque, Peru, 600-900 CE)

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Abstract

In a desert *pampa* on the North Coast of Peru, the adobe complexes of Huaca Colorada and Tecapa stand just two kilometers away from each other as opposing propositions of power articulated through the built environment. Both centers were built and inhabtited between 600 and 900 CE, when the North Coast was largely controlled by the Moche, a coastal Andean polity who navigated authority through habitual renovation of elaborate pyramids. Though contemporaneous and geographically close, the sites diverge in their design, construction, and materiality. In this paper, I examine these differences by positioning the earth itself as an archive: through adobe, shifting political relationships between the sites' occupants and their ecology are made legible in architecture, revealing how power was materially inscribed in the landscape.

At Huaca Colorada, an earthen pyramid, sundried bricks were hand-formed and embedded with shell, ceramic, and fibers--inclusions that encapsulate natural resources and cultural practice. Walls bear handprints and tactie marks, layered in episodic rebuilding events characteristic of Moche architectural ceremony, where construction was communal, rhythmic, and shaped by ritual cycles. Tecapa, by contrast, was built with standardized molded bricks, forming tall perimeter walls that enclose space in gridded form. Aligned with the Pampa's main canal, and possibly incorporating silt from its cleanings, Tecapa's construction was centralized and completed in a single phase—asserting control through uniformity and its embedded relationship to water infrastructure.

This paper reads these architectural centers as materially grounded expressions of competing political visions. Drawing on architectural and geoarchaeological data collected across the two complexes, I argue that their architectural and material differences reflect contrasting modes of engaging with the earth, the environment, and the politics of place. This frames Tecapa as the work of a highland polity intruding into the coastal Moche sphere, reshaping local practices and redefining relationships to earth.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Aeolian Ground: Transimperial Geology and the Architecture of Loess in China

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Abstract

What if the story of vernacular architecture in China begins not with local tradition, but with the winds of empire and the epistemic instruments of imperial geology? Ferdinand von Richthofen, the German geologist later credited with popularizing the term "Silk Road," began his career in California, where geological knowledge was inseparable from mining interests, railroad expansion, and the exploitation of Chinese immigrant labor. Between 1868 and 1872, sponsored by the Bank of California and the Anglo-American Chamber of Commerce in Shanghai, he conducted extensive surveys across China, producing knowledge that would not only inform Germany's colonial ambitions in Kiautschou Bay but also reconfigure the spatial and epistemic foundations of the earth sciences.

Situating Richthofen's loess research within the intertwined histories of colonial expansion, extractive infrastructures, and the professionalization of geology, this paper argues that his American experiences in the mining frontiers of the western United States shaped a form of transimperial geology. Techniques, concepts, and modes of perception forged in the context of settler colonialism were redeployed in China, where local agricultural knowledge was extracted, translated, and formalized into scientific theory. Through this process, Richthofen's aeolian theory of loess elevated the atmosphere as a primary geological agent, linking China to Central Asia within a world-historical framework of climatic change and wind-borne sedimentation.

Meanwhile, the sensorial experience of loess—its overwhelming scale, its dust that clouded vision, its pervasive yellowness—blurred the boundary between geological description and racialized perception. Through Richthofen, loess emerged as the "geological foundation of Chinese life" and drifted into architectural discourse, most notably in the work of Bernard Rudofsky. By tracing this transimperial genealogy, the paper argues that the category of vernacular architecture, particularly in the case of loess cave dwellings, was historically produced through the transnational circulation of geological knowledge, imperial power, and Eurocentric historiography.

PS14 Earthwork: From the Ground to Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Katerina Bong, University of Toronto, Canada, and Anna Renken, University of Toronto, Canada

Redeeming Wasteland: Willis Polk's Bourn House

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Abstract

The use of waste rock from mining as a construction material is not new, but examples by well known architects have received little attention by architectural historians. This paper explores one such structure: the Bourn House in Grass Valley, California, designed in 1898 by the prominent San Francisco-based architect Willis Polk for mining and water magnate William Bourn II. Built with rubble masonry walls composed of tailings from the nearby Empire Mine—one of the most productive gold mines in California history—the house embodies the transformation of geological detritus into elite architecture.

Resembling a rustic yet refined manor house and set within formal gardens also designed by Polk, the cottage served as part-time residence for the Bourn family, but its location on the grounds of the mine meant that it also functioned as a setting for dealmaking and business. Bourn could meet with investors at the cottage within a few hundred feet from where crews of Cornish workers toiled deep underground. Like a plantation house and its surrounding landscape, the Bourn cottage and its environs present a stark conjunction of consumption and extraction. This contrast is expressed materially in the rock walls of the house, which transformed ground into architecture, redeeming mining waste by rendering it both useful and ornamental.

This paper focuses on the treatment of the ground across three intertwined spheres of labor: extraction (mining), construction (stone setting), and cultivation (planting). These activities exemplify the interrelated modes of human engagement with the earth as resource, datum for building, and redemptive picturesque landscape. Together, they represent attempts to grapple with the ecological implications of mining and its residues. Rather than presenting a reconciled image of nature and industry, the Bourn House and its grounds offers an opportunity to explore the contradictions at the heart of extractive ecologies.

PS15 Architecture Against Empire in the Early Modern Atlantic World

Session Co-Chairs: Lorenzo Gatta, University College London, United Kingdom, and Harvey Shepherd, The Courtauld Institute of Art, United Kingdom

Hybridity as Resistance at San Miguel el Arcángel in Huejotzingo

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Abstract

Colonial Mexico's fortresses, like San Juan de Ulúa, and the numerous fortress monasteries of Central Mexico, are often described in scholarship as Europeanate and intentionally hegemonic constructions. While these structures can certainly be read as physical and symbolic manifestations of Spanish Christian power in the Americas, such an interpretation, although not wholly inaccurate, is incomplete. I argue that we can better understand these structures when we acknowledge their stylistic and architectural hybridity, subsequent polysemy, and cultural relevance. Through recognition of their multivalence, opportunities are created to challenge the colonial matrix of power. In so doing, I offer new insights into defensive and militaristic architecture as a form of resistance and a manifestation of the social and political complexities of its period.

Considering the fortress monastery of San Miguel el Arcángel in Huejotzingo as a case study, in this paper, I examine building techniques and materials used, labor systems, and painted and sculptural imagery to illuminate the extent to which this structure is a space of resistance where power and identity were actively being negotiated in the sixteenth century.

This approach creates a decolonial avenue for understanding defensive and militaristic architecture in Spanish America more broadly, which is important because such architecture is rarely analyzed from the perspective of those who were not victorious in the conflicts that were associated with such buildings. In applying a decolonial lens in this study, I strive to further the efforts of current scholarship in the field of Latin American architectural history to elevate Indigenous knowledge, and in this case, the Indigenous building traditions and iconography that preceded and subsequently coincided with the Spanish occupation of the Americas, with the ultimate objective of re-envisioning of the history of military and militaristic architecture in this region from the perspective of the Global South.

PS15 Architecture Against Empire in the Early Modern Atlantic World

Session Co-Chairs: Lorenzo Gatta, University College London, United Kingdom, and Harvey Shepherd, The Courtauld Institute of Art, United Kingdom

Shell Ridges, River Lobes: Edgewaters in the Colonial Gulf South

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Abstract

This paper reconceptualizes architecture in the early modern Atlantic World by examining edgewater territoriality in the ecologically dynamic landscapes of the colonial Gulf South. In fluid terrains near the Mississippi River Delta, Indigenous communities such as Chitimacha, Tunica, and Ishak developed spatial strategies that challenged imperial ambitions — not through monumental architecture, but via traditional environmental knowledge and familiarity with edgewaters. This paper examines how Native groups of so-called petits nations mobilized actively changing river lobes, bayous, and ancestral mound sites in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.

I draw on eighteenth-century French and Spanish colonial maps, archaeological evidence of mound reuse, and Indigenous origin stories—such as the Ishak tales of a turtle fashioning land from watery mud, or the Choctaw Nanih Waiya ancestral mound — to argue for a broader understanding of architecture as spatial imaginary. These narratives and geographies formed what I term edgewater territoriality: a mode of spatial ordering that used wetlands, flood cycles, and tributaries in ways that are present, but imperfectly visible, in imperial cartography that sought territorial fixity and legibility. Rather than studying fixed architecture, this paper seeks to understand edgewater territoriality: a mode of spatial ordering centered on ecological flux and relational practices.

Along the river delta and gulf coast, water itself was infrastructure—supporting mobility, subsistence, and political autonomy. By justaposing evidence of Native-occupied shell ridges, natural levees, and river tributaries with practices of imperial mapping, I show occupation and adaptations of microtopographies within wetlands by both Native and European groups. In foregrounding deltaic spatial practices over monumental architecture, this paper intervenes in broader Atlantic World histories of anti-imperial placemaking. Here, Indigenous responses to colonialism are not reactive or symbolic, but are discernible in place-based knowledge systems as enduring forms of relationality.

PS15 Architecture Against Empire in the Early Modern Atlantic World

Session Co-Chairs: Lorenzo Gatta, University College London, United Kingdom, and Harvey Shepherd, The Courtauld Institute of Art, United Kingdom

"Palmares, an Architecture of Ecology against Empire"

David Sadighian

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Abstract

This paper revisits the ephemeral architecture of Palmares (c.1605–1694)—the largest and most enduring maroon settlement of colonial-era Brazil—not only as a site of fugitivity, but also as a deliberate form of ecological resistance to plantation capitalism. Architectural history privileges values of monumental permanence, archival legibility, and formal innovation. By contrast, the botanical structures of Palmares—comprising thatched dwellings made from palm fronds, woven fibers, and other forest materials—embodied impermanence and artisanal continuity across African and Indigenous traditions facing the threat of imperial violence.

Foregrounding spatial practices often dismissed as unskilled and ad hoc, this paper argues that the architecture of Palmares enacted an anti-colonial logic: one that resisted the gridded geometries and extractive systems of plantation space. Drawing on textual sources, archaeological findings, and fieldwork in Pernambuco, this research will demonstrate how Palmares's vegetal materiality functioned not only as shelter but as a political ecology—one that subverted the settler-plantation's regimes of property, forced labor, and environmental control.

What emerges from this research is a speculative and counter-monumental approach to histories of the colonial built environment, particularly in contexts where architectural evidence is deliberately erased or not meant to endure. Palmares prompts us to reconsider disciplinary biases: What counts as architecture in architectural histories of resistance? How do we write spatial histories from absence, transience, and escape? Ultimately, then, in proposing Palmares as a site of ecological insurgency, this paper advocates for a perspective that includes fugitive, vegetal, and elusive spatialities—central not only to Afro-Brazilian resistance but to the environmental counter-histories of the Americas.

PS15 Architecture Against Empire in the Early Modern Atlantic World

Session Co-Chairs: Lorenzo Gatta, University College London, United Kingdom, and Harvey Shepherd, The Courtauld Institute of Art, United Kingdom

Counter Construction: Violence and Settlement in French Louisiana

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Abstract

In April of 1730, a man based in Kaskaskias, Illinois wrote a letter to a colleague in New Orleans, a town that was the French colonial capital of the Louisiana territory. Today, four words stand out on the page: “Je suis très mortifié” (“I am extremely humiliated”). Why was this man so humiliated? One possibility is that he felt reduced to a diminutive position because life on the frontier was dangerous and unstable. Indigenous groups, many of whom were never allied with the French, gave colonizers a precarious experience. On November 29, 1729, nearly five months before the aforementioned colonizer penned his letter, the Natchez Indians attacked the French outpost of Natchez and killed almost every European settler. This paper uses colonial accounts composed in the aftermath of the Natchez Rebellion to craft a history of indigenous counter construction: a story of the work that native populations performed to render colonial settlement frightening and precarious for Europeans. By attacking French settlements, indigenous groups like the Natchez determined where the French could and could not settle while also shaping their feelings about life in North America. Usually, when historians discuss the architecture of French Louisiana, they focus on standing buildings and urban plans (Edwards, 1994; Edwards, 2011; Dawdy, 2008). This paper argues that frantic letters from outlying settlements reveal a native architecture of resistance. Colonial settlement reached its geographical limits and achieved its geographical orientation in response to the strength of indigenous armies. They shaped the physical and psychological dimensions of colonial settlement. This paper presents an architectural history of anti-colonial violence against French buildings and towns in eighteenth-century Louisiana. Hence, it proposes a model for how to extract histories of indigenous agency and resistance from the colonial architectural archive.

PS15 Architecture Against Empire in the Early Modern Atlantic World

Session Co-Chairs: Lorenzo Gatta, University College London, United Kingdom, and Harvey Shepherd, The Courtauld Institute of Art, United Kingdom

Pastoral Urbanism in West Africa: the City of Sokoto Circa 1809

Alican Taylan

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Abstract

Located on formerly open green fields in present-day northern Nigeria, the city of Sokoto emerged in the early nineteenth century as the capital of the eponymous empire founded in 1804 by a network of sheiks committed to promoting Muslim piety. Sokoto was nonetheless unlike other empires. The city did not send out officials to govern different parts under its imperial rule. It did not function as the seat of a centralized governance apparatus but was more akin to a confederation (Last 2013, 10).

Although conceived as a rural town that eschewed worldly aspirations, Sokoto rapidly developed into a commercial hub integrated into the Atlantic world's trade network. The city was noted for its precisely laid streets and vast green expanses (Clapperton 1828, 377). Drawing on new British archival documents, travel narratives, and vernacular architectural studies, this paper traces how Hausa-Fulani pastoralists translated Sahelian mobile mat-frame tent construction into a sedentary vaulted mud-arch technology, yielding large-span domed interiors that visually synthesized "mobility, identity with Islam, and sedentarization" (Prussin 1986, 202). By examining correspondence and travel accounts from the 1800s through the 1850s alongside other unpublished visuals from colonial archival sources, the study reveals how environmental factors—seasonal grazing cycles, subsequent labor organization, and green fields—intersected with imperial politics and religion to shape Sokoto's unique "pastoral urbanism."

By foregrounding the intertwined histories of environment, politics, and building technology, this paper challenges binary assumptions about nomadic versus sedentary lifeways and contributes a new framework for understanding urbanism in West Africa. It unpacks the underexplored social, economic, and cultural histories of Sokoto's formation by intersecting the environmental and political history of the empire with the development of an innovative building technology, two facets of African history that have been studied separately until now, offering broader insights into noncolonial pathways of African urban formation.

PS16 Integrating Digital and Traditional Methods in Building Recording

Session Co-Chairs: Wei Zhao, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA and Joseph Williams, University of Maryland, College Park, USA

Community Legacy in the Face of Wildfires: GIS Mapping as First-Response Heritage Documentation

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Abstract

Following the January 2025 wildfires in Southern California, preservationists and community members mobilized to assess damage to architectural heritage in the Palisades and Eaton Fire areas—two regions shaped by distinct cultural legacies and documentation histories. With public access to burn zones restricted, ArcGIS became an essential tool for identifying, recording, and evaluating affected historic resources.

In the Palisades, the SurveyLA initiative provided a robust digital foundation for impact analysis, allowing rapid overlay of historic resource data with Cal Fire burn maps. In contrast, the Eaton Fire zone lacked formal surveys, particularly for sites valued by historically underrepresented communities. In response, grassroots data collection was initiated through partnerships with preservation nonprofits, cultural institutions, public agencies, and residents. This community-sourced documentation expanded the scope of recognized heritage, revealing vernacular and culturally significant sites often overlooked in conventional surveys.

The project culminated in interactive web maps incorporating parcel-level fire data, historic resource layers, and Google Street View imagery to visualize pre- and post-fire conditions. These maps support the identification of resources by architect, style, era, and designation status, while enabling comparative analysis across the two fire zones.

This case study demonstrates how digital tools like GIS can integrate traditional and human-centered methods in heritage documentation. Community engagement ensured that local memory and underrepresented narratives informed spatial datasets, offering a more equitable and inclusive preservation response. A forthcoming second phase will survey the Altadena area, seeking parity with the more fully documented Palisades.

As climate-driven disasters increasingly endanger cultural sites, this hybrid approach underscores the potential of combining digital platforms with collaborative, place-based knowledge. It offers a replicable model for rapid, inclusive heritage documentation and long-term cultural resource planning in the face of environmental threats.

PS16 Integrating Digital and Traditional Methods in Building Recording

Session Co-Chairs: Wei Zhao, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA and Joseph Williams, University of Maryland, College Park, USA

Rethinking Digital Methods: An Integrated Documentation of a Chinese Guildhall Case

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Abstract

This research rethinks the use of digital technologies in documentation and analysis of historic timber architecture through a Chinses guildhall case. Rather than presenting digital recording as comprehensive, it identifies key 'blind spots' and argues how these can be addressed through the integration of traditional surveying methods. To overcome the limitations of terrestrial laser scanning, aerial imaging was used to capture the roof, while observation, photography, and manual drawing supplemented gaps in the internal structures and roof corner. This integrated approach enabled the 3D reconstruction of crucial structural members, particularly the corner beams, whose analysis reveals how the guildhall is rooted in the architectural features of its founders' hometown and embodies social and cultural meanings. This integrated approach not only enables more complete architectural documentation but also makes it possible to reveal the underlying logic and intent of complex timber structures, thereby contributing to the understanding and interpretation of their cultural significance.

PS16 Integrating Digital and Traditional Methods in Building Recording

Session Co-Chairs: Wei Zhao, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA and Joseph Williams, University of Maryland, College Park, USA

Social Participation & Lidar Scanning Aguda Architecture In Benin

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Abstract

During a field data collection trip in Porto-Novo, Benin, in late 2023–4, operating a Light Detection and Ranging (LiDAR) autonomous scanning drone turned up some exciting opportunities for scaling the documentation of heritage buildings using LiDAR and drone imagery, particularly in the undocumented parts of Africa. However, it also brought to light some important limitations and challenges that digital scanning cannot achieve without human local social participation. LiDAR scanning can provide communities and asset managers in Africa with the ability to document and manage their assets, the majority of which are disproportionately at risk of collapsing. According to UNESCO, 39% of African heritage properties on the World Heritage List are in danger ("African World Heritage Day | UNESCO," n.d.)

Although LiDAR technology has great potential, in Africa it can only give a partial picture of the complex and multi-layered meanings of historic buildings. For instance, in Porto-Novo, questions such as why the Porto-Novo's Grande Mosque looks like a church more than a mosque? Why does the local population in Porto-Novo still favor the old mosque that resembles a church over the new one that was constructed as a normal mosque? cannot be resolved technologically in the absence of social participation. These broader questions in Porto-Novo needs deliberate engagement and social participation of Aguda people who built this mosque and other similar styled so-called Aguda buildings. Agudas are formerly enslaved people in Brazil who returned to settle across Benin and herald a legacy in creating a style of architecture blending baroque motifs and Yoruba place making features. This essay leverages an ongoing digitization project Aguda architecture in Porto-Novo, conducted by author and collaborating partners to discuss the need for both digital technologies to scale heritage documentation combined with social participation of local stakeholders to capture nuanced heritage buildings narratives.

PS16 Integrating Digital and Traditional Methods in Building Recording

Session Co-Chairs: Wei Zhao, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA and Joseph Williams, University of Maryland, College Park, USA

Re-interpreting Route 66: A Case Study in Barelas Historic District

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Abstract

Emerging technologies —Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), photogrammetry, and GIS based applications—can reveal the complexity of narrative in cultural landscapes by the integrated interpretation of both tangible and intangible cultural assets through digital storytelling and traditional preservation methods. As a case study, we focus on the Barelas Historic District in Albuquerque, New Mexico, one of the oldest Hispano settlements in the U.S., located at the crossroads of the pre-1937 Route 66 alignment, El Camino Real de Tierra Adentro, and Indigenous trade routes.

Technological advancements now enable more inclusive and participatory models of cultural heritage documentation. In partnership with the National Trust for Historic Preservation, we developed a proof-of-concept ArcGIS Story Map to visualize layered stories embedded in the landscape. Drone imagery and 3D modeling can reveal hidden or forgotten features—such as abandoned acequias and the now demolished South Barelas Neighborhood—providing insight into historical patterns of use and development. This story includes the controversial establishment of the National Hispanic Cultural Center on land once central to community life of that neighborhood.

The value of traditional methods is not overlooked during this study: Sanborn maps, archival photographs, historic documents, and oral histories help reconstruct a more accurate representation of the district dramatically altered by Urban Renewal (1937–1999). The methodological approach demonstrates how UAV-based surveys and digital mapping can enhance traditional preservation efforts by recovering underrepresented histories and make space for those erased or marginalized narratives visible. This work offers a replicable model for CRM (Cultural Resource Management) that values both material and immaterial heritage in the support of communities, who want to envision more resilient and culturally rooted futures.

PS16 Integrating Digital and Traditional Methods in Building Recording

Session Co-Chairs: Wei Zhao, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, USA and Joseph Williams, University of Maryland, College Park, USA

Digital Heritage and Architectural Memory: Virtual Reality as a Tool for Historical Space Analysis

Lucy Trimarco

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Abstract

This research investigates how virtual reality technologies can enhance architectural historical research by enabling immersive analysis of lost or inaccessible interior spaces. By creating digitally reconstructed environments based on archival documentation, archaeological evidence, and historical accounts, this study examines how virtual environments facilitate new forms of spatial understanding and historical interpretation. Working with reconstructions of significant historical interiors—including destroyed domestic spaces from the 1906 San Francisco earthquake and inaccessible private collections—this project demonstrates how VR technology allows scholars to experience spatial relationships, lighting conditions, and material qualities that cannot be conveyed through traditional architectural documentation. The research methodology combines historical research with digital humanities approaches, using photogrammetry, archival analysis, and period-appropriate material simulation. Findings reveal that immersive digital environments enable researchers to identify previously unnoticed spatial hierarchies, circulation patterns, and sensory experiences that influenced historical inhabitants' daily lives. This work contributes to architectural history methodology by establishing protocols for scholarly use of VR reconstruction, while demonstrating how digital tools can expand access to architectural heritage and deepen historical understanding of lived spatial experience.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

Urban Canvas: Stories on (a) Chromatic Event(s)

Lorenza Sierra Salazar

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Abstract

Mexico hosted the 19th Olympic Games in 1968, a pivotal event for shaping the global perception of Mexican identity. Together with the sports program, Mexico offered the first Cultural Olympiad, a pioneering effort inspired by Ancient Greece that helped establish the country as a global cultural reference and set a new standard for future host nations. *Urban Canvas* argues that the use of chromatics in constructing the country's image has never been incidental—it has long conveyed cultural and political messages, exemplified explicitly in the strategies deployed in Mexico 68. During this time, under the direction of Pedro Ramírez Vázquez, the International Olympic Committee mobilized design, culture, and media to layer a color veil to cover the city's dark landscape consequent to the moment's deep-rooted tensions. Amidst local and international socio-political conflicts, the Games staged a chromatic spectacle that blended tradition with modernity, realism and abstraction, and aesthetics with diplomacy.

Moreover, this research frames Mexico 68 as a symbiotic and chromatic collective memory—it was symbiotic because the echoes of the local tensions and global skepticism intertwined with its impact, and it was chromatic as an account of a world sensitizing to color while transitioning to color broadcasting media. The transformation of Mexico into a vast canvas during 1968 raises critical questions about the influence, sustainability, and outturns of a meticulously crafted modern national image. Thus, this research situates the Olympics within broader global movements in design and media, exploring how figures like Josef Albers, Emilio Ambasz, William Eggleston, and Beatrice Trueblood have informed local visions and how ephemeral solutions became vehicles to reinforce enduring national narratives. By narrating seven untold stories, this thesis invites the reader to visualize an event that continues to span screens, borders, and time.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

Corpus: Magid and Barragán

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Abstract

In 2016, conceptual artist Jill Magid approached architectural historian Federica Zanco with a most unusual proposal: a two-carat diamond ring in exchange for the return of Louis Barragán's professional archive to Mexico. Twenty years earlier, Zanco had received the archive as an engagement gift from her then-fiancé Rolf Fehlbaum, chairman of the Swiss furniture company Vitra. The diamond belatedly offered by Magid, then, was the engagement ring Zanco never had; it was also artificial, a laboratory-made stone generated from one pound of Barragán's compressed remains.

Magid's audacious gesture and the complex maneuvers that made it possible are the subject of the artist's film, *The Proposal* (2018). Both cerebral and affective, the film opens up several ideas and exposes their interrelation: art and architecture, patriotism and repatriation, agency and access, legacy and law. At the same time, the film is also a love story, or several hinged together: between Mexico and Barragán, Barragán and Zanco, Zanco and Fehlbaum, Magid and Zanco, and, of course, Magid and Barragán.

All of this information is essentially on record—both because Magid's highly self-conscious film is smart about its own operations and because several writers have translated into words what the film says via cinematic means. But here is something that is not sufficiently explored: the implied connection between a manmade diamond (the film's essential symbol) and Barragán's architecture (the film's essential subject). Why, in other words, is a diamond (and one made of the architect's ashes) an appropriate equivalent, as Magid suggests, for Barragán's archive, itself the safeguarded creative remains of the architect's corpus? To answer this question, our paper attends to the formal properties of Barragán's work—color, simplicity, planarity, faceting, all set off by the impact of light—and considers material and conceptual affinities between the objects at play in Magid's proposal.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

The Painted Underworld: Mural Modification and Transformative Practices at El Tajín, Veracruz

Brandon Agosto

Columbia University, USA

Abstract

Mesoamerican mural painting of the Late Classic through Early Postclassic periods (ca. 600–1200 CE) often contain material traces of physical interactions produced after their manufacture. At the Pre-Hispanic city of El Tajín, Veracruz, Mexico, mural programs depicting aquatic divinities with conch shells and feathers, figures with features comparable to a Central Mexican god of rain and war known as Tláloc, and a procession of warriors adorned in jaguar helmets once lined the walls of the administrative center known as the Palace of the Columns. The paintings were taken down, intentionally fragmented, and carefully interred below the architectural foundation, demonstrating a process of ceremonial caching. This ritual practice contrasts with the murals of water deities and ornamentation discovered in situ at another palatial complex known as Building I, with at least two layers of mural painting buried beneath the final construction phase.

This paper will assess diverse practices of mural engagement, fragmentation, and burial within El Tajín's Palace of the Columns and Building I (ca. 750–1110 CE). Through an interdisciplinary assessment of archival excavation reports, mural conservation photos, and visual analysis of image interactions, I conceptualize the multivalent value attributed to physical practices of mural modification and burial. Rather than considered an iconoclastic act, I will explore how mural fracture and/or layered burial activate pictorial transformations associated with ritual events. When appropriate, I will consider the documented archaeological assemblages of figurines and monumental sculpture and their relationships with painted architecture. Utilizing Mesoamerican languages and mythic traditions, I offer interpretations of how these fragmented paintings act as manifestations of powerful divinities that mediate nourishing rains within the urban fabric of El Tajín. This aquatic potency is harnessed through a syncretic tableau of local and Central Mexican pictorial canons that characterize an expansive representation of the fecund, watery underworld.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

Mexican Envois by French Prix de Rome Architects (1938–1955)

Denise Costanzo

Penn State University, USA

Abstract

Since its inception, the French Prix de Rome required architects to conduct historic research in locations authorized by the Académie in Paris. Limits on where they could go and what could be studied echoed its changing values. Initially limited to Roman sites in Italy, the perimeter expanded to encompass Greece and "alternative" antiquities. After 1935, the chronological, geographic, and stylistic scope of mandatory *envois de Rome* was undefined, with any location approved by Paris permitted. Topics still had to be "historic" (*du passé*), but the Prix de Rome's map was officially unlimited.

That freedom was seized by 1936 winner André Remondet, authorized to study ancient sites in Mexico's Yucatán. He submitted an envoi on Chichén Ítza in 1938 and added Uxmal for 1939. Soon after returning to Rome to complete his final project, his fellowship was interrupted by World War II. Remondet officially finished his Mayan envoi in 1949, thirteen years after his Prix de Rome win. Soon after, Louis Gabriel de Hoÿm de Marien (1951 Prix de Rome) also worked on Mesoamerican architecture. His 1955 envoi was an overview of sites from the late Preclassic era to Juan O'Gorman.

Written records reveal contrasting official responses to these two architects' projects. Remondet's earlier envoi documenting archaeological sites was received more critically. Hoÿm's later submission, less rigorous by many measures, was instead praised. The Académie's cultural attitudes may have changed in the interim, but visual evidence suggests that the defining factor was its deep-rooted visual bias. It expected for Prix de Rome envois to construct compelling images mirroring its own vision of French architectural primacy. By bringing Mesoamerican architecture to Paris via Rome, Remondet and Hoÿm revealed the chasm between the Académie's stated aims and its actual agenda.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

Urban-Nature Archives: architectural histories of Brazilian Amazonian frontiers

Junia Mortimer

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Abstract

How can we investigate urbanization processes facing the absence of traditional architectural documentation and taking into consideration the relationship between urban and nature? In this paper I aim to show a particular mode of interaction as an urbanising process, not limited to cities. In order to do so I will present the personal archives composed mainly by photographs and field notebooks of Roberto Monte-Mór, Professor at the Federal University of Minas Gerais (UFMG), who authored the concept of "extended urbanisation" in the late 1980s, while working with Edward Soja on the theme of Amazonian frontiers. The collection covers a timeframe that spans from the 1970s to the 1990s, and comprises approximately 500 slides, film frames and printed photographs – which I had already digitized – documenting his trips to Amazonia, including the states of Rondônia, Acre, Pará and Tocantins. He coordinated a series of urban planning projects in the area and was able to observe the drastic changes in the territory, including the settling of mining companies and the openings of highways. Through the photographs, I propose a way of seeing that restores the relationship between urban and nature, focusing on urban-nature practices not as ruins of vernacular modes of life that have been extinguished, but rather as futurities that present alternative ways for facing the Anthropocene/Capitalocene and the environmental crisis. I argue that these images, juxtaposed with other documents, constitute 'urban-nature archives' that can bring out ways of understanding and producing space, including architectural space, which sets in the liminal frontier between urban and nature, suspending their limits. But, above all, I argue that through a process of seeing with, that clashes distinct ways of seeing by involving collective dispossession, we are able to conceive of an intellectual reflection that may demand to close our eyes in order to see.

PS17 Open Session: Media and Visuality

Session Chair: George F. Flaherty, University of Texas at Austin, USA

José Sabogal's Architectural Depictions and other Visions of the Andes 1919-1945

Madeleine Aquilina

University of Michigan, USA

Abstract

This paper explores the contradictory politics of *arte popular,* handmade objects created by Andean and Amazonian artisans that meld Indigenous and colonial imagery and techniques. Thanks to the advocacy of *indigenista* artists like José Sabogal, craft production was a familiar presence in Lima's gallery and museum spaces starting in the 1950s. As *arte popular* was accepted into cosmopolitan venues, institutions that previously prioritized viceregal and modernist painting and sculptures, Marxist art critic Mirko Lauer argues it conformed to Eurocentric expectations of the art object's non-utility and mobility. By the 1970s, Lauer contends, *arte popular* was chiefly an attestation to individual artistic signature and a form of economic value.[1] Following from Lauer's reflections of the elite capture of *arte popular* in mid-century Peru, this paper proposes a slightly more complicated story. First, it analyzes José Sabogal's 1945 publication on *mates,* carved gourds that frequently pictured the Andean built environment. Here, Sabogal situated mates as an example of "criollo-indigenous" genius that glossed over the ways that a colonial land tenure system continued to subjugate Indigenous peasants in the Andes. However, *arte popular* contained its own arguments that diverged from Sabogal's nationalism and tendency to proffer cultural hybridity as an alternative to the acknowledgement of colonial violence. This paper concludes with an analysis of several examples of *arte popular* held at MUCEN in Lima. These examples of *arte popular, mates* and *illas* (portable alabaster sculptures of towns with ceremonial functions) show the Andean built environment as inhabited, contingent and a source of spiritual protection, thus diverging from Sabogal's nationalistic frame or Lauer's deterministic evaluation.

[1] Megan Sullivan, "A Marxist Alternative to Marxist Art History: Latin America's Social Theory of Art," *Selva* 5, 196.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Buried House as Resistance: On Life after Genocide in Bosnia and Herzegovina

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Abstract

In September 2020, 25 years after the Dayton Peace Agreement was signed and the war in Bosnia and Herzegovina was suspended in perpetuity, Šerif Velić held a ceremony in Kevljani, during which he unveiled a memorial plaque for his family home demolished in the war. The engraved marble plaque on a small concrete pedestal beside the grassy mound/burial site reads: “Here lies my house, raised in 1974, razed in 1992. Love built, hate demolished.” In the immediate vicinity, another memorial plaque marks the site of the Old Kevljani mass grave. Exhumed in 2004, most of the 456 victims came from Prijedor and lost their lives in the Bosnian-Serbian Omarska Camp in 1992. They are a fraction of approximately 4000 people who were killed just that year in that municipality. All these sites are located in what is now known as Republika Srpska, a Bosnian-Serb entity in Bosnia and Herzegovina. With the war formally ending, the tactics of erasing the local non-Serb population took different, more bureaucratic, and more spatial forms.

Against the ongoing violence of the stasis, the gesture of burying the house is a gesture of refusal, resistance to the active erasure and denial that followed the suspension of war by the Dayton Peace Agreement. By burying the house, Velić does not create a sacred monument, but rather a gathering space in his garden, incorporating it into everyday life, and showing how life itself is a form of resistance. Thinking with it, this paper will explore memorialization as an epistemic practice, conceptually working with the idea of the fragment, influenced by Fred Moten and Gyanendra Pandey, and brokenheartedness as conceptualised by Gargi Bhattacharyya, with anti-fascism as O horizon. The paper will reflect upon the societal, political, and aesthetic dimensions of spatial knowledge in conceptualising non-commemorative knowledge-based memorialization practices.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Land, Tradition, and Continuity: the 1976 Land Day

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Abstract

On March 30th, 1976, Palestinians from the Galilee, with the leadership of the *Committee for the Defense of Arab Lands in Israel*, organized a strike to protest the confiscation of their lands by the Israeli state. The villages marched and authorities responded by killing six civilians and arresting and torturing hundreds. This came to be popularly known as "Land Day," what this paper formulates as a spatial enactment of a tradition central to Palestinians who remained on their land after the *Nakba*. Through a study of this spatial enactment's architecture—the committee's planning and organization, the villages' political and economic relation to land, and the villager's traditional (embodied and metaphysical) positionality towards land—this paper will reframe Land Day not as an instance of resistance but as a dual embodiment of a landed tradition and a tradition of return that defied the Israeli settler regime of truth.

Through a study of the *Committee for the Defense of Arab Lands in Israel*, my paper asks whether an organizational continuity can be established between Land Day and former efforts to combat land confiscations, namely the Land Movement, active between 1958 and 1966? In what ways did villagers require political education around state-led land theft, given that it was a condition they were intimately familiar with as they continued to practice landed life and subsistence? How can we then understand Land Day as a continuation of the phenomenon that Ghassan Kanafani called a "simple axiomatic fusion between man and land?"1 Finally, this paper will close with return: namely that Land Day enacted a tradition of return—a "rehearsal" for a landed future in which Palestinians achieve sovereignty by returning to land.

Kanafani, Ghassan, [Resistance Literature in Occupied Palestine, 1948–1966], (Cyprus: Al Rimal Books, 2013, [1966]), p73.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Erased in Stone, Written in Memory: Diyarbakır

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Abstract

This paper examines the destruction and transformation of Sur—the historic walled district of Diyarbakır and a UNESCO World Heritage Site—following the 2015–2016 conflict in the district. Once a densely inhabited urban landscape of courtyard houses, narrow streets, and diverse cultural heritage, Sur was subjected to a comprehensive spatial transformation: the demolition of more than 1,300 structures, the displacement of a predominantly Kurdish community, and the replacement of an organic historic fabric with wide roads, standardized housing, and formal urban spaces.

The paper argues that this transformation was simultaneously a material and a discursive political operation. Drawing on media archives from both mainstream and dissident outlets, it analyzes how competing truth regimes constructed fundamentally different—and internally contradictory—meanings of the same spatial transformation. The mainstream regime framed demolition as security, modernization, and heritage renewal; the dissident regime documented it as erasure, displacement, and cultural destruction. These contradictions are not incidental: they reveal the epistemological instabilities at the heart of each regime, and illuminate how the re-production of urban space is always a contested political process.

Crucially, however, the competing narratives did not determine what happened. The state's power to transform Sur's built environment was not dependent on narrative legitimacy. Yet this raises a central question: what is the relationship between discourse and spatial transformation? The paper argues that spatiality itself is contested—that the re-production of space is always a political and epistemological operation in which competing truth regimes struggle over what is possible and what is worth preserving.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Architectural Determinism, Photography, and Apsáalooke Resistance

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Abstract

During the Assimilation Era (1887-1934), Indigenous nations across the United States faced a gauntlet of policies designed to eradicate their cultural practices, dispossess them of their land, and fundamentally disrupt their family structures. Reservation housing became a key site of cultural contestation for Indigenous adults, serving a purpose akin to residential boarding schools.

The Office of Indian Affairs (OIA) believed in architectural determinism, or the idea that reshaping the house could fundamentally reshape the behavior of the residents within. The OIA created blueprints for assimilation – literal blueprints for standardized houses with little regard for variations in geography, weather, or culture. The introduction of frame housing on the Crow Reservation in Montana was not just part of some material shortage for the tipi. It was an attempt to restructure the relationships the Apsáalooke (Crows) had to the house, the land, and each other.

With Indian citizenship looming on the horizon, the Commissioner of Indian Affairs Charles Burke issued an order in 1922 to Indian agents across the country to survey the agricultural industry of individual households. Burke hoped the surveys would provide data proving tribes' readiness for American citizenship. Burke did not require photographs but noted they would "add much to the reports."

So, Agent Calvin Asbury took a camera, pen, and paper to 244 houses on the Crow Reservation. The result is a stunning series of photographs documenting the vernacular architecture (and occasionally the residents) of the Crow Reservation. Asbury unwittingly (and rather ironically) recorded the Crows' resistance to frame housing through the continued use of tipis and the emergence of a distinct architectural style: the "tipi house."

The surveys also provide a unique snapshot of daily life, often documenting the Crows' resistance to other assimilation measures by preserving their kinship practices and using their houses to combat religious suppression.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Dangerous Design: Indigenous Mothers & Kids Made Alcatraz Home

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Abstract

In 1969 Native American activists seized the disused federal penitentiary on Alcatraz Island. Over the next 19 months activists made the prison home. More than 20,000 people visited the island during the takeover, and about 100 people made the prison their full-time residency. On June 11th, 1971 the United States forcibly removed the activists from the island. Shortly thereafter the state destroyed many buildings the activists had called home, then reopened Alcatraz as a tourist attraction.

The US claims to have decided which buildings to demolish based on their structural integrity. They ultimately demolished the apartments and houses built for unincarcerated workers such as wardens and guards, and retained the main cell block. Activists assert that the demolished buildings were the safest structures on the island—which is why during the takeover women and children made their homes in these buildings while single men slept in cells. Activists argue that the US destroyed these buildings because Indigenous families transformed them into homes, which posed a symbolic threat to the United States' claim to land.

Existing literature on Alcatraz has examined the construction of the original US fort and subsequent prison, the 19 month takeover by *Indians of All Tribes*, and the National Park Services' contemporary interpretive program. But the United States' selective destruction of buildings after the takeover remains unscrutinized. In this paper, I analyze primary sources such as drawings, interviews, photographs and newspaper clippings in collaboration with previously overlooked historical actors to illuminate how the US used demolitions as one part of a larger project aimed at fracturing life-giving relationships between Indigenous women, children, and land. Grounded in continued experiences of Indigenous activists and their descendants, this research reasserts the power of Indigenous place-making practices in challenging and changing the symbolic significance of colonial architectural construction and destruction.

PS18 Architecture, Bodies, Resistance

Session Co-Chairs: Tania Gutierrez-Monroy, University of British Columbia, Canada and Elijah Borrero, Louisiana State University, USA

Intimate Publics: Housing, Pools, and Imagining Otherwise

Nekita Thomas, Akima Brackeen

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Abstract

This collaborative paper explores the theme of intimacy as a spatial strategy, affective condition, and architectural critique. We treat intimacy not as a private emotion, but as a design element, signaled, and navigated through space. Drawing from Black feminist thought and theories of relationality, we ask: What does intimacy look like when considered not as soft or small, but as a designed force, encoded in the everyday, often overlooked, environments people make and remake?

Each author engages a spatial typology that indexes adaption, care, and resistance.

Public housing buildings are innately intimate. Not just the apartment units, but hallways, porches, and front yards as well. In her work, Nekita Thomas takes public housing as a point of reflection to explore the aesthetics of public home-making—how adaptation and authorship blur thresholds between private and collective life, transforming shared public space into fields of presence, belonging, and visible intimacy. From this grounding, her practice expands outward to consider how intimacy operates as a spatial condition across urban environments.

Aquatic environments offer analogous readings. Swimming pools and bathhouses; these aren't just sites of leisure, but spaces where identities are produced through practices, relationships, and flows. Akima Brackeen's ongoing research traces how water moves through Black spatial histories, restoring not just the body but a sense of belonging. These are spaces where design evokes memory, and touch is embedded in aspects of the architectural elements.

Together, this paper offers a grounded and at times speculative reading of intimacy as a critical spatial logic, one that resists reductive typologies of private/public or hard/soft. Rooted in our respective practices in graphic design and architecture, and shaped by our relationships with Midwest Ecologies, our collaboration highlights how affective, expressive, and adaptive spatial practices expand the architectural imaginary, where intimacy becomes a method for imagining otherwise.

PS19 Listen to Histories of Sound

Session Chair: Elisavet Kiourtsoglou, University of Thessaly, Greece

Constructed and Contested: Sensory Experiences of Enslavement

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Abstract

The double-faced Great Clock, designed by enslaver, inventor, and third United States president, Thomas Jefferson, is affixed to the temple-front entrance of his home and plantation, Monticello. There, its interior-facing wooden body provides a precise time of day to viewers inside the home. However, the clock's exterior face lacked minute and second hands for its primary eighteenth- and nineteenth-century audience of outdoor enslaved laborers. An imported Chinese gong attached to the Great Clock sonically enforced a schedule for enslaved people, as its ringing ranged six miles to denote the beginning and end of day's work, breaks for meals, curfews, and allotted "free" time for Black laborers. The Great Clock, in addition to a servant bell system, numerous pocket watches, and tall case and shelf clocks, exemplify audible timepieces Jefferson designed and depended upon to instruct enslaved labor across his two most prominent plantations: Monticello in Charlottesville, Virginia, and Poplar Forest in Bedford County, Virginia. These timepieces have stood as a testament to Jefferson's ingenuity and creativity as an architect, designer, and statesman. However, they have not been heavily discussed alongside his position as an enslaver of over six hundred Black people in his lifetime. My research envisions how time and sound were both constructed and contested in landscapes designed for enslavement, and investigates how Jefferson materialized soundscapes, landscapes, and clock-based time to present race-based enslavement as a natural hierarchical social order. I explore these possibilities by approaching sound as both a subject and lens of study, and utilize a sonic analysis of timepieces and landscapes designed by Jefferson. Employing Saidiya Hartman's practice of critical fabulation, I assemble fragments from written, material, and sensory sources about the people Jefferson held captive and speculate their multisensory experiences of enslavement to encourage a more complex and humanizing understanding of enslavement.

PS19 Listen to Histories of Sound

Session Chair: Elisavet Kiourtsoglou, University of Thessaly, Greece

Inca Architecture and Indigenous Way of Listening

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Abstract

For the Inca, the senses were deeply tied to placemaking. Studies have shown the complex ways in which the Inca manipulated sight to craft place and define experiences. And in recent years, sonic studies have begun to reveal the acoustic sophistication of Inca aural architecture. Yet the focus solely on Inca sightlines and sound production has meant there has been relatively little exploration of Inca ways of listening. This is a critical omission, as Dylan Robinson has laid out in his pathbreaking book *Hungry Listening: Resonant Theory for Indigenous Sound Studies*, scholars must be careful not to understand Indigenous listening through a non-Indigenous lens, but rather they need to have a respectful, mindful engagement with Indigenous knowledge, culture, and voices when considering listening.

In this paper I will examine Inca concepts and practices of listening to understand their impact on the Inca built environment. For example, the Inca understood the senses as directional and gendered. They associated sound with females, the future, and what lies behind a person (conversely, they associated sight with men, the past, and what lies in front of a person). They also considered a broad array of different types of sounds (such as produced by wind, water, humans, instruments, animals, and the earth) as having the potential to carry critical meanings that redefined place for distinct listeners. In this paper I will examine a selection of spaces within city of Cuzco (from plazas to school rooms) to show how it is only when considering the Inca's understandings and practices of listening that we can fully understand the nuances of their architecture.

PS19 Listen to Histories of Sound

Session Chair: Elisavet Kiourtsoglou, University of Thessaly, Greece

Listening to Sovereign Imaginaries in Odesa's Cathedral Square

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Syracuse University, USA

Abstract

In Odesa, Ukraine's Cathedral Square, sits the site of a 19th century church consecrated to Saint Nicholas the Wonderworker. This church, the city's first cathedral, was destroyed as part of the Bolsheviks' secularizing mission, secretly commemorated by a famed ophthalmologist in the form of a fountain, entirely reconstructed in Post-Soviet Odesa, and bombed by Russian shelling in 2023. But I have never laid eyes on this cathedral. I have only ever listened to it.

Throughout 2024, I worked with Odesa-based independent music label, система system, to commission local experimental musicians as urban field recordists for my urbanism podcast *Here There Be Dragons*. This paper will focus on an encounter musician Boris Ukrauinsky recorded, which captured a slippery dynamic in Odesa's urban identity, one that troubles ideas of regional loyalties, linear history, and urban stability. The recording crosses a threshold from a busy downtown street into the cathedral's quiet nave where Ukrauinsky himself was surprised to still be able to access. Through the boarded windows, the city can be heard under the sound of pigeons and doves transiting the eaves.

The sound, the space, and the recordist's narration seem to combine the observations of both composer Pauline Oliveros and Ukrainian American musicologist Maria Sonevytsky. In Oliveros' practice of deep listening, a sustained encounter with sound can subdue inherent aural biases to reveal the latent compositions of everyday spaces. While for Sonevytsky, the act of sound-making in the various movements for Ukrainian independence, reveal a compositional attitude towards ideas of sovereignty that surpass the conventions of the modern nation state. Through sound, Odesa's sovereign visions become legible, collapsing time and history upon themselves. In the composition of city sound, Ukrauinsky's recording offers a place to reclaim, reject, and recombine urban identity.

PS19 Listen to Histories of Sound

Session Chair: Elisavet Kiourtsoglou, University of Thessaly, Greece

Edinburgh's Festive Soundscape in 1633: Acoustic S(t)imulations

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Abstract

Through an analysis of the digital reconstruction of the festive soundscape of Edinburgh (Scotland), location of King Charles I's entry in 1633, this paper argues that sound facilitates site-specific cultural expression, engagement with built heritage, and the (re)construction of individual and collective spatial memory. The research project upon which this paper is based explored the role of acoustics in collective spatial rituals, and in creating a participatory experience during the 1633 civic spectacle, through rendered 3D simulations of what *aud*ience members heard – rather than the much overrated 'saw' – at key locations. It did so by cross-referencing documentary and evidence-based information, on the chosen locations' acoustic characteristics (evidence-driven hypotheses on layouts, materiality, and aural responsiveness), and on the spectacle's auditory elements as perceived from the position of ordinary, stationary participants. The different phases of this original project will be critically presented: from the practical experience of recording modern spaces' aural responses; to working with sound heritage technicians to create an historical digital soundscape where the aural presence of lost buildings and altered facades could be 'inserted' and 'heard'; to the challenge of finding appropriate instruments, music, and voice actors. Finally, this paper will present a selection of actual sound reconstructions of the 1633 event for discussion, commenting upon the challenges of devising and working with them not just as representational choice, but as methodological instruments in their own right. Testing the resulting historical acoustic landscape in different conditions, showed how Edinburgh's urban setting's acoustic response contributed significantly to the construction of meaning – framing, enhancing, or constraining sounds. A discussion of the preliminary results reveals that engagement with historical acoustic landscapes gives both historical and modern listeners the opportunity to immerse themselves sensorially in the community's lived experience, actively co-constructing acoustically layered cultural narratives following acoustic s(t)imulations.

PS19 Listen to Histories of Sound

Session Chair: Elisavet Kiourtsoglou, University of Thessaly, Greece

Construction Site, Sound and Labor in Brazilian Architectures

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Abstract

This paper investigates how sound epistemologies rooted in Black life inform architectural labor and spatial production in Brazil. In dialogue with concept as Construction Site (Sérgio Ferro, 1979) and Experimental Construction Site (institutionalized as a pedagogical framework in Brazilian architecture schools since the 1990s), the research explores the auditory praxis as cultural expression, design method, and constructive force in everyday built environments. By tracing a transhistorical line between the Afro-diasporic experiences, work songs and present-day listening practices in construction sites, the paper highlights continuities and transformations in the relation of sound and labor in architecture. From synchronized voices-gestures to radios and popular music circulating on-site, these reveal how collective, community-based and often "informal" modes of building – deeply marked by Black legacies – persist in shaping Brazil's urban areas. Through bibliographic review, analysis of digital archives, interviews and engagement with contemporary construction contexts, this study argues that sonic agencies – particularly through vibration and rhythm – are essential to shaping architectonic materialities and spatialities. This leads to the notion of Construction Site Sound, which is proposed to describe how sound and listening constitute fundamental tools of space, mediating relationalities between body, movement and, and situating construction sites as place of experimentation where technique and embodied material knowledge intersect.

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

Paramore's Presentation Silver: Narrating Empire with Supply Chain Symbolism

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Abstract

This paper examines the Paramore silver set—five spectacular repoussé and engraved pieces including a tureen, platter, punch bowl, creamer, and sugar bowl. Commissioned by the St. Louis Cotton Exchange in 1889, the set was gifted to James Paramore in recognition of his pivotal role in developing the cotton supply chain that underpinned St. Louis's economic and imperial ambitions.

Through detailed analysis of the silver's iconography, this study explores how the set visually constructs St. Louis's imperial mastery over landscape, labor, and technology. The imagery inscribes a triumphant narrative of control over a vast supply chain network, encompassing tenant farming, railroad construction, warehouses, cotton compress plants, and the St. Louis Cotton Exchange building itself. These linked infrastructures are symbolically embedded across the multiple pieces of the set, narrating a coherent story of industrial progress and regional domination.

Importantly, the silver set does not obscure exploitation and racial hierarchies embedded within this supply chain. Instead, it presents them as accepted, naturalized elements of the cotton economy, inscribing the continued oppression of Black labor both before and after emancipation into the symbolic material culture of the set.

This paper situates the Paramore silver set as a critical intersection of material culture and built environment, noting its close relationship to murals within the Cotton Exchange building that depict the same narrative. This connection highlights the role of architectural space and interior decoration in reinforcing and celebrating St. Louis's imperial identity and its economic control over the the regional imaginary known as "The Great Southwest."

Keywords: presentation silver, material culture, cotton supply chain, St. Louis, imperialism, racial hierarchy, railroad infrastructure, cotton compress factories, tenant farming, industrial symbolism, architectural interiors

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

Supply and Command: Logistical Landscapes of Redwood Lumber

James Buckley

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Abstract

Forest products remain an important material for construction throughout the industrialized world, yet architectural historians rarely consider the harmful impacts of modern resource extraction and product manufacture related to building with wood. Expanding on my recent book *City of Wood: San Francisco and the Architecture of the Redwood Lumber Industry*, this paper uses a cultural landscape approach to explore the logistics of redwood lumber supply chains and their effect on the lives of workers who created these products and the forests where they were harvested.

Redwood lumber companies constantly relocated production between the forest, the city of San Francisco, and intermediate locations to take advantage of cost savings in manufacturing technology, labor, and raw material. These geographic moves forced workers to adapt to changing working and living conditions. At first, owners took advantage of worker isolation in the woods to discourage union organizing, but, during the period of corporate consolidation in the early twentieth century, firms had to offer better housing and services to employees in remote mill towns to attract the best workers. The paper examines the built environments of workers in both San Francisco and the redwood forest to show how they attempted to counter the spatial regimes imposed by capitalists.

Shifting redwood supply chains also threatened to degrade the natural environment that supplied the industry's raw material. After nearly depleting the redwood forest by the early twentieth century, companies began to pursue sustainable-yield forestry in the 1920s to ensure long-term availability of lumber. Introduction of junk-bond financing in the 1980s, however, led to a rapid increase in harvesting and the "Redwood Wars" over the forest's future. The paper will consider how California architectural culture drove supply chain demand through marketing programs that promoted new uses of redwood, assuring ongoing and intensive consumption of this limited resource.

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

Collecting fingerprints: incorporating native forest land in (global) supply chains

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Abstract

While Congolese wood was barely used before, its adoption in Horta's Art Nouveau or Van De Velde's modernist masterpieces, turned Congolese wood into a (luxurious) building material by the beginning of the 20th century. The sudden economic value of certain tree species attracted numerous companies and fortune seekers to the Mayombe forest. These lands, however, were not as empty as their logging concession requests contended. Projecting the 121 concessions granted by 1932 on a detailed, hand drawn map of the area, we can start to fathom how forests were ransacked, how native structures of "chieftaincies, villages, markets, burial sites and trading posts" were erased, and how villagers were forced into labor camps (epitomizing the capitalist wage system). A report of 1950 disclosed how, "due to the generous concessions in the Mayombe, 41 out of 76 chieftaincies no longer dispose of enough land to sustain themselves".

In this paper, I will use the land registration files to understand how the Mayombe got entangled into a global supply chain of tropical wood since the beginning of the 20th century. While in documenting the process of "acquiring, distributing, and exploiting of lands" (Mudimbe, 1988) these files are indeed "monuments to these configurations of [colonial] power" (Stoler, 2009), they also contain subaltern voices in conversation with the (fragmented) power of the colonial state. In questionnaires, reports or land sales, we can read stories of resistance against land occupation, of native land uses and ownership, or of attempts to profit from the land's capitalist revaluation. While in African history, the concept of 'fingerprints' points at African agencies in colonial documents (De Nys-Ketels, 2021), here, they are the literal and bodily traces of the suspension of those agencies: an inked thumb marked the release of all native land rights and the land's final entry into capitalism.

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

Dark Trade and the Logistics of Grandeur: Jacques V Gabriel's Warehouses for the Company of the Indies in Lorient, France

Jason Nguyen

University of Toronto, Canada

Abstract

This paper examines the logistical architecture at the headquarters of the Company of the Indies (1719-1769), which was a joint-stock company that managed French trade in Asia, Africa, and the Americas. It looks at the corporation's warehouses, sales offices, and port infrastructure by the royal architect and engineer Jacques V Gabriel in Lorient, France. Located on the Atlantic coast, the Breton town was established in 1666 as the shipyard for the French East India Company (it later merged with the Senegal, China, and Mississippi Companies to form the Company of the Indies). In 1732, the conglomerate's directors decided to consolidate its operations by relocating its sales headquarters from nearby Nantes to Lorient and commissioned Gabriel to design a grand waterfront complex for the processing, storage, and distribution of commodities. A sumptuously decorated sales office anchored a quadrangle of warehouses that were articulated in the French classical manner.

The architecture's stately grandeur belied the company's wider system of trade and exchange. From the sales office, Nantais merchants could inspect and purchase goods for themselves or as middlemen for other buyers. However, the warehouses stored many foreign commodities whose importation beyond Brittany risked heavy tariffs from a royal customs union that protected state-sponsored manufactures and the Parisian luxury trades (for instance, the union barred Indian silks, which would compete with the capital's textile industries). Considering these restrictions, the company and its merchants opted to use the warehouses partly as an entrepôt, or transshipment center, whereby certain goods would be stored and then re-exported as part of the triangular trade. During the eighteenth century, nearly half of all slaving vessels departing France originated from Breton ports. In this regard, the company's dignified architecture aimed to glorify commerce while masking the displaced violence that fueled its operations.

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

When Wood Became Technical

Jia Yi Gu

Harvey Mudd College, USA

Abstract

Two key events led to the formal establishment of the University of California Wood Collection—the most extensive assemblage of wood specimens west of the Mississippi River—now housed in the Wood Products Laboratory (formerly the Forest Products Laboratory) at the UC Berkeley field station in Richmond.

Professor Emanuel Fritz, an American forestry specialist and professor of Forest Products at UC Berkeley, first envisioned a research collection of wood specimens in 1925. However, the Wood Collection did not take formal shape until 1929, after a set of specimens previously held by the Botany Department was transferred to the Department of Forestry. This transfer marked a significant disciplinary shift: the study of wood moved from the taxonomic and physiological concerns of botany to the mechanical and technical analyses central to forestry and timber product research.

As he began organizing the collection, Fritz sought guidance from Samuel J. Record—an American botanist and head of Yale's School of Forestry—on filing procedures for wood specimens. Their correspondence helped establish the organizational protocols for what would become a new type of material library. In this moment, wood emerged not only as a natural resource to be classified and managed, but also as a technical material whose measurable properties lent themselves to systematic testing and quantification. This transformation foreshadowed later computational approaches in which wood's characteristics would be "informationalized" into datasets for algorithmic analysis.

The early history of the UC Berkeley Wood Collection thus offers insight into the cultural redefinition of wood from plant to product, paralleling broader economic and political shifts in the circulation of timber and wood products in California.

PS20 Building the Supply Chain

Session Co-Chairs: Sam Dodd, Stony Brook University, USA, and Vyta Pivo, University of Miami, USA

Topography as Supply Chain: Concrete, adobe and agriculture in the Cuzco region, 1950-1980

Lucia Allais

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Abstract

The earth shook for 6 seconds on May 12, 1950 in the Andean city of Cuzco (Peru), sending much of the city's building mass tumbling to the ground: from the two-story adobe houses that made up most of the city's fabric, to the stone baroque churches that punctuated the urban grid and the large colonial monasteries that took up entire city blocks. Even some Inca retaining walls were unsettled. The earthquake exposed that these apparently highly distinct architectural periods were actually threaded-through with continuities (and deficiencies) in building methods and materials, and especially in poor quality sand and aggregate. One point of agreement thus arose in the quake's aftermath (despite stylistic and ideological rifts): that Cuzco's reconstruction would be regional, and that it would jumpstart the economy via a total reorganization of its building materials supply chain.

This paper uncovers the re-organization of the building supply chain that unfolded over the next 30 years, equally affecting historicist, adobe, and modernist building practices, and mapping itself onto the topography of the Peruvian Andes. Starting in the 1950s, national and international agencies invested in a network of concrete plants, while also encouraging the "reform" of adobe building practices. After the coup of 1969, a military government continued but redirected this strategy towards agrarian land reform, incorporating imaginaries about the industrialization of construction labor into its upheaval of Peru's social order.

As a case-study in postwar regional planning, this history shows that not only abstract plan diagrams but also topographical and geological features became key to transforming formerly agrarian places into industrial sites, through the logistics of building material supply. It also offers an early example of attempts to merge agrarian and architectural techniques into new building techniques, from hay-reinforced adobe to retaining walls for agricultural terracing.

PS21 Oceanic and South-East Asian Built Histories of Development

Session Co-Chairs: Renee Miller-Yeaman, University Of Melbourne, Australia, and Isabel Rousset, University of Technology Sydney, Australia

Contesting Expertise: UNESCO-UIA Seminars in South-East Asia

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Abstract

Documents from the UNESCO archives reveal tensions between the organization's headquarters and its regional offices over the role of international experts in development-related seminars. While regional staff—such as Indian sociologist Yogesh Atal, Regional Adviser for Social Sciences in Asia and the Pacific, and US-American architect John Beynon, Principal Architect in the Bangkok office—advocated reallocating funds to support greater participation by local and regional actors, the UNESCO headquarters insisted on including foreign experts. This insistence reflected UNESCO's institutional commitment to a form of internationalism that prioritized the symbolic presence of external (often Global North) expertise as a marker of the organization's international character, rather than supporting fully regionalized or locally grounded seminars.

This paper traces one seminar organized by the International Union of Architects (UIA), one co-organized by UIA and UNESCO, and one organized by UNESCO: the "Urban Villages" seminar in Jakarta (1979), the "Training Seminar for Improvement of Marginal Settlements (Barefoot Architects)," also in Jakarta (1981), and a follow-up workshop in Bangkok (1983). The French-Hungarian architect Yona Friedman was invited as an expert in low-cost housing at all three events. His interventions sparked criticism from regional participants, one of whom wrote to UNESCO headquarters expressing frustration with Friedman's lack of contextual knowledge and his self-presentation as speaking on behalf of UNESCO.

This moment of conflict highlights broader questions about who is recognized as an expert in international development contexts—and who gets to speak for institutions like UNESCO. The paper argues that while UNESCO and UIA upheld a vision of internationalism centered on Global North expertise, the seminars nonetheless served as platforms for South-South exchange. Participants from Australia, India, Indonesia, the Maldives, Nepal, the Philippines, and Thailand contributed to emerging regional networks, offering a more plural and grounded counterpoint to the top-down frameworks of international development politics.

PS21 Oceanic and South-East Asian Built Histories of Development

Session Co-Chairs: Renee Miller-Yeaman, University Of Melbourne, Australia, and Isabel Rousset, University of Technology Sydney, Australia

Cold War Campus: Information, Diplomacy, and Modern Architecture

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Abstract

The offices of Minoru Yamasaki and Edward Durell Stone are two formidable late twentieth century architectural practices that made indelible marks on the built landscape. In the overseas context, both architects pursued significant projects to represent the U.S. Department of State and the Department of Commerce—Yamasaki in Kobe, Stone in Brussels, and both in New Delhi. Architecture thus became a medium through which the U.S. projected ideological values across the Global South, leveraging design as a strategic component of Cold War diplomacy, both in diplomatic functions and in institutions of higher education. Not solely utilitarian in nature, such projects were conceived as physical embodiments of liberal democracy, technological progress, and aesthetic sophistication, curated to contrast with the relative architectural austerity of socialist and communist nations. Through original archival research and comparative analysis, this paper reveals the way in which U.S.-based diplomacy initiatives leveraged modernist architecture as a tool of soft power. Yamasaki's formalism in the masterplan for Pahlavi University in Shiraz (1960-79) began to define the architect's authorial signature for governmental and institutional clients, frequently emphasizing spaces that were contemplative and part of a broader agenda of aesthetic unity. On the other hand, Stone's restrained ornamental approach to late modernism deliberately channeled political stability, transparency, and an aesthetic *timelessness*. In the foothills of the Himalayas, Stone proposed courtyard-unit clusters to create intellectual zones across the University of Islamabad's campus (1966). Through these and other projects, the architects' calibrated their aesthetic agendas for specific geopolitical contexts, often blending modernist idioms with regional motifs to create an image of diplomacy and cultural exchange—all while reinforcing American ideological overtones and, at times, as a pipeline to international aid. In other words, architecture as a powerful performance.

PS21 Oceanic and South-East Asian Built Histories of Development

Session Co-Chairs: Renee Miller-Yeaman, University Of Melbourne, Australia, and Isabel Rousset, University of Technology Sydney, Australia

Jakarta's Traffic Conundrum as an Object of Development, 1970s

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Abstract

This paper takes the Sudirman-Thamrin Road to investigate Jakarta's deep-seated traffic congestion conundrum as one of the loci in which developmentalism materialised and thrived in the 1970s. The period marked a significant shift when Jakarta fully embraced the regional planning approach, which addressed economic, transportation, and land development as a unity in a supposedly comprehensive and cross-sectoral approach. At the same time, it foregrounds a narrative propagated by international development agencies (such as the UNTAA, World Bank, JICA) who saw 'traffic' as another latent problem in the so-called developing countries; much like the poor population, slums, and a non-industrial-based national economy. Traffic was framed as a development problem which stemmed from inadequacies. It has always been an issue of not enough road capacity, not enough decentralisation of industries, not enough expertise in the planning, design, and construction, not enough budget to build, or not enough governance and State power to manage the traffic congestion.

Development projects no longer revolve solely around road construction but around the complexity of the traffic overcrowding questions. The qualities of Jakarta's traffic jams – complex and seemingly impossible to resolve – tethered Jakarta to the receiving end of the development aid. Through this narrative, the 'traffic questions' provided a ground for foreign technical assistance. Because the traffic conundrum generates projects. The objectification of the traffic's complexity in Development in Jakarta touched the ground in diverse forms, from planning and construction of new roads, establishment of new mobility infrastructures, to the provision of public parks and sidewalks, even displacements. Altogether, they were showcasing how the 'traffic-questions' were constructed and perpetuated through the mass media. It shaped a public discourse that has informed Jakarta's contemporary spatial development.

PS21 Oceanic and South-East Asian Built Histories of Development

Session Co-Chairs: Renee Miller-Yeaman, University Of Melbourne, Australia, and Isabel Rousset, University of Technology Sydney, Australia

The Garden Industrial Town: Natures of Development in Singapore

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Abstract

During Singapore's transition to independence in the 1950-60s, industrialization was prioritized for economic independence. Technical assistance from the UN, the Colombo Plan, the World Bank, and British and Japanese experts recommended seeking foreign direct investment and building a large industrial zone in western Singapore for heavy industry and manufacturing, leapfrogging import-substitution directly to export-oriented growth. In 1961, the Jurong Industrial Estate was launched.

Official accounts laud Singapore's industrialization without the environmental destruction typical of other developing economies. They credit holistic planning, strict environmental regulations, and Lee Kuan Yew's Garden City vision. Planned as a "Garden Industrial Town", Jurong featured large public landscapes, tree-lined streets, vegetated factory setbacks, and a residential area was aptly named "Taman (garden in Malay) Jurong". Famously, Lee boasts of excellent environmental quality in Jurong, noting birds thriving in Asia's largest bird park alongside factories.

This paper explores the contradictory notions of "nature" underpinning the Jurong's landscape transformations in the 1950-70s as a result of transnational exchanges. We examine the political work of "garden city" landscapes developed through bilateral technical assistance to cultivate a productive workforce; the proposed "improvements" to the coastline for heavy industries through earthworks and reclamation; and the extractive logic of hydrological modifications to meet industrial water demands in a water-stressed nation. Ironically, as ecosystems were cleared for industry, environmental regulations became necessary to facilitate heavy and petrochemical industries while mitigating environmental impacts. Scholarship on development and environmental politics in architectural history in the Global South prioritize buildings and climatic responsive forms. This study of the Jurong Industrial Estate contributes by examining how transnational development rationales remake landscapes at multiple scales and give rise to a state-led ecological modernization process that continues to shape Singapore and has been exported to the Global South as a model of effective urban governance.

PS21 Oceanic and South-East Asian Built Histories of Development

Session Co-Chairs: Renee Miller-Yeaman, University Of Melbourne, Australia, and Isabel Rousset, University of Technology Sydney, Australia

Conflicting Plans: Planning and the Architectural Profession in Singapore's Transition to Modernity, 1955-68

Joshua Tan

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Abstract

Plans never proceed as intended. Recognizing the inflexibility of the 1955 Master Plan, the Singapore Government requested the United Nations (UN) for assistance to develop a plan "more suited to fast growth and change." Coupled with the discretionary powers of the 1959 Planning Ordinance, *Growth and Urban Renewal in Singapore* (1963) introduced a series of "action programs" and an urban renewal program for Singapore's rapid urban and economic development. As a result, the state's developmental strategies contained goals that oscillated between physical and economic targets, producing opaque jurisdictional overlaps and exceptions for architects. During this period of growth, the Singapore Institute of Architects (SIA) was a professional body that attempted to mediate the conflicts between planning authorities and architects. By examining the master plans, development reports, planning legislation, and the SIA Journals, I argue that the Ministry of National Development's efforts to support a private sector of professional architects frequently clashed with its developmental strategies. Specifically, I explore the state's attempt to balance its public building program with its promotion of foreign investments involving the private architectural sector.

This paper demonstrates that Singaporean modernity was not based on a tabula rasa but was instead a messy transition into modernity—a condition that modern cities experienced elsewhere as well. The "success" of Singapore's development was beneficial for Singapore's planning reputation, but this did not happen smoothly or without contradiction. The decision to pursue multiple developmental strategies not only required creating specific statutory boards and agencies, but also exceptions to planning legislation and building regulation. In discussing the Singaporean case, the paper shows how development occurred *because*—not in spite—of the ambiguity of planning regulations. More generally, however, the paper demonstrates how a focus on the problematics of planning—instead of its intentions—can help us unpack the messiness of modernity.

PS22 Afterlife of Byzantine Architecture in the Era of Modernity

Session Chair: Aleksandar Ignjatovic, University of Belgrade, Serbia

'Neu-griechisch' or 'Altdeutsch': Debating Byzantine Architecture

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Abstract

Before 'Neo-Byzantine' architecture was exported into colonial territories, the terminology and historiography of 'Neo-Greek' were subjects of intense scholarly debate in Germany, France, and wider Europe. In the first half of the nineteenth century, the term 'Byzantine' was widely applied to pre-Gothic, round-arched architecture, yet it carried a deeply rooted ambivalence, evoking both decline and progress. This paper traces the fervent disputes over classification and cultural connotation, arguing that 'Byzantine' functioned as a cultural 'other' through which national identities were negotiated and contested. Rediscovering the visual imaginaries of a fragmentary Byzantium, scholars opposed cultural associations with Greece, the Roman Empire, and the Mediterranean East to dogmatic classicism. Oscillating between 'Orient' and 'Occident', and fusing classical and medieval architecture, 'Neo-Greek' counterbalanced national culture with the potential past and future of a larger empire. The formerly neglected history and allegedly primitive status of Byzantine architecture was thus adapted to the demands of a modern bourgeois society – with markedly different outcomes. In Germany, scholars debated the genealogy of medieval architecture, caught between acknowledging Byzantine influence and insisting on the autonomy of an unadulterated national style. The more forcefully they constructed this autonomy, the more they revealed the insecurity at its heart.

In France, medievalists used 'Neo-Greek' to progressively domesticate Byzantine architecture within a narrative of imperial continuity extending from the south of France to North Africa and beyond. Where German scholars found themselves in a fraught dialectic, French scholars turned the category's ambivalence into a productive instrument of colonial legitimacy.

Interrogating the socio-political stakes of this nomenclature, this paper lays open the conflicted cultural implications and ambivalent identities inherent to stylistic categories, contributing to the understanding of nationhood and its relation to architectural forms in early-nineteenth century Europe.

PS22 Afterlife of Byzantine Architecture in the Era of Modernity

Session Chair: Aleksandar Ignjatovic, University of Belgrade, Serbia

The Afterlives of Byzantine Architecture in Modern Türkiye (1923-Present)

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Abstract

Interpretations of the past are often shaped by national agendas and by the complex interplay of ethnic, historical, cultural, political, and economic factors, all of which influence the reception and afterlives of architectural and urban heritage. The notion of *Byzantium* has long been ideologically sensitive, frequently entangled with prejudice and negative connotations in contemporary Turkish society—one of the heirs to Byzantium's rich legacy in the heartlands of the Eastern Roman Empire. The rise of ethnocentric and Islamist tendencies, often framed within the so-called Turkish–Islamic synthesis, has increasingly turned emblematic Byzantine monuments, such as the various Hagia Sophias across Turkish cities, into ideological battlegrounds and instruments of political polarization. The most recent and controversial example is Istanbul's Hagia Sophia—formerly the cathedral of Orthodox Christianity and a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1985—which was reconverted into a mosque by presidential decree on July 10, 2020, following years of political debate and public controversy.

Acknowledging that heritage can function both as a catalyst for conflict and as a tool for democratization, this paper examines the reception and afterlives of Byzantine architectural heritage in Türkiye from the perspective of heritage studies. It offers insights into preservation strategies for contested Byzantine legacies, illustrated through selected examples of both civic and religious architecture. At the same time, it shows how the act of 'preserving', walking a tightrope between the 'authenticity' of heritage resources and their contemporary cultural and political contexts, inevitably transforms architectural heritage, shaping how the past is experienced, reinterpreted, reimagined, or even distorted.

PS22 Afterlife of Byzantine Architecture in the Era of Modernity

Session Chair: Aleksandar Ignjatovic, University of Belgrade, Serbia

Byzantine Ekphrastic Space and the Expressionist Imagination

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Abstract

This paper explores the emergence of Byzantine art and architecture as a historiographical and intellectual model within modernist discourse on Expressionism—offering a counterpoint to dominant Western historiographies and methodologies. Rather than treating the 'Byzantine' as a merely historicist or revivalist style, the paper reconsiders it as an alternative paradigm of art and architecture that contributed to a rethinking of spatial perception, affect, and expression within architectural modernity.

The paper traces the modern rediscovery of Byzantium through the writings of figures such as Josef Strzygowski, Oswald Spengler, and Robert Byron, examining how Byzantium was reframed as an alternative political, aesthetic, and cultural construct positioned in opposition to classical norms. These historiographical interventions helped reposition the Byzantine not as a remote or ornamental past, but as a model deeply relevant to the emerging intellectual conditions of the early twentieth century.

This alternative framing is explored through the architectural dimension of Byzantium and its resonances with modern Expressionism. Central to this analysis is the rhetorical tradition of Byzantine architectural *ekphrasis*—a literary mode that describes buildings not in representational terms but through perceptual, affective, and narrative frameworks. By reading ekphrastic texts, the paper identifies a conception of space structured by interiority, emotional intensity, and perceptual movement.

Ultimately, the paper draws parallels between Byzantine ekphrastic space and modern architectural expressionism, viewing both through the lens of narrated space grounded in affective and imaginative experience. In this framework, the Byzantine emerges not as a static historical reference but as a dynamic and conceptual method—central to reconfiguring the spatial, theoretical, and emotional possibilities of architectural modernity.

PS22 Afterlife of Byzantine Architecture in the Era of Modernity

Session Chair: Aleksandar Ignjatovic, University of Belgrade, Serbia

Renovatio imperii: Italian Fascism and Byzantium in Colonial Africa

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Abstract

In 1936—the year in which Mussolini formalized the Italian Empire—the Cathedral of Benghazi (Cyrenaica, Libya) was acclaimed as the largest and most richly adorned of all the cathedrals within the Italian colonies. Commenced in 1929, it was designed by the Milan-based collective Alpago Novello, Cabiati, and Ferrazza. While eschewing overt Romanesque and Gothic motif, this paper contends that the edifice nonetheless shared with its predecessors a deep connection to the Middle Ages, as it was, at its core, animated by reverberations of Byzantium. The period following the colonization of Libya in the Italo-Turkish War (1911–12) witnessed the ascendancy of the fascist regime unfolding in tandem with the rise of Modernism. Italian colonial architecture is often associated with fascism, which in turn evokes narratives of modernity and, in its retrospective gaze, classicism. Archaeological and architectural campaigns in Libya—while advancing narratives of reclamation—exacerbated conceptions of *romanità*, positing a mythopoeic continuity between the Roman and Italian empires. This paper offers a counter-narrative that foregrounds the medievalisms of colonialism, problematizing the binary that positions medievalism in opposition to Modernism and classicism. Drawing on extensive textual and visual documentation, it traces the history of the Cathedral of Benghazi and situates it within a constellation of architectures, charting it as a critical paradigm of the cultural politics of historicism. By drawing on Byzantine legacies—and on the associated framework of a rebirth of the Roman Empire (*renovatio imperii*) and the notion of a dual empire reconnecting the eastern and western Mediterranean—architecture operated as a symbolic and material bridge between antiquity and modernity. Fraught with tensions between secular and religious systems of power, alongside between Catholicism and Islam, medievalism is revealed as a strikingly modern formulation that reshaped the African built environment for the fabrication, projection, and imposition of trans-Mediterranean identities.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Giétroz Gallery: Glacial Engineering and the Atmospheric Contingencies of Ice

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Abstract

Over the course of 36 days between May and June of 1818, Ignace Venetz found himself carving a gallery through a 300-foot-thick detachment of the Giétroz Glacier, which obstructed the Swiss Drance River. Together with thirty "montagnards," his motivation was urgent: to prevent a catastrophic flood by building a drainage system that would release the 4,000 cubic meters of blocked water gradually down Val de Bagnes. Although the gallery's execution succeeded, its performance only speeded up the glacial mass's collapse, unleashing the devastating flood which destroyed numerous villages downstream. Reports on both the gallery's construction and the subsequent disaster circulated widely across Helvetia and Europe, appearing in scientific journals alongside discussions of recent enigmatic Alpine phenomena: sunspots variation, meteorite falls, irregular atmospheric carbonic acid gas, and volcanic eruptions. Yet, no connections were drawn between these events. Seeking explanations, the newly formed Société Helvétique des Sciences Naturelles (SHSN) issued a particular open call, asking whether it was "true that our higher Alps were running wild?"

To the SHSN's surprise, the awarded submission came from Venetz himself—not an "expert" but a cantonal engineer only trained by the French Pont et Chaussées during the Napoleonic occupation of Val de Bagnes. This paper studies the gallery's construction and aftermath, elaborating on engineering contributions to conceptions of climate in the early nineteenth century where the violence of geological, atmospheric, and human forces was articulated as part of the same mechanical model. As Venetz advanced through the glacier's interiors, he gained insights into the internal dynamics of ice, measuring temperature fluctuations through caloric exchange of laborers' bodies. The Giétroz gallery is framed as a "meteoric artifact"—a technology where infrastructure, labor, and theoretical experimentation converge, advancing both the State's territorial ambitions and the expansion of climate knowledge by sensing the meteora from under the ice.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Where Aeronautics and Agriculture Meet: Meteorological Stations and Settler Colonialism in Italian Africa

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Abstract

This paper traces the development of "meteoric artifacts" in Italian North and East Africa as they converged aeronautics and agriculture to mutually reinforce Italy's horizontal expansion of colonial territories with vertical geopolitics. Meteorological stations in Libya, Somalia, Ethiopia, and Eritrea arose in the late nineteenth century as part of Italy's liberal imperialism to collect atmospheric data for colonial agriculture. The birth of aeronautics in the early twentieth century augmented the importance of meteorological stations: in addition to registering observations for agricultural development, they now forecasted climatic patterns for military aviation. Both the liberal and fascist governments used the latter to expand Italian agronomic settler colonialism, resulting in new architecture, infrastructure, and landscape.

The interconnection of Italian aeronautics and colonial agriculture facilitated by meteorological stations is particularly evident in Italy's 1911 invasion and subsequent occupation of Libya until 1943. Italian pilots harnessed atmospheric information to reconnoiter, launch kite balloons and dirigibles, and aerial bomb Libya to wrest its control from the Ottomans. In 1934, Mussolini appointed Italo Balbo, an aviator, as Governor of Italian Libya, who later engineered the mass migration of 16,000 Italian colonists in 1938. This led to the construction of twenty-six agricultural villages for Italians, ten villages for Libyans, and new infrastructure such as roads, railways, and airports.

The fascist regime's invasion of Ethiopia in 1935 fully militarized Italian meteorological stations in Africa. The Italian Air Force, built by Balbo, used aircrafts to take aerial photographs to strategize advances and deploy mustard gas. The elevated vantage point afforded by the "aerial eye" vertically extended the "empty landscape waiting to be conquered" upwards toward the sky. This colonization of airspace was then reverted to the ground as Italy used aerial photography to determine the location of agricultural settlements to expand its empire horizontally.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Weather in the Vein: Toward a Mechanical Meteorology of Thermal Comfort

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Abstract

This paper examines air-conditioned environmental chambers, thermostats, and psychrometric charts as meteoric artifacts that fuse human skin with the Earth's crust, transforming both into sites of meteorological inquiry and conquest. It traces the evolution of thermal comfort laboratories established by the American Society of Heating and Ventilating Engineers (now ASHRAE), from the first psychrometric chambers at the U.S. Bureau of Mines in 1911 to the environmental chamber at Kansas State University (KSU) in 1963. While the former established the entanglements between the concept of thermal comfort and meteoric artifacts, the latter contributed to the development of ASHRAE Standard-55, which continues to define thermal comfort norms. Negating bodily and geographical variations, the standard became an instrument of meteorological dominance. Skin and territory, linked through its global circulation, also emerged as sites of uncertainty and resistance. The paper challenges the illusion of technical uniformity by exposing the territorial distortions embedded in the psychrometric chart, whose initial plotting relied solely on the distribution of U.S. weather stations in the 1910s. It further shows how the skin became a site of engineering uncertainty through Chinese textile engineer Tao Peide's 1981 experiment at KSU, which compared American and Chinese physiological responses to varying thermal conditions. Taken together, these episodes reveal how meteoric artifacts externalized the temperature-regulating functions of capillaries beneath the skin into the mechanical veins of air-conditioning machines. At the same time, they absorbed planetary flows into their cavities, manufacturing rivers and winds within. Skin and territory thus converge in a mechanical meteorology carried within every enactment of thermal comfort standards.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Clouds, Cracks, and Currents: Earthquake Prediction in Socialist China

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Abstract

In the decades following the 1966 Xingtai Earthquake, China built the world's largest network of earthquake prediction. While seismic activity originates deep underground, its detection posed a horizontal problem: how should observation stations be territorially distributed to comprehensively capture the precursors? During the Cultural Revolution, this technical challenge became inseparable from radical ideology. Through the "collective monitoring, collective prevention" (qunce qunfang) program, ordinary people were trained as amateur observers to assist professional seismologists. Tens of thousands of micro-stations were established across schools, factories, communes, and military units. People scoured nature for signs—animal behavior, telluric currents, underground water, and weather patterns. With countless "ears and eyes" across the territory, the state believed, earthquakes could be reliably predicted.

Yet, these "ears and eyes" proved too sensitive. The 1976 Tangshan Earthquake, one of the deadliest in history, went unpredicted not for lack of data but its excess: overwhelmed by contradictory grassroots reports, seismologists could not distinguish signal from noise. After Mao Zedong's death late that year, the collective network soon declined, and observation was professionalized. Animal behavior studies, for example, moved from rural fields to laboratories set in the zoos. More importantly, the state adopted systems theory and information science to redesign the network—filtering "useless data" and excluding grassroots participation in favor of a purified, institutional chamber of knowledge production. Meanwhile, some amateur observers resisted this move. They formed cloud-watching groups, interpreting cloud physiognomy as seismic signs—a practice dismissed by experts as pseudoscience.

Drawing on Paul Edwards' concept of "knowledge infrastructures," this paper contextualizes observation within the politics of socialist China. While earthquake prediction remained unresolved today, its vast infrastructure—people, buildings, artifacts, and institutions—embodied the shifting mechanism of governance from Mao's mass mobilization to the post-Mao techno-authoritarianism, whose epistemic and territorial legacies continue to shape the world today.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

From Crop to Sensor: Tobacco Plantation Landscapes and Ozone Bioindication in the Connecticut River Valley

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Abstract

In the early 1960s in the Connecticut River Valley, tobacco plantations became unlikely scientific instruments. An unknown blight had decimated crops across North America in the early 1950s, spurring a flurry of research at the United States Department of Agriculture's Agricultural Experiment Stations (AES). Amid Connecticut agricultural fields growing tobacco for cigar wrappers, a 1921 clapboard farmhouse and its surrounding, urbanizing land became a site for plant pathology research aimed at protecting crop yields. Through this research, scientists identified the Bel-W3 strain as uniquely sensitive to elevated levels of ground-level ozone, exhibiting necrotic tissue damage on its leaves. In the context of ecological research, the tobacco plant earned new status as a planted sensor for air pollution, and was specified in community gardens globally by the 1990s. This transformation from crop to scientific instrument, however, demands scrutiny. By reframing Bel-W3 tobacco as a neutral bioindicator in scientific literature, its history and origins in the plantation landscape were obscured. A notoriously difficult crop to cultivate, tobacco was grown as a commodity and research specimen by migrant agricultural workers from the southern United States and the Caribbean embedded in harmful, exploitative plantation labor. At the same time, the tobacco plant, a seemingly innocuous tool of citizen science, functioned as a technical object deployed in garden design to render atmospheric pollution visible. This paper examines how Connecticut tobacco plantations were reframed as laboratories for state-sanctioned environmental monitoring with the introduction of atmospheric research plots. In doing so, it interrogates how scientists and the state shaped perceptions of utility and value in the tobacco plant, divorcing it from its original provenance. By tracing the transformation of monocrops into scientific instruments, this paper analyzes the use of bioindicator species in later landscape design that inadvertently reproduce frameworks of harm under the guise of ecological care.

PS23 Meteoric Artifacts: Architecture and the Atmospheric Sciences

Session Co-Chairs: Zaid Kashef Alghata, British University of Bahrain, Bahrain, and Tairan An, ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Atmospheric Indices: Military Science and the Climatic Governance of Bodies

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Abstract

The Wet-Bulb Globe Temperature (WBGT) index was designed to combine four meteorological variables—solar radiation, temperature, humidity, and airflow—into a single operational metric of bodily risk. Developed in the 1950s by Harvard physiologists Constantine Yaglou and David Minard's epidemiological studies of heat casualties in U.S. military research camps, the WBGT became a predictive tool to prevent physiological collapse, and a universalizing measure to codify thermal sensation and endurance into a standard index. A WBGT value was meant to standardize bodily responses, allowing military planners to treat distinct geographies—whether in dry-hot deserts or humid-warm jungles—as functionally equivalent and to make tactical decisions across otherwise incompatible environments. Today, it remains the dominant metric for correlating atmospheric conditions with human physiology, shaping protocols in military operations, occupational safety, and sports medicine, and increasingly informing global discussions on heat waves, climate adaptation, and planetary thresholds under climate crisis.

By examining the WBGT alongside Yaglou's earlier work on the *thermal comfort chart*—which helped standardize indoor climates across architectural typologies on a global scale—as epistemological meteoric artifacts, this paper explores how atmospheric knowledge became a strategic instrument in the neo-imperial logistics of postwar environmental governance. Drawing on recently declassified documents, the paper reconstructs how the British military—facing the collapse of empire in the late 1950s and reorienting toward a doctrine of rapid force projection—adopted U.S.-derived thermal indices to recalibrate bodily endurance. A series of heat acclimatization experiments in Bahrain, Kuwait, and Aden exposed troops to extreme environmental conditions, the "supercooling" of oil-company infrastructure, and climate-controlled laboratories at home, to produce generalizable data on bodily comfort, endurance, and collapse. These experiments reveal a postcolonial logic of atmospheric governance, in which climatic indices were used to rationalize mobile warfare, infrastructural austerity, and the biopolitical optimization of troops.

PS24 Plateresque and Churrigueresque in the Hispanic World

Session Co-Chairs: Charles C. Barteet, Western University, Canada, and Luis J. Gordo Peláez, California State University, Fresno, USA

An Autochthonous Flower: Mexico City's Churrigueresque Evolution Through the Work of Francisco Guerrero y Torres

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Abstract

Spanish art historian Diego Angulo once asserted that the Churrigueresque style flourished so richly in Mexico that it should be considered "an autochthonous flower rather than a transplanted one." He further claimed that "in the lands of Anáhuac, [the Churrigueresque] bore its sweetest fruits," emphasizing not only its rootedness in New Spain but also its transformation into a cultural "obsession." This exuberant idiom evolved over six decades, culminating before the Academy of San Carlos, founded in 1785, imposed a restrained Neoclassicism aligned with Bourbon Enlightenment reforms.

Mexico City stood at the epicenter of this efflorescence. The estípite column—ubiquitous in façades, retables, and *hornacinas*—became a signature of Creole taste and an architectural expression of *criollo* identity. This paper traces the style's trajectory through the figure of Francisco Guerrero y Torres, the most accomplished criollo architect of late eighteenth-century New Spain. A former apprentice of Lorenzo Rodríguez—the Spanish architect behind the Cathedral Sagrario—Guerrero y Torres evolved beyond the Churrigueresque style. Despite facing censorship and monetary penalties from academic officials, Guerrero understood his era's call for renovation, which he heeded without abandoning his hybrid and idiosyncratic Baroque criollo idioms.

Drawing on archival research and visual analysis, the paper examines how Guerrero y Torres's architecture embodied what Alessandra Russo terms "untranslatable" forms—works that defy Eurocentric terminology, shaped by distinct local conditions. In Novohispanic architecture, these include Indigenous craftsmanship, regional materials, and criollo reinterpretations of European models. The Churrigueresque, in this context, was not mere ornament but a hybridized architectural language that reflected the ambivalence of criollo identity, intercultural negotiation, and a deep emotional attachment to the land and its histories.

Ultimately, the paper examines the tension between Creole vernacular expression and the Academy's Neoclassical mandates, revealing how architectural form became a site for contesting colonial identities, taste, and imperial authority in late Bourbon Mexico

PS24 Plateresque and Churrigueresque in the Hispanic World

Session Co-Chairs: Charles C. Barteet, Western University, Canada, and Luis J. Gordo Peláez, California State University, Fresno, USA

A Taste for Power: The Churrigueresque and its Neoclassical Response in Bourbon Mexico

Rebecca Yuste

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Abstract

This essay explores debates surrounding the Churrigueresque in late eighteenth-century Mexico, at a moment when the Neoclassical idiom was beginning to take hold in the viceroyalty. Grounding the analysis in articles from the *Gazeta de México* and the *Gazeta de Literatura*, archival correspondence surrounding the construction of the *Palacio de Minería*, and state aesthetic policy for the newly-established Real Academia de San Carlos, I argue that the Churrigueresque was understood not only a style in poor taste, but also as a threat to the new imperial order.

By studying the critiques leveled against the Churrigueresque, I examine how proponents of Neoclassicism positioned their aesthetic as a symbol of modernity and rationality, cornerstones of the Bourbon Reforms and its project of solidifying Spain's hold in the Americas. As I maintain, these debates reflected broader anxieties about identity, authority, and taste in a society threatened by social upheaval. Thus, the rejection of the Churrigueresque was closely intertwined with the consolidation of power by the colonial elite, who sought to distance themselves from perceived baroque excesses – in both form and function. Ultimately, this analysis reveals the Churrigueresque as a contested site, at once part of the heritage of a celebrated colonial past, and at the same time antithetical to the current aims of the Spanish crown. Underscoring the complex dynamics at play in the architectural landscape of late colonial Mexico, this essay recontextualizes the relationship between the Churrigueresque and the nascent Neoclassical, articulating the close relationship between aesthetics, style, and power.

PS24 Plateresque and Churrigueresque in the Hispanic World

Session Co-Chairs: Charles C. Barteet, Western University, Canada, and Luis J. Gordo Peláez, California State University, Fresno, USA

American ways of interpreting Plateresque: the Tequitqui art of Mexico

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Abstract

Spanish master builders introduced Plateresque art to the territory now known as Mexico in the sixteenth century. This style was widely known among Spanish builders, coexisting with but also diverging from the full Spanish Renaissance. In Mexico, interpretations of this style took hold in Indigenous towns, where the presence of Spanish master builders hired by the Indigenous nobility has been documented.

Pre-conquest Mexico had a prolific architectural tradition and substantial teams of skilled construction specialists. These workers continued their activities during the early colonial period and worked alongside European builders. Although historiography has often categorized much of their architectural production under the Plateresque style, the differences in execution and technical resolution have remained a subject of significant scholarly interest.

The term Tequitqui art emerged in Mexican scholarship as a way to categorize these works. It refers to a type of decorative sculpture generally located on architectural façades. The most distinct feature of these sculptures is that they are flat, and their technique is reminiscent of the Mesoamerican Postclassic period. Nevertheless, European Christian iconographic motifs usually predominate. It is, therefore, an art form that blends techniques and iconographic elements from both sides of the ocean.

This presentation will examine the *Tequitqui* art as one of the ways in which Indigenous sculptors appropriated Renaissance forms through their various Hispanic variants, chief among them the Plateresque. Beyond merely describing architectural elements, the conditions that originated *Tequitqui* art speak of an interaction among the different peoples that created it, each contributing with their own knowledge and technologies, and of the Indigenous mastery of European crafts.

Additionally, I will inquire into how this type of sculpture spread across much of central Mexico in such a short time, the kind of tools used in its production and the printed models that might have served as sources.

PS24 Plateresque and Churrigueresque in the Hispanic World

Session Co-Chairs: Charles C. Barteet, Western University, Canada, and Luis J. Gordo Peláez, California State University, Fresno, USA

Miagao Church: A Philippine Legacy of Plateresque and Churrigueresque

Lalaine Bangilan Little

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Abstract

On the Philippine island of Panay, the carved façade of the church of Santo Tomas de Villanueva (Miagao Church) towers over the town plaza. A sculpted palm tree stretches to apex of the pediment, its branches radiating over a figure of St. Christopher, the mythological Christ-bearer. A carved balustrade borders the level underneath, and festoons extend around an arched portal like the wings of a bird, waiting to welcome parishioners into the church's fortified sanctuary. Built in the late eighteenth century, Miagao Church is one of four designated "Baroque Churches of the Philippines" by the United Nations Educational Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) World Heritage Convention. Miagao Church is the only one of the four located in the southern Visayas region of the Philippines and is distinguished from its sisters by its bright earthy color and its elaborately carved façade. Churches built during this time adhered somewhat to the Spanish Empire's Laws of the Indies (1573), which intended to maintain consistency throughout the Universal Catholic Monarchy. The decorative motifs of Miagao Church diverge from the austerity of churches in the northern islands and have been interpreted as an attempt at localization. This paper seeks to analyze the particularities of this expression of Philippine Earthquake Baroque, which seems to borrow from motifs of the Iberian world and combine them with motifs of Southeast Asia. This discussion will take into account the larger context of encounters in this complex milieu of Catholic clergy, agents of neighboring sultanates, and native Filipinos. Using textual and archival material, this paper will attempt to draw connections between the visual elements of the façade of Miagao church and broader themes of religious aspiration, developing trade opportunities, and intercultural exchange.

PS24 Plateresque and Churrigueresque in the Hispanic World

Session Co-Chairs: Charles C. Barteet, Western University, Canada, and Luis J. Gordo Peláez, California State University, Fresno, USA

The Plateresque and Churriguereseque in the Work of Morgan, Walls & Clements in Los Angeles

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Abstract

In the mid 1920s, architect Stiles O. Clements, the principal designer at the venerable firm of Morgan, Walls & Clements, played a pivotal role in shaping a new visual and cultural identity for Los Angeles with commercial structures designed in the sumptuous Neo-Plateresque and Churrigueresque styles for satellite towns and boulevards being developed as the city expanded laterally from the dense downtown. Clements became a leading proponent of the style, derived from the Spanish and Mexican Baroque, which was introduced at the 1915 Panama-California Exposition in San Diego by Bertram Goodhue and Carleton Winslow. This radical departure from the neoclassical and Beaux-Arts aesthetics of previous American world's fairs launched a new California vernacular style that established an immediate aura of history and sense of place.

Clements, whose firm designed many downtown Beaux-Arts office blocks, also abandoned classical propriety in adapting the scenographic style—historically used in churches, monasteries, palaces, and civic structures—to establish a Spanish-derived identity that differentiated Los Angeles from East Coast cities. The exuberant Churrigueresque sculptural forms and richly decorated Neo-Plateresque surfaces adorned shops, theaters, restaurants, automobile showrooms, and storage buildings. Among the dozens of Spanish-derived structures by Clements are the Belasco Theater, the Chapman Market, the "Monkey" Building, numerous Masonic Lodges and Odd Fellows Halls, the El Capitan Theater, the Hollywood Storage Building, and the Pig 'n Whistle Restaurant---.

Although long regarded as one of a series of decorative styles eclipsed by the advent of Modernism, by tracing the transmission of the Churrigueresque and Platersque styles across time and continents – from Spain to the Spanish Americas, and subsequently to Southern California – this study seeks to integrate these revivalist styles into the American architectural canon. Further analysis examines how Clements recontextualized the exotic architectural aesthetic to serve the cultural and economic exigencies of the twentieth-century city

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

Historian in Service: Heritage Praxis in the Time of Erasure

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Rana Abughannam

Abstract

In a time of epistemicide, the role of the architectural historian must shift. Even critical scholarship that centers marginalized voices falls short when heritage is framed as past while erasure unfolds in the present. Instead, we build on insurgent historiographies (Mignolo 2011; Bhambra 2014) that refuse to temporalize heritage as a relic, and instead, we recognize it as a practice of service, care, and refusal in the now.

In Palestine, heritage is under attack on all fronts. In Gaza, the ongoing genocide has left no heritage site untouched—from old city homes to the UNESCO Saint Hilarion Monastery. In Hebron's old city, a UNESCO heritage site, destruction takes the form of settlement expansion, forced closures, and mass displacement. Nubians share this pain, not only of lost lands, but of erased stories and displaced knowledge. Despite UNESCO recognition, Nubian environments have faced erasure since the early 20th century—flooded by dams, fractured by colonial borders, and silenced by state-driven modernity. Both Palestinian and Nubian heritage confront the violence of preservation without protection, remembrance without continuation.

For displaced Palestinian and Nubian women, documenting our architecture within Western academic traditions that are text-heavy, archival, and inaccessible, reinforces epistemic boundaries that erase oral, embodied, and material knowledge. In the case of the lands, homes, schools, archives and places that have been wrecked, our epistemic vehicles to knowing and creating knowledge were destroyed. In this comparative study, we position the role of the heritage practitioner through our current praxis of teaching and building as activists, through which we must commit to carrying heritage through time and space beyond Western modes of documentation. We argue that to be a historian for our people, we must embody the epistemic properties, continue the generational transferance, work in community, and be a historian in service.

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

A Rural War: Ideas and Materialities of Rural Homes in Wartime Ukraine

Kateryna Malaia

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Abstract

War affects places unequally: a city, impressed upon thousands of residents and visitors, well-documented by governmental agencies, satellites, and tech corporations, remains on paper and on the internet, even when it lies in ruins in the physical world. Villages, on the contrary, disappear without a trace, remaining only in the memories of their residents and occasional chimney rubble in new-growth forests.

In their full-scale invasion of Ukraine, Russians originally aimed to capture the capital—Kyiv—in three days. This blitzkrieg plan failed miserably: three years later, the frontline runs through small towns and villages in Eastern and Southern Ukraine. Although Russian territorial gains are well below their expectations, the places where war is ongoing have been all but erased. Erasure is a strategy: only through scorched earth tactics are Russians able to move forward, and only through erasure can they claim the land.

In the gentle Eastern Ukrainian landscape, a place no longer exists when its buildings and gardens are gone. Neither the rural Ukrainian mass-built homes nor their gardens are unique or pedigreed, but they are landmarks of land belonging. For outsiders—such as urbanites—now particularly in need of comprehending the Ukrainian land under attack, the disappearance of villages makes a place that is gone impossible to imagine. Yet, this knowledge of the land through its rural built environments is essential to preserving statehood.

To understand the ideas and materiality of rural places in wartime, this paper examines the architecture of rural homes. It does so through archives, Ukrainian fiction and autobiographic texts, interviews with rural and urban dwellers, and data gathered by current preservation projects. This study is part of the larger project *Housing Rural Ukraine, which* investigates ordinary rural Ukrainian homes and the changes they underwent during the 20th and 21st centuries.

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

Sacred Spaces, Contested Places: Monasteries in Post-Conflict Kosovo

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Abstract

Religious heritage often acquires new political lives in post-conflict societies. In Kosovo, Orthodox monasteries such as Deçani and Graçanica—monuments of exceptional cultural value—have become focal points of debate far beyond their spiritual significance. Since the 1999 conflict, these sites have been transformed into contested symbols entangled in unresolved questions of sovereignty, belonging, and international recognition.

This paper investigates how sacred architecture in Kosovo functions within the broader landscape of diplomacy, identity politics, and cultural heritage governance. Rather than treating the monasteries as static remnants of the past, the study considers them as dynamic agents in processes of negotiation and conflict. By examining their role in Kosovo–Serbia relations, it highlights how architecture is mobilized simultaneously as a resource for reconciliation and as a marker of division.

The analysis situates the monasteries within the legal framework of the 2007 Ahtisaari Plan, while also tracing the interventions of actors including the Serbian Orthodox Church, the Kosovar and Serbian governments, and international heritage organizations such as UNESCO. Drawing on heritage theory and critical memory studies, the research underscores that heritage preservation is never neutral: it is a contested practice that produces meaning and power.

The findings demonstrate that monasteries in Kosovo serve as instruments of soft power, shaping narratives, legitimizing claims, and influencing international policy. In doing so, the paper calls attention to the complex entanglement of cultural heritage and geopolitics, urging a more context-sensitive approach to how sacred architecture is understood and managed in societies marked by conflict.

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

Protecting Architectural Heritage in War: A Moral Analysis

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Abstract

We are sometimes forced to choose between protecting architectural heritage and protecting other goods. These forced choices are particularly acute in war. Making informed, principled decisions in these scenarios demands a conception of the morally significant value of architectural heritage. We defend such a conception, grounded in the contribution that heritage makes to human flourishing. However, human flourishing is complex, requiring access to a range of values. We cannot simply favour one value (say, healthcare) that should always be promoted at the expense of any other (say, heritage). Rather, we need to trade off these values against each other. Hence, our account of the value of architectural heritage justifies some protection for that heritage, even when it comes at the expense of other important goods. However, the complexity of the conception reveals itself when we consider cases in which (a) protecting heritage will risk harm to people, and (b) risking damage to heritage will prevent harm to people. For example, using ground forces rather than aerial assault might minimise the risk to a heritage site but increase the risks to soldiers. And soldiers' using an ancient fort as a vantage point might endanger the fort by attracting enemy fire, but be safer for the soldiers compared to the available alternatives. Resolving these conflicts requires a general account of the justified imposition of harm for the sake of heritage and our duties to incur risk to ourselves to prevent harm to heritage. We argue that such an account supports quite different conclusions about when heritage may be saved or damaged than those drawn generally by the heritage community, including by UNESCO. It is usually unjustified to protect heritage during war when doing so significantly increases the risks of harm to either soldiers or civilians.

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

The "Albanization" of Armenian Architecture in Nagorno-Karabakh

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Abstract

This paper examines the Azerbaijani state's treatment of Armenian architectural heritage in Nagorno-Karabakh, located in the South Caucasus, in the aftermath of the ethnic cleansing of its Armenian population in September 2023. By addressing the so-called "Albanization" of Armenian medieval ecclesiastical architecture, I argue that official Azerbaijani discourse engages in historical revisionism aimed at justifying territorial claims and the removal of Armenian communities.

Since the 2020 war, a systematic campaign has unfolded targeting Armenian religious, vernacular, and commemorative architecture. Alongside the physical destruction of sites, the Azerbaijani state has imposed an official narrative presenting Armenian medieval churches and monasteries as "Caucasian Albanian," thereby denying the Armenian historical presence in the region. This narrative is rooted in the Soviet-era legacy of nationalist historiography, which positions present-day Azerbaijanis as the direct descendants of the ancient Caucasian Albanians–an extinct Christian polity that once occupied parts of what is now the Republic of Azerbaijan. Drawing on extant medieval primary sources, I show how Azerbaijani authorities manipulate historical evidence to invent a usable past. I trace the mechanisms of revisionism through the study of altered inscriptions, republished historical texts with revised ethnic attributions, and state-sponsored visual and digital media, including museum displays and documentary narratives, that together construct a Caucasian Albanian provenance for Armenian monuments.

Ultimately, this paper argues that the targeting of Armenian architectural heritage in Nagorno-Karabakh is not a byproduct of war but a central mechanism of ethnic erasure that transforms architecture into an instrument of dispossession. As such, it raises urgent questions about the critical function of architectural history in confronting historical fabrication and in protecting the material foundations of cultural memory.

PS25 Architectural Heritage in War and Displacement

Session Chair: Tasoulla Hadjiyanni, University of Minnesota, USA

War as Crisis and Catalyst: Transnational Efforts for Architectural Heritage in Postwar Rome

Jiayao Jiang

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Abstract

The post–Second World War reconstruction of Europe raised urgent questions about the role of cultural heritage in rebuilding political legitimacy, collective identity, and international order. Rome—both a symbolic capital and a war-damaged city—emerged as a critical arena where international, national, and local actors converged to redefine the meaning and value of heritage in the aftermath of destruction.

This paper examines Rome in the 1940s as a case study to explore how architectural heritage was mobilised not merely for physical reconstruction but as a vehicle for political reconciliation and international diplomacy. Drawing on original archival materials and fieldwork, it investigates the collaborative efforts of the Allied Sub-Commission for Monuments, Fine Arts, and Archives (Monuments Men), Italian heritage authorities, and newly formed international organisations such as UNESCO.

Through detailed case studies—including the use of new tools like the Frick Maps and Harvard Lists to select and protect monuments from wartime bombing, and the collaborative reconstruction of the Basilica of St. Lawrence Outside the Walls—the paper argues that war catalysed new forms of transnational cooperation. Heritage was framed as a shared global responsibility transcending national boundaries, laying the conceptual foundations for what would later be institutionalised as “World Heritage.” Initiatives like the American Committee for the Restoration of Italian Monuments and its fundraising and awareness-raising campaigns illustrate how cultural preservation was entangled with ideological realignment, de-fascistization, and Cold War geopolitics.

By critically revisiting postwar Rome as a contact zone of displaced expertise, contested memory, and shifting power, this study offers a decolonial perspective on the emergence of international heritage consciousness. It underscores the dual role of architecture—as a casualty of conflict and an active agent in resilience—and reflects on the ethical and political stakes of cultural preservation in post-conflict societies today.

PS26 Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Session Chair: Dijia Chen, University of Melbourne, Australia

Participatory Practices Led by Women in Architectural Education

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Abstract

Participatory practices have emerged as a representative field of activity for women architects who work toward building more inclusive, just, and sustainable societies. In fields historically dominated by men, such as architecture, the growing presence of women has been reshaping professional practices through other ways of doing and projecting. This research explores the professional practices of women architects engaged in collaborative processes, highlighting how themes such as inclusion, accessibility, and socio-environmental demands are articulated within participatory projects.

An exploratory approach was adopted, combining a literature review with in-depth interviews. A semi-structured protocol guided the interviews, which were transcribed, organised, and performed by a thematic analysis. Eight women architects were interviewed, selected based on their professional profiles, life trajectories, and projects developed. Attempts were made to include women with diverse backgrounds, representing five different nationalities, aiming to ensure diversity and inclusion of multiple actors and contexts. Accordingly, participatory practices based on the narratives of diverse women were explored and discussed, thereby contributing to the pluralisation of invisible voices that have historically shaped discourses and practices in the fields of architecture.

The findings were categorised into thematic axes that reveal tensions between collaborative practice and disciplinary canons of architecture, emphasising the construction of a feminist pedagogy grounded in active listening, negotiation, empathy, and participatory practices. The research also identified the impacts of these practices on professional education and the insertion of the participants in the field, including gender-related challenges.

This study demonstrates that participatory practices led by women can act to propose alternative forms of knowledge production, critical thinking, studio dynamics, collaboration, and authorship. These findings contribute to rethinking the development of pedagogical experiments and non-systematic approaches that broaden architectural education and foster social justice.

PS26 Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Session Chair: Dijia Chen, University of Melbourne, Australia

The Slow Space of Her Page: Cynthia Davidson's Editorial Pedagogies

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Abstract

This paper repositions The Any Conferences (1991–2000) by foregrounding the editorial and organizational labor of Cynthia Davidson, a founding director of the Anyone Corporation and editor of *Inland Architect*, *ANY* magazine, the Any Conferences and *Writing Architecture* book series, and *Log*. While architectural historiography has canonized the initiators of Anyone—Peter Eisenman, Arata Isozaki, and Ignasi de Solà-Morales—Davidson's role remains largely overlooked. Despite her significant editorial career and foundational influence on the Any project, she recalled in a recent interview with me that "people thought Peter [Eisenman, her husband] was my puppeteer, pulling my strings," a telling reflection of how gendered assumptions have obscured her contributions to architectural discourse. Yet it was Davidson who translated the ephemeral Any debates into lasting textual form, exercising editorial authority over what was preserved on the page and, consequently, what was left out.

Drawing on feminist theory that values curatorial approaches to knowledge production, this paper interprets Davidson's editorial practice as a form of "feminine" pedagogy. Central to her approach is the concept of "the slow space of the page," a deliberate resistance to the speed of contemporary architectural media. Her journalism background, paired with a belief in the centrality of writing to architectural thinking, informs a porous editorial model centered on critical interpretation. Davidson also extends this editorial pedagogy into the classroom, where she teaches the importance of framing images with text to articulate the ambition of an architectural project. Based on oral interviews and analysis of editorial annotations, this paper illustrates how Davidson's work has created alternative pedagogical spaces that foreground writing as an essential counterpoint to image-based design thinking. As Davidson explains, her approach, embodied in *Log*, resists "the seductive power of images," affirming writing as a medium that "causes us to dream…in ways that images do not."

PS26 Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Session Chair: Dijia Chen, University of Melbourne, Australia

Co-Design in the Classroom

Linda Zhang, Simon Liao

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Abstract

This session discusses the implementation of Participatory Action Research (PAR) through a feminine lens in architecture education, and examines how it can reshape classroom dynamics, promote active learning, and empower students by placing knowledge ownership in their hands. Architecture studios, historically shaped by the 19th century Beaux-Arts tradition and master-apprentice model, often reinforce patriarchal structures by positioning instructors as sole knowledge carriers, leading to passive learning. Despite growing literature on feminine and community-engaged teaching, practical applications of PAR principles within architectural education remain limited, further constrained by normative academic structures.

This study draws on insights from an undergraduate studio course taught by Linda Zhang at the University of Waterloo School of Architecture. This course embedded feminist participatory approach to challenge male-dominated frameworks of knowledge production and classroom hierarchies through two co-design components: 1. Students co-designed with intergenerational community members of Toronto's Chinatown; and 2. Students co-designed course curriculum with the instructor.

Guided by the Research for Organizing Framework (TakeRoot Justice), this course implemented community organizing strategies, including mutual aid, collective care and decision making, and communal knowledge production. This teaching model offered alternative structures of relationality to redefine learning outcomes by centering students' personhood, lived experience and collective values. Assignments were collaborative, adaptive and iterative, encouraging co-learning and knowledge co-creation with peers, the instructor, and community members. Through a mixed methods impact evaluation, we have found that this adaptive model effectively empowered students as knowledge carriers and creators, while challenging the conventional studio norms.

This research contributes to broader conversations on feminine pedagogy by offering an experiential, evidence-based case study. It examines both the successes, potentials and challenges of implementing a feminine participatory approach to the traditional design studio classroom. Ultimately, this research aims to advance a feminine pedagogy in cultivating an inclusive and empowered learning environment.

PS26 Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Session Chair: Dijia Chen, University of Melbourne, Australia

Desiring Practices: Feminist Pedagogy in the UK, 1991–1996

Reishin Kunishima Watabe

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Abstract

Desiring Practices (1995) was an international symposium staged at the Royal Institute of British Architects and organised by Katerina Ruedi-Ray, Sarah Wigglesworth, and Duncan McCorquadale. This paper uses Desiring Practices as a lens onto feminist pedagogy as strategic, institutionally malleable intervention. It argues that the project advanced feminism in architecture through institutional tactics that used professional platforms and shifting educational rules that determined the limits of architectural work.

The argument turns on a linked pedagogical struggle at Kingston Polytechnic/University in the early 1990s, centred on Andrew Fielder's Anus-Vagina installation. After Kingston management refused permission for the project to be built on campus, Fielder constructed it off-site and the school devised an exceptional examination process that relocated the crit into the work itself. Read alongside the symposium's staging at the RIBA, this episode showed how appeals to professional standards policed sexuality and narrow architectural method but also how those boundaries could be negotiated. The paper therefore positions Desiring Practices as a feminist pedagogy of managed risk and an approach that broadened architectural knowledge by altering the conditions of assessment and encounter.

The paper uses discourse analysis with sources from architectural newspaper Building Desiring, the Desiring Practices publication, private archival materials, and oral histories. Part of this is the intentional use of audio recordings which convey different registers of information that can support feminist readings of heterogeneity.

PS26 Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Session Chair: Dijia Chen, University of Melbourne, Australia

Beyond Paradigms: Feminist Pedagogy in Architectural Education

Anna Myjak-Pycia

ETH Zürich, Switzerland

Abstract

Alleviating Misfit: Teaching and Practicing a Malleable Notion of Architecture by Anna Puigjaner's Chair of Architecture and Care

This paper examines the work carried out by Anna Puigjaner and her Chair of Architecture and Care at ETH Zürich (Switzerland) interpreting it as an educational practice that advances a malleable notion of architecture: the conceptualization of architecture as inherently adjustable and attuned to the versatility of people's bodies and preferences. Through the categories of "misfit", "accommodation", and "orientation on ordinary experience", it discusses how Puigjaner and her team have been engaging students in the exploration and design of spaces that foster inclusivity by catering to the traditionally marginalized and enabling alternative forms of kinship and domesticities. The paper points out Puigjaner's productive incorporation of performance into the set of the Chair's teaching methods. It also argues that while these woman-led teaching efforts have aligned with the traditional association of the "feminine" with sensitivity towards and servicing others, they have successfully turned care into a useful, inspiring, and needed model of design education and practice that transcends the "feminine" and accommodates a variety of users, both those who conform to conventional norms and those who do not, including the vulnerable due to disability, age, and lifestyle.

PS27 Architectures of the Indentured

Session Co-Chairs: Javairia Shahid, Columbia University, USA, and Robin Hartanto Honggare, National University of Singapore, Singapore

A New Kind of Prison: Architects of the Modern Plantation

Page Comeaux

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Abstract

Rarely is the lineage from chattel slavery to the prison-industrial complex in the United States more explicit in built form than at Angola Prison in rural Louisiana, erected on the grounds of an antebellum plantation of the same name. Operating under the auspices of the state since 1901, after three decades of convict-leasing practices, the facility has not functionally ceased to operate as a site of forced labor exploitation in agricultural fields that make up the majority of its 7,200 hectares. In 1955, New Orleans–based Curtis & Davis Architects and Engineers used prison labor to complete Angola's main buildings, which still function as the primary detention area seventy years later. With a sleek, modernist design style, Angola became a locus of the nation's prison reform movement by way of building modernization, which remains prevalent today. As their first carceral commission of dozens that followed, the architects leveraged their profile as a contemporary design firm to champion the project as a model for larger prisons at lower cost across the country and abroad, thereby making room for the prison population to expand in subsequent decades. Using Angola as an entry point, this paper will demonstrate how the design details and construction methods of mid twentieth century prisons were calibrated to take advantage of indentured laborers on site, drawing on pre-emancipation logics and leaving traces of exploitative labor practices behind. It will also show how prison innovations were wielded to legitimize the practice of mass incarceration and indentured servitude through their dissemination in trade publications and journals. Finally, it will document how the buildings' supposed improvements belie the cruelty of the institutions they serve, revealing the incompatibility of comfort with punishment.

PS27 Architectures of the Indentured

Session Co-Chairs: Javairia Shahid, Columbia University, USA, and Robin Hartanto Honggare, National University of Singapore, Singapore

The Architecture of the Colonial Sugar Factory Kampung in Java

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Abstract

The sugar factory *kampung* emerged in late 1860s Java as a strategy to facilitate labour recruitment for colonial sugar factories. Initially conceived as temporary settlements, these *kampung*s granted locally commuting Indigenous labourers a degree of autonomy, allowing them to transplant construction skills and techniques, customs, and social practices from their home villages. The 1870 *Suikerwet* (Sugar Law) formalised this arrangement, accelerating the proliferation of factory *kampung* across sugar-producing regions in Java. European manufacturers started to invest in these settlements, gaining complete control and slowly turning them into permanent workers' villages. Superficially, these permanent *kampung*s mirrored some aspects of traditional Javanese villages. Yet fundamentally, these new environments were influenced by colonial ideals of hierarchy, efficiency, and control – resulting in new residential typologies inextricably tied to sugar production.

Java's colonial sugar industry represented a distinct case within global sugar economies at the end of the nineteenth century. Unlike Cuba, which relied on enslaved Africans to resolve persistent labour shortages, Java – with its surplus of labour – did not import workers from outside regions. Instead, it developed a labour economy resembling indentured servitude, characterised by long-term contracts, debt bondage, restricted mobility, and coercive mechanisms disguised as taxation and obligation. Though differing in labour systems, both Java and Cuba rose to become leading global sugar exporters by the early twentieth century.

This paper draws on extensive site surveys and archival research – official accounts, construction reports, architectural drawings, and photographs of sugar factory *kampung*s from Java's various sugar-producing regions – to explore how shifts in land control and demographic patterns under colonial labour mobilisation altered the living practices and livelihoods of local peasantry. The emergence of the sugar factory *kampung* as a modern simulacrum of the traditional Javanese village offers a lens through which to interrogate the architectural and spatial consequences of colonial industrial expansions.

PS27 Architectures of the Indentured

Session Co-Chairs: Javairia Shahid, Columbia University, USA, and Robin Hartanto Honggare, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Alien Landings: Granite, Gold, and "Coolie" Labor

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Abstract

"Asia enters the market against Africa…Which underbids the other? And shall we take the lowest bidder?" the *New York Times* asked in 1852. Another of its articles charged that "the only medium between forced and voluntary labor, is that offered by the introduction of Orientals."

The fraught abolition of chattel slavery in the United States brought to bear imperial relations of migrant labor beyond its borders, conjuring a "Chinese question" naturalized within the settler colony. This research examines how extractive relations between architecture and land were produced by "coolie" labor as it troubled categories of liberal (un)freedom ontologizing race. Considering the 1852 transpacific construction of a fireproofed Wells Fargo building, I ask: how did Chinese labor become alien through the nativist "free soil" transformations of American landscape? This process, I contend, turned on the architectural production of white supremacy yielding enduring tropes of immigrant illegality and invasion. Set between the abstract fluidity of the gold mine and the material fixity of the granite bank, this paper reveals an architecture of solvency through which a "species of labor" achieved naturalized permanence by a conflation of race and class into whiteness in the decades leading to unprecedented immigration restriction and exclusion.

PS27 Architectures of the Indentured

Session Co-Chairs: Javairia Shahid, Columbia University, USA, and Robin Hartanto Honggare, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Building Murderously at Macquarie Harbour Penal Station

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Abstract

One morning in June 1829, the transportee John Bailey Jones was struck twice in the back of the head with an axe by fellow convict John Mayo who, according to his own account, had no personal grievance against Jones. The men had just disembarked from the boat bringing them to shore from the penal station's main settlement at Langerrareroune/Settlement Island, in their regular labor felling trees for the stations' shipbuilding and timber exports. Taking place on the shore of Macquarie Harbour in western lutruwita/Van Diemen's Land, the killing was one of a series of incidents in which incarcerated men committed murder with the apparently singular motive of seeking escape by execution, which sidestepped the damnation of suicide.

This paper draws on material traces of penal buildings in the landscape and archival documents to argue that such extremities of demoralization, and the murderous resistance accompanying them, were partly produced through penal architecture. The Macquarie Harbour Penal Station was a crucial extraction site for building materials for Hobart Town, from which ships brought provisions and returned with timber. Drawing on work contextualizing convictism within broader movements of unfree colony-building labor, this paper considers how architecture helped foreclose the possibility of freedom for convicts through both physical structures and as a process of bodily control: convicts built their own penitentiaries from timber, stone, and brick they were forced to produce from around the harbor landscape. In breaking the will of its prisoners to live, the settlement's unleashing of passionless murder interfered with the colonial government's administrative and profit objectives for the station. "Building murderously" thus describes both a form of architectural conditioning and a violent mode of resistance within which the settlement's genocidal underpinnings also flash into view, as convicts attempting escape also murder west coast Aboriginal people in resource conflicts.

PS27 Architectures of the Indentured

Session Co-Chairs: Javairia Shahid, Columbia University, USA, and Robin Hartanto Honggare, National University of Singapore, Singapore

Slavery, Indenture and Contemporary Worker Housing in Canada

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Abstract

"For nearly every injustice in the world, there is an architecture that has been planned and designed to perpetuate it," wrote architect and activist Bryan Lee Jr. This is evident in the housing of temporary migrant workers in Canada, many of whom endure economic exploitation and spatial marginalization under the Temporary Foreign Worker Program (TFWP), described by a UN Special Rapporteur as "a breeding ground for contemporary forms of slavery."

While human rights experts have traced the systemic roots of the TFWP to earlier forms of racialized labor exploitation, the spatial dimensions of this continuity remain underexamined. This paper lays the groundwork for a larger study tracing the genealogy of dehumanizing housing practices from slavery to indenture, to contemporary parallels of both in Canada. Drawing on digitized archival sources and a critical review of existing scholarship, it explores how the legacy of slavery shaped the racialization and housing conditions of Chinese indentured workers in late nineteenth-century British Columbia.

This paper argues that racial attitudes rooted in American slavery permeated British Columbia and shaped perceptions of Chinese indentured workers, because of perceived parallels between Chinese "coolies" and formerly enslaved Black workers. It analyzes the Canadian Pacific Railway's Chinese worker camp at Kamloops during the 1880s to demonstrate that housing was instrumentalized as an apparatus of socio-spatial control and surplus extraction. Segregation, overcrowding, unsanitary conditions, social isolation and limited autonomy reinforced racial hierarchies, deepened economic marginalization, compounded health risks, and increased employer dependence. Precarious housing conditions, weaponized by xenophobic actors, further entrenched notions of Chinese racial inferiority, unassimilability, and perceived competitive advantage over white labor, leading to federal restrictions on Chinese immigration.

By foregrounding housing as a key site of labor exploitation, this study invites critical rethinking of how spatial arrangements perpetuate inequality and contribute to the architecture of racialized labor systems.

PS28 Architectural Histories of Expansive Families

Session Co-Chairs: Sergio Preston, Princeton University, USA, and S.E. Eisterer, Princeton University, USA

Dwelling Otherwise: Queer Housing Experiments in 1970s Italy

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Abstract

In 1977, the Italian magazine *L'Espresso* described the emergence of the *Collettivi Omosessuali Milanesi* (C.O.M.), a network of queer collectives in Milan that met weekly to share experiences and coordinate activities. To explore new patterns of intimacy and inhabitation, members occupied Casa Morigi, a building in the city center, experimenting with alternative forms of domesticity—some living as couples, others in communes, and still others exploring fluid relational models. Among the members of the C.O.M. and animators of Casa Morigi was the architect, artist, and writer Corrado Levi, who, at the Politecnico di Milano where he taught, had established a course focused on a critique of urban planning's exclusive focus on the heterosexual couple.

This paper reconstructs the overlooked history of queer housing experimentation in 1970s Italy as a form of spatial and political resistance to normative patterns of inhabitation. Using the case of Milan as a lens, it explores how squatting, cohousing, and self-managed communes facilitated the emergence of new forms of kinship, care, and intimacy that challenged dominant heteronormative housing paradigms. Despite their historical significance, these housing experiments remain absent from Italian architectural historiography. Drawing on archival research—including magazines tied to the homosexual liberation movement—this paper examines how these experiences articulated new domestic imaginaries beyond the heterosexual couple and nuclear family. The research integrates methods from architectural history, social history, and queer studies to foreground housing as a site of contestation and care.

By revisiting these experiments in inhabitation, the presentation contributes to broader efforts to reconceptualize domestic space as a terrain of political struggle and identity formation. It highlights how queer homemaking in 1970s Italy resisted capitalist and patriarchal pressures while offering enduring models for collective life beyond the family.

PS28 Architectural Histories of Expansive Families

Session Co-Chairs: Sergio Preston, Princeton University, USA, and S.E. Eisterer, Princeton University, USA

Alternative Landscapes of the Spirit: Queer Domesticity and Kinship in the Deep South

Stathis Yeros

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Abstract

This paper explores how queer communities in the American South have reconfigured religious and domestic life to create expansive forms of kinship beyond the nuclear family. While Christianity has often functioned as an instrument of heteronormative and racial discipline, Southern queer communities have repurposed its symbols, rituals, and spaces to foster alternative modes of belonging. I begin with Skip Ward, a white gay man in rural Louisiana, whose writings in *RFD*magazine (1974-present) and private correspondence helped cultivate queer spiritual networks blending Christian mysticism, eroticism, and countercultural domesticity. I then examine the Faerie Playhouse in New Orleans, a home transformed by its founders into a queer sacred site of ritual, performance, and communal care—a hybrid space where spirituality, kinship, and resistance merged. These examples reveal how queer Southerners developed affective and architectural practices that destabilized the boundaries between church and home, blood and chosen family. The paper concludes with the growth of the Metropolitan Community Churches and the Unity Fellowship Church Movement since the 1960s—the latter explicitly affirming Black queer experiences in the Deep South. These churches not only offered queer-affirming worship but also reshaped their urban landscapes, influencing local politics and neighborhood dynamics. Across these cases, sites of communal life become media through which queer Southerners resisted normative family structures and imagined expansive, spiritually rooted alternatives.

PS28 Architectural Histories of Expansive Families

Session Co-Chairs: Sergio Preston, Princeton University, USA, and S.E. Eisterer, Princeton University, USA

La Riqueza: Rural Housing for Elder Trans Families

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Abstract

Historically, transgender people in Colombia have lived in conditions of poverty. According to Daniela Maldonado (2025), co-founder of Red Comunitaria Trans (RCT), a grassroots organization founded in 2012 by trans sex workers, “the first thing we trans people lose is the house and home (…) without networks of affection we are excluded, forced to live on the streets and there we have to build a new family.” Maldonado and her kin established a home in the Santa Fe neighborhood of downtown Bogotá. For nearly a decade, “through prolonged inhabitation and cultivated familiarity” (Gustafsson 2024, 85), they created a space where trans people could see themselves—and be seen—as subjects, not objects.

In recent years, however, the steamroller of progress arrived in Santa Fe, promising bright facades and fresh faces, while flattening the trans communities that had taken root there. Rejecting “a future of solitude and loneliness” (Weston 1997, 23), Maldonado and her sisters envisioned a new home, 110 km from Bogotá.

La Riqueza is an ambitious architectural plan offering shelter to elder trans sex workers. For Maldonado *La Riqueza* is not based on capital accumulation or property ownership but grounded in the celebration of life, air quality, water purity, clean energy, and food sovereignty. Like its trans inhabitants, *La Riqueza* will be a self-built home of care and resistance.

This paper will explore the following through literature review, archival research, and the voices of Maldonado and her trans family:

- What is home when displacement is constant? Studying the entanglement of architectural heritage, sex work, gentrification, and violence in the Santa Fe neighborhood.

- What is family when kinship is fluid? Exploring queer domesticity, RCT's activism, and communal living.

- What is architecture for non-compliant bodies in rural settings? Questioning the city as the sole refuge for queer lives.

PS28 Architectural Histories of Expansive Families

Session Co-Chairs: Sergio Preston, Princeton University, USA, and S.E. Eisterer, Princeton University, USA

Qu'est-ce que tu fais? Family, Collaboration and Aging as an Architect

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Abstract

How does living and working outside the institution of the nuclear family intersect with the production of architecture meant to transform institutions of care? Nicole Sonolet (1923–2015), an un-coupled architect who worked amid a constellation of collaborators, family and friends, designed public housing, rural villages, and mental health facilities in France and North Africa that offered care through de-alienation and architectural modeling of community integration.

Sonolet's family was shattered when her father was killed in WWII and her mother was subsequently hospitalized with a severe mental illness. While remaking this family and parenting her siblings, as many did in postwar France, Sonolet completed a thesis focused on de-institutionalizing asylums and empowering mental patients to repair personal and family trauma. Through multi-disciplinary collaboration, conversation, and observational drawing research, she designed institutions which centered community as an agent of healing. Her subsequent work supporting student protests in 1968 (done alongside Felix Guattari and affiliated thinkers) and designing villages for Bedouin women similarly sought to restitch relations between the State, the individual, and the family.

I will analyze Sonolet's theories, research and drawings of these new interrelationships, especially a series of drawings about aging out of architectural practice, which she called "Qu'est-ce que tu fais?" (What are you doing?) Turning herself into a research subject, the folio shows Sonolet tinkering alone in her garden, but also hosting dinners for a giant circle of family and friends: being a "woman alone," in retirement in the countryside, but also creating her own structures of care. I also hope to explore feminist methods for telling intertwined stories of family and professional work: to claim the labor of assembling collaborators, interlocutors, and care structures as not just "personal history," or part of private life, but as central to and a feeder of architectural research and design.

PS28 Architectural Histories of Expansive Families

Session Co-Chairs: Sergio Preston, Princeton University, USA, and S.E. Eisterer, Princeton University, USA

Architectures of Polyfidelity: Spatial Governance and Regulation of Sexuality and Affect in the Kerista Commune

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Abstract

The Kerista Commune's iteration in San Francisco (1971-1991), founded by John Peltz Presmont–known as "Bro Jud" (1923-2009)– is known today for its practices of polyfidelity. Centered around communal living and overlapping heterosexual romantic relationships, the family supposedly invented the concept of polyamory and compersion, inscribing itself deliberately in neopagan and New-Age experimentations on love, family, relationship and sexuality. Throughout the twenty years of its existence, the Kerista Commune developed many tools for community cohesion and management of sexuality, such as a sleeping schedule for Best-Friend Identity Clusters (B-FICs) a name chosen for multiple non-preferential polyfidelous group.

The term polyamory has became central in media, popular culture, academic research and in many queer and trans*(q&t*) communities today, but the concept and its genealogies have received only limited attention. This proposal will extend existing scholarship by Kim Tallbear and Angela Willey who have critically examined polyamory's historical and cultural positioning respectively, especially addressing whiteness and its entanglements with settler-colonial forms of relationality and understanding of land, people and kinship.

This paper will illuminate the documents and archives of the first communities and polyamorous families–from the beginnings of the Kerista "Old-Tribe" in New York in the 60s to its San-Francisco iteration– to analyze how love, sexuality and romance were spatially produced and regulated. Looking at archival documents, books, letters, and zines, the paper will propose a critical and spatial reading of the racial and affective biopolitics of polyamory in these contexts in which white members were in the majority. It will particularly emphasize the ways in which polyamory was in search of a framework to overcome certain capitalist and settler colonial social institutions such as the nuclear family and marriage, while (re)producing others, such as liberal ideas of love and romance, and its racial, historical and biopolitical dimensions.

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Sandstone and Car Pujas: Immigrant Place Making Through Religious Space

Anusha Khansaheb

University of Pennsylvania, USA

Abstract

This paper examines the relationship between the Hindu Center of Charlotte and the built fabric of the greater Charlotte-Mecklenburg region, asking whether “preservation” can become a tool to not only recognize but also ensure the longevity of the impact of South Asian immigrants in the built fabric of the American landscape.

Although the main Hindu temple of the Hindu Center of Charlotte is not yet fifty years of age, constituting it as “historic” according to preservation policy in the US, it is a unique building worthy of the preservation field's attention.

From pink sandstone shipped across the world to car pujas and elections held for deciding deities, The Hindu Center of Charlotte is significant as a present day-space as well as a physical repository of the memories and history of the first of their community to come to the US.

It represents how South Asian immigrants have created place by forever altering the American built environment through transnational processes and simultaneously developing uniquely new identities as South Asian Americans.

This paper is split into three parts: Historical Context, The Hindu Center of Charlotte, and In Terms of “Preservation.” The first section provides background on both the South Asian community as well as the Hindu community in the United States. The second section analyzes the material history of the Hindu temple as well as its social history and importance through observation and ethnographic methods. The final section looks to preservation discourse and proposes methods of planning and policy for specifically immigrant religious space.

I conclude by asking: how can the temple be a model for other diasporic minority communities and religious spaces in the US?

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Performing Diversity, Silencing Faith: Muslim Visibility and Urban Space in Copenhagen

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Abstract

This paper examines how Muslim immigrant communities in Copenhagen navigate religious placemaking amid increasing regulation of visibility in the built environment. Focusing on three interconnected projects—*Superkilen* (2012), the unbuilt Bjarke Ingels-designed mosque (2005–c.2012), and the Hamad Bin Khalifa Civilisation Center (2014)—I trace how sacred space becomes alternately politicized, suppressed, and displaced in Danish urban discourse.

While *Superkilen*, designed by the Bjarke Ingels Group (BIG) and celebrated as a multicultural design landmark, incorporates fragmented aesthetic references to global cultures (including Islamic objects), it avoids overt religious symbolism and aligns comfortably with secular civic narratives. In stark contrast, the grand mosque that BIG proposed a decade earlier—openly Islamic in form and program—was quietly shelved amid political controversy, funding issues, and public backlash. What ultimately emerged in its place was a subdued, foreign-funded mosque built in an industrial fringe with strict limitations: a capped minaret height and no public call to prayer.

Drawing on architectural theory, urban sociology, and critical studies of Islamophobia, this paper argues that Muslim visibility in Danish public space is not merely shaped by integration policy but governed by what I term *securitized pluralism*: a system in which aestheticized diversity is permissible, while overt religious expression—especially Islamic—is managed, minimized, or redirected. I situate these projects within the broader context of Denmark's ghetto laws, which disproportionately affect Muslim neighborhoods like Nørrebro through spatial interventions and forced dispersals. By analyzing the built and unbuilt landscape of Copenhagen's Muslim diaspora, this paper interrogates how sacred architecture is mediated by the politics of national identity, belonging, and control. It contributes to interdisciplinary conversations on how diasporic religious expression is both enabled and constrained by the urban regimes of multicultural Europe.

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Feng Shui, Clan Power, & Sacred Space: Reshaping Marginalized Identity in Nanping (14th–19th C.)

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Abstract

Nanping village in Huizhou, southeastern China, was settled by multiple clans. Arriving last in the 14th century, the Ye clan faced initial geographical and feng shui disadvantages due to their latecomer status and less desirable locations. Nevertheless, driven by strong clan cohesion, the Ye clan spearheaded extensive village spatial restructuring during the Ming and Qing dynasties (14th-20th c.). They constructed clan buildings (residences, ancestral halls) and public infrastructure (temples, schools, bridges).

This study examines how the Ye clan, as a spatially marginalized group, mobilized collective resources to construct sacred spaces (ancestral halls, feng shui systems) for identity reassertion. Through persistent modification of key elements – village entrances, ancestral hall plazas, road networks, and water systems – they deliberately transformed Nanping's physical layout and symbolic meaning (feng shui). This centuries-long effort aimed to assert their dominance within the village's spatial order and perception. The clan's collective vision culminated in the 19th-century Map of Nanping Village. The subtle differences between this idealized depiction and reality visually represent the Ye clan's aspirations and their success in redefining the village's spatial hierarchy.

Using the Map as a core source, alongside fieldwork and historical texts, this study analyzes Nanping's historical spatial structure, particularly the strategic siting and symbolism of Ye ancestral halls. It investigates how the Ye clan, as latecomers, employed coordinated spatial practices (land acquisition, construction, environmental redesign) to systematically overcome geographical constraints, dominate village planning, and embed their clan authority into the spatial fabric. The Ye clan's centuries-long rebuilding of sacred spaces shows how marginalized groups regain cultural power through spatial design – a method also used by immigrant communities to rebuild their identity in new lands.

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Telz Yeshiva: A Transnational History of Piety & Self-Segregation

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Abstract

What happens when religious isolationist attitudes migrate across borders? The history of Telz Yeshiva, an Orthodox Jewish educational center, is a case in point—one that spans three distinct sites and shows how such attitudes consolidate, endure, and transform, sometimes with lasting effects on the host society.

Founded in the town of Telšiai in Lithuania in the late 19th century, the yeshiva became one of the most prestigious centers of Jewish learning in Eastern Europe. It attracted students from across the region, who rented rooms from local families and took part in the town's public life. Following the Nazi occupation in WWII, the yeshiva relocated to Wickliffe, Ohio, where the traumatized Holocaust survivors—keen to avoid both the temptations of American consumer culture and the realities of urban racial tensions—created an isolated campus on a former farm. In the 1970s, in collaboration with a local philanthropist, the yeshiva established a branch near Jerusalem, in a new suburb built exclusively for the yeshiva community and named Telzstone. Here the goal was to shield students not from American society but from secular Israeli culture. Though construction of the Israeli branch was halted midway, and the yeshiva leaders returned to Ohio, the suburb itself endured, setting a precedent for self-segregated ultra-Orthodox towns that would proliferate in subsequent decades.

Drawing upon archival material and interviews, this paper will trace the evolution of Telz Yeshiva and its environs across these three locales, tracking how isolationist attitudes, which were peripheral in Europe, became central to the project of religious education once the community moved across political contexts.

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Architectures of Endurance: Spatial Practices of Muslim Migrants

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Abstract

In 1961, a leather shop was purchased by Rajjab Assim, standing as a storefront on a busy street of Toronto's west end. While the space continued to operate commercially, a mosque quietly functioned in the back, constituting one of the city's earliest congregational prayer spaces for Muslims.

Invisible to most passersby, the leather shop mosque became a vital spatial reference point that Muslim migrants utilized to map the city during their initial periods of settlement. Through repeated and regular congregation at the mosque, the site mitigated migrant anxieties stemming from dislocation and shaped early sentiments of belonging for these congregants within the urban fabric. Although it began as a congregation of migrant workers who were employed in the neighbourhood's meatpacking and manufacturing industries, the community would later draw Muslims from across the city. Thus, the leather shop mosque became a central node in a larger urban network of practitioners, rendering the city legible through a distinctly social infrastructure and grounded in a religious valence.

Using ephemera and oral histories collected through interviews with former congregants, this paper foregrounds the lived spatial knowledge of Muslim migrants in the 1960s and '70s. Through an investigation of community sentiments and a mapping of movements and gatherings around the leather shop, the paper challenges dominant narratives that equate religious placemaking solely with monumental, architectural typologies and fixed sites. Instead, this paper examines the ways in which spatial claims within a city can be constituted by a distinctly "peopled" infrastructure activated through presence, ritual and repetition. In doing so, it reveals how diasporic placemaking emerges not only through the act of building but through inhabiting and traversing the urban landscape.

PS29 Religious Places and Sacred Spaces in the Diaspora

Session Chair: Gita V. Pai, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, USA

Diasporic Design: The Church of San Giorgio dei Greci in Venice

Leah Marangos

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Abstract

The fall of Constantinople in 1453 prompted an influx of Greek-Orthodox migrants to the Italian peninsula, particularly to port cities. These diasporic communities required their own designated sacred spaces and soon began advocating for their establishment. However, the construction of Orthodox churches—especially in the wake of the Protestant Reformation—was frequently met with resistance from local Italian authorities. The enduring schism between the Catholic and Orthodox churches, formalized in 1054, cemented the division between Catholic and Orthodox churches.

In Venice, this tension manifested in prolonged delays. Although the city's Greek community began petitioning the Venetian Republic in the late fifteenth century for permission to build a permanent church, construction was not completed until 1573. Once the church was completed, the Greek confraternity who was responsible for the church's construction commissioned the Cretan painter, Michael Damaskinos, to paint the interior and also several icons to the church's imposing iconostasis.

This paper examines the architectural and artistic strategies employed in the design of this Orthodox church in sixteenth-century Venice. I argue that both the exterior and interior of the building reflects a careful negotiation between ethnic and religious identity and the integration of a migrant community into a new place. Externally, the church employs the visual vocabulary of Renaissance architecture in Venice, allowing it to blend seamlessly into the urban fabric. Internally, however—where access was more controlled—the decoration adheres to an Orthodox visual language. Within the decoration, Damaskinos contends with the demands of his patrons while experimenting with new visual forms he is exposed to while residing in Venice. The church is an example of how a building design acknowledges its geographic and political context, resulting in a nuanced expression of diasporic identity.

PS30 Arctic Architecture and Urbanism

Session Chair: Frederik Braüner, University of California, Berkeley, USA

"Kiruna 4-ever" rifting: the new urban plan for Kiruna/Giron

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Abstract

In Sweden's northernmost city of Kiruna/*Giron*, over 120 years of governmental priorities, economic ambitions, and geological histories have encouraged the groaning collapse of the ground on which it sits, as the city is forced to relocate or face sliding into the expanding deformation zone of the world's largest iron mine.

The new "Kiruna 4-ever" plan, by White Arkitekter, endeavors to build upon the legacy of the original 1900s model town—a unique, compact, and climate-adapted design created by unofficial city architect Gustaf Wickman and city planner Per O. Hallman. However, the new city diverges starkly in its ethos.

White's proposal, an ambitious one-hundred-year plan for the future of the city, aims to phase out the old city and create a new "sustainable" community to the east. While renderings of this "Model town 2.0" depict a winter haven with public squares surrounded by generic neo-Scandinavian modernist buildings, complete with children on kicksleds playing in the snow, the design paradoxically anticipates its own demolition in fifty to one hundred years as mining continues to consume the land.

This paper compares the ontological and design principles of the original and new city plans through Marx's concept of the "ecological rift." It argues that the new city, though well-intentioned, embodies a deeper contradiction: it undermines environmental, cultural, and social stability, perpetuating cycles of extraction and displacement. Fundamentally, a city that was built to last is being replaced by one built to be destroyed, historical social spaces are erased, and land dispossession deepens on territory already taken from the Sámi people.

Far from the people-centred planning of Wickman and Hallman, the new Kiruna/*Giron* prioritizes corporate profit and resource exploitation. At its core, the city is being reestablished not to heal rifts, but to embed them—establishing a rifting nature at its foundation.

PS30 Arctic Architecture and Urbanism

Session Chair: Frederik Braüner, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Arctic Visions: Ralph Erskine's 'Sub-Arctic Habitat' and the Colonial Imaginary of the North

Frida Rosenberg, Carlos Mínguez Carrasco

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Abstract

Swedish architect Ralph Erskine played a pivotal role in shaping a futuristic urban discourse for the Arctic region through his visionary proposals for settlements in Kiruna, Svappavaara, and Resolute Bay. His concept of the Arctic City—disseminated through international publications and presentations, including the final CIAM meeting in Otterlo in 1959—merged modernist urban strategies with vernacular knowledge systems. Scholars have highlighted Erskine's sensitivity to Indigenous building traditions and his capacity to address the extreme climatic conditions of the Arctic through an architectural lens that recognized local knowledge.

In 1970, the Canadian government commissioned Erskine to design a city in Resolute Bay, in the wake of the forced relocation of Inuit populations from northern Quebec. Although his plans were never implemented—instead replaced by conventional modernist solutions—the project underscores the broader colonial strategy of asserting sovereignty over the Arctic Region. Despite its unrealized status, Erskine's Arctic City endures as a powerful architectural myth, emblematic of both visionary potential and political failure.

This paper critically examines Erskine's Arctic City within the historical and political framework of Arctic development and colonial governance. It will analyze architectural drawings, writings, and public presentations to unpack the myth-making around the Arctic City and how it continues to influence contemporary narratives of northern urbanism. Furthermore, the paper will interrogate the contemporary imagination of the Arctic as a new "green frontier," caught between extractive industries and Indigenous land stewardship. A central line of inquiry will explore how Indigenous voices have been structurally excluded from future-oriented urban visions of the Arctic, and what it would take to meaningfully integrate Indigenous epistemologies into these discourses. In doing so, the paper aims to reassess the legacy of Erskine's Arctic projects while contributing to a broader conversation about decolonizing architectural futures in the North.

PS30 Arctic Architecture and Urbanism

Session Chair: Frederik Braüner, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Beyond Blubber and Baleen: Commercial Whaling, Architecture, and Labor in 19th-Century Inuit Nunangat

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Abstract

Inuit Nunangat, meaning “the land, water, and ice of the Inuit people,” refers to the Arctic homelands of Inuit communities currently living in Canada. This vast territory comprises 35% of the country’s landmass and 50% of its coastline. Since the early 19th century, Inuit Nunangat has undergone significant architectural transformations that disrupted traditional Inuit building practices. These changes were largely driven by an unprecedented influx of Western materials, ideas, and people—particularly European and American whalers who traveled to the Arctic to exploit animal-based resources such as blubber, baleen, ivory, and tusk.

Although commercial whaling had been active in the region earlier, the 1850s marked the first time whaling crews began wintering along the edges of the Arctic Archipelago, a strategic move intended to extend the hunting season and increase economic returns on their extractive ventures in Inuit Nunangat. To survive the harsh conditions, they established a network of colonial-style wooden whaling stations, often constructed with Inuit labor and abandoned seasonally. Over time, these land-based structures, along with ships moored offshore or trapped in ice, became what might be called “architectural contact zones,” where Inuit and Western building cultures encountered one another for the first time. Though architecturally modest, these sites of interaction significantly reshaped the built environment of North America’s northernmost region. Yet they remain largely overlooked in architectural history scholarship.

Accordingly, this paper examines the architectural legacy of 19th-century commercial whaling in Inuit Nunangat. It argues that both onshore stations and offshore vessels are historically significant structures, as they represent some of the first “Western” architectural spaces with which Inuit communities engaged. While Western dependence on Inuit expertise for hunting and survival is well documented, the architectural dimensions of these encounters have received far less attention. Adopting a decolonial, place-based approach, this study draws on whaling logs, photographic archives, and Inuit oral histories to show how whaling infrastructure contributed to the early material footprint of imperialism and colonization in Inuit Nunangat—foreshadowing the broader colonial transformation of the region’s built environment in the following century.

PS30 Arctic Architecture and Urbanism

Session Chair: Frederik Braüner, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Greenhouses to Glaciers: On the Ground in Icelandic Deserta

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Abstract

The Icelandic landscape is an overwhelmingly urban construct shaped by humans. Deforested and denuded by its early settlers, the resulting wet desert of Iceland has been an unlikely environment for human habitation and adaptation. Domestic and urban life are inseparable from the temporalities of natural processes and the exigencies of climate change in this Arctic state. The innovations and technologies of humans have harnessed natural forces to create energy, grow food, fish, process aluminum, capture and fix carbon, year-round. From turf houses to greenhouses, glaciers to rewilded plains, port towns to aluminum plants, geothermal landscapes to hydropower dams, Iceland's wet desert provides the setting for a journey through distinct architectures in extreme environments.

This research examines the architectural forms, urban landscapes, community infrastructures, and social organizations that have emerged from the tenuous negotiation between humans and the Earth including: glacier melt and land rise in Höfn and Vatnajökull; infrastructures of hydropower and geothermal energy in Karahnjukar and Hellisheiði; the oldest and newest forms of agricultural and industrial production in Hveragerði and Reydarfjordur; deforestation and reforestation in the Hallormsstaður Forest; and adaptive forms of settlement in Glaumbaer and Seyðisfjörður.

The Icelandic cryosphere is the protagonist in the story of a world that is transforming irrevocably. "Greenhouses to Glaciers: On the Ground in Icelandic Deserta" revisits and critiques conceptions and designations of deserts as humans constructs through the globalized lens of the Anthropocene. It foregrounds the architectures and landscapes of the Icelandic cryosphere as phenomena of urbanization and climate change to bring the sublime curiosities of the receding cryosphere into close view. This paper assembles five years of field work, research, and analysis to break ground on postglacial terrains–critical sites transformed by collective human actions – whose alternative localities might renew the relationship between humans and the planet.

PS30 Arctic Architecture and Urbanism

Session Chair: Frederik Braüner, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Colonial Grid: Energy and Operationalization of Sami Landscapes

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Abstract

This paper explores historical and contemporary *natureculture* landscapes of resource extraction in the Swedish and Norwegian Arctic and Sápmi, with a particular focus on energy development. Through two case studies—the Norrbotten Technological Megasystem in Sweden and the ongoing electrification of the Hammerfest Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) plant in Norway—the paper examines how energy architectures and infrastructures operationalize Sami landscapes as logistical and economic assets.

Drawing on Neil Brenner and Christian Schmid's concept of the *operationalization of landscapes* (Brenner and Schmid 2023), the paper analyses how energy extraction inscribes technical, territorial, and ideological logics onto Arctic and Sami geographies. Special attention is given to the ways these areas have been historically constructed through a colonizing gaze—as 'wild', 'empty', or available for development—thus legitimizing the exploitation and transformation of Sami Indigenous lands. I argue that this colonial framing persists in contemporary discourse, particularly in narratives that position the Arctic as a renewable energy frontier.

By examining these sites through the dual lenses of infrastructural operationalization and colonial spatial imaginaries, the paper contributes to an understanding of the intertwined trajectories of resource extraction and territorial dispossession. It calls for a more critical view of the Arctic and Sápmi—not as a frontier of untapped potential, but as a lived and contested landscape shaped by ongoing infrastructural, political, and cultural interventions.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

Ephemeral Brazilian Classicism: French Experiences, 1817-1822

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Abstract

Between 1808 and 1821, the Portuguese Court was based in Brazil. From his palace in Rio de Janeiro, King João VI governed not only Portugal but also its global colonies. In 1816, following Napoleon's defeat, a group of French artists led by Joachim Lebreton (1760–1819) arrived in Rio with the aim of founding a new Beaux-Arts academy. Although classically trained and experienced as architectural designers and authors on Renaissance heritage, these Imperial artists had to establish their legitimacy through practice on Brazilian soil.

Architect Auguste Henri Victor Grandjean de Montigny (1776–1850) and painter Jean-Baptiste Debret (1768–1848) designed numerous ephemeral structures for royal ceremonies. These included two triumphal arches for the arrival of the Austrian princess in 1817; an arch, a Temple of Minerva, and an Egyptian obelisk for the king's coronation in 1818; and six arches for the proclamation of Brazil's constitutional emperor in 1822. Through these projects, the artists gained the trust of the Luso-Brazilian elite, solidifying their roles in the establishment of the Academy and their professional reputations.

Montigny would become a central figure in the development of Brazilian Neoclassical architecture, where the austere colonial "plain style" merged with lavish imperial classical aesthetics. The analysis of these early ephemeral monuments reveals the symbolic, political, and stylistic negotiations involved in forging a new national architectural identity. Dialogue, translation, hybridization and adaptation were essential to the cultural formation of the emerging nation.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

The Astoria Column and the American Epigraphic Habit

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Abstract

Friends of the Astoria Column in Oregon will celebrate the monument's centennial in 2026. The column rises 125 feet on a hill overlooking the historic port where the Columbia River meets the Pacific Ocean. In this paper I examine the Column's similarities with its ancient precedents through a reception lens and analyze Rome-inspired strategies through comparison with a younger monument located nearby.

The Astoria Column is modeled on Trajan's Column in Rome: its spiraling narrative frieze commemorates the colonization of the Pacific Northwest and the processes whereby Oregon became a state. As with its Roman model, distinctions are apparent between the white explorers associated with the area (Lewis and Clark, John Jacob Astor, and Robert Gray) and the native populations, with striking contrasts in physiognomy and dress as well as in naval technologies and architecture. Although different in materials and artistic technique, both monuments depict events in ways that may evoke wonder, confusion, skepticism, and even disgust. (Recent restoration projects, as well as the upcoming centennial celebration, have had to manage the inaccurate depictions of the Chinook and Clatsop people.) Both monuments align civilizing forces with the conquest of nature, and the construction projects of the invaders are presented as more marvelous than nature itself.

Beyond colonization, technologies, and conquest, further comparisons are possible via preservation issues and the use of epigraphy. Unlike Trajan's Column, which has an inscription only on its base, the images on the Astoria Column are clarified by labels, seals, and dates. The nearby Garden of Surging Waves, a recent, award-winning monument that celebrates the history of Chinese immigrants in Astoria, includes a permanent installation of personal histories on a monumental gate. These inscriptions form a productive counternarrative to the events depicted and named on the Astoria Column.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

Monument by Serendipity: Mexico's Monument to the Revolution of 1910

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Abstract

Mexico's Monument to the Revolution has not only become an iconic symbol of Mexico City but also a significant contributor to the city's urban and social fabric. Its original conception, deeply rooted in the country's political and cultural zeitgeist, has evolved to shape the city's identity, making it a landmark of immense cultural significance.

The original building, ordered by Porfirio Díaz, would be the House of Representatives and the Senate, taking as one of its references the United States Capitol Building in Washington, D.C., with its neoclassical style, which represented the ideals of the Mexican

Republic: order and progress.

Initially designed by Emile Benard and initiated in 1903, the building's construction was halted due to a lack of coordination among architects, engineers, and builders. It was not until 1933, under the threat of demolition, that architect Carlos Obregón Santacilia proposed to the Federal Government the transformation of the building into a monument to commemorate the Revolutionary Movement.

This paper will explore how Carlos Obregon Santacilia, through his innovative approach, transformed the original building's classical architectural principles into a new meaning that resonated with the revolutionary government's nationalist cultural ideals. It will also explore the various interventions and restorations that have shaped the monument's social, architectural, and urbanistic significance in the city and among its inhabitants.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

The WWI Victory Arch in New Orleans' Ninth Ward: Race, Class, and Cultural Heritage in a Changing City

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Abstract

On an unassuming block of Burgundy St. in the Bywater neighborhood of New Orleans' ninth ward, a nearly 30-foot-tall, granite triumphal arch stands commemorating the residents of the ninth ward who served in WWI. Dedicated in 1919 and reputed to be the first permanent WWI monument in the US, the classicizing triumphal arch originally stood in the center of was then McCarty Square, a public park named for Augustin Francois de Macarty a prominent Creole planter and the sixth mayor of New Orleans, whose plantation had originally occupied this area. Moved in 1951, it now stands on the edge of the sidewalk beside the chain-link fence at the rear of Fredrick Douglass High School. The monument was entirely funded by subscriptions raised within the ninth ward, one of the city's original Creole Faubourgs (neighborhoods) and lists the names of 1231 men (and one woman) from the neighborhood, segregated by race, on four cast-bronze plaques flanking both sides of the archway.

This paper explores the form and social context of the original dedication and the shifting place of the monument over several periods of significant demographic and social change. The monument is notable both for its architectural form and the fact that unlike other nearly contemporaneous monuments in the city, it was specific to the neighborhood. Although at the time of the dedication the ninth ward was one of the most diverse, working-class neighborhoods of the city, several watershed periods have dramatically redrawn its demography and physical landscape: the "white flight" fueled by desegregation, the devastation and displacement of Hurricane Katrina, and subsequent gentrification. Dedicated when the city's prominent monuments to Confederate leaders and other monuments of racial oppression were erected, the arch also has a particular place in current debates about cultural heritage, racial reckoning, and taking down monuments.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

Classical Echoes: Building National Identity in South America

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Abstract

This paper explores the multifaceted reception of classical antiquity in the architecture of South American republics during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Following independence from Spain, newly formed countries across the region appropriated Greco-Roman architectural languages to construct visual narratives of statehood, progress, and modernity. Through the creation of emblematic public buildings, it is argued that neoclassical elements functioned not merely as aesthetic choices, but as symbolic instruments within the broader project of nation building. The use of Graeco-Roman columns, temple-like façades, and allegorical reliefs reveals how classical motifs were recontextualized to express civic virtue, institutional authority, and cultural legitimacy on a global stage.

For the purposes of this paper, particular focus is given to Chile, whose centennial commemorations of independence generated a rich architectural program, especially present in the capital city of Santiago. Through a visual and historical analysis, this study interweaves classical architecture and art reception with postcolonial identity negotiation and seeks to understand the meanings – both political and symbolic – attributed to these classical elements. It also considers how such forms engaged in dialogue with contemporary European styles, most notably French and Italian neoclassicism, raising the question of whether these appropriations represent a direct reception of antiquity or a mediated expression of modern European aesthetics.

References to neighbouring countries – such as Argentina – serve to highlight how Chilean architecture adopted classical language not as passive inheritance, but as an active, strategic reimagination of national identity in a postcolonial context. Ultimately, it argues that classical forms in Chile were mobilized to anchor the young republic within the current discourses of progress and modernity while asserting its cultural autonomy.

PS31 Triumphal Arches and Classicizing Monuments in the Americas

Session Chair: Kimberly Cassibry, Wellesley College, USA

Monumental Receptions: La Minerva's transtemporal critiques

Andres Carrete

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Abstract

A bronze sculpture of Minerva, the ancient Roman goddess of wisdom and warfare, stands at the old gates of Guadalajara, Jalisco. Colloquially known as 'La Minerva', this monument has become a salient symbol of the city despite an initially mixed reception. Due to its salience, La Minerva has been the site of important protests and demonstrations. In particular, this monument has witnessed discursive interventions to the state's ongoing problems of femicide and gender violence in the form of protests and so-called vandalism. In this talk, I wish to examine La Minerva's anti-femicide demonstrations as instantiations of Mexico's complex approach to classical receptions. The site evokes a mythological and idealized European past, but the act of protest superimposes Mexican concerns and aesthetics upon it for the sake of a community living in the present. As I will argue, the images of subversion and condemnation laid atop La Minerva's monumental site create discursive meaning not through syncretism, but instead through the simultaneity of cultural histories and tensions. This simultaneity - of Mexican histories and culture on the one hand and Greek traditions and mythologies on the other - allows seemingly incongruent cultural components to converse and embolden a meaning in the present. As a site for community discourse, La Minerva models a path forward for the study of classical receptions in historically overlooked and underrepresented cultural contexts.

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PS32 Open Session - Recalcitrant Spaces in Home and Housing

Session Chair: Cecilia L. Chu, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Class Consciousness, Housing, and Bourgeois Lisbon 1974-92

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Abstract

In 1974, slumdwellers living just outside the middle-class neighbourhood of Alameda in Lisbon formed 'Portugal Novo', 'New' Portugal's first low-cost housing cooperative after that year's revolution. Emboldened by a framework of nationwide programs promoting self-build, community engagement and participatory design, they sought to exercise their newly acquired right to improved living conditions and create 300 homes 'with electricity and sewerage'. A team of architects and students led by M. Vicente designed the ensemble and helped the cooperative navigate changing politics, land disputes and funding options; Vicente had previously planned the area's private real-estate development. Those were the heated, difficult early years of democracy. More than a decade would pass before the first residents moved in.

My paper discusses this lesser-known outcome of the (now celebrated) Portuguese SAAL program. I dissect Portugal Novo's design and construction process based on records from state and local authority archives and the architects' papers. I examine how the designers' public and private discourse and composition choices addressed an acute (guilty) class consciousness that was typical of the post-revolution period. The team wished to avoid patronising visions of village-like architecture 'for the People' that characterised many SAAL schemes (and uncannily evoked some dictatorship-era housing). Instead, they devised an outspoken urban artifact, compact and sturdy, that might fearlessly face the surrounding bourgeois city. The architect as city-maker, more than object-maker; the city as a collective project drawing on popular wisdom; a semiotically charged architecture–exuberant even– with the courage to postmodernly place 'The Façade First' (Vicente): such were the tenets behind their singular proposal.

In Portugal Novo, the discipline's zeitgeist encountered a charged socio-political context against the backdrop of the cooperative's frustrated expectations. This exercise in design outreach and class-struggle architecture survives today, incomplete and dilapidated, awaiting renewal or demolition; a despondent, inner-city remnant of beliefs bygone.

PS32 Open Session - Recalcitrant Spaces in Home and Housing

Session Chair: Cecilia L. Chu, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

A Contradictory Home: Gender and Brazil's Early Female Prisons

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Abstract

This paper examines the conception of female prisons in Brazil during the first half of the twentieth century, focusing on how the complex interplay between gendered discourses and architecture deliberately blurred the boundaries between home and institution, producing a persistent contradiction. Penitentiary experts and public agents, predominantly men, advocated for rational designs aligned with emerging criminological theories and prevailing gender norms. By contrast, philanthropic women from the *Patronato das Presas* emphasized home-like spaces as instruments of moral rehabilitation, while the religious order *Congregação de Nossa Senhora da Caridade do Bom Pastor d'Angers* favored convent-like settings aimed at spiritual salvation. Feminists from the *Federação Brasileira pelo Progresso Feminino*, instead, defended scientifically grounded institutions managed by trained female professionals.

Drawing on archival sources, institutional histories, and feminist architectural historiography, this research explores how these competing visions were spatially materialized. While early facilities were often installed in existing domestic buildings, reinforcing the association between incarceration and the language of home, purpose-built facilities later emerged, shifting configurations of this relationship. The first specifically designed female prison in Rio de Janeiro featured a pavilion-style design that reflected the scientific discourses promoted by both feminist and penal experts. It marked a slight and brief shift away from the prevailing home-like rhetoric traditionally associated with women's prisons. By contrast, a later project in Recife, led by the religious congregation, combined prison and convent structures within a single complex, reinforcing domesticity.

These built forms embodied specific and often conflicting visions of female correction and its associated imaginaries. Considering architecture as cultural production, this study positions early female prisons in Brazil as contradictory domestic spaces, where gendered ideologies of care, discipline, and punishment were negotiated and materially enacted by non-architect actors, revealing how women's philanthropic, religious, and feminist ideas shaped institutional design from outside the architectural profession.

PS32 Open Session - Recalcitrant Spaces in Home and Housing

Session Chair: Cecilia L. Chu, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Simulating Democracy: Housing and Computation in 1970s Mexico

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Abstract

In 1972, Mexico's single political party, the PRI, began requiring the use of computers to allocate low-income housing. This idea of replacing government officials with an automated decision-making system was framed as a more "democratic process," and was part of a clever rhetorical strategy by the new president, Luis Echeverría, who was seeking to win back the support of the CTM Workers' Union and restore the party's legitimacy after the Tlatelolco Massacre. In the following years, housing bureaucracies invested in developing a computer center at UNAM in Mexico City for housing research. The mortgage lender INFONAVIT became the largest user of this center, and the Banco de México developed applied futurological models that weighed projected housing insecurity against economic growth.

Using the same housing research center, the Banco de México also conducted a study of 6,000 miles of coastline to create a computer model to select the location of five new tourist enclaves, most famously, Cancún. Although similar in method, this simulation model reflects a shift in Mexican economic policy away from public housing to housing international tourists, illustrated in the variables of risk, where data on income and family size were replaced with mosquitoes, sharks, sand color, weather, and water drinkability. These enclaves were publicized through economic models that improved opportunities for farmers and laborers, despite the reality of life in the resorts, where low-paying seasonal employment rarely benefited locals.

Through an institutional history of this housing research center at UNAM, I will demonstrate how modeling risk was central to understanding a shift in the practices of Mexican housing bureaucracies in the 1970s and part of a strategy to attract international investment. In particular, I highlight the rhetorical language of computerized "democratic" decision-making which was used by policymakers to avoid the risk of concerns about political corruption.

PS32 Open Session - Recalcitrant Spaces in Home and Housing

Session Chair: Cecilia L. Chu, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Closed Doors: Masculinity & Queer Dungeons in the American Garage

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Abstract

This paper investigates how overlooked domestic spaces, particularly garages and basements, shape gendered subjectivities outside normative domestic scripts. Long treated as unfinished, peripheral, or leftover zones of the home, these spaces have functioned as sites of retreat, containment, and experimentation. Focusing on the queer BDSM dungeon as a primary case study, this paper argues that such leftover domestic spaces enable alternative architectural practices that challenge dominant expectations of privacy, propriety, and control.

Situating the dungeon within a broader genealogy of American domestic leftovers, the paper briefly contrasts it with the suburban man cave, a space the author has previously analyzed as an architecture of toxic masculinity and patriarchal retreat in *Sick Architecture* (MIT Press, 2025). Where the man cave is structured around withdrawal, ownership, and entitlement, the queer BDSM dungeon reframes these same leftover spaces through intentional design, negotiated boundaries, and consent-based use. In this sense, the dungeon stages a form of intentional masculinity, one organized around responsibility, vulnerability, and mutual agreement rather than domination or escape.

Drawing on the author's dissertation research (*Slut Architecture*), including oral histories, archival fragments, and spatial fieldwork, this paper positions garages as domestic spaces that sit at the edge of the home's moral and architectural order. Their material informality and adaptive construction support forms of spatial use shaped through conversation, negotiation, and embodied knowledge rather than fixed domestic scripts. In these interiors, masculinity is not presumed or inherited but intentionally produced through spatial practice, negotiation, and consent.

By centering the queer BDSM dungeon as an architectural practice rather than a subcultural curiosity, this paper contributes to an architectural historiography that acknowledges how queer subjects inhabit and remake domestic space, often with more intentionality and consent than those adhering to the heteronormative script.

PS32 Open Session - Recalcitrant Spaces in Home and Housing

Session Chair: Cecilia L. Chu, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Thresholds of Belonging: Placemaking in Jersey City's Ethnoburbs

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Abstract

This paper examines how immigrant placemaking reshapes spatial identity in Jersey City, ranked the most ethnically diverse city in the United States, and a compelling example of New Jersey's polycentric "ethnoburbs." Unlike planned suburban enclaves in California or Canada, Jersey City's corridors such as Journal Square and Central Avenue, emerge from layered infrastructures shaped by Lenape byways, colonial grids, postwar highways, exclusionary zoning, and contemporary digital platforms.

Within this context, diverse immigrant populations, including South Asian, East Asian, Latin American, Middle Eastern, Caribbean, and Eastern European communities, transform threshold spaces such as storefronts, sidewalks, transit stops, and entrances into everyday zones of belonging, negotiation, and visibility. Drawing on spatial ethnography, archival research, and participatory cognitive mapping, the study reveals how infrastructural fragmentation can paradoxically foster collective identity.

Building on Kevin Lynch's theory of imageability, the research frames these urban thresholds (Giloi, 2019) as material and symbolic mediators between mobility, memory, and contestation. Episodes such as the Dotbusters attacks of the 1980s underscore how racialized violence becomes spatialized and how urban and suburban streets become sites of resistance and reinvention over time.

Rather than reading ethnoburbs as culturally fixed zones of ethnic clustering, the paper theorizes them as spatially dynamic and historically layered arenas where plural identities are actively negotiated. It expands the methodological toolkit of architectural and urban history by linking urban morphology with cultural geography and digital mediation. By offering an East Coast perspective grounded in the everyday spatial practices of one of America's most diverse cities, this research reframes ethnoburbs as vital platforms for reimagining identity, infrastructure, and suburban heritage in post-1965 America.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

Post-Independence African Eco-Brutalism, 3 Case Studies

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Abstract

Following the Second World War, newly independent nations across the Global South commissioned ambitious public architectural projects as part of a broader effort to articulate postcolonial national identities. In several African countries, such as Morocco, Senegal, and Burkina Faso, this drive took the form of a localized Modernism rooted in Brutalist design principles—marked by rational forms and exposed concrete—combined with climate-responsive strategies such as passive cooling, the reinterpretation of vernacular forms and patterns, and the use of local materials.

This paper explores the emergence of what may be termed “eco-brutalism” in three emblematic public post-independence works: the thermal complex of Sidi Harazem by Jean-François Zevaco, the Dakar International Fair (CICES) by Jean-François Lamoureux and Jean-Louis Marin, and the Maison du Peuple in Ouagadougou by René Faublée. Designed in the 1960s and 1970s, these complexes remain striking for their material economy, high thermal performance, and spatial adaptability. Their continued relevance, despite programmatic obsolescence and lack of maintenance, underscores the capacity of their architecture to endure through vernacular resonance, climate appropriateness and community appropriation.

Drawing on archival documents and oral histories (www.modernwestafrica.org) gathered by the architecture office of Aziza Chaouni Projects' (ACP), responsible for the rehabilitation of the three sites, this paper analyzes the socio-political conditions and discourses that gave rise to eco-brutalism and the ways these three emblematic sites were built, inhabited and have evolved. It presents a comparative reading of their environmental design logics, their adaptive reuse potentials, and how local users have shaped their transformation over time. By foregrounding the environmental intelligence embedded in these post-independence projects, this study challenges the notion that sustainable design principles in African architecture are limited to vernacular typologies and highlights the urgent need to preserve these threatened modern legacies.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

South American Pachyderms and their Not-So-Beloved Legacy

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Abstract

Lina Bo Bardi once said she wanted her much-celebrated concrete building for the SESC Pompeia sports complex (1977) “to be ugly, much uglier” than her former Museum of Art of São Paulo (1957-1968). The MASP building was also a massive reinforced concrete structure, but its critical reception had been much more uneven than that of the Pompeia Factory reuse project. Oddly enough, when MASP was just about to be inaugurated, after more than a decade of a complicated building process, she published a drawing of the building’s big span, a technical tour de force, depicting it as an already aged structure, marked by small crack lines and taken over by vegetation, like a decaying ruin where nature had eventually prevailed over blinding dreams of progress.

Clorindo Testa repeatedly compared his National Library (Buenos Aires, 1962-1992), a colossal building rising over four giant concrete pillars, to the prehistoric glyptodont skeleton discovered during excavations for the building's construction. Testa’s architecture was never free from a controversial reception, particularly the Library, which took a long time to build and remained for years as an incomplete structure “not easily digestible”, as a critic put it.

Antipathy toward huge concrete buildings has not been an uncommon feeling, either for ethical or aesthetic reasons (recalling Reyner Banham’s inaugural question on Brutalism). If the environmental shift reevaluated the brutalist legacy as proof of a failed developmentalist ethic, it is worth noting that aesthetic issues played perhaps a more complex and even contradictory role.

The paper addresses the brutalist legacy through its overlooked ambivalences. I will argue that Bo Bardi and Testa’s contested aesthetics unveil two antagonistic presences. Biomorphic, biophilic, and archaic dimensions are, without conciliatory maneuvers, an intrinsic and intriguing part of a boldly technical solution, remorselessly confident in progress and human mastery over nature.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

Soft Brutalism and the Anticipatory Ruin

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Abstract

Brutalism in Brazil is generally associated with the modernist Paulista School; the moniker first appears in Bruno Alfieri's 1960 essay "João Vilanova Artigas: Ricerca brutalista" in *Zodiac* 6. Yet an expanded interpretation of Brazilian brutalism may be traced back to the deft pen of Lúcio Costa and the imaginative pencil of Lina Bo Bardi. Each articulates what may be described as "soft brutalism" in Brazil, envisioning tropical plant life provoking a slow decomposition of form. Costa notes the synthesis of climate and concrete -- the defining element of brutalist architecture -- in his 1951 essay "Testimony of a Carioca Architect: Concrete, Sun, and Vegetation," adapted from his letter to Gustavo Capanema advocating for the designation of the Ministério da Educação e Saúde building (1942) as a national landmark. After lauding the plastic inventiveness of concrete in the hands of Brazilian structural engineers, Costa adds two key elements: the tropical climate and vibrant plant material, with "nature itself invited to be part of the plan." He identifies the contributions of landscape architect Roberto Burle Marx, who shaped the sky gardens and ground planes of the MES building, softening its forms to receive atmosphere and plant life. As Achille Mbembe notes in his 2020 text, brutalism seen through a political lens might be understood as a slow demolition, a fracturing and fissuring. This image of an anticipatory ruin is evoked by Lina Bo Bardi, the Paulistana architect who brought the essence of Costa's "Concrete, Sun, and Vegetation" to her early projects Casa Cirell (1958) and Casa do Chame-Chame (1964) as well as the Museu de Arte de São Paulo (1968). With her evocative colored pencil drawings, Bardi renders animate plant forms fracturing the solidity of concrete, with tropical vegetation provoking future decay—perhaps an appropriate metaphor foreshadowing the *anos de chumbo* and cultural resistance.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

A global environmental history of a Congolese 'Concrete Monster'

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Abstract

Between 1968 and 1974 an imposing building emerged in the skyline Kinshasa, the then capital city of the country known today as the Democratic Republic of Congo. Initially designed as the headquarters of the United Nations in Congo, it still accommodates today the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The building which could be labelled a 'Concrete Monster' (*SOS Brutalism*, 2017), displays an obsession with the 'vertical' which formed an essential dimension in president Mobutu's nation building project and is, as Achille Mbembe recently suggested, one of Brutalism's "privileged positions" (Mbembe 2020/2024). Designed by a team of architects led by Sicilian born Eugenio Palumbo, one of the complex's most striking features is a spectacular cantilevered folded roof plate in concrete, covering the assembly hall. Designing and constructing this roof was a challenge, as becomes clear from archival documents from the *Compagnie Congolaise de Construction* (CCC), the Belgian firm responsible for erecting the building. In this paper we propose, however, to focus on less spectacular fragments of its architecture, by investigating a particular source within the CCC's archive: the extensive series of so-called "bons de commande" which enable us to trace the origin of all building materials and components used. In line with Kiel Moe's work (2017, 2020), this source allows us to situate this particular 'Concrete Monster' in a wide and global geography of supply chains, ranging from Congo to Belgium, to Europe and even Canada. More importantly, these "bons de commande" also offer a powerful starting point to write an environmental history of construction in post-independent Central Africa, tracing the use of materials such as concrete, copper, wood and asbestos cement and the businesses involved. Such history, we argue, inevitably confronts us with unsettling stories of labor, extraction, deforestation and (post)imperial debris (Stoler, 2013) across a wide geographical scale.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

Tropical Monsters, Brutalist works in Medellín.

David Vélez

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Abstract

Between 1960 and 1980, architects trained in traditional technical schools, responded to ambitious programs by designing buildings that projected institutional presence at Medellín, Colombia. University halls, theatres, offices, and social housing complexes were conceived using expressive formal and structural systems, primarily in concrete and brick, that embodied the last progress ideologies.

Often labeled as brutalist due to their material presence, these buildings stand out today in two contradictory ways. On one hand, they are criticized in preservation debates as costly, inflexible, or visually awkward. On the other, they are increasingly viewed as obsolete with the current expectations of technology and efficiency. Despite such critiques, many of these works have endured as eccentric monuments within the city's landscape, maintaining a largely overlooked quality: an appropriate and often sophisticated response to tropical environmental conditions through the original material logic.

This paper analyzes selected examples of Medellín's brutalist architecture through both historical and environmental lenses. It asks what lessons does the history of these buildings offer for rethinking environmental adaptability in architecture from the Global Sout. Drawing on theories of material ethics in architecture (Vidler 2014), contemporaneous architectural discourses, and recent scholarship on Latin American brutalism (Zein 2023), the study seeks to move beyond purely stylistic or preservationist readings. Instead, it emphasizes the symbolic, political, and environmental dimensions that define these tropical monsters. As Daniel Barber (2019) declares in his historical studies, what emerged with these works is also resonant across a possible future?

Rather than calling for their literal "repair," this study underscores that these buildings inherently embodied environmental intelligence from their inception. Their contemporary significance does not rest on adaptability alone, but on how they disrupt prevailing narratives of obsolescence, providing critical insights into how architecture from the Global South engaged with climate, materiality, and ideology well before today's ecological crisis.

PS33 Repairing/Demolishing: An Environmental History of Brutalism

Session Chair: Joaquin Barriendos, Tecnologico de Monterrey, Mexico

Ecological Aesthetics and the Spectacle of Brutalism in the Aftershock of Morocco's Agadir Earthquake

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Abstract

As the Moroccan contemporary artist Yto Barrada asked in her 2018 Barbican Center exhibition exploring the ghosts of 1960 Agadir earthquake, "How does one conceive reconstruction after a disaster?" At the time of Agadir's reconstruction, Brasilia was being constructed and Chandigarh was nearly fully constructed. Both Brazil and India were once colonized, like Morocco, and their embrace of functionalist urbanism and an architecture of raw reinforced-concrete was just as much a political decision as it was an aesthetic one, just like in Morocco. If brutalism came about in Europe in response to the devastation wrought by the Second World War, as a reflection of the aesthetics of destruction, and in India and Brazil as a future-oriented embrace of the utopic promises of high-modernism, then in Agadir, both of these founts of brutalism come together at the intersection of an ecological event that accelerated decolonization efforts. And yet, many critics of the Agadir reconstruction questioned the spectacle of high-modernist monumental architecture and asked: For whom was the new city intended for? This paper argues that brutalism in Agadir, while embraced as part of various future-oriented, nation-building strategies, was charged with traumas of the past caused by colonialism, war, and nature-induced disasters. What happens when we think of brutalism alongside ecological phenomenon like earthquakes? And how do we account for the runoff and other destructive ecological impacts of concrete production in local communities? This paper will focus on some of the top-down politics and aesthetics of the reconstruction of Agadir as part of Morocco's history of decolonization while also tracking some of the critiques of this nation-building project from below in form of a avant-garde short film titled *Retour á Agadir* (*Return to Agadir*) by Mohammed Afifi.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

Designing at the Margins: Migrant Women's Infrastructural Counter-Practices in Río Azul, Costa Rica

Silvia Mata-Marin

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Abstract

Situated on the eastern periphery of Costa Rica's Central Valley, the mountain range of Cerro la Carpintera marks a spatial boundary between the Greater Metropolitan Area and the rest of the national territory. On its steep slopes lies Río Azul, a marginalized urban neighborhood that originated informally from the remains of the city's former sanitary landfill. Today, Río Azul emerges as a complex socio-environmental landscape, shaped by precarious topography, environmental toxicity, and exclusionary urban policies, where its informal dwellings and infrastructure reflect both sociopolitical abandonment and practices of spatial resistance.

Focusing on the lived experiences of undocumented Nicaraguan women in Río Azul, whose everyday practices of care build and reveal alternative forms of infrastructural design, this paper shows how migrant women navigate a terrain marked by state neglect and legal invisibility, developing essential infrastructures—such as water distribution systems, care networks, barter practices, and spatial modifications for accessibility and safety—that are neither state-provided nor formally recognized.

Drawing from ethnographic fieldwork and framed by critical border studies, feminist theory, decolonial thought, and political geography, the research conceptualizes Río Azul as a *borderland landscape* (Mezzadra and Neilson 2013). In this context, the colonial logic of difference is materially embedded in the spatial configurations that regulate movement, access, and recognition. The paper argues that the design practices emerging from this contested space enact a form of *material politics*, in which design operates both as a means of spatial reconfiguration under undocumented conditions and as a strategy of redistribution, resistance, and autonomy.

Ultimately, this paper positions undocumented women's infrastructural practices not as mere survival tactics but as political acts that challenge dominant urban and national imaginaries. Their work renders visible other ways of world-making, where design becomes a tool for constructing the communal through care, reciprocity, and embodied knowledge.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

Ella Briggs in Movement: New Ways to Write and Archive History

Despina Stratigakos

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Abstract

The challenges to documenting the histories of women architects increase with women's migration across national borders. Many early female practitioners of architecture relocated—sometimes multiple times—to pursue professional opportunities. Such moves contributed to women becoming conduits for new ideas, including modernism. But it also made it harder to tell their stories. Expatriation often leads to the loss of archival materials. Additionally, historians need a broader range of linguistic skills and cultural expertise to navigate these varied settings. As a result, women architects who built vibrant practices through migration remain vastly understudied.

This paper presents a new model of collaborative architectural historiography and archival practice developed to produce a biography of Ella Briggs. A significant but largely unknown modernist architect, Briggs was active for over fifty years and in six countries. Previous attempts to write about her struggled to transcend national boundaries, obscuring the importance of her international activity.

Despina Stratigakos addresses the two-year-collaborative project (co-led with Elana Shapira, University of Applied Arts Vienna) that brought together an international group of sixteen historians, architects, writers, and curators. She explores why a team approach was needed, how the collaborative was formed, and their methods of working, including lessons learned along the way. She also discusses how the Architekturzentrum Wien partnered with this transnational collective to create the Ella Briggs Archive as a hybrid model for women architects whose papers no longer survive.

The Ella Briggs biography project demonstrates that a novel team-based approach to making history and creating archives can overcome many of the limitations faced by scholars and institutions working on their own. It also confronts the pragmatic and systemic challenges involved in developing new historiographical and archival practices to capture the rich histories of women architects in migration.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

Alternative Cartographies: Trans Women's Agency in Queens

Laura Rojas

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Abstract

This paper examines how trans migrant women in Jackson Heights, Queens, exercise collective power by appropriating public spaces. This creates what I call alternative cartographies of New York City, which challenge dominant spatial narratives and exclusionary urban practices. Through ethnographic observation and spatial analysis of street-based activities including food distribution, drag performances, and political demonstrations, this research reveals how women historically marginalized by intersecting systems of race, ethnicity, migration status, and gender identity actively reshape urban landscapes through embodied spatial practices.

Alternative Cartographies moves beyond traditional narratives that confine immigrant women to the domestic sphere. This work centers on their lived experiences, as they simultaneously inhabit multiple locations—both physically, through transnational connections, and spatially, through the transformation of Jackson Heights' streetscapes. Drawing on Jack Halberstam's work on queer temporal and spatial arrangements, I argue that their "taking of the streets" represents more than temporary occupation. It constitutes world-making that produces new spatial categories and challenges the normative boundaries between public and private, belonging and displacement. Four years of collaboration (2019-2022) with the *Colectivo Intercultural TRANSgrediendo* has connected me to what I conceptualize as a "living archive", one constituted through organizational activities, shared histories, street demonstrations, and community networks of mutual aid. Through these practices, the trans migrant women I encountered transform their positioning within the city's political and social life, even while navigating uncertain immigration status. Rather than being constrained by legal precarity, they organize collectively as active political subjects, creating overlapping geographies of care, celebration, and resistance that extend beyond conventional neighborhood mapping.

This paper contributes to architectural history by foregrounding how gender, migration, and spatial practice intersect to produce new forms of urban belonging. In that sense, *Alternative Cartographies* reveal Jackson Heights as a dynamic space where marginalized bodies assert presence and claim rights to the city.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

Mapping Female Migration: Landscapes of Mobility in Bouchra Khalili's Work

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Abstract

In her "The Wet Feet Series," created in Florida in 2012, French-Moroccan photographer and multimedia artist Bouchra Khalili focuses on the traces left by forced female migrants from Latin America and the Caribbean onto concrete objects and architectures placed in (urban) nature—stranded boats, makeshift floats, and rusted containers along the Miami River. Her environmental photographs are based on the "wet foot, dry foot" policy, which allowed only Cuban immigrants who reached the U.S. shore to stay, but promptly rejected those who were intercepted in national waters. This paper explores how Khalili's photographs mark the transitory time between stasis and mobility, while taking into account the parallels drawn between trade routes and bodies, and the scars left by women's migratory experience. I contrast her photography with the "The Mapping Journey Project" (2008-2011), which was created via collaborative storytelling with refugees and prominently exhibited at the 2024 Venice Biennale "Strangers Everywhere." In an 8-channel video installation of static shots, refugees here draw their circuitous migration routes with a black permanent marker on maps, metonymically inscribing their bodies onto the environment. Carving out landscapes of global migration routes as active agents, immigrant women draw alternative maps of the Mediterranean and inscribe their circuitous forced journeys of loss and unrooting onto what become (geo)graphic abstractions. I show how they hereby offer their personal and civic narratives as acts of defiance if not resistance, allowing Khalili's audience to understand the tracing of migration routes as new ways of female environmental worldmaking via visual and spatial representations of mobility.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

Housing sites and spatial constructions of women labourers in mid-twentieth century Singapore

Eunice Seng

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Abstract

Until the 1930s depression, Chinese immigration to Singapore was predominantly male. The women first came, worked, sent their remittances back to families in South China villages, and hoped to return eventually. Many found work as contract laborers at construction sites. Most were "Sansui women," named after the "Three Waters" district in Guangdong Province. The women were the end of a small stream of the many waves of immigrants to South-East Asia. They lived together in shared accommodations in Chinatown, mostly on Upper Chin Chew Street, known as "Women Street," and Upper Nankin Street. In the early 1950s, some engineers, frustrated with the shortage of skilled construction labor, complained that the women in the building industry "never wanted to become anything else but laborers"—they were, at best, "helpers for the tradesmen." Later, a 1960 report on the conditions of Upper Nankin Street, conducted by a research fellow at the University of Malaya, contained an explanation for why the survey did not include Upper Chin Chew Street: the women did not want to be interviewed. At the start of Singapore's housing program in 1960, these "unskilled" laborers were still working on construction sites throughout a young country undergoing radical transformation. Their distinctive red headgear dotted the radically changing landscape of scaffolding, concrete, and debris as they worked silently, carrying sand buckets. After her passing, the samsui woman became a national construct. Drawing on the 1986 drama series Samsui Women and the 2023 film Sisterhood, this paper examines the "worlds" the women inhabited and built, and the systemic exclusion that shaped their spatial practices and perpetuated their perceived "unskilled-ness." It aims to recast Singapore's housing past through the lens of migrant women's labor and interrogate the contesting representations and lived realities of development amid a changing social milieu.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

From Fredericksburg to Harlem: The Architectural Journey of a Woman's Migration

Robert Louis Brandon Edwards

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Abstract

Ruby Rollins was born in a racially segregated Fredericksburg, Virginia in 1939. Retail stores, theaters, and hospitals were segregated. Ruby occupied many labor roles as a child, including harvesting crops by hand. When she was 15-years-old, she gave birth to her first daughter, Cindy. When she was 19-years-old, she gave birth to her second daughter, Linda. The three of them lived with Addie, Ruby's mother, in a four-room white-cinder-block house with two bedrooms, a kitchen, and a living room. The outhouse was located in the backyard and the water pump was located in the front yard. To provide for her two girls, Ruby worked at a cellophane factory and as a short-order cook at a diner where Black customers could only place to-go orders and Black employees had to enter through the back of the building.

Upward mobility for African American women was almost impossible in a racially segregated southern town. In 1964, Ruby packed up her girls and boarded a bus at the Greyhound Bus Depot and migrated to New York City. When she arrived, she, like many of the other Black southern migrants temporarily settled with relatives who had already migrated and begun constructing their worlds. Soon after, Ruby found work at a printing factory where she continued to build a life for her girls.

Both Cindy and Linda graduated from college and retired from successful careers. Linda had a son who is currently the first Black PhD candidate in Historic Preservation in the United States. Although many of the buildings associated with Ruby's journey no longer exist, the legacy and the world that she built not *in*, but rather *through* migration, will continue to thrive as I am Ruby's grandson.

PS34 Women and the Worlds They Build in Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Arijit Sen, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA, and Maria Rose Francis, University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, USA

The Jacaranda as Transcultural Symbol Between Mexico and Brazil

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Abstract

The French gardener Gilles Clément declares that to comprehend the landscape, it is necessary to perceive the circulation of plants on a global scale, as they, oriented by the immutable laws of nature and counterposed to the desire for habitat transformation characteristic of human activity, abandon their original territory and establish themselves in others, in a perpetual movement of landscape hybridization. This erratic phenomenon of plants links distant places and is conditioned by social, cultural, aesthetic, anthropological, and scientific factors. The Jacaranda is a South American native tree widely disseminated throughout Brazilian rainforests. From the end of the 19th century, this tree began migrating to far-off places in the world, such as Mexico City, where it has been used in gardens and parks due to its beautiful flowers. Hence, this proposal explores the historical, social, and cultural meanings of the Jacaranda within the transculturation processes of Brazilian and Mexican landscapes. The interdisciplinary approach circumscribes this proposal's methodological perspective, shedding light on Cultural and Environmental History, Landscape Architecture Studies, Anthropology, Aesthetics, and Geography, researching how the Jacaranda became a cultural identity symbol in places so far from each other. This approach will utilize iconography, along with old and new photographs, in order to articulate the meaning of the Jacaranda in the landscape connections between Brazil and Mexico, indicating the agents (architects, artists, politicians, and people) who have participated in the construction of the Jacaranda's itinerary between both countries throughout history. Thus, we can think of the Jacaranda as one of the symbols of the cross-border Americas, whose landscapes are in a constant process of hybridization.

PS35 Plant Back: Gardening As Transformative Practice

Session Co-Chairs: Anette Freytag, Rutgers University, USA, and Rosetta

Seeds of Diplomacy: The Araucaria araucana and the British Consul in Chile (c. 1825)

Camila Medina Novoa

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Abstract

On 7 April 1826, Chilean deputy Diego José Benavente wrote a letter to the trader, agriculturalist, and politician Antonio Pantaleón Fernández thanking him for the *piñones* (*Araucaria araucana* seeds) he had sent. The seeds came from forests in Pehuenche Indigenous territory near Concepción and had recently become a desired ornamental species in London. They had, in fact, been requested by a mysterious third party—most likely the British Consul Christopher Richard Nugent, who knew Benavente, had an interest in the species, and had promised that same year to help James McRae, a collector for the Royal Horticultural Society, obtain the seeds. These were later distributed to botanical gardens in the UK, as well as to nurserymen and "pine-tribe" collectors affiliated with the society.

Because *Araucaria araucana* could not be propagated by vegetative methods, its presence in Britain depended on successful seed collection and transport, making British figures in Chile—such as Consul Nugent and McRae—essential for its transplantation. The species' biological characteristics and reproductive rhythms, in this sense, prompted journeys and social encounters among Britons, Chileans, and Pehuenche Indigenous communities. These exchanges entangled diplomatic interests with scientific and botanical ambitions at a moment when the newly independent Chilean republic was seeking formal recognition from Britain while attempting to resist new forms of economic dependency.

By following the movement of *piñones* through journals, letters, and transplantation manuals, this paper explores how trees—in the form of seeds and seedlings—became mediators in diplomatic exchange. Drawing on the diplomatic functions later codified in the *Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations* (1961)—representation, negotiation, and communication—I examine how *Araucaria araucana* circulated within political, scientific, and horticultural networks, shaping relations between Chile and Britain during the early nineteenth century. In doing so, the paper proposes that the species' biological characteristics and modes of circulation materially participated in these exchanges, a connection that would later become visible in the growing popularity of *Araucaria araucana* in Victorian gardens.

PS35 Plant Back: Gardening As Transformative Practice

Session Co-Chairs: Anette Freytag, Rutgers University, USA, and Rosetta

Gaimenteki Doka: Gardening as Resistance in Japanese Internment Camps

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Abstract

During WWII, persons of Japanese ancestry living in the western United States were unconstitutionally incarcerated during Japanese American Internment. Building on the previous work of Anna Tamura and Kenneth Helphand, and through recent field study of Amache National Historic Site in partnership with the US National Parks Service, I will examine acts of gardening by internees and reinterpret the meaning of these gardens.

Internment camp gardens were, on the surface, benign. Beautification of camp grounds aligned with the desires of government officials and was a peaceful activity. While other Japanese cultural practices were disallowed, gardening was encouraged.

And yet, gardens embodied resistance. Camp gardens stood in stark contrast against a hostile architectural backdrop of barracks and barbed wire. Against pressure to "Americanize", camp gardens became manifestations of Japanese religious practices and aesthetics.

The outward assimilation and inward resistance demonstrated by camp gardens is a survival strategy referred to as *gaimenteki doka*, and had existed for centuries prior to Internment. As a third-generation Japanese American, my lived experience reflects the impact that hegemonic pressure to assimilate has had as cultural traditions have been withheld or stripped away.

Internment camp gardens reflect an aporia; they are sites at which the binary logic of Japanese/American, and of resistance/compliance begins to unravel. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak once asked "Can the Subaltern Speak?" In similar fashion I ask what resistance was possible under such conditions.

Like plants, interned Japanese were forced to adapt; they carved out the conditions for their survival. Camp gardens were a critical part of this process eighty years ago, and they continue to be relevant today. This paper asks: what can a more nuanced analysis of camp gardens tell us about cultural identity, about survival, and about resistance in the face of injustice?

PS35 Plant Back: Gardening As Transformative Practice

Session Co-Chairs: Anette Freytag, Rutgers University, USA, and Rosetta

Plants and Pruning: Relational Infrastructure in Premodern China

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Abstract

In Chinese environmental and scientific histories, plants have often been portrayed as passive— either as victims of urbanization or as managed resources within agrarian systems. Similarly, garden history tends to emphasize plants as symbolic or aesthetic forms, drawing heavily from Chinese literary traditions. These perspectives privilege elite textual sources, often overlooking everyday practices, the material agency of plants, and the indigenous knowledge systems that shaped human-plant relations.

This paper reconsiders plants as active participants in landscape-making through two case studies from premodern southern China. The first examines bamboo, a versatile material integral to architecture, craft, food, and daily life. Its growth cycles, embedded in traditional calendars, structured seasonal labor and informed the spatial and temporal organization of domestic and literati life. The second case explores the pollarding (*kūn*) of willows along waterways. This cyclical pruning produced fuel and building materials, maintained hydraulic systems, and created vernacular landscape forms that shaped both the visual and literary image of the region. These cases demonstrate how human-plant relations— and the interspecies practices they entail— constituted a form of relational infrastructure, sustained through interdependent, cyclical, and generational acts of care, labor, and adaptation. Rather than passive subjects of cultivation, plants emerge as co-creators in shaping daily life, settlement patterns, and material environments.

By foregrounding these relational practices, the paper challenges the anthropocentric hierarchies underlying many historical narratives. It advocates for methodological approaches attentive to practice, materiality, labor, and indigenous knowledge, proposing a model of landscape history grounded in situated relationality and reciprocal human-plant interaction.

PS35 Plant Back: Gardening As Transformative Practice

Session Co-Chairs: Anette Freytag, Rutgers University, USA, and Rosetta

A Critical History of Plants in Design

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Abstract

This article argues for a critical reorientation of landscape architectural historiography by foregrounding plants not merely as ecological or aesthetic components but as historically situated, politically charged, and culturally mediated agents within design practice. Drawing on a recently developed course, A Critical History of Plants in Design, the essay examines how landscape architecture has historically relied on dualistic frameworks—plants as either ecological service or formal material—that obscure the complex sociopolitical dynamics embedded in selection, use, and representation. Through close analysis of historical texts, planting precedents, and botanical discourse, the article demonstrates how design professions have been shaped by colonial taxonomies, racialized ideologies, and gendered labor hierarchies, all of which have governed the management and marginalization of plant life.

By centering plants as both subjects and collaborators, the article outlines a methodology for interpreting vegetal material through decolonial, feminist, and multispecies frameworks. Topics such as nativist planting ideologies and the devaluation of land stewardship labor are presented to illuminate how regulatory and affective structures constrain contemporary plant practices. The article concludes by reflecting on the pedagogical implications of a plant-centered historiography and, in doing so, it advocates for rethinking the role of plants in shaping not only landscapes but also the cultural and epistemic terrains of the design disciplines.

PS35 Plant Back: Gardening As Transformative Practice

Session Co-Chairs: Anette Freytag, Rutgers University, USA, and Rosetta

Casting Shade: Acacia nilotica and Cash Crop Cultivation in the Nile Valley, 1821-1868

Samaa Elimam

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Abstract

At the heart of urban Alexandria, a long, narrow square, *Place des Consuls*, hosted the world's first cotton futures exchange in 1861. The square featured two circular fountains at each end, an equestrian statue of Ottoman viceroy Mehmed Ali Pasha (r. 1805–1848) at the center, and two perimeter allées of *Acacia nilotica* trees. Yet the growth habit of *Acacia nilotica*, with jagged, thorny branches and dense, tannin-filled pods did not quite fit into the polished urban setting, often described as cosmopolitan. Though native to the Nile Valley, the relationship of *Acacia nilotica* to the long-staple cotton seed it helped cultivate was entirely obscured. It has a similar fate in historical scholarship.

This paper centers *Acacia nilotica* (gum Arabic tree, Arabic: *sanṭ*) as an undervalued plant in the historiography on cash crop agriculture in late Ottoman Egypt. Surrounded by vast, treeless deserts, inhabitants of the Nile Valley found the timber of *Acacia* species indispensable for boats, buildings, and irrigation works. Medieval scholars like Ibn Khaldun celebrated *Acacia nilotica* in lyrical terms, as a nurturing, life-giving resource. By the nineteenth century under Mehmed Ali, the significance of *Acacia nilotica* reached new heights as the administration aggressively promoted tree planting of multiple *Acacia* species. Landscapes were transformed, from basin irrigation that supported subsistence farming, to perennial irrigation that served a cash crop economy. When the viceroy invaded Sudan in 1821, his eyes were set on the abundant *Acacia* forests of the Upper Nile, now also valued for gum Arabic. While existing scholarship investigates Mehmed Ali's exploitation of the countryside for large-scale cotton cultivation, less examined is the expanded plant economy, including the critical role of *Acacia nilotica* in sustaining this increasingly productive landscape. Cotton relies on nutrient-rich silt, which could not have survived without the irrigation devices built from durable *Acacia* timber, nor its ability to replenish the soil. The paper aims to remedy this oversight, but also to appreciate the unruliness of the tree, its refusal to be smoothly subsumed into an anodyne story of cosmopolitan modernity. How did *Acacia nilotica* push back against these changes, and how would the historical urban narrative change if the tree was brought back into consideration?

PS36 Erasure and Resilience in Eastern European Architectures

Session Co-Chairs: Dimitrij Zadorin, Edinburgh School of Architecture and Landscape Architecture, Scotland, and Aleksander Musial, gta Institut, ETH-Zürich

Settlement, after 1861

Alla Vronskaya

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Abstract

Responding for this panel's call for reflections on the global relevance of Eastern European architecture by prioritizing its transnational legacies, this presentation proposes examining connections between historic events and architectural models developed in Eastern Europe and settlement in its colonies, above all, in Central Asia.

The year 1861 was a milestone for the Russian empire: after decades of failed attempts, serfdom, which often amounted to slavery, was finally abolished. Having solved one, the emancipation of the serfs (bound peasants), however, opened other problems. If in the past, the landlord ensured that every peasant had enough land to cover for his family's needs, now, growing peasant families were left with continuously subdividing their plots, which led to land degradation, impoverishment, and waves of famine. Solving "the agrarian question" now became the task of the state. As my presentation will argue, this state intervention, which unfolded in the course of the second half of the nineteenth century following the gradual aggravation of the situation and culminated with the reform of 1904—a state-led mass resettlement of peasants in Siberia—was conceived in connection to the expansion of the empire.

Focusing on the simultaneous Russian penetration into Central Asia, the presentation will explore the legacy of Peter Semenov Tian-Shansky, a geographer, explorer, statistician, art dealer and connoisseur, and a key participant in the discussion around the emancipation of the serfs and the resettlement of peasants. Comparing research conducted in connection to colonial settlement and to peasant re-settlement, particularly in what concerns the study of existing settlement types in their natural setting, and speculative proposals for new types of settlement, the presentation will argue that this entangled work laid the ground for the later development of human and regional geography, and with it—for late-imperial and early-Soviet ideas about location and urbanism.

PS36 Erasure and Resilience in Eastern European Architectures

Session Co-Chairs: Dimitrij Zadorin, Edinburgh School of Architecture and Landscape Architecture, Scotland, and Aleksander Musial, gta Institut, ETH-Zürich

Czech Architects in Adriatic Paradise: Cultural Colonialism as Inter-Imperialism

Ladislav Jackson

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Abstract

In the short period between 1900 and 1912, we can trace the intense interest of architects from the Czech lands in designing for Czech and Austrian investors in the Adriatic countries — today's northern Italy, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina. The Czech lands had been a politically secondary country since the Austro-Hungarian Compromise in 1867, but they were of primary economic importance to the empire. The Adriatic region began to play a similar role, which from the 1870s began to transform into a cheap resort for Austrian clients. This was also the case with the architect Jan Kotěra, who focused his creative ambitions on the Adriatic between 1910 and 1912. If we look at his individual projects, we see different variants of client constellations, which all had the same goal: to create infrastructure for the reorientation of the previous rural coastal area into a segment of recreational services, dependent on Austrian capital. This short episode in the biographies of a number of Czech architects shows the strategy of negotiating with imperial power: instead of solidarity and common resistance, the Czechs joined the Austrian colonization of an even weaker territory with the prospect of supposed advantages. The article shows the activities of Czech architects in the Adriatic just before the outbreak of the Balkan Wars as a symptom of the so-called inter-imperiality, a concept proposed by Laura Doyle for smaller entities that were subject to changing ambitions of domination, which is the case of the Adriatic and the Czech Lands. The Czech architectural colonization of the Adriatic shows that small countries dominated by modern empires did not have to be only in the role of the dominated, but could also be complicit in the colonization of other territories in order to gain a higher status within the imperial order.

PS36 Erasure and Resilience in Eastern European Architectures

Session Co-Chairs: Dimitrij Zadorin, Edinburgh School of Architecture and Landscape Architecture, Scotland, and Aleksander Musial, gta Institut, ETH-Zürich

Cellular Vaults and Repair of Fifteenth-century War-torn Bohemia

Alice Klima

University of Florida, USA

Abstract

Cellular (or prismatic) vaults were built throughout Eastern and Central Europe from 1471 until the early 16th century. The shapes are so abstract and angular they later inspired the so-called “cubist” architecture in the early 20th century. Despite their impressive features, these vaults and accompanying structures are often overlooked in histories of architecture, not only since they have been on the geographic periphery of European art, but also since they do not fit neatly into traditional Gothic and Renaissance periodization. While these liminal designs have been ignored, even marginalized, I will show the style created visual unification and renewal in a war-torn land.

In the fourteenth century, the Medieval Kingdom of Bohemia was prosperous, the center of the Holy Roman Empire and an exporter of religious art and design. Yet, during the late fourteenth century religious reforms ignited civic unrest which resulted a civil war (Hussite Wars 1419 – 1434) that altered the political, religious, and economic context of the kingdom.

Cellular vaults were adapted as a favorite style of rebuilding almost immediately after their introduction in Saxony. They were utilized in both sacred and secular contexts and serve as an indicator of new stability and post-war reconstruction, a way to connect Catholic centers outside of Bohemia. They were particularly favored by the Franciscan order, and several monasteries, such as the Observant Franciscans. Secular spaces, especially residences of the Catholic nobility also prospered from these designs. By examining the history, patronage, and religious context of the cellular vault designs in fifteenth-century medieval Bohemia, I hope to explore the use of architecture as a form of repair and renovation, perhaps an example and point of discussion for contemporary Eastern European contexts.

PS36 Erasure and Resilience in Eastern European Architectures

Session Co-Chairs: Dimitrij Zadorin, Edinburgh School of Architecture and Landscape Architecture, Scotland, and Aleksander Musial, gta Institut, ETH-Zürich

Models and Miniatures: Ethnonationalism in Interwar Bucharest and Prague

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Abstract

In 1936, Edvard Beneš, President of Czechoslovakia, and King Charles II of Romania strolled through farmsteads in the newly inaugurated open-air Museum of Romanian Villages in Bucharest. Described by its founders as a "lesson in nationalism" (Stahl 1936), the museum included relocated rural houses - *models* inhabited by Romanian-identifying people - yet excluded representations of the 30% minority populations in the country, thus presenting the nation as a monoethnic environment. Beneš' visit triggered interest and, in 1938, the Czechoslovak National Museum proposed an open-air museum in Prague with relocated rural farmhouses from across the nation - models that essentialize an ethnic type.

Though never built, the proposal structured a linear walk from Prague eastwards, *miniaturizing* the nation into a hierarchical sequence of multi-ethnic identity. This paper focuses on the tensions between the *model*, the full-size detailed representation of a building (King 1996), and the miniature, the deliberate abstraction and scaling (Knappett 2012) of the nation in open-air museums in interwar Romania and Czechoslovakia. Both new nations' authenticity discourses required the relocation of buildings to capital cities, along with rural builders to perform construction crafts. The difficult transactions between rural owners and national institutions, and the rural builders' misconstructions situate the *model* as a site of negotiation, contestation and indifference to the nation, complicating institutional ethnonationalist aspirations. Against these complications, the open-air museum is examined as a miniaturization of the nation where ethnicity and territory are conflated. Unlike 19th c. colonial villages in World Fairs or 20th c. folk architecture museums in North America, interwar open-air museums in Eastern Europe were deployed as tools to construct ethnonationalist identities.

The comparative analysis combines novel archival research with spatial analysis of the open-air museums, revealing how rural communities and national institutions spatially negotiated identities, while honing in on the specificity of nation-building processes in Eastern Europe.

PS36 Erasure and Resilience in Eastern European Architectures

Session Co-Chairs: Dimitrij Zadorin, Edinburgh School of Architecture and Landscape Architecture, Scotland, and Aleksander Musial, gta Institut, ETH-Zürich

Negotiating Identity: Contested Heritage in Post-Soviet Kyiv

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Abstract

In the context of Russia's war on Ukraine, the question of how to address Soviet-era architecture has taken on renewed urgency. The built legacy of Soviet rule—once imposed as a homogenizing system—now emerges as a contested terrain where questions of identity, memory, and agency collate. This paper examines how architecture in Soviet and post-Soviet Ukraine operates as both a tool of imperial erasure and a vehicle of cultural resilience, focusing on three emblematic sites in Kyiv: Avraam Miletsky's Hotel Salut (1984), the Park of Memory's Wall of Remembrance by Ada Rybachuk and Volodymyr Melnychenko, and the complex memorial history of Babi Yar.

All three projects reflect a tension between centralized ideological control and local architectural agency. Hotel Salut's nonstandard form, developed in the wake of state censorship and resource withdrawal, resists formal standardization through material innovation. The Park of Memory's sculptural reliefs—buried under concrete by Soviet authorities for failing to conform to socialist realist aesthetics—embody both the suppression of Ukrainian narrative and the endurance of artistic idea. Babi Yar, the site of a Nazi massacre of over 33,000 Jews in 1941, was systematically denied adequate memorialization during the Soviet era. Its belated and highly politicized recent commemorations reflect a refusal to acknowledge both the Jewish suffering and the specificity of Ukrainian historical trauma.

Drawing on the work of Ukrainian historians such as Ievgeniia Gubkina, this paper reframes Soviet architectural heritage in Ukraine not as inert imperial residue but as a complex layering of contested authorship and historical suppression. These case studies reveal how architecture served simultaneously as a mechanism of ideological control manifested in the entanglement of architectural form with histories of violence and censorship, and a medium through which local actors were able to articulate alternative identities, historical narratives, and aesthetic values.

PS37 Open Session - Urbanism: Tools Enacting Urban Change

Session Chair: Alona Nitzan-Shiftan, ETH Zürich, Technion Haifa

Trees Come to the City: The Case of Baroque Rome

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Abstract

In 1611, Pope Paul V Borghese opened the Via di San Francesco a Ripa in the Trastevere neighborhood of Rome. A new street to improve circulation in the congested and isolated neighborhood had already been planned under Sixtus V and was finally realized after more than a decade. The Via di San Francesco a Ripa established a direct connection between the homonymous church near Rome's river port, the Ripa Grande, and the church of San Callisto. In 1614, the new street was planted with elm trees, the first such attempt in the papal city. This was the beginning of a new era of Rome as a green city.

Increased interest in arborscapes is a unique characteristic of Baroque Rome. Ancient Rome had tree-planted sacred precincts, groves, and parks. The public streets of medieval Rome, as in many European cities, were treeless; greenery was confined within enclosed gardens or grew wild in uninhabited areas. Renaissance urbanism introduced straightness and markers in the circulation network, but plants were still the stuff of private gardens. In seventeenth-century Rome, concurrently with the emergence of private properties at the urban periphery incorporating sylvan landscapes, systematic implementation of tree-lined avenues and planted plazas progressed in the city.

This paper offers a nuanced interpretation of the coming of trees to the city of Rome, at the intersection of urban renewal and globalization. It argues that Rome weathered spiritual, intellectual, social, and environmental crises in the second half of the sixteenth century, emerging more resilient and flourishing as a cosmopolitan center embracing diversity in its own way. An important component in this urban renewal was the introduction of trees as urban amenity, following a substantial shift in the perception of trees and nature, especially their relationship to the urban realm.

PS37 Open Session - Urbanism: Tools Enacting Urban Change

Session Chair: Alona Nitzan-Shiftan, ETH Zürich, Technion Haifa

Altering the Code: The Influence of Lotty Rosenfeld's Pavement Markings on Resignifying Feminist Appropriation of Public Space.

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Abstract

Lotty Rosenfeld's (1943–2020) public art actions emerged as a critical response to the repressive Chilean dictatorship that followed the 1973 US-backed coup, which ousted President Salvador Allende and installed General Augusto Pinochet. The regime enforced neoliberal policies while violently suppressing dissent, resulting in over three thousand political executions and prohibiting cultural expression in public space.

As part of Santiago's avant-garde, Rosenfeld broke from conventional art practices by staging interventions beyond gallery walls. Her seminal project, *A Mile of Crosses on the Pavement*, transformed traffic lines into plus (+) signs by applying white tape across existing lane markers. This subtle yet radical gesture disrupted the authoritative symbolism of urban infrastructure, proposing a visual grammar of resistance that reclaimed public space for feminist and political expression.

This paper examines Rosenfeld's use of the plus sign as a mode of re-signification that challenges hegemonic representations of public space. The study is structured in three parts. First, it considers the semiotic implications of the plus sign as a symbol of interruption and inclusion, enabling the feminist re-appropriation of space. Second, it explores Rosenfeld's challenge to the fixed conventions of street markings, arguing that her interventions introduce a transnational, mobile visual language. Finally, it traces the migration of the plus sign from the street to feminist protest banners, illustrating how Rosenfeld's visual language extended into collective movements advocating for women's rights and social justice.

The research concludes that Rosenfeld's pavement markings redefined both the symbolic and physical dimensions of Chilean public space. Her interventions created a language of dissent that made room for women's subjectivities and collective resistance. By destabilising dominant visual codes, Rosenfeld's legacy continues to influence contemporary forms of spatial activism and feminist discourse, both within Chile and beyond its borders.

PS37 Open Session - Urbanism: Tools Enacting Urban Change

Session Chair: Alona Nitzan-Shiftan, ETH Zürich, Technion Haifa

Reclaiming the City: Architecture, Democracy, and the Rise of Advocacy Planning in the Civil Rights Era

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Abstract

This paper examines the advocacy planning movement within the socio-political context of the U.S. civil rights era around 1968, focusing on how architecture and urban planning became instrumental in the broader struggle for democracy. It examines two key case studies: the founding of the Architect's Renewal Committee in Harlem (ARCH), which was dedicated to advocacy planning, and the establishment of the City Planning Forum at Yale School of Art and Architecture, a student–faculty body formed to democratize planning education and diversify institutional governance. Through the lens of architectural practice, the paper explores how advocacy planners sought to transform architecture from a profession serving elite interests into a democratic instrument responsive to the needs of marginalized communities. Special attention is given to the contributions of C. Richard Hatch and Christopher Tunnard, then Chair of Yale's Department of City Planning, who challenged the technocratic, top-down logic of urban renewal. ARCH, under Max Bond's leadership, envisioned the architect not as an enforcer of spatial order but as a representative of community voices. Bond advocated for "city living" over "city building," reflecting a vision of architecture rooted in social justice and participatory design. At Yale, Tunnard's opposition to the university's complicity in New Haven's urban renewal sparked student activism. In 1969, planning students formed the City Planning Forum to critique institutional power and promote inclusive planning processes. Their alliance with the Black Workshop, a collective of African American design students, underscored a demand for racial and spatial justice within architectural education. The paper argues that these movements exemplified efforts to reimagine architecture as a democratic practice. Yet, it also highlights the paradox that their strategies, while aiming to empower the public, still relied on federal funding and professional structures, raising questions about the limits of participatory planning within institutional frameworks.

PS37 Open Session - Urbanism: Tools Enacting Urban Change

Session Chair: Alona Nitzan-Shiftan, ETH Zürich, Technion Haifa

Building as Protagonist: The Cliff-Dwellers and the Skyscraper

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Abstract

In Chicago, the skyscraper matured in a remarkably short period of time (1882-1893) and architects such as Adler & Sullivan, Burnham & Root, and W. L. B. Jenney are renowned as the buildings they created – the Auditorium Theater, the Monadnock, and the Home Insurance Building. As buildings grew in height, the structure moved towards the edges of the building and the heavy brick exterior walls dissolved into facades. The way that city inhabitants reacted to each other changed as the infrastructure of the buildings shaped interactions. At the same time, these skyscrapers were built during great transitions in construction, labor, and health with skeleton construction, the Haymarket Riot and strikes, and germ theory taking hold. While a great deal is known about the transitions in construction technology, less is understood around how Chicagoans reacted to the very fabric of their city transforming into shadowed canyons and towers of capitalism.

This development occurred during what Lewis Mumford labeled as the "Brown Decades" of the arts, literature, and architecture under the pressures of increased urbanization and social conflict. This paper combines two of Mumford's arts and examines architecture through the lens of literature, specifically Henry Blake Fuller's best-selling *The Cliff-Dwellers* (1893). The Cliff-Dweller is a fictitious skyscraper that stands alongside the Tacoma and Monadnock buildings in the business district of Chicago. Fuller's characters float in and out of the building and up and down it. Using Henry Blake Fuller's Papers, a close reading of *The Cliff-Dwellers,* and historic newspapers, this paper argues that the skyscraper is a protagonist in the novel, and the characters' interactions with it reveal contemporary reactions to the change occurring in the built environment. The building Fuller imagined was a monument to business that facilitated social compression, restricted mobility, and reinforced class separation.

PS37 Open Session - Urbanism: Tools Enacting Urban Change

Session Chair: Alona Nitzan-Shiftan, ETH Zürich, Technion Haifa

Imagining a Profitable Future: Constantinople's Insurance Maps

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Abstract

In 1904, the European *Syndicate of Fire Insurance Companies Operating in Constantinople* commissioned British cartographer Charles E. Goad to develop detailed maps of the Ottoman capital's large-scale urban developments. The risk of fire, underlying both the creation of the maps and the urban changes they depict, engendered two forms of foreign capital investment. Indicating precise physical characteristics such as materiality, wall types, roof shapes and skylights, the maps served as an instrument to assess the risk of fires, calculate insurance premiums and, ideally, transform the conditions of risk into a profitable investment. The maps' original purpose was thus to secure financial returns on European capital invested in a foreign insurance market. Yet the urban changes made to mitigate the risk of fires, such as widening roads and replacing older wooden structures with masonry buildings, also constitute foreign involvement. To finance the massive construction projects, the Ottoman state took on foreign debt by issuing state securities. Crucially, this implies a specific temporal order: debt requires perpetual economic growth since future earnings are already committed in the present. Therefore, what Goad's maps depict—debt financed urban development—is realized foreign capital investment, borrowed by the Ottomans from the future.

Following sociologist Jens Beckert's *Imagined Futures* (2016), this paper considers Goad's maps as "interpretive frames" to manage the inherent uncertainty of an unknown future, attempting to control and manipulate the contingent link between past (fires), present (urban development) and future (profits). In both the insurance and state securities markets, I argue, Goad's maps operated as the interface between fictitious foreign capital and material changes to Constantinople's cityscape. In charting Constantinople, private European investors imagined a profitable future for themselves. Yet by tracing the maps' genesis and prime users, I reveal a group of local Ottoman bankers profiting from the frictions in the interface.

PS38 From Living Organism to Silent Structure: Material and Environmental Perspectives on Wood in Premodern Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Saida Bondini, Kunsthistorisches Institut in Florenz - Max-Planck-Institut, Italy, and Costanza Beltrami, University of Stockholm, Sweden

Organic Bonds, Wooden Frames: Writing Histories of the Bohío

Paul Niell

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Abstract

Upon a wooden framework, Caribbean builders secured palm thatch to a roof with vines, which some Indigenous Knowledge Keepers suggest may have been living, their roots sunken into the ground so that the joinery tightened as the plant grew. The diverse roles of wood in the construction of the Caribbean bohío (a thatched dwelling)—from structural frames to palisaded walls and finely hewn boards—speak to a long-evolving architectural practice rooted in local ecologies. Beyond its Indigenous origins, this dwelling underwent a significant colonial transformation within landscapes of extraction, enslavement, maroonage, and diaspora, fostering both continuities and shifts in human-plant relations.

This paper argues that a focused attention on wood is a crucial element of any environmental history of the Caribbean bohío. This dedicated perspective offers fresh insights through which to write histories of these buildings, illuminating how the use of wood forged cultural connections and common lifeways between Indigenous, African, and Afro-Indigenous people and their descendants. It also registers how socio-ecological relations evolved over the colonial period. Importantly, this focus on wood provides a crucial form of material evidence within deeply fragmented and discontinuous building histories. Drawing on multiple disciplines and evidentiary forms (archival research, imagery, material culture, and oral accounts), this paper addresses the challenges of historical erasure and the rewards of recovery in writing histories of the bohío from the vantage point of wood.

PS38 From Living Organism to Silent Structure: Material and Environmental Perspectives on Wood in Premodern Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Saida Bondini, Kunsthistorisches Institut in Florenz - Max-Planck-Institut, Italy, and Costanza Beltrami, University of Stockholm, Sweden

Yumedono and the Afterlife of Timber in Japanese Architecture

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Abstract

Timber in Japanese architecture has long functioned as more than a construction material, embodying a cosmology of renewal, impermanence, and continuity sustained through ritual rebuilding and hereditary craftsmanship. This lineage is exemplified by sacred structures such as the *Ise* Shrine (690 CE) and *Hōryū-ji* Temple's *Yumedono*, the Hall of Dreams (739 CE). Through an examination of the afterlife of timber in Japanese architecture across the ruptures of the Meiji Restoration, industrial modernity, and post-war high growth, this paper explores the persistence of its ontological and cultural significance even as wood and shoji were materially displaced by other industrial materials and increasingly Westernized spatial and programmatic logics.

The paper draws on Gaston Bachelard's concept of material imagination, architectural theorist Marco Frascari's formulation of *technê* (practice, skill, or craft) and *logos* (myth, memory, and narration), and philosophical readings of the *Ise* Shrine by Japanese architects and theorists such as Kenzo Tange, Fumihiko Maki, and Kisho Kurokawa. Together with the recollections of Hōryū-ji's master carpenter, Tsunekazu Nishioka, I argue that timber in sacred premodern Japanese architecture embodies a vibrant entanglement of material and formal causality, expressing a worldview rooted in transience and environmental continuity that transcends Western paradigms of material preservation.

Tracing shifts in the perception of timber through Japan's encounters with modernism—and highlighting the historical reception of the *Ise* Shrine as a register of this transformation—the paper demonstrates that while modern architecture in Japan embraced industrial materials, timber's cosmological logic persisted symbolically and spatially. The study concludes by examining how this cosmological logic reverberates in the contemporary works of Kengo Kuma. This is particularly evident in the material recalibration of timber in the observatory, the *Yume* Terrace of Nihondaira (2018), which references the form and details of Hōryū-ji's *Yumedono*, revealing timber's enduring capacity to shape architectural imagination.

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Session Co-Chairs: Saida Bondini, Kunsthistorisches Institut in Florenz - Max-Planck-Institut, Italy, and Costanza Beltrami, University of Stockholm, Sweden

From Forest to Silver. Wood Policies in Early Modern Mining Cities

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Abstract

From around 1450 on, mining experienced a significant boom - first in Europe and soon after in Latin America. Numerous towns were newly established as part of this development, and adits, along with ore-processing facilities, were constructed. Timber was the most essential construction material and was used in large quantities. In the early modern period, the often unregulated extraction of this resource reached its first peak with all the associated consequences: entire regions were deforested and formerly wooded areas were left barren. Taking the major mining regions and towns of the Ore Mountains, the Harz, and the Viceroyalty of Peru as a case study, this paper aims to explore and compare the various strategies of early modern wood policy and extraction. The approach bases on the environmental history of architecture implying the idea that architecture balances the intricate interplay between social practices and planetary systems.

What were the consequences of the long-range and extensive transport of wood? In the Ore Mountains and the Harz, elaborate systems of rafting canals were built to get the timber to the towns via waterways. What was the impact of these constructions and the widening reach into surrounding areas on the cultural landscape? In Peru, massive migrations took place involving animals and compulsory labour entailing and influencing the exploitation of local populations and animals. What kinds of infrastructure for wood processing such as sawmills, emerged in the following? What strategies were pursued for ensuring reforestation, for seeding and replanting as well as for introducing new tree species to meet the insatiable demand for wood? How did wood regulations, directives and governmental mandates develop during this process and how did these regulatory measures ultimately affect the built environment of the city? Were there any directives developed to preserve and reuse timber or to use alternative materials?

PS38 From Living Organism to Silent Structure: Material and Environmental Perspectives on Wood in Premodern Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Saida Bondini, Kunsthistorisches Institut in Florenz - Max-Planck-Institut, Italy, and Costanza Beltrami, University of Stockholm, Sweden

The "Living" Oaks of Notre-Dame

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Abstract

Although traditionally marginalized in the "big story" of Gothic architecture—and, indeed, in the historiography of European architecture writ large—wood played a fundamental role in the design, construction, and meanings of Gothic cathedrals like Notre-Dame of Paris. The fact that Notre-Dame's complex, timber-framed roof system is called "the forest" (*la forêt*) and elements of its spire "the stump" (*la souche*), "the trunk" (*le fût*), and "the needle" (*l'aiguille*) points to the cathedral's continuing connections to its environment.

What values did medieval landowners, carpenters, clergy, and laypeople ascribe to the oaks harvested to build Notre-Dame? What meanings did they hold for those who saw the timber arrive and the finished trusses raised in the twelfth century—giving the cathedral its distinctive silhouette—before being obscured by the lead cladding of the roof above and the limestone rib vaults below? How about those who glimpsed the thirteenth-century reconstruction of the choir roof that incorporated timbers recycled from the twelfth-century original, or those who witnessed the construction of the medieval spire? And finally, which of these meanings are firmly fixed in the medieval past, and which ones continue to resonate in the present?

Drawing not only from my own fieldwork, but also from Notre-Dame's robust medieval archive, its medieval liturgical manuscripts, its vast secondary literature, and in-depth interviews I have conducted with many of those who have recently sourced, harvested, milled, hewn, cut, and sculpted around 2,000 oaks for the Notre-Dame roof and spire, installing them as high as nearly 100 meters in the air, my paper situates the oaks of Notre-Dame within their medieval and modern environments.

PS38 From Living Organism to Silent Structure: Material and Environmental Perspectives on Wood in Premodern Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Saida Bondini, Kunsthistorisches Institut in Florenz - Max-Planck-Institut, Italy, and Costanza Beltrami, University of Stockholm, Sweden

Mediterranean Wood, Foundational and Fluid: Two Case Studies

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Abstract

My paper examines two disparate uses of wood across the Mediterranean. In medieval and Renaissance Venice, the unusual topographical conditions of the city necessitated a constant, renewable supply of wooden piles, which served as foundations for the rapid construction of the city. A fifteenth century building boom fueled a dire need for timber, resulting in frequent crises of supply, rapid deforestation, and the necessity of developing an elaborate system of administration and governance. While Venetian systems of flood management and strategies of maintaining their food supply have received their attention, in an architectural context, their approach to cultivating, harvesting, and using wood is as significant, and sets it apart from any other city in Italy.

In Southern Spain, by contrast, uses of wood were an essential ornamental feature of Islamic architecture, prominent in the ceilings of the Alhambra, among many other examples. What is significant here, however, is the suitability of wood for cultural appropriation and reuse. While many aspects of the Islamic building tradition were imitated by artisans working for Christian patrons following their conquest of Cordoba (1236), Seville (1248) and Granada (in 1492), they found greatest success in the imitation of wood ceilings. The subject of a treatise on carpentry, the technique became fully absorbed within the Spanish tradition, given a Spanish name, “artesonado,” and was employed not only throughout the peninsula but also in Mexico and throughout Latin America. My paper will consider the reasons for the particular facility of this wood technique, with its geometric features and ornamental and structural components, to move with such fluidity across many geographical, cultural, and chronological contexts.

Seen together, the two case studies illustrate the range of uses of wood in the early modern Mediterranean context, from structural to ornamental, as well as its ecological significance and cultural fluidity.

PS39 New Insights on Histories of African Architecture

Session Chair: Kuukuwa Manful, University of Michigan, USA

Housing Research in Post-Independence West Africa

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Abstract

Architectural historians have often argued that, after decolonization, former colonial metropoles remained centers of architectural knowledge production, disseminated to newly independent countries. This talk qualifies that view by mapping institutions responsible for architectural knowledge in post-independence Ghana and Nigeria. These included Ghana's Building and Road Research Institute, the Research Department at the University of Science and Technology, both in Kumasi, and the Tema Development Corporation's Research Unit. In Nigeria, housing research was carried out by the Federal Housing Authority and the Nigerian Building and Road Research Institute, both in Lagos. Whether newly established or inherited from the colonial period, these institutions were tasked with producing research on housing in rural and urban contexts, thus placing housing at the center of postcolonial nation-building.

Part of a broader research project on the Africanization of architecture and construction in West Africa, this paper explores how African professionals and scholars rethought conceptual frameworks inherited from colonial rule. Central among these was the figure of the "African inhabitant," shaped in colonial-era "African housing," resettlement, and slum clearance schemes. I argue that a redefinition of the inhabitant emerged through a wave of empirical research beginning in the late 1960s in Ghana and in Nigeria during the following decade. These studies expanded earlier concerns with material durability and environmental control by incorporating surveys of everyday practices of tenants and homeowners, including extension, maintenance, and repair.

This shift informed design guidelines and experimental housing projects designed by Ghanaian and Nigerian architects. While many remained one-off structures, some received state support before structural adjustment programs of the 1980s curtailed state involvement in housing. By foregrounding these institutions and research efforts, the paper shows how architectural knowledge was re-centered in West Africa itself, revising colonial concepts and reframing housing as a political and cultural project during the second post-independence decade.

PS39 New Insights on Histories of African Architecture

Session Chair: Kuukuwa Manful, University of Michigan, USA

"A matter of urgency": modern architecture for a "modern" Seminary in Cabo Verde

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Abstract

From the beginning of the colonisation of Cabo Verde, the Church was the state's main ally in imposing Portuguese/European culture on the archipelago. Even in the late colonial period, the state continued to assign the Church a significant part of instructing or "civilising" the "Cape Verdean people". Within this historical context, the Ministry of Overseas Territories endeavoured to build the new facilities for the Praia's Seminary "urgently needed, all the more so because it [was] necessary to maintain the high religious tradition of the Cape Verdean people".

In the historiography of modern architecture of the Portuguese empire, the Seminary of Praia is described as an "exceptional work" and as one of the few works on Cape Verdean territory to have achieved such artistic, functional and constructive performance. The building is seen as one of the works of public promotion at the end of the colonial cycle, "potentially more integrated into the African landscape" due to the "updating it introduces into the aesthetic discourse of architectural production promoted by the Portuguese state in the former colonies" developed by architects based on the metropolis. However, research on local archives shows that the initial sketches were developed by the intern architect Pedro Gregório, the first Cape Verdean architect, whose name remains on the footnotes in recent scholarship.

Despite the leading role played by Gregório in this and other projects developed during the late colonial period, the role played by this African architect in public works has not yet been properly studied. Taking the Seminary as a case study, this paper explores the ambiguities, tensions and contradictions produced by local and extra-local agents working within the public work's mechanisms of development of architectural buildings aiming to modernise Cape Verdean society in the late colonial period.

PS39 New Insights on Histories of African Architecture

Session Chair: Kuukuwa Manful, University of Michigan, USA

Beda Amuli and the Architecture of Ujamaa

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Abstract

Beda Amuli (1938-2016) was the first indigenous Tanzanian to register as an architect. While Amuli is often granted at least footnote status in histories of (East) African architecture for his pioneering design of the iconic Kariakoo Market in Dar es Salaam (completed 1974), his larger oeuvre remains absent from the literature. This paper will provide the first comprehensive overview of Amuli's achievement, focussing on the period from the 1960s to 1980s when he became the most influential architect of public buildings in mainland Tanzania. Against the backdrop of Julius Nyerere's Ujamaa politics, Amuli not only designed government buildings, schools and universities, and co-operative buildings across the country but also became a leading figure in the administration of architecture and public planning.

Drawing on previously unexplored archival material as well as interviews with colleagues and collaborators of Amuli's, our paper will contextualize his architectural oeuvre through an examination of the extent of his engagement with local architectural and art traditions, the philosophy of Ujamaa, and the long history of co-operatives in Tanzania. Our project will thus both contain and aim to exceed the two more traditional strands of research into Tanzanian architecture of the second half of the twentieth century, i.e. the architectural study of Ujamaa villages and the wider paradigm of African/Tropical Modernism. As a result, we hope to draw attention to the lasting influence of an unjustly neglected major figure in twentieth-century East African architecture.

PS39 New Insights on Histories of African Architecture

Session Chair: Kuukuwa Manful, University of Michigan, USA

Building on a Pre-colonial Foundation: The Collectivities of Abomey

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Abstract

This paper examines the physical and social aspects of the large, domestic, architectural compounds known as *xwedo*, or collectivities, which are located in West Africa's city of Abomey, Benin – the pre-colonial capital of the kingdom of Dahomey. Through their decorative bas-relief sculptures, as well as through ceremony, collectivities reference the pre-colonial kings of Dahomey. In this way, these homes become vehicles of identity and of connection for the living and their ancestors.

Wealthier families sometimes commission an artist to adorn their collectivity with relief sculptures. These colorful, pictorial reliefs often depict the current head of household and include symbols and stories referring to the family's history and spiritual roots. If a family claims descent from one of the pre-colonial kings of Dahomey, they will often include the dynastic line of kings as represented by their royal symbols on the outer wall of the compound.

Additionally, in order to become the titled head of the household of a collectivity, one must undergo an installation ceremony. These ceremonies take place in the Royal Palace of Dahomey, in the heart of Abomey, where the current king witnesses and authorizes the event. The ceremony concludes with a procession that moves from the palace to the market and ultimately to the family's collectivity. This ceremony draws on the political power of the palace, the once active center of rule in order to endow the spatial collectivity with the power of the royal past in a reciprocal relationship where both palace and home as well as the head of household and the king are mutually bolstered and sustained in the post-colonial moment.

Using primarily field research, this paper considers the social and spiritual implications of collectivities as well as their role as a vehicle for post-colonial identity.

PS39 New Insights on Histories of African Architecture

Session Chair: Kuukuwa Manful, University of Michigan, USA

What Does a Mask Build? Ékpè Masquerade and the Spatial Politics of Secrecy in Eighteenth-Century Old Calabar

Joseph Godlewski

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Abstract

To engage Ékpè masquerade, the ritual and performative practices associated with the Ékpè society native to southeastern Nigeria and Cameroon, is to confront a spatial formation that resists the categories through which architecture has traditionally been known, studied, and valued. In eighteenth-century Old Calabar, the Ékpè society organized civic and territorial life through a performative and esoteric system that defied both colonial spatial logics and the normative frameworks of architectural history. This paper explores Ékpè not as an aesthetic ritual on the margins of architecture, but as a sovereign practice that structured urban experience and mediated transatlantic political economies at the height of the slave trade. Drawing from the writings of slave traders, African oral accounts, and diagrammatic reconstructions, I argue that Ékpè masquerade operated as a legal and spatial technology. It was mobile, coded, and strategic rather than strictly built and permanent. Central to this system was the Ídèm Íkwò, the society's costumed emissary, whose authority was enacted not through architectural fixity but through symbolic thresholds, auditory presence, and choreographed motion. What emerges is an elusive architecture: a mode of territorial control organized through palm-frond boundaries, nsìbidì inscriptions, and the powerful resonance of the úyó (Voice). Ékpè's spatial logic displaced the compound as the dominant spatial typology, asserting instead a politics of movement, concealment, and ephemerality. This study challenges the historiographic tendency to equate architecture with visibility and endurance, and instead foregrounds the epistemologies embedded in African spatial practices that demand recognition not only for their formal ingenuity but for their political force. In doing so, it contributes to a decolonial architectural history attuned to opacity, performance, and sovereignty.

PS40 Open Session - The Politics of Preservation: Untold Stories

Session Chair: Adedoyin Teriba, Dartmouth College, USA

Death, Life, and Afterlife in the Architecture of the White War

Sophie Higgerson

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Abstract

What happens when the environment destroys the architectural heritage of conflict? This question lies at the heart of the Dolomites' memorial landscape, where the as-yet under-researched architecture of the First World War's Alpine front is preserved in ruins, embedded in the mountains. The fighting, postwar memorial visitation, and climate change have all contributed to the architectural destruction of the conflict now commonly called the White War. This paper reconstructs the architectural history of the Dolomites' front line – from its wartime occupation to its reinvention as a leisure landscape and open-air memorial – to examine how the mountains' natural environment and the piecemeal preservation of its architecture have hampered the remembrance of Alpine warfare.

The architecture of the Alpine front was precarious from its inception, and its destruction embodied the meeting of armed and environmental violences. The mountain landscape itself – its cirques, rock faces, and glaciers – became the architecture of war, transformed by trenches, suspended barracks, and tunneled depots. Alpine troops left pollution, vast deforestation, and dynamited peaks in their wake. But the war's architecture was dually destroyed by the environment: by wind, snow, avalanche, and lightning strike.

This dual destruction draws timely attention the agency of the environment in histories of war, architectural history, and memory studies. The contemporary preservation of the war's architecture, as part of both open-air and indoor museums, raises further questions about how visitors memorialize a conflict whose visibility in the landscape has been gradually – in some cases, inevitably – destroyed. In examining how current preservation strategies interpret this landscape of historic violence, often in the absence of the war's architectural evidence, this paper will critically examine how such memorial landscapes balance both violence against human beings and violence against the environment.

PS40 Open Session - The Politics of Preservation: Untold Stories

Session Chair: Adedoyin Teriba, Dartmouth College, USA

Joseph Elian Sarkis (1856–1932): A Syro-Lebanese Archive for Alternative Genealogies of Islamic Art

Damla Göre

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Abstract

Islamic archaeology and art history, two closely intertwined fields, entered Ottoman intellectual life between the late nineteenth century and the 1920s, providing the framework for emerging heritage narratives. Although much has been written on how Ottoman elites institutionalized these disciplines in centers such as Istanbul and Cairo, further work is needed to explore how these elite aspirations resonated across more modest echelons of society, and how different ethnic and religious communities contributed to their making. The research sheds light on this underexplored field through the works of Catholic-Arab scholar Joseph Elian Sarkis (1856-1932), who worked not only at the Ottoman Imperial Bank, but also as a part-time bibliographer, translator, merchant, and collector-dealer of historical artifacts. After settling in Cairo in 1912 and opening the bookshop-cum-publishing house "J.E. Sarkis et Fils," Sarkis channeled his art historical knowledge into writings published in popular literary and scientific journals run by Arab-Christians, such as *Al-Muqtataf* (1876–1952), published in Beirut and Cairo; *Al-Machriq* (1898–1998), published in Beirut; and *Lughat al-Arab* (1911–1931), published in Baghdad. His oeuvre mapped the Christian heritage of the region with writings on Maronite convents and Oriental societies in Beirut, while also offering pluralistic insights into the architectural histories of urban centers such as Aleppo, Homs, Damascus, Er-Rastan, and Mosul.

Focusing on Sarkis's varied outputs, including bibliographies, monographs, catalogs, and articles, this study challenges the dominant conceptions about historic heritage in the Middle East in the early twentieth century. Reading Islamic art and archeology through the amateur lens of Christian and Syro-Lebanese intellectual circles, additionally, offers new ways to question the Sunni-Muslim dominance within the heritage discourse, which had been historically conceived from an exclusivist and corporate lens that often excluded non-Muslims.

PS40 Open Session - The Politics of Preservation: Untold Stories

Session Chair: Adedoyin Teriba, Dartmouth College, USA

Measured Care: Visual Methods for Contested Landscapes

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Abstract

Preservation frameworks in the U.S. frequently rely on fixed “periods of significance” that suppress histories not easily legible within institutional timelines or material taxonomies. These protocols often exclude forms of use, care, and meaning that do not conform to dominant narratives or leave behind durable physical evidence. This paper explores how visual methods—particularly measured section drawings—can intervene in this dynamic, offering a more layered and inclusive representation of historic landscapes.

Focusing on the Florence Indian Mound in northwestern Alabama—a Woodland-era earthwork transformed over centuries through ceremony, agriculture, radio broadcasting, and commodified artifact trading—this project uses sequential section drawings to record both visible elements and erased or ephemeral site transformations. Compiling written, photographic, archaeological, and orthographic sources, the drawings operate as a counter-archive: not merely documenting presence, but visualizing absence, loss, memory, and contested use. The project draws deliberately from atypical sources—oral histories, maintenance records, and informal accounts—rarely rendered into measured drawings and typically excluded from the claims to “truth” and “objectivity” that preservation practices often purport to trade in. These strategies refuse tidy narratives of stasis and significance, foregrounding the fragmentary, incidental, and marginal.

This methodological approach aligns with “scavenger” practices that reassemble disparate forms of evidence to surface minor and neglected histories. Drawing becomes a practice of care—an attentional strategy that resists flattening and insists on the complexity and multiplicity of a place’s pasts. Section, in particular, allows for a temporal and spatial thickness often omitted by conventional preservation graphics, making visible the discontinuities and negotiations that shape cultural landscapes.

Ultimately, this project argues for an expanded visual toolkit in heritage work—one that embraces ambiguity, transformation, and suppressed narratives. It asks how visual methodologies might not only represent, but actively reshape, how we understand and relate to “historic” sites.

PS41 Modeling the Future: Architecture and the Construction of Risk

Session Co-Chairs: Nushelle de Silva, Fordham University, USA, and Ginger Nolan, University of Southern California, USA

Henry Phillips, Property Development and Early Modern Actuarial Practices

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Abstract

A peny well sav'd is a peny got, / And will do well to keep thy Kitchin hot, / But he that will not spare for th' other pot, / Doth seldom thrive, oft finde the begers lot. [sic.]

With these few lines, mathematical practitioner and author Henry Phillips provided advice on financial moderation in the last pages of his *Purchasers Pattern*, a small book published in London in 1653 and dedicated to property development. Phillips' was the first publication that attempted to systematically address the problems of urban land and building finance, in order to counter the uncertainty and distrust among investors generated by both 'honest ignorance' and 'crafty covetousness'. Instead, Phillips promised to assist in the 'purchasing of Land and Leases' by providing synthetic quantitative notions on land valuation, tenures, leases, and basic linear and superficial measuring. By establishing strict principles and clear rules that could minimise risks and maximise returns, the book presented early actuarial practices in building investment.

The Purchasers Pattern was an editorial success: it was published six more times before 1720. An enlarged edition appeared in 1667, just a few months after the Great Fire of London, and was quickly followed by similar publications (Primatt 1667, Leybourn 1668). However, while this body of knowledge can be considered the basis for a modern understanding of real estate development, it was largely constructed on well-accepted notions, like present value and interest rates. This paper examines the instruments presented by Phillips to formalise property investment practices, vis-à-vis the building culture of the time and contemporary books on the same topic. It argues that the novelty of publications like Phillips', which actively contributed to a tradition of acturial finance for property, lies in the ways in which established methods were reformulated for the burgeoning urban economy of London.

PS41 Modeling the Future: Architecture and the Construction of Risk

Session Co-Chairs: Nushelle de Silva, Fordham University, USA, and Ginger Nolan, University of Southern California, USA

Insurance and the Architecture of the Sugar-Enslavement Economy

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Abstract

Risks pervaded each site within the network of the sugar-enslavement complex, from labor camp-plantations to refineries. In Caribbean boiling houses, skilled enslaved workers gradually transferred sugarcane juice between copper vats for controlled evaporation. Containing flames of varying intensity, these buildings were susceptible to destruction both because of the infernal activities they housed, and because enslaved people targeted them for destruction.

Sensing opportunity, the Phoenix Fire Company proffered policies across the Atlantic beginning in 1782, opening a new—conspicuously risky—frontier for the insurance industry. Surveying Caribbean markets, a Company Director wrote to London: "Insurances on Sugar Works, if they could be more encouraged, would prove extremely beneficial to the Office," excepting the "Negro Huts," which were "seldom of value" anyway. After Port of Spain, Trinidad burned in 1808, the Company exerted financial pressure to ensure reconstruction with widened streets and fire-resistant materials, as the colonial governor mobilized corvée labor for construction. Policies commonly included provisions that insurrections would be treated as *force majeure* events.

While fire insurance around 1800 was not a formal practice of actuarial calculation, policies entailed a summation of value of materials and objects at risk of destruction. Analyzing insurance policies and correspondences alongside architectural drawings, I regard insurance and architecture as elements in a complex that extorted value from enslaved workers. This paper thus argues that architecture for making sugar was designed with a future-oriented outlook, and due to the volatility of the industry's manufacturing processes, fire insurance triangulated between the value of the physical plant and the ultimate commodity. Insurance also induced anticipatory reactions, compelling enslavers to build using incombustible materials, with the collateral effect of deterring potential arson. As insurance linked the sugar-enslavement economy and the buildings in which production occurred, it revealed architecture's essential position in the creation and retention of value.

PS41 Modeling the Future: Architecture and the Construction of Risk

Session Co-Chairs: Nushelle de Silva, Fordham University, USA, and Ginger Nolan, University of Southern California, USA

Model City: Representing risk in an unstable delta

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Abstract

Residents of Cần Thơ, the Mekong Delta's central city, are increasingly underwater: not only during the flood season, but during dry season high tides and afternoon rains. In a region where flood control historically emphasized analyses of rice productivity rather than urban safety, rural infrastructure projects have diverted the annual flood pulse into urban centers. This paper examines the use of models to manage flooding in Cần Thơ, culminating in recently completed a "smart" model for flood infrastructure management. In the context of a subsiding delta, rising seas, eroding riverbanks, and fast-paced local adaptations, how do expert representations of the delta city attempt to tame space-time gaps to control water? Drawing on one year of spatial-ethographic fieldwork, I examine the everyday practices through which experts navigate leaky datasets, unstable landscapes, and patched-together infrastructures through a $300 million USD World Bank project. Both the politics of data access and the misalignments between past plans and the material world result in a patched-together model of the city. When resulting gappy models create demonstrably false results, international experts defer to "expert judgement" rather than their representational tools. This results, on the one hand, in side effects in the socio-material world, while also cementing the role of experts in increasingly technical forms of urban and regional management. Residents themselves deal with the leaky results, creating their own patches that in turn make the city—and the delta—even more difficult to depict in maps and models. Rather than stabilizing flooding, the model's attempts at water system omniscience make the hydrological landscapes of the city more unstable than ever. This reflexivity—and instability—between representations, gaps, and the socio-material calls into question the god-view of hydraulic models, and raises questions about what kinds of models are appropriate to manage risk in this fluid context.

PS41 Modeling the Future: Architecture and the Construction of Risk

Session Co-Chairs: Nushelle de Silva, Fordham University, USA, and Ginger Nolan, University of Southern California, USA

Bohemian Timber Futures and Models of Vertical Growth, 1848-72

Lasse Rau

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Abstract

In the decades following the 1848-9 revolutions, a debate on the value of forests, timber, and land ensued within the German and Austrian territories. This tension brought to the fore a longstanding land use conflict between mineral extraction, agrarian cultivation, and forestry. Locating the "intensity of forestry" in its capitalized reproduction, foresters presented their organicist model of prediction as a metaphor and remedy for a national economy. By pegging opposing sources of value to their perceived risks, the visual mechanisms of discounting enabled administrators and landed elites to negotiate between the expansion of railroads, industrial production, and the naturalized vertical growth of Bohemian forests. This paper examines how foresters advanced "natural growth" as an alternative source of value to the necessary reproduction of proletarian workers in factories, fields, and mines. By examining how graphs, tables, panoramas, and architecture modeled forests in Bohemia as ideal landscapes devoid of risk, I argue that representations of tree growth constructed a secure economic foundation bereft of the uncertainties of labor revolts and material shortages.

Working backward from the speculative value of trees at peak height, liberal foresters Johann Gottfried Judeich and Max Pressler empirically compiled growth tables and curves that predicted the idealized reproductive capacity of trees. The discounting of timber flattened necessary forestry labor, topography, and soil to price an organicist understanding of time. In turn, Judeich and Pressler expressed growth speed as a rate of interest or opportunity cost on the revenue produced from future timber sales. Material choices and the idealized rate of return in bridges, factories, and state buildings turned architecture into an economic index of risk. As their common denominator, representations of growth provided the means to restore a "harmony" of past struggles and future risks across the Austrian and German territories and beyond.

PS41 Modeling the Future: Architecture and the Construction of Risk

Session Co-Chairs: Nushelle de Silva, Fordham University, USA, and Ginger Nolan, University of Southern California, USA

Games in Planning from Michigan to Ghana, c. 1976

Alex Whee Kim

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Abstract

Amidst the myriad upheavals and uncertainties of the 1960s and '70s, the logic and process of urban and regional planning appeared, for many professionals of the time, to have ground to a halt. As University of Michigan planning professor Richard D. Duke diagnosed in his 1975 book, *Gaming: The Future's Language*, planning now comprised "multisystems within multisystems, alternative upon alternative presenting an incomprehensible, many-futured state which is being rearticulated daily—a great multifaceted sphere of complexity that cannot be managed, but must be." If planning was an endeavor to manage the future of development, how then, could a planner contend, in an increasingly complex present, with an increasingly uncertain future?

For Duke, as the title of his book suggests, the solution was *gaming*. As the complexities of urban development compounded in an increasingly globalized and environmentally precarious world, Duke saw gaming as a medium of "gestalt" communication through which to recognize, manage, and mitigate the risks and uncertainties of planning. This paper focuses primarily on Duke's work as consultant to UNESCO/UNEP's "Human Settlements Managers Training Programme" (HSMTP). Commenced in 1976, the HSMTP implemented gaming as a communicative and pedagogical tool for urban and regional planning in developing nations. In particular, this paper will examine IMPASSE and HEX, two games developed for the Ghanaian HSMTP session, wherein local officials and academics roleplayed various community stakeholders as they negotiated the risks and challenges of development decisions while navigating emergent political, economic, and environmental crises. Drawing on games studies and discourses of postcolonial development, this paper presents an analysis of development games to argue that they did more than merely train its participants to communicate effectively through risks and uncertainties—it also served to inculcate and internalize risk as an epistemology in itself through which to understand the relationship between environment and settlement.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Food Flows: Design, Logistics, and Urban Reconfiguration

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Abstract

In 1982, Mexico City officials opened the Central de Abasto, one of the largest consolidated food wholesaling facilities in the world. Designed by architect Abraham Zabludovsky, it functioned as a kind of 'city within a city,' with restaurants, clinics, security posts, banks, and offices supporting some ten thousand vendors. While an impressive achievement of High Modernist design, Central de Abasto also amplified a set of transformations in scalar logistics around the movement of food into and through cities, with a range of consequences for urban politics and social life. This paper examines these transformations through three case studies: Rungis in Paris, Hunts Point in New York, and Central de Abasto. The case study approach allows for close consideration of how the universalist claims of Modern architecture and planning unfolded across territories with distinct political and governmental configurations. In Paris, the demolition of Les Halles and the relocation of its operations to Rungis in 1971 effectively gutted the heart of the working-class city, replacing Baltard's pavilions with a massive subway station for middle- and upper-middle class commuters. New York's Hunts Point, by contrast, reflects the piecemeal nature of U.S. planning, where various wholesale operations such as Fulton Fish Market, the Washington Street Produce Row, and Chelsea Meat Market relocated gradually over the course of three decades. Like Paris, Mexico City's centralized planning system enabled the rapid relocation of several wholesale operations to the Central de Abasto. Unlike suburban Rungis, however, both Hunts Point and Central de Abasto rose up in densely settled working-class districts, leading to substantial increases in traffic as well as high rates of pollution and asthma. In all cases, these large-scale wholesale food markets reshaped how and where food flows into cities, the nature and distribution of commodity forms, and the labor, class, and social relations therein.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Hong Kong's disappearing MSBs: from "wet" markets to civic nodes

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Abstract

Hong Kong's 'municipal services building (MSB)' is a threatened indigenous architectural type built atop pre-existing "wet" markets that represent the city's pre-Handover civic aspirations. First realized by the Urban Council (UC) in the 1980s, the vertical stacking of additional public programs atop markets seemed to be compelled by the city's demographic density and space scarcity. The UC's condensing of produce and food hawking with studying and working out, which in other cities take place in separate single-function volumes, however, is not only pragmatic. Archival research show that the conceptions of these everyday buildings in the 1970s as UC complexes, as they were named, were part of the then-elected body's growing remit "by the people, for the people, and of the people." The Sanitation Board—from which UC originated—had constructed market buildings for controlling informal street-side hawking. In the aftermaths of 1960s social unrest, however, the UC evolved into a semi-autonomous representative body in the colonial government restructuring of the 1970s. In turn, through their verticalization into UC complexes, including markets, libraries, sports facilities and sometimes theaters and galleries, all under one roof, the UC realized neighborhood nodes provisioning for the public. This paper will unpack the development trajectory of the MSBs, renamed so after the dissolution of the UC as consequence of 1997, and contextualize the type's conception and demise against institutional transitions. Today, these publicly-owned market buildings remain the last civic bastions in the Special Administrative Region's further transitioning into executive-led neoliberalization. Their post-Handover institutional governance, together with changing market demands—notably for the market itself—is expediting their functional obsolescence. From the Kwun Chung to the Kowloon City complexes, designed by Wong & Ouyang and P+T—the innovative first generation local architects—urban renewal plans today are quietly disappearing these overlooked civic nodes.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

Competition and Transition of Covered Markets in French Indochina

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Abstract

Today, numerous towns across former French Indochina retain covered markets built during the colonial period, particularly in the early 20th century. While monumental examples, such as Phnom Penh Central Market and Battambang Market, are recognized as architectural heritage sites, many others in smaller towns remain understudied and are often regarded as buildings without significant historical value.

This study analyzes the institutional framework underlying the public design competitions for these markets and the roles of two key construction firms, clarifying how covered markets evolved as urban facilities with spatial and structural continuity. These competitions reflected the colonial administration's ambitions to modernize public spaces and commercial life while also generating social contestation. Market designs had to respond to aesthetic, technical, and urban demands, as well as user needs.

Two competing companies—the Société de Constructions de Levallois-Perret (SCLP), formerly Établissements Eiffel, and Société Indochinoise d'Études et de Constructions (SIDEC)—were central to the design and delivery of these markets. Their rivalry demonstrates a continuous spatial and constructional logic, evolving from prefabricated iron to cast-in-place concrete in response to changing urban and climatic conditions.

The SCLP pioneered prefabricated iron markets, manufactured in France and assembled on-site. SIDEC later introduced reinforced concrete systems with cast-in-place, mass-produced elements suited for tropical climates, emulating iron-frame principles. Internal correspondence from SCLP engineers praised SIDEC's system for replicating the logic of metal structures in concrete.

Rather than leading to rupture, the shift from SCLP to SIDEC reflects a broader transformation in how markets have influenced—and have been shaped by—the colonial city. Public design competitions, driven by colonial political agendas, played a crucial role in defining market forms, mediating urban ambitions, and negotiating social and climatic demands. This study proposes a framework for understanding markets not as isolated heritage artifacts but as elements with region-wide serial heritage.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

From Center Market to Commerce Department

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Abstract

This paper investigates the demolition of Washington, DC's Center Market and the rise of the US Department of Commerce in its place as a pivotal shift in the architectural history of US federalism and capitalism. Once an anchor of DC's public and commercial core, Center Market was closed and demolished in 1931. Its disappearance was not due to competition from private capital, lack of public interest, suburbanization, depressed sales, or business mismanagement. Rather, it was an effect of the redefinition of federal economic governance and spatial order emergent with the establishment of the Department of Commerce in 1913. In place of the open, heterogeneous Center Market arose a monumental administrative complex, anchored by the department's first headquarters. Tasked with promoting and developing domestic and foreign commerce, the Department of Commerce asserted control over who could participate in exchange, what goods could circulate, and how fair competition was defined. Through statistics, standardization, public campaigns, and diplomacy, it sought to govern the economic space of the nation and condition the shape of its markets. This paper offers a two-part architectural history of the Commerce Department and it's dedicated building to analyze this transformation. First, it examines the devaluation and subsequent demolition of Center Market. Second, it examines how market redefinition appears in architecture of the Commerce building, designed by architectural firm York & Sawyer. By reading the demolition of Center Market and the rise of the Commerce Building as linked architectural events, this paper shows how federal economic governance reconfigured both the physical and ideological space of exchange in the capital city.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

The Real Market Makers: Vernacular Placemaking Practice and Market Modernization in Cape Coast, Ghana.

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Abstract

This paper examines how the redevelopment of Cape Coast's historic Kotokuraba Market reveals tensions between global modernization pressures and local spatial practices. Drawing on ethnographic research conducted between 2017-2020, I analyze how the market's transformation from a traditional open-air market structure to a contemporary shopping mall-style facility demonstrates the ways that technological innovations, social contestation, and environmental adaptation intersect with architectural and aesthetic qualities in this globally ubiquitous yet regionally specific typology.

The market modernization project, funded through a Chinese concessional loan, introduced new materials, engineering strategies, and spatial configurations that reflected global retail aesthetics but failed to attend local trading practices. After inauguration, traders found the market virtually useless, with many refusing to inhabit it for more than a year. Only after investing significant time and personal resources to adapt the modern design did the architectural structure come to life.

Market vendors' material interventions reveal the dynamic relationship between global architectural forms and local realities. They retrofitted unnecessary parking structures into produce sorting areas, constructed additional display and storage systems using local materials, and sculpted new circulation patterns to accommodate familiar spatial practices of traders and customers. These adaptations represent vernacular architectural practice that challenges the deterministic narratives typically associated with development-driven architectural interventions.

By examining these post-occupancy transformations as integral to the market's architectural evolution rather than simply informal responses to formal design, this research reframes market buildings as hybrid socio-material assemblages mediating between global flows and local conditions. The case demonstrates how this West African market typology functions as both architectural infrastructure and cultural technology. Understanding market traders as "everyday architects" helps reframe market modernization as an open-ended development with the capacity to adapt continuously to economic and environmental change while maintaining its role as Cape Coast's most vital urban social and economic institution.

PS42 Making Markets

Session Co-Chairs: Trude L. Renwick, University of Manchester United Kingdom, and Alexander Stewart, University of California, Berkeley, USA

The New Markets of the Mexican Miracle: Architecture and Political Economy

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Abstract

The period of economic ascendency and pronounced urban and infrastructural growth experienced by Mexico in the nineteen fifties and sixties — known alternately as *desarrollo estabilizador*, or *el milagro mexicano* (the "Mexican Miracle") — witnessed the construction of hundreds of new municipal markets in major cities across the country. While a number of these structures have long been celebrated by architectural and urban historians as key entries in the country's modernist canon, their reception by the vendors and publics they were ostensibly erected to serve has been somewhat more contentious, sparking debates about the tensions between processes launched in the pursuit of a techno-scientifically inflected vision of modernity, on one hand, and the value of more venerable social, economic, and spatial practices, on the other. This paper seeks to elaborate upon the narrative surrounding government-led municipal market construction during this period by interrogating the architectural and political-economic facets of this phenomenon, attending to the construction of key projects in Mexico City — where a vast majority of these markets were initiated during the long, divisive tenure of Ernesto P. Uruchurtu, the presidentially-appointed regent of the city's municipal authority, the Departamento del Distrito Federal, from 1952 to 1966 — as well as in Guadalajara, Monterrey, and Cuernavaca. It will examine municipal and federal officials' deployment of technocratic, often paternalistic discourses of hygiene and security, coupled with the cultural cachet and mimetic potential ascribed to modern architectural materials and forms, as a means to displace from the street—and to literally concretize—the dense assemblies and lightweight structures that frequently accompanied temporary popular markets, or *tianguis*. Building upon this last point, the paper asks how municipal markets may have been deployed by the ruling party to reinforce the loyalties of working class, often indigenous populations, even as they sought to expunge those same groups from urban arteries crucial to the PRI's burgeoning agendas of industrialization and urbanization, and its aim of revolutionizing the country's patterns of commerce and consumption.

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Reframing Neo-Imperial Outposts as Symbols of Korean Sovereignty

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Abstract

The inauguration of the Korean Empire in 1897 was accompanied by the construction of monumental diplomatic headquarters by the United Kingdom, Germany, Russia, Italy, France, and Belgium. These revivalist European buildings materially expressed Western claims over Korea's political and economic future. Dominating the cityscape, they symbolized Korea's weakening sovereignty through unequal diplomatic relations and Western neo-imperialism. After Japan's annexation of Korea in 1910, the buildings were absorbed by the colonial bureaucracy and later repurposed by capitalist institutions, deepening their association with foreign domination.

Whereas Japanese colonial architecture remains heavily problematized as a site of national trauma, former diplomatic buildings have been reframed in the past decades as historic evidence of international legitimacy and diplomatic recognition of (South) Korean sovereignty. This paper examines how the problematic origins of these Western neo-imperial structures have been neutralized and recast as positive heritage, by focusing on the former Belgian and Russian legations.

The Belgian Consulate-General (1903–1907) was offered back to Belgium in the 1990s. Belgium declined, citing high renovation costs. The building was dismantled, relocated, and reconstructed as part of the SEMA museum. Current narratives highlight Belgium's historic neutrality and support for Korean sovereignty as fellow secondary power, obscuring Belgium's colonial past and Leopold II's neo-imperial ambitions that created the building. The former Russian Legation, towering over Deoksugung Palace, was largely destroyed during the Korean War (1950-1953). The tower has been reconstructed (2015-2016) and reimagined as a memorial to Emperor Gojong and his refuge here after the assassination of Empress Myeongseong (1895).

Both cases reveal a selective framing of difficult imperial legacies in contemporary South Korea. These heritage discourse not only neutralizes the buildings' original functions as instruments of foreign domination, but leverage the historic ties as a geopolitical tool, strategically reinterpreting imperial architectures to align with present-day narratives of independence and sovereignty.

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Bradlaugh Hall: Disavowal, Erasure, and Postcolonial Memory

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Abstract

Bradlaugh Hall in Lahore occupies a fraught position in Pakistan's political memory because it harbors previously erased histories that unsettle dominant state narratives. Constructed in 1900 with funds raised by Dayal Singh Majithia, a Sikh reformist, banker, and Indian nationalist, and named after the British radical and freethinker Charles Bradlaugh, the hall quickly became a crucible for secular anti-colonial politics. It hosted revolutionary groups while also serving as a vibrant venue for Parsi theatre, literary gatherings, and civic debate.

After the 1947 Partition, however, the hall's symbolic and ideological associations became increasingly problematic for the newly formed Pakistani state. Figures linked to the building - such as Bhagat Singh, an atheist and Marxist committed to Indian nationalism lay outside the ideological bounds of the Islamic Republic and its project of producing a singular, homogenized history of national origin. The hall's legacy evokes anxieties around pluralism, dissent, and non-Muslim contributions to Lahore's anti-colonial past –dimensions often minimized in state historiography.

By the 1960's, the building was placed under the control of the Evacuee Trust Property Board, a state body which manages "abandoned" non-Muslim properties. This classification suspended the hall in a decades long state of legal and bureaucratic limbo rendering it neither usable nor fully erasable. Its physical deterioration reflects this ideological discomfort and the state's strategic avoidance of its legacy.

Although the past five years have seen state-led restoration efforts aimed at reintegrating Bradlaugh Hall into public cultural life with federal support to repurpose the building –these initiatives rely on selective remembrance, foregrounding Muslim figures while sanitizing its pluralist, anti-colonial legacy. This paper draws on archival records, press reports, and interviews with local residents to explore Bradlaugh Hall's contested afterlife and how the state embeds itself in everyday spatial practices –through decay, omission, and the managed reshaping of collective memory.

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Afterlife of Goa's Inquisition: A Lost Architecture of Repression

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Abstract

This paper explores the afterlife of the palace of the Inquisition of Goa, a structure long perceived as a symbol of religious persecution in India during Portuguese colonial rule. Initially part of Sultan Adil Shah's palace in the 16th century, the structure was repurposed in 1560 to accommodate the Tribunal of the Holy Office, which emerged as the epicentre of Catholic orthodoxy and repression in the region. At the same time, Portuguese authorities had to apply inquisitorial practices carefully, as they feared disturbing the fragile social balance they were trying to maintain.

As Enlightenment philosophy and reformist politics advanced under the Marquis of Pombal, beginning in 1774, the edifice's reputation began to deteriorate. By the late 18th century, it had become an ideological liability, described with increasing discomfort in official documents. After the Inquisition's suppression in 1812, the structure declined, reduced to ruin. Yet its symbolic weight endured: it was remembered locally as a site of suffering and feared memory and internationally invoked by Protestant powers to propagate the "Black Legend" framing Catholicism as inherently intolerant.

Despite its physical disappearance, the building's legacy remains accessible through a range of sources. This paper draws on early descriptions, including Richard Dellon's 17th-century account and Claudius Buchanan's visit to the ruins in 1808, alongside architectural plans by Linschoten (c. 1630) and João Nunes Bocarro (c. 1770), which document its layout of cells, chapels, and inquisitors' quarters. These materials allow for the reconstitution of a lost site but also reveal how architectural space materialized and symbolized ideology and fear.

Today, the site houses the guesthouse and offices of the Archaeological Survey of India. Through the lens of this "bad building," the paper examines the preservation of victim memory in built (and unbuilt) environments, and how contested pasts are mediated through architecture, memory, and historiography.

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Robin Hood Gardens: Capital, Preservation, and the Trauma of Loss

Alexandra Staub

Penn State University, USA

Abstract

Robin Hood Gardens, a London social housing complex designed by Alison and Peter Smithson, completed in 1972 and torn down in 2017, is considered an "uncomfortable" building for several reasons. The building's fate pitted architects and architectural historians against developers and popular opinion, with the former presenting the building as a progressive Brutalist masterpiece worthy of preservation, while the latter called it a concrete monstrosity that had to go. In a nod to the building's historical importance, the Victoria and Albert Museum acquired a section of the building as a relict for display. Countering this interpretation, the building's replacement provided 1500 new housing units for a gentrifying neighborhood.

Rarely considered in this debate are the perceptions of the people who were most directly affected by Robin Hood Garden's demise: the working-class residents who called it home.

This paper explores the tensions between Robin Hood Gardens' perceived architectural merit, the capital demands that led to its downfall, and its social significance as resident housing. The paper contrasts the arguments made for and against historical preservation with a visual and textual analysis of residents' spaces and lives collected through photos and texts by Kois Miah and Nick Thoburn in the years before the estate's deconstruction. This alternative understanding allows us to explore the meaning of home and the trauma through loss experienced by the estate's residents.

Understanding the varying receptions and interpretations of Robin Hood Gardens and its demise allows us to better position the histories of other housing projects that are aesthetically controversial, including informal housing communities and high-rise public housing projects such as Pruitt-Igoe in St. Louis or Cabrini-Green in Chicago. This paper concludes by asking if it is legitimate to evaluate housing stylistically at all – or if other means of historical evaluation should be used instead.

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Shaping "Italianness": Expatriate Childhood at a Seaside Summer Camp in Cattolica (1934)

Michela Bonomo

EPFL, Switzerland

Abstract

Unlike in Germany, where Allied-supported denazification led to the destruction of most monuments associated with the dictatorship, Italy preserved the majority of buildings constructed during the Fascist era. Among these were thousands of seaside summer camps for children (*colonie marine*), built to serve both social and ideological functions. In Cattolica, a coastal town on the Adriatic Sea, the Colonia XXVIII Ottobre (28th October) was completed in 1934 to accommodate thousands of children born abroad to Italian families. Designed as an immersive environment, the camp functioned as a site for shaping expatriate identity through the construction of new memories of "home." Through regimented routines of eating, sleeping, and collective discipline, the architecture contributed to reinforcing the regime's image and ideological reach beyond national borders.

This paper examines the *colonia* as both an architectural object and an ideological instrument. Conceived as a miniature "city of childhood," the camp produced an intensive, highly structured experience that left a lasting impression on its inhabitants, whom the regime regarded as "the most dangerous member of society". Drawing on archival research and typological analysis, I investigate the relationship between Fascist ritual and architectural form, asking whether the building's material presence can be meaningfully defined as "Fascist" and how such a designation might be critically assessed. The building remained in use as a summer camp until 1943; following multiple reuses, it has most recently been converted into an aquarium. This final adaptation resonates with architect Busiri Vici's original formal conception: three vessel-shaped buildings poised as if ready to set sail, a configuration that inspired its enduring appellation, *Le Navi* ("Ships").

PS43 Bad Buildings: Writing the Stories of Difficult Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Cara Rachele, ETH Zürich, Switzerland, and Lindsay Blair Howe, Technical University of Munich, Germany

Plantation Banking: Default, the Crédit Foncier Colonial, and Architectural Fragments in Réunion (1860–1920)

Elena M'Bouroukounda

Columbia University, USA

Abstract

After the abolition of slavery in the French Empire, the Colonial Land Bank (Le Crédit Foncier Colonial), the colonial arm of the French national land bank, sought to revitalize plantation economies by refinancing and industrializing sugar production.

In Réunion, a French colony in the Indian Ocean, the bank acquired architectural fragments of plantations, hoping to convert them into mechanized factories. While the integration of mechanized parts into sugar plantations occurred in some regions, such as the mega-plantations in Brazil, this transformation did not materialize on former plantations modeled after the Pere Labat system, which relied on manual power from slave labor. As planters defaulted on loans, the bank accumulated a portfolio of architectural remnants — sugar mills, processing sheds, and colonial buildings — across the French Indies. In 1876, the company owned 26 buildings, including 16 sugar plantations in Réunion. By 1885, that number had increased to 39 buildings, including 20 sugar plantations. The company spent the next sixty years of its existence selling off unwanted properties and, in some instances, undertook the rebuilding of structures damaged by cyclones and hurricanes.

This paper examines a dual history of the Colonial Land Bank's collection of plantation fragments. In centering the buildings that constituted the material foundation of a larger plantation unit — a legal entity that brought together the enslaved body, monocultural production, and buildings into a single heterogeneous whole — I question what endures of an architecture contingent upon its living parts. How did the direct afterlife of the plantation on Réunion materialize as architectural and financial detritus? Moreover, what does the defaulting of plantations reveal about the situated understanding of architecture's complicity in a system premised on racialized labor exploitation?

PS44 Interiority and Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Robin Schuldenfrei, Courtauld, University of London, United Kingdon and Min Kyung Lee, Bryn Mawr College, USA

Archiving Absentia: Lost Homes of China's Wu Region

Xixi Chen

Syracuse University, USA

Abstract

Things are not as they were, people are no more.

- Adapted from a poem by Li Qingzhao.

Archiving Absentia reconstructs the former lives of demolished homes in greater Shanghai, using their biographies as an intimate lens for understanding the lived effects of urban transformation at the turn of the millennium. Part of a larger project Ghost Houses 记忆中的家, glimpses of untold and previously unwritten histories are shared through my own family's journey of becoming Shanghainese.

For this presentation, I define interiority as an unfixed and multiscalar expression of kinship, privacy, and belonging within shared domestic spaces. I argue that its quality has changed as a result of migration and state-led redevelopment. In my position as a descendant of this region, I combine oral history, archival research, mapping, drawing, and physical modeling as ethnographic operations on my own ancestral archive to trace the interiority of Shanghai and the greater Wu language region for an approximate 50-year period– from the second half of the 20th century into the 2010s.

As regional migrants who moved to Shanghai and eventually became part of the urban working class, my family is part of the larger– and largely invisible– demographic that felt the most effects from housing modernization and eminent domain policies. Their cumulative experiences, and the collective representation of the interiors they once inhabited, make up a majority of the ethnographic dimension to my research. Expanding on research by diasporic cultural historians who have challenged dominant colonial narratives of Shanghai, I examine overlooked intimate spaces by extending the timeline into the 21st century and repositioning it within an interdisciplinary design discourse.

PS44 Interiority and Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Robin Schuldenfrei, Courtauld, University of London, United Kingdon and Min Kyung Lee, Bryn Mawr College, USA

"Improvised Interiors: Migration and Material Culture in Post-1959 Havana"

Sara Reed

Virginia Commonwealth University, USA

Abstract

This paper explores how internal migration and revolutionary restructuring in post-1959 Havana gave rise to improvised domestic interiors that challenged conventional notions of space, design, and domesticity. Following the Cuban Revolution, a wave of rural migrants moved into urban neighborhoods vacated by exiled elites, particularly in areas like Miramar. Once characterized by spacious, single-family homes, these neighborhoods were rapidly transformed into densely inhabited zones where multiple families shared subdivided spaces. Garages became bedrooms, living rooms were partitioned, and entire houses were retrofitted using salvaged or improvised materials. In these adaptive environments, migrants forged new forms of domestic life using what was available: chickens roamed on straw-covered tile floors, orange crates became stools, and broken furniture was repaired and repurposed with creativity and care.

Despite material scarcity and the provisional nature of these interiors, aesthetics, comfort, and dignity remained central concerns. This tension between limited resources and the desire for beauty was actively negotiated through state-supported media, particularly *Mujeres*, the magazine of the Federation of Cuban Women. *Mujeres* encouraged women to beautify their homes using discarded materials, framing such efforts as both revolutionary and respectable. These publications validated improvised interiors as expressions of national pride, resourcefulness, and feminine creativity.

Drawing on ethnographic work by Oscar and Ruth Lewis and Susan Rigdon in *Neighbors*, as well as visual and textual materials from revolutionary-era publications, this paper argues that these interiors were not merely products of necessity, but deliberate responses to social and ideological change. Rather than passive reflections of architectural intent, they were dynamic, lived environments shaped by revolution, migration, and personal agency. In 1960s Havana, the domestic interior became a site of negotiation where beauty and belonging were continually redefined within the shifting conditions of a radically transformed urban landscape.

PS44 Interiority and Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Robin Schuldenfrei, Courtauld, University of London, United Kingdon and Min Kyung Lee, Bryn Mawr College, USA

Interiors, Buildings and Infrastructures in Daily Bare Life

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Abstract

This paper examines the interior architecture of Bourj el-Barajneh, the largest Palestinian refugee camp in Beirut, using the example of Samir's one-room apartment.

Founded in 1948 as a tented settlement without electricity or sewage and with only communal bathrooms without doors, the domestic spaces of the camp have evolved into dense, vertical structures. Here, improvised and organised external aid are intertwined to shape the interior spaces, while prolonged displacement has redefined the concepts of privacy, intimacy, and utility.

At home, when Samir turns on the tap, the water flows through the pipes installed by the Italian Government; if he turns on the light, the electricity is supplied by a new substation donated by Japan. His building is built on unstable ground: every time a new storey is added, he observes that the ground floor columns, lacking adequate foundations, grow larger as they sink into the sandy soil.

His family life is closely linked to infrastructure systems provided by international aid organisations. His children attend classes at Terre des hommes, while Al-Ghad organises activities in its playgrounds, his grandchildren go to a nursery school in a building equipped by a Turkish agency, his family receives healthcare at Haifa Hospital. In his free time, Samir meets his friends in UNRWA-renovated shelters.

The absence of formal toponymy underscores a collective interiority, where alleys and shelters become extensions of every home. A hybrid interiority, where domestic survival depends on external actors, yet is also negotiated through familial and communal practices, altering spatial hierarchies as humanitarian infrastructure permeates private life, blurring the boundaries between institutional support and personal adaptation.

Through field surveys and interviews documenting refugees' placemaking, we explore how camp interiors challenge architectural norms. We present this controversial yet existential domain, where migration transforms the notion of home, from improvised thresholds to transnational NGOs.

PS44 Interiority and Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Robin Schuldenfrei, Courtauld, University of London, United Kingdon and Min Kyung Lee, Bryn Mawr College, USA

The Expanded Domesticities of Migrant Worlds

Olga Touloumi

Bard College, USA

Abstract

In the early 1970s, two friends, the Japanese artist Tamiko Kawata and the French architect Christine Benglia-Bevington, made a pact. Living in New York City, away from the extended family structures that would have supported them back home, they found themselves struggling to make time and space for their own work. Instead of dealing with childcare alone in a system that penalized young mothers, they joined forces and shared childcare. Each week and for the entirety of the day, one of them would tend to the children, meanwhile the other would pursue creative work, or leisure, or simply time alone. Expanding and connecting their families was a liberatory strategy that allowed them to forge a place for their work and desires, against the gendered realm of the postwar US nuclear family. In doing so, they built another world.

Based on interviews and family archives of these two women, this paper will explore the expanded domesticities that emerge in migration and the role that friendship plays in building and sustaining them. Unlike immigrants with family ties to ethnic enclaves, the story of those two women afford us the opportunity to examine the transnational solidarities at the heart of migratory homemaking away from home. The expanded interiors that emerge are often shaped by difference – social, ethnic, cultural – and a continuous exchange of ideas and support that ultimately transforms not only the everyday life but also the practice and work of those who inhabit it. The pact led Kawata to experiment with scale, rethinking her sculptures as worlds; and Benglia-Bevington to decidedly take on a research project on cooperatives, reimagining the “American home” and launching her practice Architecture for the Child, Woman, and Man.

PS44 Interiority and Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Robin Schuldenfrei, Courtauld, University of London, United Kingdon and Min Kyung Lee, Bryn Mawr College, USA

Inhabiting Transition: Labor and the Interiority of Migration in Dhaka

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Abstract

This paper examines the spatial experiences of rural-urban migrant workers who move cyclically between agricultural villages and urban construction sites in Dhaka. Often displaced by climate-induced vulnerability and disappearing agrarian livelihoods, the movement of construction workers links shifting landscapes with the unfolding of the urban built environment.

For many migrant workers, construction sites are recurring places of arrival in the city. As buildings take shape, workers cook, gather, and sleep in the architecture they are constructing. Within unfinished structures, fragile interiors are partitioned with cloth, bamboo, and corrugated sheets, producing domestic zones within planned architectural spaces. The construction site becomes a place of transition – an interiority within the city anchored to villages through seasonal agrarian rhythms and family ties, embodying the rural loss, resilience, and the environmental transformations of the delta.

Through an interdisciplinary framework and ethnographic attention to spatial practices, this paper situates the construction site as a site of migration, examining the layered and asymmetric experiences of migration within architecture as well as in architectural narratives. By foregrounding overlooked experiences of interiority and migration, this paper reconsiders architecture as a divergently experienced yet collective and embodied process.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

'Ruins of Remembrance': War-Damaged Churches and the Making of Memorial Gardens in the City of London

Boryana Ivanova

University of Cambridge, United Kingdom

Abstract

This paper investigates the post-war histories of three Blitz-damaged churches in the City of London: St. Dunstan-in-the-East, Christ Church Greyfriars, and St. Mary Aldermanbury, focusing on their mid-twentieth century transformation into landscaped public gardens. While these sites are often discussed in terms of wartime destruction or ecclesiastical heritage, this study is the first to systematically explore how they were reimagined and reconstructed in the decades following the Second World War. By foregrounding this overlooked architectural history, the archival research reveals how these church ruins were deliberately reshaped through landscape design to function as informal, yet potent, commemorative environments to the Blitz.

Drawing on extensive archival research of new material alongside on-site analysis, the paper argues that these church ruins represent a distinct and understated typology of post-war memorials – one that eschews heroic statuary or overt symbolism in favour of embedded, spatial modes of remembrance: landscape memorials. Their ruined forms were neither fully restored nor cleared but instead retained as evocative fragments within carefully curated green spaces. In doing so, they reflect evolving post-war attitudes towards loss, memory, and urban renewal in Britain.

By focusing on the post-war transformation, rather than solely the wartime damage, this paper recovers a neglected dimension of these sites' histories and repositions them as essential components of London's memorial landscape.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Making the LIC home: a dweller's perspective of public housing in India

Rukmini Swaminathan

University of Michigan, USA

Abstract

From the 1970s onwards, the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) established a series of housing projects across Indian cities for its policyholders. As a public institution, LIC participated in the construction of post-independence nation-making that brought the home to the forefront of India's political economy. Much has been written about LICs' role in insurance constructed through paper trails, loan agreements, government sanctions, and advertisements found in the national archives. However, the history of its townships has been neglected as it resides outside the "official" archive.

In this paper, I draw on methods of visual culture, oral history, and house biographies to build a history of LIC's townships. These methods also provide a lens to observe how various actors, from architects, contractors, to the policy-holding dwellers, negotiated with the state and participated in post-independence anxieties of unpredictability and phase-wise development that was borne out of it. At each stage, they dealt with uncertainty but sustained their belief that LIC was worth waiting for. As a dweller put it, "Once an LIC-ian always an LIC-ian." This paper builds on fragments of material memories to construct a history of the LIC home. It is reflective of a history of post-independence India that relied on collaboration. Bringing insurance and housing together, the LIC home participated in imagining their policyholders as dwellers, creating a community held together by the corporation. Simultaneously, these homes came together with the joint efforts of architects, contractors, and policy-holding dwellers. The various stakeholders involved in the construction of the LIC's housing are reflective of the collaborative nature of imagining the post-independence home. Public housing, therefore, was not only a result of stateist imagination but one that was endorsed and adapted by various actors.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Aqueous Landscapes of Sacredness across South Asian Waters

Amrita Vinod

University of Pittsburgh, USA

Abstract

This talk focuses on two sacred sites, one Christian and one Hindu, in the cultural and ecological zone connecting southern India and northern Sri Lanka. It explores the entanglements among sacred architecture, ecology, and commerce in the aqueous landscapes shared by two nation-states within the broader Indian Ocean region. By situating two sacred places within the larger fabric of ordinary and secular activities, I argue that sacred architecture in this cultural zone is co-created by humans and non-human agents such as water, wind, and marine life. Sacred architecture in South Asia has been framed as "timeless" by historical narratives rooted in coloniality and Orientalism. Such narratives have privileged monumentality and iconography, freezing the region's sacred architecture in the past. I challenge such static readings by investigating sacred places not as fixed places of ritual purity but as dynamic and porous geographies—places where everyday life, labour, and devotion are interwoven. For this, I trace the overlapping realms of sacred and profane in these sites through on-site observation, mapping, and sketching. At the Kothanda Ramar temple on the southern tip of Rameswaram Island in India, an economy of fishing alongside ritual immersion for purification utilises water as an element of sacred architecture as well as a source of daily livelihood. Here we see how water operates as both a material of everyday labour and a cosmological agent to co-create, define, and maintain architectures of sacredness and secularity. Drawing from cultural landscape studies, anthropology, and South Asian architectural history, this talk proposes a relational understanding of space, one that transcends architecture and landscape divisions, nation-state boundaries, and anthropocentric definitions of the built environment.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

On the Frontier: Territorial Sovereignties in al-Dahiye, Beirut

Sarah Soudki

University of Waterloo, Canada

Abstract

Beirut is a dynamic and divided city, formerly split along the "Green Line" during the Lebanese Civil War (1975-1990.) While the war has long passed, the city remains divided along a multitude of informal borders. Various – and often opposing – actors claim their territorial sovereignty within its urban fabric. The spatial manifestations of these claims serve as a form of bordering, bringing the politics of belonging into the daily life of Beirut's residents (Yuval-Davis, 2006) – and creating a subconscious separation into an "us" and "them." More often than not, this bordering does not occur along a precise geographical line. Instead, areas in and around Beirut become a frontier where cues in the built environment signal what actors have claimed territorial sovereignty, and with that, whether residents belong in the space they are inhabiting.

This paper investigates Beirut's southern suburbs – colloquially known as al-Dahiye – as a frontier. An infamous area of the city, al-Dahiye is home to working class Beirut's, internally displaced Lebanese, refugees, and migrant workers. Largely recognized as a "Hezbollah stronghold," it has been heavily bombarded throughout its history – most recently in the fall of 2024. In recent years, Hezbollah and other quasi-state organizations have slowly expanded their territorial sovereignties, staking their claim through posters, construction, and other spatial means. Similarly, the Lebanese state has enforced their sovereignty through an infrastructure of checkpoints, roadblocks, and flags. These competing claims expanding into each other have increased tensions, with many residents seeing this as a threat to their continued existence in al-Dahiye and Beirut (Bou Akar, 2018.) As such, this paper investigates spatial manifestations of territorial sovereignty in al-Dahiye, ultimately documenting its complex urban fabric and unveiling the resulting social implications.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Grounding imperialism: Zschokke and the construction of the El-Kansera Dam in Morocco from 1927-1934

Tiffanie Paré

EPFL, Switzerland

Abstract

What can a colonial dam's foundations reveal about imperial practices and hidden social impacts in architecture history? The El Kansera Dam in Morocco (1927-1934), built by the *Omnium d'Entreprises* and Swiss contractor Zschokke French subsidiary *Entreprise des grands travaux hydrauliques de France*, serves as a paradigmatic case study. Through the French subsidiary of the Swiss contractor Zchokke, this deep involvement in the French colonial apparatus demonstrates yet another imperial entanglement through the private industries of "neutral" Switzerland. Hidden Swiss partners bringing the power of Alpine dam expertise and Swiss financing, making the dam one of many Swiss–French hydraulic projects outside its border.

Rather than focusing on unilateral technical transfers from Switzerland to Morocco, this paper examines how knowledge was exchanged and created through such projects. It explores how mercenary forms of private engineering firms were supported by Swiss federal institutions, illustrating how the Swiss state utilized private industry to exert control abroad. It then considers the project's relation to French colonial governance, questioning why such an elaborate technoscientific apparatus collaborated with a neighboring European nation. Finally, by cross-reading institutional archives, the paper investigates the project's interactions with local farmers, Moroccan rock and soil, Moroccan territorial knowledge, and the development of know-how, ultimately exploring the agency of a project treated as a testing ground.

This lightning talk presents research from a larger project arguing that Swiss domestic networks of knowledge production expected Zschokke and other contractors to export immaterial expertise abroad. However, it examines how much of that expertise was produced in colonial contexts, using them as testing grounds, and then imported back into Swiss practices. I will focus on the investigative methodological approach, emphasizing how archival documentation offers potential for uncovering counter-archival moments that reveal hidden sociocultural dynamics behind seemingly polished imperial infrastructures such as the El Kansera Dam.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

From Jea to MIDUVI and Beyond: Social Housing in Achuar Territory

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University of Oklahoma, USA

Abstract

This paper traces the historical trajectory of state-sponsored social housing in Indigenous territories of the Ecuadorian Amazon, with a particular focus on the Achuar people in the Ecuadorian Amazon. Since the early 2000s, the Ecuadorian Ministry of Urban Development and Housing (MIDUVI) has introduced standardized housing models into Achuar communities, often disregarding local lifeways, cosmologies, and spatial traditions. These interventions—designed to modernize and improve Indigenous dwellings—have in practice facilitated the erosion of traditional forms of Achuar living embodied in the "jea," a traditional thatch and pole house deeply tied to ritual cycles, gendered divisions of space, and ecological timekeeping.

This paper critically examines three major housing interventions: a 2009 and 2013 MIDUVI prototype, an international competition design allegedly inspired by Achuar/Shuar cultural values, and a 2025 community-generated alternative in Sharamentsa. By drawing on interviews, visual documentation, and spatial analysis, the study looks at how these housing models have impacted Achuar communities, especially in terms of how knowledge is shared across generations, how people interact, and how cultural traditions are maintained.

By comparing government and international models to a collaborative, community-based design process, the paper shows how returning to traditional architectural ideas can help strengthen cultural identity and community well-being. This research aims to contribute to the broader understanding of housing policy in the Amazon and highlights how Indigenous communities like the Achuar are finding ways to adapt and sustain their traditions through innovative, culturally-informed approaches to building.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Claim to Shame? Vienna's Ernst-Kirchweger-Haus, 1990-2025

Ulli Unterweger

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Abstract

The Ernst-Kirchweger-Haus (EKH) is one of Vienna's most contested buildings—architecturally, politically, and symbolically. Located in the city's 10th district, it has served as an autonomous leftist social center since 1990, initially as an occupied space and later legalized in 2008. Over decades, it has weathered calls for closure by conservative politicians and repeated violent attacks by far-right extremists. Labeled an "eyesore" and a "place of shame," it nonetheless persists as a hub for activism and alternative culture.

This lightning talk explores how the EKH's resilience is rooted not only in its activist community but also in its architectural form. Built in the early 1930s by the Czech School Association Komensky, the building's design reflects both the modernist ideals of the new democratic republics and the marginalization of Vienna's Czech minority during the Habsburg Empire. Originally designed as a school, it did not serve this purpose long, as it was taken over by the Nazis in the 1940s to house the Hitler Youth, then by the Austrian Communist Party, until its current chapter began in 1990. Each use drew on the adaptable layout, enabling reinvention amid shifting political conditions.

Building on methods from my dissertation *Claims from the Margins: Group Activism and Strategies of Place-making in Vienna's Built Environment, 1870–1938*, this case study analyzes architectural features of the EKH that echo earlier experiences of resistance, solidarity, and resource sharing. The structure was designed for flexibility and multifunctionality, to serve not only as a school but also as a shared space for the larger Czech community. These design choices enabled drastically different uses and adaptability.

This paper highlights how design can enable enduring spaces of resistance and community in contested urban contexts and raises broader questions about choosing analytical methods with political intentionality.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Auxiliary Images: Models, Mock-ups, Molds and Their Curatorial Uses

Maria del Carmen Barrios

Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico

Abstract

"Auxiliary Images" is an essay about a series of objects and images that have become increasingly common in exhibitions about public art and architecture in Mexico: models, mock-ups, prototypes, molds, studies, and contact sheets. Auxiliary images are all those created by an artist or architect during the process of producing a final work. These images are not the final work, and they are treated differently from the reverence usually afforded to a finished artwork or architectural project: sometimes, they are dismissed as detritus and discarded. In other cases, they are preserved due to their association with the work process and archived as documentation of that very process. Finally—and increasingly commonly—curators use them as substitutes for non-existent or immovable works that they wish to place in dialogue with other pieces within the exhibition space, as seen in recent exhibitions of Juan O'Gorman, Ángela Gurría, and Helen Escobedo.

The paper presents a thorough critical examination of what it means to use auxiliary images as stand-ins for public art or architectural works in exhibitions. This is important in order to assess a current curatorial practice in Mexico that has not previously been identified or described, but which has the potential to reassign value to images that were not created with the intention of becoming final works—yet, through curatorial decisions, may be displayed, collected or traded as if they were.

PS45 Graduate Student Lightning Talks
Session Chair: Sylvia Faichney, University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Life, Care, and Death: Armenian Making of 19th-Century Constantinople

Eyüp Özkan

McGill University, Canada

Abstract

This study examines the spatial presence of the Armenian community in Constantinople before the 1915 genocide, defining spatial presence as a social production realized through conception, use, experience, and articulation. The nineteenth century is the focus for two reasons. First, nineteenth-century figures indicate that Armenians reached about one-fifth of the city's population (Shaw 1979). Second, from 1839 to 1876, the Ottoman Empire implemented the Tanzimat reforms, a program of imperial reorganization that introduced comprehensive regulations in planning, public health, and infrastructure and transformed the urban landscape. Within this setting, I ask how Armenians across social segments engaged with a state-aligned modernization program and how its implementation influenced communal spatial practices and social structures. My objective is to reconstruct the extent and modalities of spatial presence at pivotal life stages through Armenian responses to nineteenth-century urban modernization. To do so, I consult systematic registers of baptisms, marriages, and funerals, documenting where individuals lived, died, and were buried, of the Armenian Apostolic Patriarchate and the Catholic Archdiocese, as well as patient and staff registers from two communal hospitals. By employing different digital distant-reading technics, I spatialize archival data and reveal dispersed and overlooked forms of spatial and discursive appropriation of the city by Armenians. The hypothesis is that spatial claims do not hinge on population size; they are continually reproduced through individual and collective appropriation. I demonstrate that even the most vulnerable segments of this presumed minority exercised spatial agency across multiple domains of daily life, and in doing so, produced a situated version of the city. This account shows that minority designation is analytically irrelevant in spatial terms.

PS46 Architecture and Capital in Spanish America, 1500 to 1700

Session Chair: Jesús Escobar, Northwestern University, USA

Beyond the Myth of the Architect: Naming Building Hierarchies in New Spain

Maryluna Santos-Giraldo

Tulane University, USA

Abstract

This paper addresses the understudied distinction between *alarife* and *obrero mayor* within the hierarchical framework of colonial architectural production. In prior historiography, these terms have often been conflated or mistranslated—frequently rendered as "architects" or "builders"—a slippage that is especially problematic given that "builders" referred to a third and separate group of agents, typically identified by their practical knowledge. Embedded in the archival contracts and city ordinances of the sixteenth and seventeenth-century New Spain lies a central question: if labor, expertise, and responsibility were often comparable, why did the cabildo distinguish so clearly between the roles of the *alarife*, the *obrero mayor,* and the builders?

Such conflation flattens the complex human relationships at the core of colonial building practices, privileging stylistic interpretation over the labor systems and economic structures that shaped architectural production. Through a close examination of town council records, guild regulations, payment accounts, and legal disputes, this paper traces how colonial, racial, and economic hierarchies were articulated in the difference between the *obrero mayor* from the *alarife*, because of the frequent noble titles of the first and his apparent holding of the position to ascend within the ranks of the Cabildo. Meanwhile, *builders* occupied yet another position, often tied to marginalized communities and manual labor.

The task of reimagining these figures as economic agents embedded in colonial systems of governance and racialized labor control, invites for a methodological shift—one that moves away from formalist frameworks and toward a deeper engagement with the labor economies that shaped the colonial Latin American built environment.

PS46 Architecture and Capital in Spanish America, 1500 to 1700

Session Chair: Jesús Escobar, Northwestern University, USA

The Hacienda as Rehearsal for the City: Architecture as Privatization

Gabriel Gutierrez Huerta

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Abstract

A critical process in the Hispanic monarchy's expansionist enterprises in Mesoamerica during the sixteenth century was the acquisition and conversion of knowledge and subjects. While Spanish settlers and resources were deployed extensively across newly-acquired territories, it was the appropriation and reworking of indigenous knowledge of the basin's land, water, and agricultural systems that facilitated the reproduction of imperial power. Native populations were indispensable as continuous sources of this expertise and labor, and thus an invaluable asset to harness in the processes of colonization. Among the various means of procuring and assimilating communities for subjecthood was the creation of urban and agrarian networks, such as the hacienda system linked to new Spanish municipalities as centers for economic production and governance. Within this mechanism, multiple strategies for controlling labor and capital were introduced and iterated, from encomienda and repartimiento to private debt peonage, all inherently turning on fabricated asymmetries of class and race. The juridico-economic organization of the hacienda was inseparable from its spatial form; an architectural apparatus that refined, at the scale of the estate, the institutional logic the colonial city was developing. The emergent spatial syntax of enclosure and hierarchy organized labor and social reproduction, absorbing populations into imperial ideas of civilized living and conditioning subjects as much through the ordering of space as through law. By tracing the hacienda's emergence from the ecological privatization of agrarian landscapes, through its consolidation as fixed capital and territorial instrument, to its structural homology with colonial urbanization, this paper examines how a nascent typology and the colonial city were coextensive expressions of a single spatial project.

PS46 Architecture and Capital in Spanish America, 1500 to 1700

Session Chair: Jesús Escobar, Northwestern University, USA

Economics of Power: Potosí's Casa de La Moneda in the Seventeenth Century

Christina Nagel

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Abstract

This paper critically examines the architectural spatial history of the Casa de la Moneda in Potosi during the 17th century, situating the building within the broader context of Spanish colonial urbanism and extractive economies in the Andes. Constructed in the imperial mining city of Imperial Villa of Potosi, the Casa de la Moneda was not merely a minting facility but a monumental expression of colonial power, material wealth, and indigenous/ enslaved African labor exploitation. Its austere yet imposing design, characterized by massive stone walls, minimal ornamentation, fortress-like features, and an impending Bacchus mask, reflects both functional concerns—such as security and durability, and symbolic aims to assert imperial and colonial dominance. Drawing on archival sources, architectural analysis, and critical historiography, this study interrogates the ways in which the building's form and function embodied the coercive infrastructure of colonial exploitative silver exploitation and production. Furthermore, it examines how Indigenous and enslaved African labor, often under the mita system, was deeply ingrained in the very material and spatial fabric of the structure, rendering the Casa de la Moneda a palimpsest of exploitation, colonization, resistance, and a distinctive architectural typology situated in the colonial Bolivian landscape. By reevaluating this key monument through a critical lens, the paper contributes to a deeper understanding of the intersections between architecture, colonialism, and exploitation in Bolivia and early modern Latin America.

PS46 Architecture and Capital in Spanish America, 1500 to 1700

Session Chair: Jesús Escobar, Northwestern University, USA

The Urban Aesthetics of Policía

John López

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Abstract

An "empire of towns" is how historian Richard Kagan characterized the Spanish city building program in the non-European Hispanic world. Buenos Aires, Lima, Bogotá in South America; Havana, Santo Domingo, and San Juan in the Caribbean; and Puebla, Mexico City, El Paso, and Santa Fe in North America are just a handful of the three hundred and fifty settlements the Spanish founded. In Asia, Manila also illustrates the Spanish urban ideal. Not since Roman times had as many gridiron towns been established as a tool for conquest. Surely, Spain's city building program is unparalleled in the history of urbanism for the number of settlements founded and for their geographic breadth.

The classical European world informed the Spanish on how to understand their colonial cities. Spanish *policía* was modeled after the ancient Greek ideal of *politeia* (πολιτεία), a republic of citizens organized into a *polis* (city-state) united in political governance. Yet under the Roman statesman and orator, Cicero, Greek *politeia* became associated with *res publica* and *urbanitas* that the Spanish transformed into the Christian, moral imperative of *policía Cristiana*. For the Spanish, *policía Cristiana* meant an orderly Christian society living in an architecturally ordered city. However, what is less understood about *policía* is that it also had an aesthetic mandate, a point that Sebastián de Covarrubias Orozco (1539–1613) registered in his 1611 dictionary, *Tesoro de la lengua castellana o Española*. As Covarrubias indicates, *policía* was a legislative matter whose jurisdiction fell to the "council of police" in governing "the small things of the city" including "its adornment and cleanliness." This talk scrutinizes the philosophical implications of *policía* to the aesthetic character of Spanish New World cities.

PS46 Architecture and Capital in Spanish America, 1500 to 1700

Session Chair: Jesús Escobar, Northwestern University, USA

Social Formation and Labor at the Cathedral of Santo Domingo

Michael Schreffler

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Abstract

The Cathedral of Santo Domingo, in the Dominican Republic, was the first cathedral to be built in the Americas. Constructed between 1521 and the mid-1540s, it is a rare example of a sixteenth-century building in the Americas outside of Mexico that remains standing with its sixteenth century features largely intact. The earliest scholarship on the cathedral dates to the 1930s, when the historian Luis Alemar wrote a monograph about it. Since then, the building has been the subject of a substantial body of scholarly literature focused largely on the analysis of form and style, and seeking to link aspects of the building to counterparts on the Iberian Peninsula. Scholarship prompted by conservation and restoration projects begun in the 1980s refined our understanding of the cathedral's construction history, the materials used to build it, and its interior and exterior ornamentation. The cathedral's place in the broader social history of Santo Domingo—that is, in relation to the city's population and social hierarchy—has been less examined. A consideration of the cathedral's history and ornamentation that is attentive to the social and statutory environments in which it took shape provides a different view, linking its construction to distinct communities, social formations, and forms of labor on the island in the first half of the sixteenth century.

PS47 Oceanic Histories

Session Chair: Adil Mansure, Harvard University, USA

"Christian Architecture and a Boat": Gothic Revival and the Victorian Shore at A. W. N. Pugin's Ramsgate

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Abstract

The recent "global turn" of Gothic Revival frames architecture under the transnational network of ideas and materiality, which comes at the expense of the sea, flattening it into a pure symbol of its geographic extension. Within existing scholarship, there are scant mentions of Pugin's engagement with the environmental element, such as his penchant for sailing or his decision to build his own church and residence by the Kentish coast. This present paper argues that the sea and the coastal environment have a greater presence in Pugin's work than in the symbolic or biographical. I highlight two ways in which the material conditions of the sea shaped Pugin's work: the Gothic spire conceived as a vertical marker of maritime visibility; and his rejection of eclectic seaside building in favor of a coastal architecture more fully rooted in the material and cultural character of its environment, a sensibility he shared with contemporary geologists. In the first case, the coast and the sea were not simply a threshold across which Gothic traveled, but a site where architectural visibility and scale were rearticulated from a maritime perspective. In the second case, the extensively urbanizing British seaside in the early 19th century, for the tourism industry, presented a unique context and platform for the articulation of new architectural styles. In this sense, the sea and the coast interacted with the Gothic not only as its accidental site, but also conferred it with new meanings and conditions. Co-existing with the global circulation of the Gothic Revival is the intellectual and practical conditions of the style, rooted in local particularities and the maritime environment.

PS47 Oceanic Histories

Session Chair: Adil Mansure, Harvard University, USA

Ships, Stains, and the Scales of History

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Abstract

The story in this paper is about marine expertise and repair and it centers nineteenth-century oceanic architectures and mobility-reliant regimes of knowledge production. Situated amidst naval architecture's transition from wood to iron and sail to steam, it begins with the 1855 controversy over the specifications of paint compounds for the *Great Eastern* – the gigantic transatlantic vessel whose experimental design heralded "modern" shipbuilding – and extends forward some thirty years to the ship's whitewashing in preparation for laying telegraph cables in the tropical waters and hot climate of the Indian Ocean. Never incidental, paint – ships' outmost layer – was increasingly called upon to render hulls watertight, manage plates' oxidization, and limit bottoms' biofouling as the contingencies of timber gave way to those of metal in the second half of the nineteenth century. Positing paint as architecture's (oceanic and terrestrial) interface with its host media (water and air), this paper brings to the fore the ways in which pigments, stains, and coatings arbitrated ships' relationship with the various marine environments encountered *en route*. It does so to parse how such material contingencies enabled the production of technical expertise not only *in* transit but also *through* it. The pigmented membranes traced in archival material (memoranda, reports, correspondence) and published accounts pertaining to the *Great Eastern's* construction-and-repair, then, tell a story of knowledge about oceanic architecture being produced through the friction between globally itinerant matter and local conditions, environments, or intelligences. Crucially, they thereby outline an oceanic approach to architectural history, which complicates historiographical debates on scale by attending to ships' operation across micro- and macro-historical scales: that is to say, by surveying their ability to transfer architectural matter or expertise across colonial networks *and* metabolize them in transit; by heeding their capacity to remain embedded in globally mobile practices *and* subject to local conditions.

PS47 Oceanic Histories

Session Chair: Adil Mansure, Harvard University, USA

The "Mechanics" of Whaling: Labor, Knowledge, and Techniques in the Nineteenth Century United States

José Monge

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Abstract

Before the adoption of tryworks in the 1750s, Whaling was a trade based exclusively on experience. Sailors avoided land in direct proportion to their ambitions, as their skills, their "craft", were shaped only at sea. A hundred years later, with whaling voyages averaging three years in length, different conditions of unreliability forced whalers to diversify their crews by adding skilled workers to them. Known as "mechanics," these workers included coopers, blacksmiths, carpenters, and stewards, and had special privileges compared to the regular sailors.

Whaling ships were complex modular constructions that prioritized durability and cargo storage over speed, with maintenance being crucial to guarantee their success. As skilled laborers, blacksmiths mainly fabricated the harpoons used to strike whales, carpenters repaired the main ship and boats, and coopers built the casks used for storing the rendered oil, But, at the same time, the tools, furniture, and vessels they depended on were a product of the combined labor of all of them, turning ships into small, self-sustained, constructions.

I argue that the study of these "mechanics" offers an opportunity to bridge the land-to-sea gap expertise, both in terms of labor/production and knowledge, the two components of "technique." Mechanics transported their skills to the sea at the same time they established a system of apprenticeships on land, changing the landscape of coastal settlements. Being able to learn from a young age on land, work at sea as adults for higher wages, and become masters in their later years, mechanics diversified and stretched their window as able laborers. By being "visitors" of the trade, considered outsiders by the sailors, they succeeded at putting knowledge transference on hold to maximize profit when their bodies were at their peak. This is almost the opposite of regular sailors and has yet to be studied closely.

PS47 Oceanic Histories

Session Chair: Adil Mansure, Harvard University, USA

Militarizing the Lingding Sea: Boat Dwellers, Fisheries Communes, and Environmental Conflicts in South China

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Abstract

After 1949, the Lingding Sea—the waters between mainland China, Hong Kong, and Macau—emerged as a Cold War border zone separating the socialist mainland from colonial Hong Kong and Macau. For centuries, the coasts of the Lingding Sea had been home to boat-dwelling communities, often stigmatized as Dan, who sustained themselves through fishing, oyster farming, pearl collecting, and water transport. Shaped by the ever-changing ecology of the sea, their adaptive movements enabled them to operate largely beyond the effective reach of the state. This maritime way of life marked them as both ethnically and politically marginal, exposing them to recurrent suspicion as smugglers, pirates, and spies.

The Cold War recast the Lingding Sea as a political and ideological frontier between the newly established socialist state on the mainland and British Hong Kong and Portuguese Macau. Under Mao, these mobile, highly specialized maritime communities were mobilized as militia and as a crucial labour force in socialist fisheries production. From the 1950s through the mid-1980s, the establishment of fisherfolk's "new villages" and fisheries communes sought to concentrate dispersed maritime populations onshore and anchor them in fixed, land-modelled settlements. As spatial instruments of Maoist mass mobilization, these projects aimed not only to collectivize and mechanize production, but also to draw fisherfolk into militia organizations, secure the maritime border, and reorient Hong Kong and Macau fisherfolk toward the mainland.

However, the sea itself—imagined by the state as a territory that could be made safe and governable—kept unsettling this vision. Tides, fish, oysters, salinity, and the embodied knowledge of those who depended on them continually disrupted efforts to fix mobility and impose terrestrial modes of control. Drawing on gazetteers, atlases, newspapers, and oral history interviews, this paper explores the contradictions at the heart of these coastal experiments. Fishing continued to require seasonal migrations and cross-border exchanges, which in turn necessitated local knowledge and pushed back against state interventions, compelling authorities to accommodate the unruly materiality of the sea.

PS47 Oceanic Histories

Session Chair: Adil Mansure, Harvard University, USA

The Qayaq and the Sea: Watercraft in the Global North Pacific

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Abstract

A Russian imperial map from 1775 pictures a Native man and his qayaq riding the sea south of the Aleutian Islands. Wearing a feathered hunting visor and a waterproof parka stitched from seal gut, the sea hunter propels himself forward at a pace outstripping seabirds. In the late eighteenth century, lightweight watercraft like his frequently surprised Russian warships seeking to project mastery over the Bering Sea region. Flying like arrows across open ocean, qayat were sources of Unangax̂ and Sugpiaq power and critical media for their authoritative engagements with a sea-oriented world.

This paper, focused on the Native qayaq and its aquatic material culture at the outset of Russian colonization in the Bering Sea, offers a counter-narrative of global empire in the North Pacific Ocean, in which the qayaq was not a limited local technology but a critical actor in the region's unfolding conflicts. Introducing the term "watercraft" to theorize the qayaq's dual material and cosmographic dimensions, the paper analyzes the qayaq's historical role in intra-Indigenous networks, its mobilization for worldmaking, and its appropriation by colonial actors in attempts to dispossess people of their homelands. Taking the qayaq as an analytic, the paper proposes, can expose the contested nature of the Bering Sea's terraqueous geographies. Watercraft designs, with their insurgent materialities and living connections to ocean ecologies, from the circulation of Arctic driftwood to the migrations of sea mammals, illuminate an inhabited and territorial ocean that contradicted later Russian imperial claims to an empty and universal sea.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Erasure in the Urban Imaginary: From Mutual Aid to Master Plans

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Abstract

The end of World War II marked a global turning point that prompted significant adjustments in statecraft logics, the emergence of US technical assistance programs and international organizations conferences opened the terrain to the circulation of ideas on how housing problems could be addressed following the Western knowledge and solutions (Brizuela, 2022; Escobar, 1995). Thus, Puerto Rico became a U.S. showcase through a wide-array of Technical Assistance Programs and professional organizations, which gave a sense of legitimacy and reassurance to Colonial State agents and their development/planning strategies (Encarnacion Burgos, 2022). A perfect illustration of these international exchanges can be traced in the *International Exhibition on Low-Cost Housing* in New Delhi, India, in 1954. Aided self-help housing as part of Community Development in Puerto Rico presented two opposing governmental approaches to housing: the community-driven Mutual Aid and Self-Help program, and the technocratic urban planning embodied in public housing and urban renewal projects. Since 1945, the Mutual Aid program has empowered rural communities to collaboratively build their homes with technical and material support from the government. The participants gained construction skills, materials, and accessible payment plans. This approach fostered a sense of ownership, solidarity, and self-sufficiency as part of the government's vision of progress. Yet, this narrative stood in sharp contrast to the state's vision of urban modernization, which promoted the displacement of thousands of urban dwellers from self-built barrios or 'slums' in state vernacular. These contrasting models reflected a deeper tension between community autonomy and centralized state control in the production of housing. This paper aims to deconstruct the image of progress projected during this historical period through archival materials and interviews. Thus, reveals the inherent inequalities and silencing of community voices within the government's developmental agenda, while also questioning the persistence of these contradictions in contemporary urban planning.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Theorizing Space from the Caribbean

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Abstract

We have not given the Caribbean the importance and centrality that it holds in our history. Despite being the knot that tied the Americas, playing a role very much like the Mediterranean in European civilization, the Caribbean has been quite invisible, especially in architectural history. Ancient cultures flourished on its shores, its waters being the site of war conflicts between colonial empires. Before the fifteenth century, those shores supported the Olmecs, Totonacs, Huaxtecs, Mayas, Siboneyes, and Tainos. After the European invasion, the Caribbean became the site of both modernization and coloniality, as defined by Quijano (1992), Escobar (1995), and Mignolo (1998).The buildings and landscapes of the Caribbean continue to represent a summary of the American experience and need to be discussed as the core of our identity, not at all as a periphery or an exception.

However, the theories and concepts that we have used so far to discuss the built environment of the Caribbean do not come from or relate to those lands. In this short essay, I propose to elaborate on five Caribbean authors whose concepts of space can illuminate our understanding of those places: Aime Cesaire (1913-2008); Frantz Fanon (1925-1961); Edouard Glissant (1928-2011); Sylvia Wynter (b. 1928) and Marise Condé (1934-2024). Together, those authors expand the knowledge base of our discipline as a whole. The old, unspoken definition of architecture as buildings designed by famous architects does not hold water anymore. A few decades of gender, race, and ethnic decolonization have made evident how self-referential this old idea of architecture is. The urgency of decolonizing architecture goes beyond challenging the Eurocentric narrative or fighting for more diversity in the ranks of the profession. It entails designing a whole new set of concepts that will foster the best in all of us.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Marcus Rainsford's Passage to the lan guiné

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Abstract

In 1798 the British colonial officer Marcus Rainsford was shipwrecked en route from his outpost in British Occupied Mole St. Nicholas, in the northern peninsula of Saint-Domingue, and forced ashore at Cap Français – the center of the Haitian Revolution. There he claims to have visited a "Temple of Emancipation," a neoclassical septostyle tholos, in honor of the French colonial governors Sonthonax and Polverel. This paper examines a rendering by Rainsford of this temple printed in his *Historical account of the black empire of Hayti,* the 1805 memoir of his travels through Revolutionary Saint-Domingue during the period that Toussaint L'Ouverture acted as colonial governor of an effectively independent revolutionary body. This temple, I argue, exists in two worlds. Rendered in picturesque space, it recalls the enclosed landscapes of the colonial bourgeoisie. Within revolutionary Haiti, it is an allegory of the revolution unpacking questions of race, personhood, and sovereignty in a decolonizing context. Rainsford offered varying descriptions and renderings of this Temple over three distinct published accounts of his travels. Through these he built upon a literature of "Caribbean Critique," weaving his own biography into a discourse of decolonization. I trace these changing depictions in relation to his gradual disenchantment with the colonial endeavor and his growing enthusiasm for an alliance with the revolutionary project. Across these texts and images, I argue, Rainsford complicates the political and representational spheres of the neoclassical within coloniality and revolution.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Ruins of Return: Unsettling the Dominican National Project

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Abstract

This paper situates the nineteenth-century Mayorazgo de Koka plantation, located in present-day Cabarete, Dominican Republic, as a site of architectural and historical counternarrative. Founded in the 1830s by the mixed-race descendants of Spanish Florida planter Zephaniah Kingsley and his Wolof wives under Haitian President Jean-Pierre Boyer's Black reconstruction project, Mayorazgo de Koka predates U.S. imperial incursions in the region. Its ruins, largely absent from canonical architectural histories, challenge dominant narratives that position U.S. influence in the Caribbean as beginning with the Banana Wars at the turn of the twentieth century.

What emerges when this history is read contrapuntally—through ancestral knowledge, oral histories, and plantation ruins—is a series of ruptures in the archive that reveal claims to Black citizenship as negotiations and resistances, along with alternative imaginaries of Black geographies and architectures. The ruins of Mayorazgo de Koka, expropriated and effaced from the Dominican national narrative to make room for tourism development, index not only erased spatial histories but also the banishment of Kingsley descendants throughout the twentieth century, especially during Trujillo's regime.

I propose a critical methodology that centers oral history, speculative cartography, and digital humanities to interrogate the institutional frameworks—such as architectural syllabi and preservation standards—that have marginalized these histories. Drawing on extensions Lara's spatial theories for the Americas, I position Mayorazgo de Koka as part of an expansive archipelago of poetic relations that defy singularity and containment within the bounds of borders, race, and class.

By activating the built environment as an archive, this work insists on reading the Caribbean not as an ahistorical backdrop to colonial extraction disguised as leisure, but as a geography of contested domesticities, radical Black homemaking, and spatial memory—revealing the unfinished work of emancipation and where question of space and modernity might begin again.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Construction Sights: The Unsettled Imagery of Machado's Cuba

Andrew Scheinman

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Abstract

In 1929, several thousand builders of Havana's new Capitolio were staged on its steps for a propagandistic photograph marking the second inauguration of Cuban president Gerardo Machado. Grouped by trade and backdropped by a banner crediting the New York–based construction firm Purdy and Henderson, the pictured workers were posed to populate a transnational building project, standing in as allegory for both the Cuban body politic and the worker modernized under American aegis. Where the Capitolio was designed as a hybrid of the US Capitol, the Panthéon in Paris, and St. Peter's Basilica in Rome and conceived to house the Sixth International Pan-American Conference, the builders in the photograph begin to gesture away from this geopolitical genealogy. Climbing scaffolds and drifting out of frame, they disrupt the ordering logic of the camera, instead embodying a plural and incomplete modernity—one at odds with the architectural projection of republican principles that Joseph Hartman calls Machado's "dictator's dreamscape." This paper draws on the construction photographs circulated by the Ministry of Public Works, alongside building records and planning documents, to reframe the transnational construction site during the machadato as a space of negotiation within the architectural and imperial entanglements of the Caribbean. Rather than treat these images as passive documents, I follow Tina Campt in reading them as acts of visual enunciation—assertions of presence within, and sometimes against, the symbolic frameworks that conscripted them. These images, I argue, render visible a counter-archive of labor, one in which Cuban workers appear not as instruments of imperial design but as agents of an unsettled, fractured, and embodied modernity. Through these photographs, the construction site becomes a vantage for writing architectural history from and with the Caribbean—where the cleanliness of imperial ambition and the messiness of social relations are held, uneasily, together in view.

PS48 Counter-narratives: Architectural Histories from/with the Caribbean

Session Chair: Yazmín M. Crespo-Claudio, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, USA

Building an Ocean Fairyland: International Modernism in Noir

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Abstract

This paper positions the 1949-1950 *Bicentennial Exposition in Port-au-Prince* as a critical site for architectural history. It argues that the exposition in Port-au-Prince functioned as both a showcase and a battleground for competing visions of Haitian modernity, noiriste sovereignty, and postwar identity amidst the persistent racialized gaze of Western imperialism. By examining the fair's architectural strategies, associated hotel construction, and the racial politics of Haiti's tourism industry, the paper reveals how these elements simultaneously projected self-determination while exposing Haiti's material dependence through political ideology, economic structures, and cultural representation.

The paper employs contrapuntal readings of architectural documents and visual records to expose contrasts between official narratives of the exposition, underlying labor and urban conditions, as well as ideological clashes between *noirisme* and Western technical and economic dependence. The analysis reveals how the fair's use of concrete, while symbolizing modernity and technological progress, simultaneously recast historical legacies and spatial logics of the U.S. Occupation. It further highlights how Haitian officials and media presented nuanced narratives of national authorship, rooted in the collective effort of intellectual and manual workers, directly countering foreign critiques that discounted the contributions of Haitian figures and Black self-fashioning through appeals to myth and magic. Scaffolding off the state-sponsored cultural spectacle of "folkloricization," these appeals to myth and magic simultaneously sought to reclaim national heritage even as they were transformed into tropicalized "local color" for foreign consumption.

By analyzing these visual and spatial contradictions, the paper offers methodological insights into how colonial visual regimes persisted in postcolonial nation-building projects across the Caribbean. Ultimately, this research provides a politically engaged reading of Haitian architecture in the twentieth century, an analysis of material and symbolic sovereignty under imperial constraint, and a historiographic intervention that positions Haiti as a dense site where racial logics or postwar intervention were refined.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

Forks in the Road: Black Women and Food Activism in the Favelas of Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

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Abstract

Since the 2010s, Black women in the favelas of Rio de Janeiro have turned to food as the focus of urban activism. They reclaim, resignify, and elevate ingredients and preparations that white elites had negatively associated with low-income, Black, and indigenous peoples.

These activists include scholars, policy makers, research groups, and social-media influencers, who work collaboratively and individually. Taken as a whole, they have produced an output of scholarly research, policy documents, educational materials aimed at their communities, and online videos posted on social media that all send the same message: traditional foodstuffs are healthier than ultraprocessed products; they can be affordable and accessible; and they are more environmentally sustainable than food industries and corporate grocery stores. In addition, these women also recast the identity of these foods as a proud record of their ancestries: indigenous Brazilian nations, enslaved African peoples, and poor Northeastern Brazilian migrants of mixed race.

I look at their food activism in two ways: first, as a synecdochical history that is part of and stands for the whole history of favelas, migrations, and Black and indigenous spaces in Brazil. Second, I analyze their activism as a fulcrum of urban action, which uses food to address socio-economic and spatial injustice. By historicizing the spatially based food activism of contemporary Black women, I give their collective efforts narrative shape while also illuminating the broader history of Brazilian inequities. I argue that these women not only elevate their traditional, racialized, indigenous and Black foods, but they also elevate the spaces of the favelas—from their individual shacks to the alleyways to the favelas as a whole.

I analyze their work by referring to theories of racial capitalism, informal urbanism, and the afterlife of European colonial extractivism and slavery, which continue to grip Brazilian society long after independence and abolition.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

From Refugees to Refugee-Farmers: Potato Cultivation and the Making of Ottoman Muhâcir Subjecthood (1875–1920)

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Abstract

In the late Ottoman period, mass displacement following the Balkan Wars (1912–13), combined with the ongoing movement of roughly two million refugees from the Caucasian Wars (1817–64) and the Ottoman–Russian War (1877–78), created a large population of Muslim refugees—termed muhâcirs in Ottoman legal terminology. Resettling muhâcirs was central to sovereignty and population control, emphasizing their self-sufficiency through food production. Beginning in the 1860s already, Ottoman officials aimed to transform refugees into self-sufficient "refugee-farmers" as part of their broader project of agrarian industrialization. Agricultural school directors such as Ethem Bey and Ferid Bey demanded empire-wide land surveys and promoted model village plans for muhacirs. That same year, the Refugee Commission issued the Refugee Regulation, and in 1919 the Empire's first standardized refugee village layout appeared.

I argue that rather than being a purely politico-legal category, the subjecthood of muhâcirs was constructed through their settlement and involvement in agrarian production. One of the central qualifications for being a muhâcir was "productivity," a criterion embodied not only by the individual muhâcir but also by the land they cultivated and made to yield agricultural produce, such as potatoes. Indeed, already in 1875, journalist Basiretçi Ali Efendi wrote in Basiret journal about the struggles of Muslim communities under Russian rule and advocated potato cultivation in central Anatolia as an alternative to bread, aiming to solve food shortages after the 1873–75 famine.

Muhâcirs and the lands they cultivated, both rendered productive, were conceived as an integrated whole under the legal framework of the Refugee Commission. Focusing on potato farming in the Ottoman Imperial Farms in central Anatolia between 1875-1920, I explore how the muhâcir labor, the refugee villages, and restrictive land-tenure policies not only produced the "refugee-farmer" subject but also forged an industrial-scale agrarian laborer and an engineered agricultural landscape.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

Labor, Space, and Discipline After Slavery: Two Brazilian Worker Colonies, c. 1850–1900

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Abstract

As slavery declined in late nineteenth-century Brazil, coffee plantation owners turned to immigrant labor through systems such as partnership contracts and colonato arrangements. These new contractual forms gave rise to a distinct architectural form: the worker colony. Designed to house migrant laborers, these settlements, consisting of rows of identical family dwellings and farming allotments, functioned not only as housing, but as tools of recruitment, assimilation, and the biopolitical management of laborers within the coffee economy. This paper examines the architectural and social formation of these colonies through two influential coffee plantations: Ibicaba, an early adopter of the partnership system that became a site of revolt, and Santa Gertrudes, celebrated as a "model" plantation at the turn of the twentieth century.

Through a close reading of site plans, labor contracts, travelers' accounts, and colonist testimonies, the paper explores how the built environment mediated the transition from coerced to waged labor, while also serving as a disciplinary infrastructure for migrant workers tasked with fueling Brazil's growing role in the global coffee market. In 1850s Ibicaba, where enslaved and "partner" labor co-existed, the placement and architecture of the colony emphasized the distinction between the two kinds of workers, while contracts, surveillance, and economic measures restricted colonos' mobility. In Santa Gertrudes forty years later, the fazenda was no longer a closed system, and infrastructure serving its multiple colonies sought to manage and retain a larger, and more autonomous, population of workers. This paper considers how colonies incorporated racialized beliefs about workers' aptitudes and emerging labor management practices. Finally, the situates these worker colonies within a broader constellation of agricultural institutions, including penal colonies and agricultural schools, where food production, labor, and discipline were enmeshed. By interrogating these spaces, the paper contributes to an architectural history of migrant lifeworlds and post-slavery landscapes in the Americas.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

Exhibiting Plenitude: Zionist Agricultural Displays, 1924-1939

Iddo Ginat

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Abstract

Between the World Wars, Zionist institutions strategically participated in major international exhibitions, establishing pavilions to represent Jewish settlements in British Mandate Palestine (‘the Yishuv’) despite lacking sovereign status. This participation formed a crucial component of Zionist nation-building efforts, utilizing exhibition spaces to construct and disseminate territorial legitimacy claims.

Central to these representational strategies was the displaying of the Yishuv's agricultural achievements highlighting mechanization, scientific planning, and large-scale cultivation of oranges and non-native fruits that appealed to European markets, such as pears and plums. These displays portrayed Jewish migration as a source of territorial transformation while strategically sidelining indigenous Palestinian agriculture, suggesting a causal relationship that inserted the Yishuv into the teleology of civilizational modernization.

This paper examines constructed narratives of Zionist agricultural transformation at four venues: the British Empire Exhibition (London, 1924), Colonial Exhibition (Paris, 1931), Paris International Exposition (1937), and New York World's Fair (1939).

Through analysis of exhibition media - including produce and food samples, photographs, maps, and statistical diagrams - the paper demonstrates how agricultural representations advanced three interconnected political arguments for different audiences. First, they illustrated productivity to British authorities to secure immigration permits, which Britain linked to land absorption capacity. Second, displays served as promotional tools to encourage continued Jewish migration and attract investment from wealthy diaspora communities. Third, they legitimized the Zionist project in key political locales by adopting colonial exhibition tropes, such as the "civilizing mission," drawing parallels between Jewish settlement and European imperial activities while claiming modernization benefited indigenous Palestinians, even as they were marginalized.

This analysis contributes to understanding how representations of agricultural development and food products functioned as rhetorical tools of settlement legitimacy in contested territories between the World Wars, facilitating the transformation of a Jewish migrant culture into a settler society in Palestine.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

Transient Extractions: Negotiated Ecologies of Salt Production in Colonial India

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Abstract

This paper traces the movement of labour between the salt marsh of the Little Rann of Kutch and Kharaghoda and Odu, two peripheral villages developed by the British colonial government in the early 1870s, to present the history of this landscape at the threshold of colonial extraction and ecological mediation. Annually, from around October to May, salt extraction would transform the arid ecological system through the building of salt pans, adjacent houses, and transport infrastructure. Then, the environmental system obliterated all traces of this work as the monsoon rain and tides flooded the low-lying land. The process itself necessitated an annual migration. We closely examine the strategies that enabled this cyclical occupation of the desert to be maintained year after year, decade after decade. Our research looks for evidence of the disassembly — of temporary desert housing, control posts, and retractable railway infrastructure along with ingenious systems of storage and transportation. Conversely, we will examine the permanent villages which developed at the edge of the desert, especially Kharaghoda. It developed infrastructure and systems to entice migrant populations including salt workers, colonial bureaucrats, and railway workers to remain during the lull in salt production rather than move to other locations. With substantial colonial infrastructure at the brink of abandonment and ruin, especially after the 2001 Kutch Earthquake, there has been a rise in new systems of salt extraction. Industrialization and new systems of transportation have reduced the need for workers and all but eliminated the practice of cyclical migration far into the desert each year. Gandhi's Salt Satyagraha walk politicized salt as a pivot of India's Independence movement, but the walk towards salt has a longer history of movement with architecture being central to its extraction, storage, and transportation, transforming and being transformed at the edge of constructed extractive zones.

PS49 Food Spaces of Migrant and Refugee Worlds

Session Co-Chairs: Fatina Abreek-Zubiedat, Tel Aviv University, Israel, and Ateya Khorakiwala, Columbia University, USA

Colonized Bodies: Humans, Cows, and the Architectures of Food in the Rio de la Plata

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Abstract

At the end of the 19th and beginning of the 20th century, the lower part of the Rio de la Plata basin that traversed the fertile territories of Argentina, Uruguay and Brazil became one of the largest producers of meat in the world. During this period, architecture and biopolitics conspired to produce global capital through meat. In an unprecedented scheme, meat preservation plants were constructed along the river to enhance the productivity of black bodies in the plantation economy; a new border was built to separate the lucrative territories of cattle-raising from the indigenous population inhabiting the region; a military campaign was launched to exterminate them when the new border proved insufficient; and "undesirable" immigrants were expelled to the countryside as labor for the meat industry, while simultaneously a new, industrious white European population was welcomed in the cities. This extractive territorial reorganization destabilized rural-urban metabolic relationships of food, energy, water, and human productivity, reconfiguring them into a modern capitalistic outpost in South America. Tracking the convergence of two usually separated movements, hygienics and eugenics, this paper examines how the meat industry created a scientifically-supported arena for the biopolitical appropriation of human and non-human resources, fueled by forced migration, expulsion, and displacement. It moves beyond the dichotomy of urban and rural spaces at the center of modernity to unveil the rearrangement of laboring bodies towards the instrumentalization of the built environment in metabolic circuitries and the production of capital.

PS50 Small Objects, Spaces, and Practices of Care

Session Co-Chairs: Dijana O. Apostolski, Carleton University, Canada, and Zoë Cope, McGill University, Canada

Matter of Thresholds: The Door to the First X-Ray Laboratory (1895-1896)

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Abstract

This paper focuses on the wooden door to Wilhelm Conrad Röntgen's laboratory, where the "incidental" discovery of x-rays invoked, in the words of Thomas Kuhn, a "paradigm shift." By placing an x-ray discharge tube on one side of the wooden door and a photographic plate on the other, Röntgen produced one of his earliest shadow pictures, dated November 1895. In a gradient of shadows, his x-ray photograph made visible the passage of rays through architectural space, thus disrupting the laboratory as an enclosed, bounded room. In other words, with this image, the door — typically conceived as an opaque medium that operates spatial limits — suddenly became visibly permeable. Unlike several other objects that Röntgen irradiated, the door, I argue, was an ordinary yet evocative object that, once shed with "new" light (i.e., x-rays) turned into a site of wonder, stirring scientific imagination. By revealing the wooden door as porous and permeable to environmental influences, rather than an impenetrable partition, the x-ray photograph prompted Röntgen to reimagine space as a function of *materiality.* As I will show, by January 1896, Röntgen drew from his x-ray experiments to devise a new kind of enclosure, a portable darkroom made of zinc. The dark room exemplified a space that was first and foremost determined by the permeability of matter to radiation. Considering doors as liminal objects "betwixt and between" inside and outside, I will discuss the symbolic significance of doors in everyday material culture, the scientific techniques of visualization used to produce the shadow picture of the door in Röntgen's laboratory, and the conceptual implications of rendering its familiarity as foreign. Ultimately, I will demonstrate how the newfound properties in the material structure of this particular door led to rethinking enclosures from a scientific standpoint.

PS50 Small Objects, Spaces, and Practices of Care

Session Co-Chairs: Dijana O. Apostolski, Carleton University, Canada, and Zoë Cope, McGill University, Canada

Getting it off Your Chest: Women Reclaiming Spaces through Objects in Ottoman Istanbul

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Abstract

Chests, purses, pouches, sacks, and boxes are objects frequently found in the list of Ottoman women's inheritances and possessions from the early modern period. Their monetary value changed according to material features, ranging from those made of silk and carved and inlaid walnut to those made of cotton and plain wood. The furnishings and accessories in inventories showed the owner's status and affluence within the society. Additionally, we can understand their functional role in daily life as containers and preservers of mundane and precious items. These qualities can be deduced more easily from the court records. However, the written sources are silent about their significance for women's emotional worlds. When it wasn't common for women to have their own rooms, these containers not only preserved things, but also kept emotions: from a piece of soil from pilgrimage to a piece of fabric with blessings, and to a piece of paper with words from a lover, they could become their owner's safe spaces. Thus, when women couldn't speak up, they expressed their feelings and memories by putting things in these containers and opening and unfolding them to evoke emotions. Placed in a closet or hidden within mattresses and textiles, they were folded, locked, closed, and opened, sometimes in layers, through rituals that mediated many intimate moments, sometimes with companions. They could be portable or built in, mobilized by women's movements, or passed on to the next house inhabitant. This paper will explore the agency and historical role of daily objects such as furnishings and accessories in Ottoman women's lives as containers of emotions, creating safe spaces in and around them.

PS50 Small Objects, Spaces, and Practices of Care

Session Co-Chairs: Dijana O. Apostolski, Carleton University, Canada, and Zoë Cope, McGill University, Canada

Provisional Permissions: The Cane, the Corset, and Crip Reconfigurations of Space

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Abstract

The cane and the orthopedic corset are approached as minor architectures of care and resistance that shape how bodies move through and inhabit space. They emerge as critical sites where power, care, embodiment, and knowledge intersect, while also revealing how many environments remain structured around normative assumptions of mobility. Central to this argument is the notion of "provisional permissions," understood as negotiated forms of access that emerge through encounters between bodies, objects, and infrastructures, and that remain contingent rather than guaranteed.

Focusing on Carmen Papalia's non-visual navigation practices—particularly *Blind Field Shuttle* and *Mobility Device*—this paper explores how the cane functions as a relational tool that reorganizes space through trust and interdependence. A related configuration emerges in Frida Kahlo's painted orthopedic corsets, understood as material forms of embodied experience in which medical devices become artistic tools. Departing from institutional models of "universal design," their work foreground what disability theorists describe as "crip time" and "crip spacing": lived temporalities and spatialities that subvert formal norms and resist abstraction.

Reading the cane and the corset as small objects that transform their social and sensory surroundings, this paper draws on disability studies, feminist material culture, and affect theory to frame assistive devices as sites of relational negotiation. This perspective extends to a broader field of adaptive tools and informal infrastructures—tactile, embodied, and provisional—that reframe space through lived experience. In dialogue with Jesse Darling's sculptural practice, which exposes the precarity and contingency of bodies and built environments alike, the paper considers how assistive objects function as forms of spatial critique—at once intimate and infrastructural.

By attending to the affordances and frictions of these objects, the paper contributes to the session's inquiry into the cultural agency of marginal objects and examines how practices of care emerge through small, often invisible gestures that quietly hold and remake space.

PS50 Small Objects, Spaces, and Practices of Care

Session Co-Chairs: Dijana O. Apostolski, Carleton University, Canada, and Zoë Cope, McGill University, Canada

Spatial Agency of Domestic Objects: Informal Practices and Collective Living in a Shanghai Courtyard House

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Abstract

While domestic objects are often overlooked in architectural discourse, this study demonstrates their spatial agency and transformative potential through an investigation of informal practices in everyday urban life. These small and seemingly trivial objects bring forward values often marginalized in architectural studies—such as fragmentation, temporality, materiality, memory, trace, and symbolism.

The research focuses on a traditional courtyard house in central Shanghai, built in the late Qing dynasty and continuously inhabited through waves of socio-political transformation. Since the 1950s, such dwellings have been subdivided into multi-household units; in this case, eight families now occupy individual rooms of 12–15 square meters, while the courtyard has become a shared site for cooking, washing, storage, and planting.

To meet basic needs in limited space, residents appropriate and adapt their environments using accessible materials and everyday objects. Through acts of selecting, arranging, and appropriating, these objects enable residents to transgress and reconfigure the house's original spatial logic—generating new functions and atmospheres. In parallel, residents negotiate new social relations—among individuals, families, and neighbours—through the curation of objects. In this process, fragmented and improvised spaces are transformed into homes, fostering a culture of collective domesticity.

This study employs both hand-drawn and digital drawings to examine how domestic objects operate as spatial agents. Oil pastel drawings capture the affective and atmospheric dimensions of domestic life, while axonometric projections adopt architectural conventions to represent inhabitation—repositioning these everyday practices as legitimate forms of spatial design.

Ultimately, the study proposes that homemaking can be understood as a curatorial practice: a continuous process of selecting, negotiating, creating, and displaying objects that articulate identity and relational belonging. In doing so, domestic objects emerge not only as extensions of the self but also as active mediators within a lived network of spatial and social relations.

PS50 Small Objects, Spaces, and Practices of Care

Session Co-Chairs: Dijana O. Apostolski, Carleton University, Canada, and Zoë Cope, McGill University, Canada

Skill Sets, Settlement and the Materials of Inuit Labour

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Abstract

This paper seeks to explore how colonial settlement in the Canadian Arctic in the 1970s relied on practices of architectural mechanization and rapid assembly that were premised on the availability of unskilled Inuit labourers. The designs of assimilationist school projects by the Montreal-based architectural firm Papineau, Gérin-Lajoie, Leblanc, Edwards were premised not on the absence of these labourers but on their perpetual marginalization and deskilling. One of the most darkly iconic of these schools, Nakasuk Elementary School, that still occupies the centre of the city of Iqaluit, is notable for its reliance on composite materials, particularly pre-fabricated panels made of glass-fibre reinforced polyester resin that had to respond to the technical and environmental parameters that came with building in the Arctic—with low temperatures, the absence of diurnal time, and high wind speeds shaping the final form of the building. Given the constraints of a short, ice-free shipping season, and the high cost of moving construction materials and personnel to the North, the firm had devised a method of assembly that not only minimized but precisely prescribed the skills needed to attach the panels to the steel assembly system. This paper's ambition is not only to understand what 'skill sets' Inuit were forced to perform, it is to situate how Inuit labourers, often paired in teams of two, usually totally not more than six or eight individuals working on each project, were integrated into this logistically defined architecture. Their experiences of this system of assembly would in part lead to their own advocacy efforts for the creation of vocational college programs for Inuit in the territory of Nunavut—a formalization of their capacity to build 'without' skills.

PS51 Mapping New Epistemologies of Collecting and Archiving

Session Co-Chairs: Christina Pech, University of Oslo, Norway, and Gabriel Hernández de León, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid, Spain

SITIOS, A Map of Puerto Rico's Modernization: Finding Henry Klumb

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Abstract

SITIOS is a pilot project of archival research aimed at georeferencing architectural projects whose plans are held by the collections of the *University of Puerto Rico's Architecture and Construction Archive* (AACUPR). The project's final product is an online interactive map that utilizes *Geographic Information System* (GIS) technology, allowing users worldwide to explore the collection spatially and intuitively, thus significantly enhancing the visibility and accessibility of the documentary archive and our architectural heritage.

The pilot phase focuses on the *Henry Klumb Collection*, the most consulted in the Archive. Henry Klumb (1905–1981), a disciple of Frank Lloyd Wright, became a leading figure of Caribbean modernism, whose work was emblematic of the island's development process and greatly influenced generations of Puerto Rican architects. This highly consulted collection, comprising architectural drawings, written documents, photographs, models, and other items, encompasses the documentation of 527 projects designed by Klumb throughout his career, totaling 368.78 cubic feet of materials.

A significant challenge of this research has been georeferencing these projects, as many records lack location plans. Georeferencing them required a thorough forensic examination of other documentary resources in search of clues. We delved into letters, newspapers, property records, construction permits, and both current and historical satellite photos. More than a hundred field visits were conducted to gather as much information as possible on each project, finally managing to geolocate 468 of his proposals.

With the eventual inclusion of other collections from the Archive in the map, our long-term goal is for SITIOS to become a cornerstone platform for studying Puerto Rico's recent architectural heritage, thereby strengthening the community's connection to its built history. The research aims to reintegrate the stories of many of these forgotten structures into Puerto Rico's architectural narrative while also telling the story of the landscape of modernization through archived architectural projects.

PS51 Mapping New Epistemologies of Collecting and Archiving

Session Co-Chairs: Christina Pech, University of Oslo, Norway, and Gabriel Hernández de León, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid, Spain

Towards a Networked Archive: The VAi's Archival Practices and Discourses

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Abstract

In 2012, the Netherlands Architecture Institute (NAi) published *Keuzes Maken* (Making Choices), a new collection policy that proposed a radical departure from its previous archival models. While it introduced an innovative thematic structure to support the NAi's ambition for a comprehensive archive, it also—albeit somewhat overlooked—gestured toward a radical new idea: the architectural archive as a decentralized organism, adaptive and distributed.

Although never truly implemented in the Netherlands, this conceptual shift found fertile ground in Belgium, as the Flanders Architecture Institute (VAi) gradually implemented an archival paradigm bringing those ambitions to life. Through its research center and partnerships with local institutions, municipalities, private archives, and—controversially—architectural offices, the VAi continues to develop a federated model of archival stewardship for architecture. Serving as both a central node and a facilitator of shared capacity, the VAi has enabled the emergence of a distributed structure that expands what can be collected and, most importantly, by whom, effectively reshaping the very possibilities of architectural memory.

Therefore, the most significant epistemic shift in architectural history today lies in this reconfiguration of how we collect, structure, and access archives. Rather than relying on additive strategies that simply widen the canon, emerging practices—from federated digital infrastructures and open linked data to grassroots and post-custodial approaches—offer the possibility for more plural and dynamic archival models.

By focusing on the VAi's evolving practices (and discourses), it becomes clear how once-marginal archival approaches are moving from the fringes to the center, transforming experimental ideas into structural change. Furthermore, it also reveals how recasting the archive not only challenges the dominance of author-centric models but also revises how architectural histories are produced. Ultimately, it makes explicit how collecting and archiving are critical practices, as histories are no longer to be inherited but, instead, co-constructed.

PS51 Mapping New Epistemologies of Collecting and Archiving

Session Co-Chairs: Christina Pech, University of Oslo, Norway, and Gabriel Hernández de León, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid, Spain

Rewriting the Archive: Digital Experiences in Ibero-America

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Abstract

The rise of digital platforms has significantly reshaped how architectural archives are collected, structured, and shared. This paper examines recent digital initiatives in the Ibero-American sphere as case studies for understanding how contemporary archival practices are producing new epistemologies— new ways of organising knowledge, narrating history, and defining what is worth preserving in architecture.

Among the examples considered is "*ArchiteXt Mining*", a project that provides tools for analysing modern Spanish architectural journals while also building a repository that links to existing digitised issues (*https://architextmining.es*). Rather than simply increasing accessibility, this initiative highlights how digital archives can challenge dominant historiographies by assembling dispersed or marginalised materials and fostering new modes of critical engagement.

Other ongoing projects, such as those focused on documenting underrepresented architects in Latin America, likewise aim to reframe visibility and authorship in the field. These efforts contribute to a broader rethinking of architectural archives—not as static collections, but as dynamic, situated infrastructures shaped by curatorial choices and institutional priorities. One example refers to the professional profiles of archival collections made available online by the Research and Documentation Centre of the Faculty of Architecture and Urbanism at the Federal University of Rio de Janeiro (https://npd.fau.ufrj.br/index.php).

This paper argues that architectural archiving today is not solely a matter of preservation. It is a form of critical practice that reflects shifting values, redefines disciplinary boundaries, and opens the field to new interpretations. While these digital platforms often present themselves as open and universal, they are embedded in specific cultural and historical contexts that require critical examination. By analysing these and other emerging cases, this study proposes a conceptual framework for understanding digital architectural archiving in Ibero-America as a process of rewriting the archive, reshaping what is remembered, as well as how architecture is written, read, and circulated.

PS51 Mapping New Epistemologies of Collecting and Archiving

Session Co-Chairs: Christina Pech, University of Oslo, Norway, and Gabriel Hernández de León, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid, Spain

Archiving Moroccan Modernism: Challenges, Strategies, Applications

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Abstract

Research on architectural modernism in Morocco often reproduces systems of colonial control in which foreign scholars briefly consult archives before returning home to write histories of the built environment from afar. However, thanks to recent initiatives, this situation is changing. Moving beyond scattered, incomplete, and inaccessible records, efforts are being made to simultaneously consolidate and expand archives documenting modern architecture in Morocco. These developments are not only important for rectifying written histories but bear real effects upon the study of architecture, building, and preservation efforts within the country. Moreover, it is both urgent and necessary to preserve this period of architectural experimentation which not only threatens to disappear from the historical record but from the physical landscape, as well.

This presentation explores the work of the Association pour la Memoire des Architectes Modernes Marocains (MAMMA) to create a new archive of Moroccan modern architecture. While select figures of the architectural vanguard are represented in archival collections abroad, no centralized archive exists attesting to and securing the history of modern architecture in Morocco. Instead, MAMMA is building an archive outside the bounds of traditional institutions, involving novel and unconventional tactics for amassing and uniting information composed of public and private records yielding an alternative archive no longer tied to a physical location but rather a digital resource open to all.

Documenting an understudied geography of architectural modernism and underappreciated era in the history of Morocco, this archive tells the history of post-independence building enacted by the first generation of Moroccan architects. Given the government's lack of care for this rich period, foreign control of colonial era records, and scholarly oversight of Morocco's pivotal role in the development of architectural modernism, this new archive holds potential to shape the past, present, and future of both history and building in Morocco.

PS51 Mapping New Epistemologies of Collecting and Archiving

Session Co-Chairs: Christina Pech, University of Oslo, Norway, and Gabriel Hernández de León, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid, Spain

The "Born-Digital" Archive as William J. Mitchell's "Definitive Record"

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Abstract

In 1996, William J. Mitchell, a pre-eminent figure in architectural computing, outlined the archival challenges facing a "digital era." The work of architects, he argued, had transformed radically over the late century, marginalizing paper documents as "throwaway byproducts" of architecture's "definitive record:" the three-dimensional, digital model. He charged archivists with perserving this model's "file," a necessarily volatile artifact that would have to be stabilized and insulated against the ephemerality of software and hardware. In the 30 years since, numerous institutional collections have taken up this challenge, gathering and making accessible vast archives of architecture's "born-digital" artifacts.

But while complex issues concerning obsolescence and preservation have been deftly confronted in these efforts, the historiographic assumptions that characterize such collecting practices have received less attention. By delimiting the boundaries of the archive, the framework of "the digital" channels historical narratives that prefigure interpretation. It posits a distinct break between paper-based and computational practices, suggests a seamless relation between architects and the technologies they mobilize, and reifies the evidentiary authority of architects' graphical representations.

This paper will trouble the digital archive by engaging an assembled collection of Mitchell's own work from the early 1970s, the artifacts of which ardently defy such epistemological categorization. In these materials, documenting imbrications of software research and architectural design, any distance between paper-based and digital practices is collapsed: input forms feature hand-written data sets, decks of punch cards serve as the error-prone medium of computation, and reams of computer code take their place beside stacks of layered drawings. Looking outwards from these overt examples, the paper will draw upon recent critical scholarship on digital preservation to ask how interpretive work can recognize this mediatic instability and extend its reach through collecting practices, challenging both disciplinary histories of architecture and hegemonic narratives of computer technology.

PS52 New Architectural Histories of the British Empire

Session Co-Chairs: Hannah Kaemmer, University of Pennsylvania, USA, and Aaron White, Mississippi State University, USA

Dundas House and the Dualities of Empire in Edinburgh

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Abstract

Edinburgh's eighteenth-century New Town is at once a representation of Scotland's position within the United Kingdom, as well as a demonstration of Scotland's participation in the British Empire. Architecture and urbanism played a crucial role in solidifying the concept of Edinburgh as the capital of North Britain instead of a separate Scottish kingdom. Through the example of Sir Lawrence Dundas' understudied mansion on St. Andrew Square in the eastern New Town, this paper argues that both the internal and colonial imperial projects had an effect on domestic architecture. The self-anglicized, pro-Union Lord Dundas acquired his wealth by first supplying goods to the British Army during Jacobite rebellions and later supplemented it through his personal and political involvement with the British East India Company. His fervent participation in the business of war and empire earned Dundas the moniker, "the Nabob of the North."

Dundas, a wealthy baronet, was the ideal resident for Edinburgh's New Town, which was intended as a suburb for aristocrats and elites. Dundas solicited architectural plans from two architects, rejecting both, before seeking plans from the king's architect, William Chambers. In the original urban plan for the New Town, each square had a church. Using local political power as the MP for Edinburgh, Dundas displaced the church in St. Andrew Square in 1771 in order to construct his palatial mansion, dominating the square both visually and spatially. This paper departs from previous scholarship that contextualizes the New Town within the Scottish Enlightenment in order to explicate the role of empire in Scottish urbanism. It relies on unpublished archival documents to argue that Dundas House represents Sir Lawrence Dundas' personal imperial ambitions as part of a united Great Britain, and his support of the internal and colonial imperial projects of the British Army and the East India Company.

PS52 New Architectural Histories of the British Empire

Session Co-Chairs: Hannah Kaemmer, University of Pennsylvania, USA, and Aaron White, Mississippi State University, USA

Curation and Empire: Colonial Aesthetics and the Politics of Hybridity

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Abstract

This paper explores the fire-temple, ritualistic complexes of the Zoroastrian Parsi community in colonial India as a site of architectural hybridity and imperial negotiation. By examining the spatial and visual cultures of these temples, particularly the main halls adorned with Academic-style portraiture, the paper argues that Parsi architecture reveals a localized yet globally entangled response to British colonial authority. These spaces materialize the Parsis' aspirations for social mobility and reflect their strategic mimicry of colonial aesthetics and power structures. Situating the fire-temple within the broader networks of early British imperialism, the paper frames architecture as a medium through which colonized communities shaped and asserted modern identities. Drawing on the art historical concepts of *Kunstwollen* (the will to art) and *Kunstkammer* (the curated space of knowledge and power), the analysis considers how built environments functioned as instruments of both self-representation and ideological inscription. The fire-temple, in this light, becomes not only a devotional space but also a colonial archive curating memory, mobility, and identity in architectural form. Engaging with theories of hybridity and mimicry, this paper positions the fire-temple as a colonially inferred space deeply embedded in imperial geographies of trade, migration, and cultural exchange. In doing so, it contributes to a broader understanding of how architecture mediated local negotiations of empire in the early phases of British colonial expansion.

PS52 New Architectural Histories of the British Empire

Session Co-Chairs: Hannah Kaemmer, University of Pennsylvania, USA, and Aaron White, Mississippi State University, USA

"Protection for her Foreign Favourites (no British Race)": Glasshouses and the Popular Production of Empire

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Abstract

This paper considers a unique architectural typology—the prefabricated, iron-frame glasshouse mass-marketed to upper middle-class British consumers—and its commensurate refraction and amplification through a burgeoning print culture dedicated to the cultivation of a world's worth of exotic plants in the soil of the metropole as key technologies in evolving notions of British Empire in the years between the "loss" of significant numbers of colonies in British North America and its global territorial domination in the later nineteenth century. As material advancements in building technologies transformed domestic horticultural structures from the reserve of royalty and the uppermost echelons of the nobility into a just-within-reach status investments of an upwardly aspirational bourgeois, participation in glasshouse culture allowed for a form of popular participation and investment in the project of empire as both a collective imaginary and commercial venture. Especially for new landowners or renters in the suburbs of the home counties, the glasshouse offered a kind of empire in miniature: a carefully controlled artificial environment in which one could collect and display luxury exotics as synecdoches for real and imagined British colonies.

Grounding this new architectural history of the glasshouse—a form more conventionally associated with triumphalist narratives of structural rationalism—is a case study of the Camellia House at Wollaton Hall, Nottingham, as the oldest extant building of this type. But what interests me about the Camellia House are its unremarkable qualities—how it stands in for a constellation of similar structures attested to in period illustrated manuals and magazines. Turning attention from the extraordinary members of this architectural family (such as Joseph Paxton's later Crystal Palace) to their myriad country cousins reveals a new way of comprehending the emergence of empire as not the project of a few elite actors but rather a collective project of the many.

PS52 New Architectural Histories of the British Empire

Session Co-Chairs: Hannah Kaemmer, University of Pennsylvania, USA, and Aaron White, Mississippi State University, USA

Tombs and territory in eighteenth-century British India

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Columbia University, USA

Abstract

In eighteenth-century India, monuments to the dead were among the most visible signs of British imperial power. Before the era of major public architecture and infrastructure, the mausoleum was a mass medium, a building of almost pure exteriority with its meaning literally inscribed onto it. Some British tombs publicized an alliance with Indian society by incorporating Mughal motifs or Persian epitaphs, while others proclaimed their difference through the use of urns, obelisks, and the classical orders. Ideological differences between individual tombs notwithstanding, British cemeteries in India marked the beginning of modern burial reform, when the city of the dead moved outside of the churchyard and into a landscape garden. Historians have explained this colonial origin story in a variety of ways: the adaptation by Europeans of Islamic funerary customs; the absence of parish attachments in the colonies; and the high mortality rates of Europeans in the tropics. Alongside these diffusionist-functionalist accounts, this paper points to a link between burial reform and territorial upheaval that was underway in north India since the transfer of the *diwani* rights, or power to collect taxes, to the East India Company in 1765. Focusing on the South Park Street Cemetery established in Calcutta in 1767, I argue that tombs were small claims to land. These new forms of everlasting tenancy were echoed in the subsequent decades by the implementation of what in 1793 became the Permanent Settlement of Bengal. This paper collates evidence from popular architectural literature on sepulture such as pattern books and the contemporaneous debate over how best to take possession of Indian territory in an attempt to understand how ideas about land were embedded in the design of small, ornamental structures like tombs, and why the invention of the garden cemetery was integral to the foundation of Britain's new territorial empire.

PS52 New Architectural Histories of the British Empire

Session Co-Chairs: Hannah Kaemmer, University of Pennsylvania, USA, and Aaron White, Mississippi State University, USA

Dublin Castle: Architecture of the Viceregal Court under the Stuarts

Sarah Hutcheson

Harvard University, USA

Abstract

The viceregal court at Dublin Castle was a site of contested monarchic authority in a colonial setting. Under the Stuarts, the architecture of Dublin Castle was altered in ways that reflected the tensions inherent in royal rule by proxy. In the 1630s, a new brick lodging was built within the castle courtyard to house Sir George Radcliffe, advisor to Thomas Wentworth, Earl of Strafford (Lord Deputy 1632 – 40). Strafford's policies were harshly anti-Catholic, suppressing attempts in Irish Parliament to pass protections for Catholics, thus prompting English contemporary to claim that Strafford "gouerns like a king: and …show[s] vs an example of envye, by hauing Parlaments and knowing wisely how to vse them." The new quarters materialized political strategy: Parliament met in the Great Hall in the middle of the courtyard, with Strafford's and Radcliffe's lodgings on either side of the castle mirroring their grip on Ireland's Parliament. In 1639, as England headed toward Civil War, both Strafford and Radcliffe were impeached in England as extensions of royal prerogative in Ireland. The fraught task of asserting English political authority played out later in the century in constant remodelings and refurnishings that attempted to convey royal splendor and thereby monarchy by proxy. These were not resoundingly successful: a 1684 fire prompted the quip that the loss was merely "six barrels of powder and the worst castle in the worst situation in Christendom."

PS53 The Other Actors: Nonhuman Agency in East Asian Built Environment

Session Co-Chairs: Jingliang Du, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, and Xinhui Chen, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

The Will of Water: Rivers and Humans in Edo-Tokyo

Michelle Hauk

Washington University in St. Louis, USA

Abstract

Every summer, monsoon rains drench the city of Tokyo during *tsuyu*, the rainy season that stretches from June to mid-July. Soon after, typhoons unleash another series of downpours, often swelling the bodies of water harnessed to quench the thirst of what is still the largest metropolitan region in the world beyond the capacity of the infrastructure designed to contain it. Since its inception in the late-sixteenth century, the urban terrain of Edo—now Tokyo—has been continuously shaped by the volatility of the Kantō Region's fast-running rivers. Scholars including Eimori Kōjiro and Horikoshi Masao have recounted how the Tokugawa Shogunate redirected rivers into canals and neighborhood wells in the seventeenth century and transformed uninhabitable marshland into thriving mercantile neighborhoods. Others such as Jinnai Hidenobu have traced how the modernization of the Tokyo's water-supply system three centuries later expanded reservoirs deep into the surrounding mountainous regions and buried once-open waterways beneath roads and highways, erasing the city's riverine past. This paper asks what happens when we reconsider this aqueous history from water's perspective, reading material such as the Tokyo Waterworks Bureau's centennial history (1999) against the grain and across disciplines to reveal water's coproduction of urban space and entanglement with human life in Edo-Tokyo. It argues that the ways in which water has circumvented attempts to constrain its flow has, through its floods and droughts, continued to exert as much influence on the built environment of Edo-Tokyo as human efforts to engineer away water's risks. This paper asks us to reconsider our relationship with water as one between two agents in motion—whose actions respond to but do not depend upon entirely upon the other—rather than between subject and object, so that we can redefine the temporal, spatial, and psychological distances between the human and the nonhuman in the megalopolis.

PS53 The Other Actors: Nonhuman Agency in East Asian Built Environment

Session Co-Chairs: Jingliang Du, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, and Xinhui Chen, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Earthquakes, Termites, Darwinian Concrete: The Making of A Modern Style in Japanese Colonial Taiwan

Meng-Hsuan Lee

Columbia University, USA

Abstract

As the most common building technique used in everything from apartment blocks to national monuments, reinforced concrete defines modern Taiwanese cities. While its widespread adoption during the Japanese colonial period (1895–1945) is well documented, the material's own agency in shaping not only its practical use but also early architectural theory in Taiwan remains underexamined. Focusing on its most prominent promoter during this period, the colonial architect-technocrat Ide Kaoru (1879-1944), this paper challenges the simplistic idea that reinforced concrete was merely a suitable material chosen to construct the colony of Taiwan.

Instead, in Ide's theoretical writings he foregrounded the agency of reinforced concrete against that of nature. My paper takes the idea of agency from Annabel Jane Wharton: that an agent need not have intentions or consciousness. Rather, an agent is an entity that has effects on proximate things and cannot be fully controlled. Ide theorized that to secure Taiwan as a colony, architects needed to step back and observe a dialectical and Darwinian process of "struggle between architecture and nature." He stresses the agency of the "hostile" nature of Taiwan and credited such "formidable enemies" as termites, storms, humidity, and earthquakes in pushing architecture to evolve. It is through this process of struggle that reinforced concrete emerged as the premier construction material. As an agent, it continually improves and adapts itself against nature. Only by observing this evolutionary process can architects achieve a modern style authentic to Taiwan's "local colors." Across his oeuvre, Ide gradually evolved early historicist designs into a unique style celebrating concrete's heaviness and its protective role against nature. By recentering reinforced concrete's agency, this paper also seeks to uncover how its promotion in colonial Taiwan instigated an intra-empire economy of extraction and production from Japan proper to wartime Southeast Asia.

PS53 The Other Actors: Nonhuman Agency in East Asian Built Environment

Session Co-Chairs: Jingliang Du, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, and Xinhui Chen, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Elephants March North: Landscape Literacy and China's Territorial Spatial Planning

Jiaqi Chen

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Abstract

This paper addresses China's recently implemented nationwide Territorial Spatial Planning (TSP) system from the perspective of non-human agency. It centers on a widely publicized event between March 2020 and September 2021: a herd of 16 Asian elephants left their home in Xishuangbanna National Nature Reserve in southern China and trekked over 500 km northward to the outskirts of Kunming, the provincial capital, before being channeled back home. Rather than treating this episode as an ecological anomaly or a management challenge, this paper approaches it as a confrontation between two different modes of landscape literacy—the capacity to make landscapes intelligible and to act within them. By juxtaposing the still-fledgling TSP system and the elephants' unprecedented movement, this paper argues that they showcase two ontologically incompatible landscape literacies. Their encounter does not produce synthesis or mutual accommodation, rather, it generates breaches—moments in which the totalizing aspiration of territorial planning is exposed as structurally impossible. The elephants' movement thus becomes a vantage point from which to interrogate the politics of state landscape legibility and to imagine other ways of construing the world.

PS53 The Other Actors: Nonhuman Agency in East Asian Built Environment

Session Co-Chairs: Jingliang Du, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, and Xinhui Chen, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

Cracks in Empire: Stone Wall Trees and the Rewriting of Urban Nature in Hong Kong

Ting Wang

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Abstract

This paper explores the stone wall trees of Hong Kong—trees that have grown spontaneously on colonial-era masonry retaining walls—as active nonhuman agents shaping the city's urban and environmental history. Rather than planned green infrastructure, these trees emerged unintentionally from British colonial engineering practices in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries—specifically, the terracing of the slope, the adaptation of stone dressing techniques, and the introduction of British cement. By tracing the material and technical evolution of stone wall construction across three distinct phases, this study links the emergence of banyan and other spontaneous plant species to broader imperial networks of infrastructure and resource flows, including granite and cement, between Britain and Hong Kong.

Drawing on archival research, field mapping, and interviews, this project establishes a new archive of stone wall trees in Hong Kong'. It documents wall typologies, construction periods, associated plant species, and community reuses. Viewed through a political ecology and material history lens, this research shows how stone wall trees have redefined interstitial urban spaces, transforming overlooked infrastructure into contested heritage sites, sacred loci, and extensions of communal life.

In doing so, it argues that the spontaneous growth of these plants constitutes a form of nonhuman resistance and adaptation—challenging colonial control over nature and anthropocentric narratives of urban development and landscape design. Ultimately, the study reveals the entanglement of environmental processes with infrastructural regimes in East Asia and reconceptualizes these hybrid formations as agents reshaping urban space, identity, and heritage in the postcolonial city.

PS53 The Other Actors: Nonhuman Agency in East Asian Built Environment

Session Co-Chairs: Jingliang Du, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, and Xinhui Chen, The University of Hong Kong

Galloping Agents: Horses, Racecourses, and the Making of Early Urban Shanghai

Zijiao Li

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Abstract

This paper examines how horses shaped the urbanization of Shanghai in the early twentieth century through their presence, needs, and symbolic value. As key nonhuman agents, horses played a central role in transforming the city's built and ecological environment during the semi-colonial period. Racecourses flourished during this time, catering to both international and local residents. They symbolized a modern urban identity, generated unique architectural typologies, and stimulated new forms of civic cultural consumption built around these galloping agents.

By the 1930s, Shanghai hosted three major racecourses: the Shanghai Racecourse (in today's People's Park, Jing'an District), the International Racecourse (northeast of the center, near today's Hongkou Gymnasium), and the Far Eastern Racecourse (further northeast, near today's Changyang Road, Yangpu District). These sites defined and expanded the city's spatial boundaries, which remain largely intact today. The growing horse population necessitated extensive infrastructure, including stables, training grounds, and marketplaces. In response, the *mafang*—literally "horse house"—emerged as a multifunctional building type and proliferated across the city. Among them, Longfei Mafang, better known as the Shanghai Horse Bazaar Motor Company, located adjacent to the Shanghai Racecourse, was the most prominent. These facilities transformed horses into economic commodities, with racehorse prices reflecting elite social status. Equine architecture thus not only housed animal bodies but also catalyzed broader spatial and economic shifts.

This paper argues that horses served as vital actors in Shanghai's contested colonial urbanization, shaping architectural forms, urban design, and cultural imaginaries. It analyzes the spatial and architectural features through visual and textual primary sources, including photographs, postcards, and newspapers. Adopting actor–network theory and Donna Haraway's concept of hybridity, it interrogates the human-animal-city link and offers a new perspective on how animals shaped East Asia's built environment, highlighting horses as nonhuman mediators, evident in the international horse trade and standardized equine architecture.

PS54 The Colonial Building Industry in the Americas

Session Co-Chairs: Alexander Wood, Massachusetts College of Art and Design, USA

Knowledge-Making and the Rise of the Building Industry: The Evolution of Early Timber-Construction Education in New England and Its Role in Shaping the Timber Building Sector (17th–18th Centuries)

Jieyi Wu, Sky Ming Li, Jie Liu

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Abstract

This study takes the New England colonies in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries as its primary context and considers how these earlier systems shaped later developments into the early nineteenth century. It examines how early timber-building education helped drive the capitalization and professionalization of the colonial construction industry through three main channels: apprenticeship, itinerant master-carpenter instruction, and the circulation of early illustrated manuals. Apprenticeship converted traditional, orally transmitted layout and scribing techniques into a standardized and measurable training process. In doing so, it not only reinforced building norms, but also enabled builders to better predict labor supply and manage costs. Itinerant master instruction, in turn, promoted the movement of skills and information across towns, forming an early regional network of labor and capital. Later, Asher Benjamin's 1830 *The Architect, or Practical House Carpenter* translated practical craft knowledge into drawings and text, lowering the barrier to learning and fostering an intermediate role between "craftsman" and "architect," which provided a foundation for the industry's subsequent development.

Early timber-building education was closely tied to the growth of the construction economy. Standardized training increased the efficiency with which carpentry knowledge circulated, and it also supported the rise of larger-scale building demand, which further stimulated related sectors such as timber supply, tool making, and the trade in building materials. At the same time, colonial legal and administrative frameworks increasingly regulated training arrangements and wage standards for different social groups. Free white craftsmen were more likely to receive better support and clearer paths for advancement, while indentured workers and enslaved people were often confined to low-cost labor over the long term. This tight coupling of education and capital not only reinforced class and racial divisions within the building trades but also helped create the institutional and economic conditions for the emergence of more formal advanced training in timber construction and for the formation of general contracting models by the late eighteenth century.

PS54 The Colonial Building Industry in the Americas

Session Co-Chairs: Alexander Wood, Massachusetts College of Art and Design, USA

Two Hundred Years of Construction: Fortifying Old Point Comfort and the Emergence of the Building Industry

Michael Osman

UCLA, USA

Abstract

Fortress construction on the peninsula called Old Point Comfort, strategically located between the Chesapeake Bay and the James River, spans from the first decades of the Virginia Colony into the early American republic. During those two hundred years, the meaning of "industry" shifted from a virtue of labor to a production system that included building construction. This paper shows that the military significance and the difficult conditions posed by the site make Old Point Comfort a unique case for observing this shift over a long duration.

Starting with the "20 and odd" enslaved Africans transported to this very location in 1619, chattel labor became part of Virginia's agricultural economy. But planters also developed contracts to lease enslaved workers to the colony to participate in the tasks of fort construction. After several failed attempts at building in wood, the colony invested in masonry bastions for Fort George during the 1720s, drawing on brickmaking facilities up the James River. A storm destroyed that fort, leaving the Bay open for naval invasion. Unfortified, the position became part of the British military strategy during the Revolutionary War and the War of 1812.

Loosing battles to defend the Bay from the British during those wars led the US Board of Engineers to mount a monumental construction effort at Fort Monroe on the ruins of Fort George. Designed by the French officer Simon Bernard, it was built by hundreds of leased slaves and military conscripts. It was the largest construction project of a newly formed federal government, leading to a huge amplification of brick production and founding of a granite quarry in Maryland. The paper will survey changes in the coordination of labor and materials during a two-century period to study the rise of a building industry at a site of nearly perpetual construction.

PS54 The Colonial Building Industry in the Americas

Session Co-Chairs: Alexander Wood, Massachusetts College of Art and Design, USA

Constructing a Royal Mint: State Building and Labor in the Andes

Lucia Galaretto

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Abstract

In 1773, the Spanish Crown completed the Royal Mint in Potosí. The building aligned with Crown-sponsored efforts to standardize coinage, incorporating state-of-the-art technology to regulate existing artisanal practices. Hailed by historians as the most significant work of civic architecture in the Viceroyalty of Peru, the Mint's rational layout reflected Bourbon application of classicist Enlightenment ideals to a colonial productive space. In this paper, I seek to both expand and complicate this vision of rationalized production by considering the decades-long process of materializing the building itself. Drawing on records of labor, materials and technologies, I argue that construction documents themselves already served to synchronize isolated manufacturing processes. Extending beyond the realm of the building, the forms of regulation promoted by these documents also served to further state authority and legitimacy, at a moment when distinctions among Indigenous, Creole and Spanish populations were undergoing significant reconfigurations.

To ensure the provision of materials to one of the highest-altitude cities in the world, the Crown sponsored expeditions to survey surrounding valleys, registered in *padrones* Indigenous subjects in possession of pack animals, and extended credit to Creole suppliers using long-established Iberian legal instruments (*asientos*). On the construction site, weekly cost logs broke down the set of architectural drawings sent from Lima into trades compatible with the local workforce—various types of free labor including those derived from Inca social structures. Concurrently, architectural specification of classical elements not only sought to curb Andean Baroque stylistic tendencies but also served to regulate the work of Indigenous stonemasons by enforcing compliance with paper documents. By attending to the rule of drawings, cost logs, *padrones* and *asientos*, the paper sheds light on the role of state-sponsored construction works in the evolving systems of environmental transformation, technical development and economic regulation that shaped the city during the eighteenth century.

PS54 The Colonial Building Industry in the Americas

Session Co-Chairs: Alexander Wood, Massachusetts College of Art and Design, USA

Mastering the System: Regulating Labor in colonial America c.1720

Erik Carver

USC, USA

Abstract

The South Sea bubble of 1720 represents a watershed in British construction history—marking the effective end of the metropolitan guild and the dawn of new labor regimes in such leading colonial cities as Philadelphia and Charleston. The South Sea Company is best known as a speculative vehicle with a monopoly on slave sales to Spanish America. Savvy investment in the bubble allowed London's carpenters' company to phase out its already-tenuous involvement in construction and become a charitable and social institution by midcentury.

By this time, the American colonies had developed into prosperous breadbaskets for Caribbean plantations. Yet the volatility inherent in this new market led to cyclical recessions beginning in the 1720s. In 1727 Philadelphians responded by organizing their own carpenter's company, which appropriated the London company's regalia and reinvented its old powers over costs and wages in construction. The Philadelphians did not continue guild traditions so much as re-enact them in a radically new landscape of resource abundance, labor scarcity, and racialized free and enslaved labor. By calibrating wage rules, the carpenters' company attempted to balance local abolitionism with its members' investments in enslaved labor as its planners allocated price risk among carpenters and clients.

In the 1720s, enslaved black artisans in Charleston began to outnumber their white counterparts. By the end of the decade, masters had institutionalized a flexible "hiring out" system that allowed for leasing their artisans and supplementing unfree with waged labor to manage market volatility. In this way the system assigned risk to bound workers at the cost of an elaborate apparatus of policing.

In comparing these colonial labor regimes, I hope to ask how their distinct articulations of labor processes and new urban conditions emerged from common perceptions of an emerging, unstable world system.

PS54 The Colonial Building Industry in the Americas

Session Co-Chairs: Alexander Wood, Massachusetts College of Art and Design, USA

Building Colonial Lima: Indigenous, African and European Architects and Builders.

Laura Fernández-González

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Abstract

The histories of architecture and urbanism of colonial Lima have chiefly responded to the Vasarian method, centred on the analysis of the urban and architectural design (*traza*), the 'life' and work of 'prominent' architects and patrons, as well as construction history. The lives and work of residents in the City of Kings were conditioned within a complex framework of urban and spatial regulations that aimed to control economic activity, architecture, space, and impose social hierarchies. Regulations were not always successful. Spanish carpenters unsuccessfully tried to prevent African carpenters from partaking in the building trade in 1555 and made subsequent attempts, also in the guild ordinances of 1579. Literature on the ordinances of the guilds in Lima and their transatlantic comparisons has shed light on ideas of continuity and change. Scholarship has amply demonstrated that workshops in Lima, including carpenters' workshops, were largely multiethnic. And yet, our knowledge of the names, work and life of Indigenous and African architects, builders and their descendants in Lima is limited compared to their European counterparts. The silencing of the presence of subaltern groups in the building trades is prevalent in archival records across the Iberian World. But this is also an epistemological issue in architectural history, for the 'classical' study methods tend to perpetuate such silences. Thus, this paper turns its attention to the social history of architects and builders in Lima. By exploring a corpus of documentation in the form of building contracts, testaments, marriages, among others, that record the presence and activity of architects and builders in colonial Lima, this article will expand our knowledge about architects and builders of Indigenous and African descent who worked alongside their European counterparts.

PS55 The Power and Politics of Craft

Session Co-Chairs: Anooradha Siddiqi, Columbia University, USA, and Ana María León, Harvard University, USA

The Map and the Camera: Dorothy Pelzer, Ethical Imperatives, and Documentary Desire

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Abstract

The soaring roof structure of a rong in Kon Tum province in the Vietnam highlands fills the frame of the monochrome photograph. In one corner, two small figures in military fatigues and unmistakable US Army helmets look on. The photo was taken on December 25th, 1964, by architect Dorothy Pelzer, who visited several villages in the Central Highlands by military helicopter. Having been exposed to traditional architecture through her work in the International Voluntary Service, she traveled to Vietnam with the goal of studying it further. We can elucidate her itinerary and the focus of her attention through the photographs she made during this visit. Pelzer documented rural environments in the context of their increasing militarization. Her photographs, taken through the helicopter's open door, record the "Strategic Hamlets" (Ấp Chiến lược) program, a scheme of the US and South Vietnam governments to fortify rural villages with perimeters of barbed wire, ditches, and watchtowers to "protect" the local populace from the Viet Minh.

If Pelzer was interested in crafted ancestral architectures, such as this rong house in Kon Tum, her camerawork was hampered by the militarizing context that provided her access. Nonetheless, publishing her photographs in a book about this and similar architectures in Asia would, as she wrote in a letter to a colleague at USAID, be "the most useful first step in a craft program." Whether directly through international-scale conflict (such as in Vietnam), or indirectly through paramilitary-backed governments, the rise of the military-plantation complex directly threatened rural livelihoods and framed the contextual urgency of Pelzer's project. This paper seeks to situate her entanglements with this context. I want to ask, how did her reliance on military access and its toolkit, namely maps and cameras, trouble the ethical implications of her work? And how does it illuminate the wider racializing processes that advocates of so-called "vernacular" architecture have played a role in?

PS55 The Power and Politics of Craft

Session Co-Chairs: Anooradha Siddiqi, Columbia University, USA, and Ana María León, Harvard University, USA

Artisanal Returns: Transnational Craft Knowledge After Enslavement

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Maura Lucking

Abstract

This paper historicizes artisanship through its vexed relationship to enslavement, following nineteenth-century freepeople to West Africa. Despite assumptions African cultural expression was severed by the Middle Passage, enslaved builders were among the most skilled craftspeople in the Americas. Plantation houses capture these contradictions–sites of bondage, archives of Black labor, and ultimately blueprints for diasporic futures. The social status of artisans provided not only economic opportunity but relative mobility, as skilled workers were often "lent out" while enslaved and later figured disproportionately among free people of color targeted by colonization societies for African resettlement. While these individuals made the crossing for the first time, they brought their multigenerational knowledge of ornamental plaster-, wood- and metalwork from the plantations and seaports of the Americas back across the Atlantic.

"Return" was integral to nascent political formations of pan-Africanism on the continent, a central tool of imagined community even before its twentieth-century consolidation. This paper argues that African-descended craft traditions, marked by but also sustained across enslavement, were integral to constructing transnational Black identity. Following carpenters, blacksmiths, and plasterers from their bonded training in Greek Revival big houses and Baroque urban *sobrados*, we consider how their identity as artisans helped them forge distinctive social worlds in West Africa. Craft knowledge often translated into class ascension over local ethnic groups, while simultaneously demonstrating their embodied cultural interrelation. Artisans drew critiques of reinscribing the plantation system in Africa; indeed, ambivalence to its loaded forms paradoxically allowed returnees to assert their own freedom through its languages of modernity.

We focus on the family history of Egba-American free artisan Scipio Vaughan, whose status enabled his son Churchill's travel from South Carolina to Liberia and finally Nigeria as an associate of early Black nationalist Martin Delany, eventually becoming a leading builder in Lagos. Despite his intimate craft knowledge, Churchill had his family's opulent homes constructed by Brazilian *Agudás* builders. This invocation of broader diasporic imaginaries–what Delany would call "Africa for Africans"–transcended Yoruba and American affiliations, advancing a pan-African solidarity rooted in the material and materialist affinities of the ironmonger's shop rather than newsprint or the pulpit.

PS55 The Power and Politics of Craft

Session Co-Chairs: Anooradha Siddiqi, Columbia University, USA, and Ana María León, Harvard University, USA

Cultivating Rubber, Recovering Craft: Improvement, Agriculture Societies, and the Rubber Exhibition of 1906

Anirudh Gurumoorthy

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Abstract

The 1906 Rubber Exhibition, held within the Peradeniya Botanical Garden, reveals a complex interplay of power exerted by the British Empire in its deployment of agricultural and horticultural expertise not only toward the plantation economy but also over local craft in colonial Sri Lanka. Held under the auspices of the Ceylon Agricultural Society, the exhibition heralded the successful acclimatization of the prized *Hevea brasiliensis* species of rubber-producing trees to Ceylon, while also showcasing the Exhibition of Arts and Crafts, whereby local craft, like rubber, was displayed for the public to 'realize' its "character and value."

The Agricultural Society's role in cultivating rubber is mirrored paradoxically in its treatment of craft. As noted by Ananda Coomaraswamy in his exhibition report, the society was interested in recovering indigenous craft practices that had become "endangered" with declining local demand and local craftsperson adopting "easier methods of work." But the shift away from craft, according to Coomaraswamy, was directly related to craft labor being forcibly reconfigured towards the plantation economy.

This paper aims to articulate how the Rubber Exhibition both represented the success of a three-decade long venture of agricultural improvement and simultaneously attempted to uplift local craft at the same event. Housed in a structure hand-built by local crafts persons in twenty-seven days, the exhibition comes to display the entangled politics of craft and agriculture within the activities of Agriculture Societies operating in aid of the colonial plantation economy. By focusing on this parallel and paradoxical improvement of both rubber cultivation and craft, this paper examines a historiographic shift from craft's usual counter to industry.

PS55 The Power and Politics of Craft

Session Co-Chairs: Anooradha Siddiqi, Columbia University, USA, and Ana María León, Harvard University, USA

Crafting Bengal Jute Ecologies: Molding Expertise and the Ethics of Architectural Materiality

Priyanka Sen

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Abstract

In 1971, USAID contracted the development organization CARE to conduct grassroots work throughout South Asia, including experimentation with architectural materials in East Pakistan (later Bangladesh). Though previous efforts introduced CINVA-RAM earth block as an ecologically efficient construction solution, environmental forces including monsoons, floods, and cyclones in the Bengal Delta necessitated the invention of a water-resistant material capable of enduring extreme weather conditions. Aligning with larger USAID motives of "productive rural development," the cultivation, instrumentalization, and eventual exportation of jute became a central preoccupation for CARE design experts hoping to capitalize on native agricultural expertise and labor. These material studies incorporated industrial-based manufacturing processes that impregnated the Bengal jute—referred to as indigenous fibers in reports—with various forms of synthetic binders, including resin, plastic, and polyurethane foam, believing the amalgamation of "industrial technologies" and "craft techniques" would better withstand environmental catastrophes.

In this paper, rather than recount a narrative of yet another neo-colonial enterprise, I excavate this material history through the lens of local craftspeople, from cultivating farmers to the skilled laborers processing jute, arguing that without their inherent knowledge of the tumultuous Bengal Delta, the crafting of this architectural material would prove impossible. This production hinged on East Pakistani (later Bangladeshi) farmers' expertise—built on centuries-old land practices—making their contribution to the material's functionality inextricable from the manufacture of impregnated jute wall panels. This narrative challenges the power dynamics prevalent in South-North exchanges of developmental aid and importantly exposes an overarching extractivist ethic that attempted to reconfigure land, labor, and native skill to the mold of technological mass production. This paper brings into frame larger questions concerning the authority over knowledge production and asks how this dynamic folded into ventures of capital accumulation by exploiting native labor and expertise.

PS56 Open Session - Matters, Materials and Materiality

Session Chair: Sibel Zandi-Sayek, William & Mary, USA

Subversive Tectonics: Granite and Chunam in Colonial Hong Kong

Tsz Ching Joy Zhu

UCLA, USA

Abstract

This paper examines how weathering granite, an active nonhuman agent, shaped Hong Kong's built environment and urban ecology in the early 20th century. Focusing on photographs taken by Robert Larimore Pendleton, Chief Soil Technologist of the Geological Survey of China from 1931–1935, I examine how visible joints and fissures on the granite retaining walls of Shau Kei Wan register and catalyze their geological decomposition into soil. These massive yet vulnerable structures are held together by Chunam plaster, a lime paste derived from burnt seashells and imported from Madras, India. These tectonic membranes, produced in a tropical British colony, paradoxically reinforces and reveals the unstable rockface it covers. In doing so, it visualizes a solidarity across colonial geographies, where landscapes in both India and Hong Kong subvert colonial authority through geological and ecological decay.

Foregrounding towering rock walls against small human figures or trams at their base, Pendleton's photographs are articulated with a distinctively modernist visual language of scale and order, visualizing the infrastructural ambitions of the U.S. institutions that funded his work. Pendleton's survey work, funded by the Rockefeller foundation and other U.S. institutions, was part of broader American efforts to modernize Chinese agriculture and extend its imperial influence. While universalist in its visual logic, the photographs reveal the specificity of its subtropical milieu: the joints, catalyzed by frequent erosive monsoons, sets in motion the imminent decomposition of granite. This paper answers the questions: how can weathering granite and chunam plaster be seen as animate agents of geological subversion? How does attention to these materials challenge human-centered narratives of urban construction in Hong Kong, revealing a built environment shaped by the erosive forces it seeks to contain?

PS56 Open Session - Matters, Materials and Materiality

Session Chair: Sibel Zandi-Sayek, William & Mary, USA

The Two Tectonics in Himalayan Geology and Nepali Architecture

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Abstract

Through the lens of Nepal, one of the world's most geologically dynamic countries with a rich architectural history, and as a collaboration among practicing architects and a geologist, this paper explores two distinct yet overlapping conceptions of *tectonics*: 1) the geological processes that deform the earth's crust, resulting in faulting, and 2) the architectural expression of structural elements and construction assemblies. While these two definitions are both derived from the Ancient Greek root *tekton*, or "builder," it is in seismically active regions like the Himalayas that traditional architectural tectonics most closely responds to *geological* tectonics, revealing their common etymological origin.

After introducing the geology of Nepal and the Main Central Thrust (MCT) fault, we consider ethno-architectural research of the *janajati*, the country's more than sixty official indigenous ethnic groups. Exploration of the traditional architecture of the *Newar* people of the Kathmandu Valley and *Thakali* communities of Mustang, Nepal, in particular, reveals construction rituals for seismic resilience that diverge sharply from modern approaches and reframe architectural tectonics as a relational and spiritual negotiation with the earth rather than a means of geotechnical control. We briefly revisit theories of tectonics by architectural historians such as Gottfried Semper and Kenneth Frampton, with special interest in the essay "Structure, Construction, Tectonics" (1965) by the Harvard historian Eduard Sekler, founder of the Kathmandu Valley Preservation Trust. And finally, we turn our attention to modern approaches to seismic resistance in reinforced concrete that are reshaping Nepal's built environment – methods which often *conceal* more than they reveal – as well as alternative approaches in timber-laced masonry designed by the nonprofit Building Bureau.

What does it mean to build *on* or *with* the earth when the ground itself is dynamic and what is the role of a contemporary architectural tectonics in unstable terrain?

PS56 Open Session - Matters, Materials and Materiality

Session Chair: Sibel Zandi-Sayek, William & Mary, USA

Plastic Culture: Inflatable Architecture as Petrochemical Corporate Strategy

Katarzyna Balug

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Abstract

In the mid-1960s, plastic films such as polyethylene were widely adopted by young American and Western European architects experimenting with inflatable forms. Plastic inflatables had existed since the 1930s, were refined for wartime applications, and were used as pneumatic formwork by well-established architects in the 1950s. Why did his familiar medium suddenly gain traction in experimental architecture? Scholars have often cast inflatables as emblematic of the era's psychedelic counterculture, the nascent environmental movement, and rejection of modernism, attributing their decline to the 1973 oil crisis. This paper affirms that endpoint while complicating the notion of inflatables as purely radical. It traces how corporate patronage, rooted in the petrochemical industry's efforts to promote fossil fuel-derived synthetic materials in cultural and consumer markets, cultivated the inflatable.

This paper examines three manufacturers who supported creative experimentation with plastics, considering it both a testing ground for new materials and a vehicle for cultural adoption. Artist Domenico Mortellito spent decades working for DuPont in Wilmington, Delaware (1945-1979), exploring plastics as media for sculpture, murals, and shelter. Hooker Chemical sponsored the 1968 exhibition *Plastic as Plastic* at New York's Museum of Contemporary Crafts, which framed plastic as a defining material of art and everyday life. In the UK in 1971, Imperial Chemical Industries provided recent architecture graduate Graham Stevens with polymers, production facilities, and publicity for his inflatable environments.

The three cases reveal a timely convergence between the radicalism of plastic architecture and the marketing strategies of plastics industries seeking to rebrand synthetic materials for domestic and cultural markets. The paper expands on Jeffrey Meikle's seminal cultural history of plastic and draws on Mimi Sheller's investigation of aluminum to show how fossil fuels were embedded in, concealed by, and yet made culturally legible through experimental architecture.

PS57 Geometry, Cosmology, and Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Tracy Miller, Vanderbilt University, USA, and Robert Bork, University of Iowa, USA

Cosmology at Chartres Cathedral

Elizabeth Pastan

Emory University, USA

Abstract

This paper explores the motivations behind the use of geometrical systems at Chartres Cathedral from an architectural and pictorial perspective. In this communication, I seek to join the insights of Madeline Caviness whose influential study of 1983, "Images of Divine Order and the Third Mode of Seeing," identified a "mode of seeing" in pictorial imagery with attributes of symmetry and stasis that could portray a universe ordered by divine knowledge to Robert Bork's "A Geometrical Perspective on Otto von Simson's Gothic Architecture," of 2022. In his equally foundational paper, Bork looked at the mathematical calculations that undergird Chartres Cathedral and identified "complex plays on reflection, rotation, and scaling" (p. 397) that I argue have a counterpart in the cathedral's pictorial images. I will look specifically at Chartres's pavement labyrinth and its three rose window, both of which offer imagery that is integral to the building fabric and coordinated with it, suggesting that there was a larger cosmology at play. This is a topic with a certain history, going back to verses from Lincoln Cathedral of the late twelfth century that refer to the pivotal role of rose windows, comparing its two transept roses to the sun and the moon, while referring to the other windows as "common stars." It is a notion that percolates through William Durandus of Mende's exegetical interpretation of the oriented church. In addition, Hans Sedlmayr famously argued identified the rose window as Christological-solar image, a thesis in which Chartres's south transept rose of the Glorification of Christ took a starring role. This paper allows me to me to integrate discussions from different domains – mathematical, exegetical, architectural, and pictorial in better understanding how the Gothic cathedral drew upon observations from the natural world in its conception.

PS57 Geometry, Cosmology, and Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Tracy Miller, Vanderbilt University, USA, and Robert Bork, University of Iowa, USA

Translations from Pictogram to Building: A Media Account of a Sumerian Construction

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Abstract

In 2016, a British Museum–sponsored archaeological expedition at Tello (ancient Girsu) in southern Iraq excavated portions of a previously unconfirmed 3rd-millennium BCE Mesopotamian structure. Since the 19th-century excavations of Ernest de Sarzec, archaeologists and Assyriologists had long suspected the existence of this structure. Among the artifacts uncovered in the earlier campaign were a statue of King Gudea with an inscription resembling a building plan on his lap, two monumental cylindrical tablets narrating the construction process in cuneiform script, and various inscribed nails and bricks.

While the recent excavations confirmed the existence of the structure, they also introduced a critical revelation: the plan-like inscription on Gudea's lap was mathematically scaled to the dimensions of the actual building. This finding raises important questions about the role of mathematical and geometric operations in ancient Mesopotamian building endeavors.

Drawing on three interrelated objects—the building site, the plan-like inscription, and the cuneiform textual narrative—this paper examines the translation process from tablet to building scale. Engaging with recent scholarship on cuneiform knowledge systems, I argue that this translation reflects a logic distinct from architectural plans on paper-like media and presents a unique and complex cosmo-epistemological framework. First, the dual role of clay as both an inscription surface and a building material underscores a material continuity that resists modern representational frameworks that distinctly separate representation from the object represented. Second, the inscription's formal logic emerges not from geometric abstraction but from pictographic and cosmological principles emerging out of cuneiform knowledge systems. Finally, I propose that the scaling of the inscription to match the building's dimensions served not a utilitarian operation in construction, but a ritual one: it produced a visible inscription on the great clay tablet of earth legible to the god Ningirsu, thereby ensuring favorable agricultural conditions.

PS57 Geometry, Cosmology, and Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Tracy Miller, Vanderbilt University, USA, and Robert Bork, University of Iowa, USA

The Influence of Hellenistic Science on Roman Architectural Plans

Ashton Fancy

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Abstract

In the preface of *De Architectura* Book 6, the Roman architect Vitruvius tells the story of the Socratic philosopher Aristippus and his companions shipwrecked on the island of Rhodes. On the beach, the presence of geometric diagrams traced in the sand alerted the group that the island's inhabitants must be learned people and therefore safe to contact, connoting the presence of such images with knowledge and *humanitas*. Mathematical, scientific, and mechanical treatises of the Hellenistic world were replete with simple, graphic diagrams illustrating the texts they accompanied, visualizing knowledge in a tangible, if abstract, way. Aristippus' association of such images with a safe intellectual haven is indicative of the elevated status that technical knowledge held in the ancient Mediterranean, especially in the scientific center of Hellenistic Alexandria.

In the Roman period, the sciences continued to represent erudition, which in visual culture was symbolized by the presence of technical tools and research apparatuses like sundials and the groma—items that created or produced their own forms of simple, graphic, geometric shapes. At the same time, Roman patrons begin producing reduced-scale ground plans of buildings with varying degrees of technical acumen. While 1:1 scale schematics of architectural features utilized in the construction process are present much earlier in the ancient Mediterranean, with but one exception, all known reduced-scale images come from the Roman period. This paper proposes that Hellenistic scientific practice was an important source for this new interest in producing Roman architectural reduced-scale plans. By comparing the visual similarities of treatise diagrams and scientific tools to Roman architectural plans commissioned by non-specialist patrons, I demonstrate how individuals leveraged the lexicons of scientific knowledge and architectural practice to fashion themselves as possessing technical expertise and cultural capital.

PS57 Geometry, Cosmology, and Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Tracy Miller, Vanderbilt University, USA, and Robert Bork, University of Iowa, USA

From Stars to Structures: Tracing Geometry in Medieval Iran and Turan's Observatories

Seyed Alireza Seyedi[1], Amir Hossein Moghtadaei[2], Amirmahdi Basiri Kheradmand Tehrani[2]

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Abstract

In the premodern Islamic world, the connection between the sky and the earth was far more than just two separate elements. Many decisions made by rulers and the daily activities of the people, especially religious rituals and Islamic occasions, depended on the study of the relationships between celestial bodies. This situation led to the study of the sky becoming a practical science, developed under the special attention of rulers. One of the most remarkable periods of astronomical research in Iran was from the Ilkhanid to the Timurid eras, which saw the construction of major observatories managed by renowned scholars. Among them,
the Maragha Observatory was established by the order of Hülegü Khan under the supervision of Khwāja Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī (astronomer, mohandis, mathematician, and theologian) in 1259. This observatory became a model for others in neighboring territories, including the Samarqand Observatory, which was founded by the wise Timurid king Ulugh Beg in 1420 and was overseen by Ghiyath al-Din Jamshid al-Kashi (astronomer, mohandis, mathematician). Despite its short lifespan, the Samarqand Observatory significantly impacted astronomical knowledge, geometry, and mathematics, demonstrating the deep connection between these fields, as many scholars wrote treatises on them simultaneously. The presence of multifaceted scholars in observatories established them as essential spaces for nurturing, research, and scientific collaboration. Historical records and archaeological findings further indicate that observatories were composed of multiple sections and,
like Maragha, were not necessarily single buildings but rather complexes of adjacent structures. Thus, this research seeks to examine the physical structure of these observatories based on historical sources, particularly the works and treatises of Tusi and al-Kashi. It aims to evaluate them alongside archaeological discoveries and uncover the hidden geometry within them, as well as their possible connections to discovered astronomical instruments.

PS57 Geometry, Cosmology, and Architecture

Session Co-Chairs: Tracy Miller, Vanderbilt University, USA, and Robert Bork, University of Iowa, USA

Geometry and the Tuning of Affects in English Decorated Gothic

Sean Akahane-Bryen

The University of Sydney, Australia

Abstract

With reference to the relativity of scale in English Decorated Gothic architecture (*ca.* 1250–1350) and three coeval parts of Ely Cathedral in particular (*ca.* the 1320s–1340s), this paper argues that Paul Binski's affective interpretation of medieval architecture is entirely consistent with a content–form analogy between Gothic architecture and scholasticism (as opposed to Panofsky's famous form–form analogy). It accepts as a premise Binski's conclusion that Gothic architecture was designed to elicit, more often than transcendental experience, non-transcendental yet profound affects which were intended to uplift and persuade the beholder. Nothing in Binski's affective interpretation discounts François Bucher's assertion that the masons' ideal was the "spatial realization and imitation of laws which were thought to govern the universe as well," and that these laws were essentially geometric; not as long as consonance with God's plan was considered a prerequisite of a building's capacity to inspire *admiratio* (wonder), or even its *firmitas* (stability), since it was God who put Aristotelian dynamics in play.

The paper draws on the work of Joel Kaye, who has observed a "new model of balance" underwriting the greatest intellectual achievements of *ca.* 1250–1375, to reinforce what Binski has described as the "elective affinity" between the practical geometry of the masons and its "academic quadrivial counterpart"; and on research in the cognitive science of religion that has identified recursiveness (imperfectly defined as the coincidence of self-reference and a relativity of scale) as a method of bringing infinity into the realm of sense-based representation. The paper asserts that a repertoire of cosmologically-informed geometric procedures served as the primary instrument by which medieval 'architects' tuned the affective charge of their work—not least because it scaffolded other qualities such as colour, material, and light, and media such as figurative sculpture, with which it was continuous.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

Solar Observatories, Solar Weather, and the Cold War

David Salomon

Ithaca College, USA

Abstract

In 1965 the US Air Force Weather Services division (AWS) inaugurated the Solar Observing and Forecasting Network (SOFNET), a web of observatories that monitored the sun's behavior and its effects on the Earth, particularly on the ionosphere. During the Cold War this atmospheric zone was crucial for guiding, communicating with, and surveilling missiles and aircraft – both foreign and domestic. SOFNET allowed the US military to monitor, predict, and work around disturbances to the ionosphere caused by solar weather events. The AWS network, in collaboration with other institutions, gathered and immediately reported information back to its headquarters at NORAD in Colorado.

The initial SOFTNET sites were in Massachusetts, Athens, Manila, Hawaii, and California (and soon included ones in Tehran, Puerto Rico, and New Mexico). Each location intersected with a varied set of geographical, political, and architectural landscapes. What linked these locales was not just the shared scientific task of generating knowledge about the sun's behaviors. They were also beholden to the US government and miliary for financial and technological aid. These dependencies helped the US expand its soft power into the regions and nations in which SOFNET operated.

This paper will look at three sites within this network (Manila, New Mexico, Athens), examining the different scales that this local-global-cosmological axis interacted with, the distinct architectural manifestations they took (from modernist to neo-classical to infrastructural), the specific landscapes they occupied (from urban to hinterlands), the different institutions they existed in (academic, military, civic), and the distinct economic, religious, political, and military systems they were embedded within. In doing so, the instruments (i.e. telescopes), buildings, and landscapes will serve as the entry point to understand how the forms of these objects represented, obfuscated, and enacted the forms of power that created them.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

US Army Corps of Engineers (USACE) in Saudi Arabia: Contracts and Contractors for the Infrastructure of "Mutual Defense"

Gabrielle Printz

Yale University, USA

Abstract

Centering on the construction projects authorized at the outset of the US-Saudi diplomacy in the 1940s-1960s, this paper renegotiates two predominant frameworks for interpreting the so-called “special relationship” between the United States and Saudi Arabia: in oil concession, and in the post-Second World War maneuvering against communist encroachment in the Middle East, for which “aid” became a tactic of “mutual defense.” Construction projects, their contracts, and the diplomatic agreements that transacted building and training for a US security partnership scened work that was delivered simultaneously as material aid, physical infrastructure, technical assistance, and incorporation into the US-capitalist sphere of global economic relations. These American provisions to the nascent Saudi state were filed indistinguishably under a more capacious project of “development,” that proceeded under the auspices of non-combat military cooperation, but provided the conditions for the recapture of Saudi petrodollars by US firms.

Despite the acclaim garnered by Yamasaki’s Dhahran Civil Air Terminal (1961), architects were not instrumental agents of development here. Instead, the United States Army Corps of Engineers (USACE) acted decisively as purveyors of contracts and the primary mediators between American construction multinationals and Saudi government clients. Here, building is understood not in its object form but as a productive process wherein expat civilian contractors built Saudi infrastructure and meanwhile trained nationals on the job. USACE materialized the operative relationships and personnel that produced the physical infrastructure and human capital for Saudi government-sponsored projects, namely on behalf of its Ministries of Information and Defense and Aviation. Narrating between these projects and their contractual protocols, I’ll identify the disposition of large companies entrenched in the oil industry, like Parsons, Bechtel and Fluor, and smaller American joint ventures that made their business from USACE and USAID projects alike, as they solidified an American position in the growing Middle East construction market.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

Between a Model for US Aid and a Tool for Arab Unity: Point VI, Pan-Arabism, and the Rural Life Institute in Lebanon

Dalal Musaed Alsayer

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Abstract

President Harry Truman announced the Point IV plan to extend assistance and aid to the so-called "underdeveloped" nations in January 1949. With many Point IV administrators entrenched in the agricultural extension service during the interwar years, village improvement schemes and agricultural cooperatives became a centerpiece of the program. Using the Rural Life Institutes (RLI) established by the Near East Foundation (NEF) and subsumed by the Point IV program in Lebanon, this paper unpacks how the rural village became the center of US global campaign against communism under the banner of democracy and "development." RLI were modeled around agricultural education and cooperative extension employed in the Southern US and were imagined as sites of training in rural life with cooperative farming, home economic programs, and "live" agricultural laboratories. US administrators imagined the village as a site of crafting a nationalist identity within nascent nations in the region. While rural and village life were a central tenet of Point IV, rurality was cast in a different light for Arab thought leaders. *Al-Haraka al-ʿArabiyya al-Sirriyya* (The Secret Arab Movement) played a crucial role in the establishment of the village welfare service, where its leaders were able to use the RLI to recast the *fellah* (farmer) not as an illiterate, poor, and desperate person, but as an active member of a larger, regional, Arab unity. Taking on the slogan "From the Educated Youth to the farmer"*("Min alshabab almuthqaf ila al fellah"),* Arab youth were urged to take on village welfare service as means of political, social, and intellectual Arab *nahḍa* (renaissance). This paper examines the RLI as both a site of imperial ambitions, at once enforcing new spatial practices, altering diets, and producing new architecture; and a site of counter-insurgence when the rurality was the building block for Pan-Arabism.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

Designing Dakawa: Solidarity, Legitimacy, Late Socialism

Holly Bushman

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Abstract

For much of its 40-year existence, the German Democratic Republic's foreign aid and development assistance programs were officially deemed "socialist solidarity" initiatives: an ideological framing which emphasized internationalism and anti-imperialist cooperation, rhetorically opposed to capitalist aid models of patronage and indebtedness. By the 1980s, however, longstanding "solidarity" practices (including "gifts" of large-scale architecture or infrastructure projects to newly postcolonial states) had become economically and politically untenable in a world of increasingly neoliberal aid regimes. While maintaining the language of "solidarity" in official parlance, East German foreign assistance came to resemble, and occasionally collaborate with, the Western practices it had long opposed.

To investigate the fraught dynamics and lived realities of late-socialist "solidarity" assistance, this paper analyzes the design, construction, and reception of a development center for members of the South African anti-Apartheid liberation movement African National Congress (ANC) living in exile in Dakawa, Tanzania in the late 1980s. Initiated at the request of ANC leader Oliver Tambo in 1987, the center was to include housing, childcare facilities, schools, and other municipal buildings designed by architects collaborating with the East German Solidarity Committee. The project was eventually financially supported by UN-HABITAT, yet was only partially completed at the time of the GDR's dissolution in 1990.

This paper draws on research in the archives of the ANC, the GDR's Solidarity Committee, and UN-HABITAT to demonstrate how Dakawa was developed and publicized in East Berlin, in contradistinction to the experience of its construction and reception by ANC members living in Tanzania. In bringing together these different frames of experience, I demonstrate how Dakawa functioned in the East German political imaginary as a means of legitimizing socialist aid efforts in a neoliberal world—a legitimacy that, I argue, ultimately privileged its reception in the so-called "Global North" over the community it intended to serve.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

Cold War Cuba: Architecture and Alliance Building

Erica Morawski

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Abstract

To mark the occasion of Fidel Castro's visit to Hanoi and his trip across the 17th parallel to the denominated Quang Tri Liberation Area, the people of Cuba gifted to the people of North Vietnam a group of architectural and infrastructural projects, including a hospital, a highway, a hotel, a dairy farm and more. While committed to the Non-Aligned Movement and alliance building across the Third World, the Cuban state was also staunchly committed to communism and negotiated a complicated relationship with the USSR. As a state that conflictingly railed against imperialism yet tried to impose its own ideologies, Cuba serves as a rich example to parse out the ways architecture was bound to foreign aid as part of international geopolitics across different parties during the Cold War and beyond.

Looking to these projects in Vietnam, as well as other architectural programs Cuba pursued in Africa and the Caribbean, this research connects the Cuban state's mobilization of building practices, resources and materials, and labor across different geographies, cultures, and political ideologies to explore continuities and variations in aid projects. In doing so, it expands how we can understand architectural networks when we consider how aid in the form of building materials or construction labor may be reciprocated with gifts of rice or military force. It also examines how these projects were fashioned as part of liberation and solidarity movements through formal groups and informal networks, many of which persist today if we look through the changing language of aid, gifts or exchange. By considering both Cuban state narratives and the experiences of Cubans engaged in these programs and exchanges, this research points to the challenges in understanding what liberation, cooperation, and resistance look like at local, national and international levels and what we may learn from incongruities between these spheres.

PS58 Foreign Aid, Architecture, and the Cold War

Session Chair: Eun-Jeong Kim, Cornell University

Dialectic of Experiment and Sabotage in the Postcolonial Bengal Delta

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Abstract

During the late 1970s, the UN-FAO's Bay of Bengal Program charged by cold-war politics of tropical protein extraction and guided by phytoplankton density surveys launched pilot shrimp aquaculture projects across villages in the Bengal delta, aiming to transform artisanal fishing settlements into replicable models of "coastal aquaculture development."

My paper analyzes how the topographical technologies of this Cold War rural modernization operated as a bureaucratic experiment, filtrating a new kind of coastal subject from the rural population through a caste-neutral, apolitical vetting process- "not politically active," "not too old," "sober" were some of the criteria creating a moralized worker subject that can be folded into the transnational protein economy. Through modest architectural forms- field laboratories, nylon-mesh shrimp pens, and sluice-controlled ponds- the experiment reclassified caste-coded farmers and fishers into what FAO termed "resource users," a technocratic category tied to eligibility for aid, training, and credit. Filtration also followed infrastructural lines: farmers with land near regulated canals were inducted as "progressive small farmers," while those outside the network were excluded from the experimental frame.

Departing from Partha Chatterjee's account of subaltern agency as political negotiation, this paper argues that Cold War aid regimes engineered architectural conditions in which politics was preemptively foreclosed. Focusing on premature abortion of the experiment, I will show how the program released an experimental rationality into coastal landscape whose effects persisted through unauthorized modifications, local reappropriations, and the ungovernable reorganization of land-water relationship without the visible hand of architects. Condemned by FAO field reports as 'sabotage acts', it is within this space of infrastructural overreach that sabotage emerges neither as political negotiation in Chatterjee's sense nor a resistance from outside, but as the immanent contradiction of the experiment itself and its failure to universalize its own rationality in the face of contingencies, vernacular epistemologies, and moral orders.

PS59 Farming Architecture Beyond the Farm

Session Co-Chairs: Angela Gigliotti, Eastern Switzerland University of Applied Sciences / Syracuse University, and Fabio Gigone, ETH Zürich

From Leaf to Landmark: Tobacco, Architecture, and the New World

Louis Wyatt

University of Melbourne, Australia

Abstract

By the end of the nineteenth century, Australians were among the largest per capita consumers of tobacco globally, with tobacco consumption continuously increasing until World War I. Despite this high rate of consumption, the Australian colonies were largely dependent on imported tobacco. Subsidised by Australian governments, a series of multinational companies imported raw tobacco before manufacturing a variety of tobacco products locally. American tobacco was favoured, with American-based multinational companies dominating the market. To support these transnational corporations, a vast network of physical infrastructure was required, including warehouses, manufacturing facilities, and retail stores.

Existing research into the architecture of the tobacco industry has focused extensively on the communities that produced the crop, with an emphasis on the farming infrastructure. Consideration of drying sheds and the warehouses of tobacco merchants has received particular attention. By contrast, the architecture of imported tobacco has received limited scholarship. Despite this, the tobacco industry shaped the architectural landscape of importing countries.

In Australia, tobacco companies played a vital role in shaping the physical form of the city. As the wealth of tobacco was funnelled into architectural commissions, architects deployed new architectural styles which consciously embodied American commercialism. Simultaneously, the trade in tobacco encouraged transnational communication, providing Australian-based architects with international tobacco-funded commissions. Ultimately, the tobacco trade created a multi-directional exchange of architectural ideas.

Through an examination of Australia's late nineteenth and early twentieth-century tobacco architecture, this paper argues that, despite Australia's vast geographic distance from major tobacco fields, tobacco played a significant role in shaping Australia's urban fabric and, remarkably, its architectural profession. At the same time, the wealth associated with tobacco manufacturing transformed local understandings of architecture and permanently altered local architectural discourse.

PS59 Farming Architecture Beyond the Farm

Session Co-Chairs: Angela Gigliotti, Eastern Switzerland University of Applied Sciences / Syracuse University, and Fabio Gigone, ETH Zürich

Reclaiming London: Newcourt's Ideal Fortified Garden City, 1666

Lydia Soo

University of Michigan, USA

Abstract

After the Great Fire ended, various proposals were made to rebuild London, most no longer extant. The plan by Richard Newcourt, surveyor and mapmaker, does survive but has been long overshadowed by those of his famous contemporaries, including Wren. Newcourt's design, however, was innovative, bringing together diverse sources, including land reclamation for agriculture, to create the first garden city.

Three drawings by Newcourt present a new rectangular riverside city, replacing the old city and suburbs. Within fortified walls, the same block of houses repeats to form a grid, interrupted only by a central civic and commercial piazza and several smaller market piazzas. In the center of each block is either a large churchyard or livery company garden, the latter including a mount offering fresh air and prospects over the new city.

During the 1660s, scant visual information was available on cities, past and present, using orthogonal planning. There were treatises that presented the ideal fortified city, based on the Roman castrum. Also available were images of real places influenced by those sources: gridded new towns in Europe and colonial settlements dividing the land into a grid.

Evidence shows that Newcourt was aware of another source: contemporary reclamation and parcellation practices. In 1653 Cressy Dymock, influenced by the agrarian reformer Samuel Hartlib, proposed subdividing reclaimed land by using canals and walls to create a grid of squares, one or more of those squares forming farms. An earlier, well-documented Dutch source almost certainly known to both Dymock and Newcourt was the Beemster polder (1612). Praised as a "garden," the drained lake was laid out as a grid, with canals and roads creating squares further subdivided for fertile farms and verdant country estates.

In his plan, Newcourt reclaimed London's smoldering ruins and labyrinthine slums, creating in their place a gridded garden city.

PS59 Farming Architecture Beyond the Farm

Session Co-Chairs: Angela Gigliotti, Eastern Switzerland University of Applied Sciences / Syracuse University, and Fabio Gigone, ETH Zürich

Made of Maize

Paul Mosley, Laure Nolte

Kent State University, USA

Abstract

This paper examines how maize—*Zea mays*—has shaped systems of land use, spatial organization, and the built environment, from Indigenous cultivation methods in the Americas to industrial agriculture in the U.S. Corn Belt. As a human invention, maize was gradually transformed from a wild grass into an edible and storable crop through selective breeding and, more recently, genetic engineering. We argue that corn, more than a crop, is a spatial medium: bred to maximize yield, embedded in monocultural grid systems, and entangled with modernist ideals of universality and control. Following the grain itself, we link agronomic developments such as planting grid miniaturization to broader spatial regimes, where architecture becomes complicit in—and possibly resistant to—the infrastructural logics of extraction and containment.

Our research focuses on the U.S. Corn Belt, where cornfields now function as carbon infrastructures—fueling ethanol production, feeding confined livestock operations, and furnishing global supply chains. Yet the architectural consequences of corn extend well beyond the farm: in land value policies shaped by commodity agriculture, in zoning regimes that prioritize biomass production, and in logistical systems built to manage surplus. The corn grid is not merely agronomic—it is a territorial apparatus that structures human settlement.

We contrast this with maize domestication in Mesoamerica, where cultivation systems such as milpa polycultures and Zuni waffle gardens were based on nutrient cycling, polycropping, and species interdependence. Corn was not a commodity—it was kin. Ultimately, we position maize as a planetary material that underwrites territorial expansion, energy regimes, and carbon economies. From single-use plastics and biofuels to livestock feed and sweeteners, corn saturates the material conditions of everyday life. In tracing a history of architecture through the history of corn, we reveal a genealogy of space shaped by extractive infrastructures, colonial land systems, and agrarian abstraction.

PS59 Farming Architecture Beyond the Farm

Session Co-Chairs: Angela Gigliotti, Eastern Switzerland University of Applied Sciences / Syracuse University, and Fabio Gigone, ETH Zürich

'The Key to Economics.' A Construction of Nitrate Fertilizer Wealth beyond the German Field

Ella Neumaier

EPFL, Switzerland

Abstract

When nitrogen was recognized as essential for plant growth in the second half of the 19th century, German agronomists proclaimed chemical soil manipulation—and the predictability of crop supply it promised—as 'the key to economics' and 'the secret of prosperity.' The 'discovery' of nitrate deposits in Chile's Atacama Desert led to the large-scale European-headed extraction of Chilean saltpetre, involving thousands of exploited workers under a harsh sun. These industrial operations, peaking at the beginning of the 20th century, turned the desert into a commodity of unprecedented significance for German agriculture. One soil fed the other: Nitrogen-rich dirt transformed depleted fields on the other side of the world into productive land.

This paper investigates this metabolism not as a linear 'alchemy' from Atacama to the German farm, but rather as a circular process of negotiation and valorization, produced in scientific, industrial, mercantile, and cultural spaces in between. Drawing on primary sources and archival material from Germany and Chile, I examine the relationship of methods of quantification and practices of rationalization with the establishment and support of philanthropic spaces by key actors in German agriculture, commerce, and politics.

The paper argues that the co-constructed valorization of nitrate fertilizers—mediated by experimental testing stations, laboratories, industrial steel structures, but also by churches, clothing drives, and employment offices, a) not only positioned Chilean saltpetre as central to German agricultural wealth, and b) reified the asymmetrical accumulation of monetary wealth that, in turn, continued to fuel the nitrate industry, but c) can also be read as the negotiation between soil as matter and soil as an idea in the socio-politically tumultuous Wilhelmine period: enriching German industrialist and mercantile elites, employing tax-efficient philanthropy to embed conservative, nationalizing values in a mobile working class population, and deepening structural dependencies through repeated investments in a transatlantic network of nitrate architectures.

PS59 Farming Architecture Beyond the Farm

Session Co-Chairs: Angela Gigliotti, Eastern Switzerland University of Applied Sciences / Syracuse University, and Fabio Gigone, ETH Zürich

Earning by Eel: From Fishing to Farming in the "Haunted" Fenlands

Jennifer Mack

KTH, Sweden

Abstract

Ely Cathedral was "built by eel," as a resident of the town of Ely told me in December 2024, explaining that its construction was paid by the proceeds made from sales of this aquatic animal in the 11th century. Ely lies on what was once an island in the Fens, Cambridgeshire, UK, a region where freshwater and saltwater formerly met in regular patterns of flooding. Here, locals navigated streams and meres in small boats, living between earth and sea and using eels as currency.

In the 1630s, a new system of earthworks and dams began to transform these soggy Fenlands into dry land to be cultivated. This drainage altered their ecosystems and transformed their peat bogs into ideal, highly productive agricultural sites. These "reclaimed" wetlands allowed yields previously unimagined yet radically altered social and economic conditions in the region while shrinking the eel population. While drainage created new sources of agricultural wealth for those who had the power or vision to purchase the sites, it also displaced Fen dwellers accustomed to free movement, living with water, and the revenue from aquatic animals. Even today, the Fenlands remain an active agricultural zone, yet they are often represented in films and novels as "bleak" or "haunted" and "damp" rather than amphibious.

In this paper, I focus on eels and other animals to explore how the material conditions by which the "farming architecture" of reclaimed wetlands met class, society, and economy in the Fenlands in the early 19th century. During this period, negotiations around new and old animal-based economies again tested the legal frameworks that emerged after the earlier drainage of the Fens, with the eel trade partially moving into the realm of the illicit as new cartographies of ownership and animal husbandry remade economic relations.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

A Quest for Origins? Danish Encounters with Mexican Architecture

Dorian Bianco

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Abstract

This paper investigates the postwar encounters of Danish architects with Mexican architecture—Pre-Columbian, colonial, and vernacular rather than contemporary—as reflected in their travels, publications, and projects between 1949 and 1965. Alongside Mediterranean and Muslim regions, Mexico held a privileged position in the internationalization of Danish architects through study trips. In 1949, Jørn Utzon undertook a seminal journey with Norwegian architect Arne Korsmo, traveling from the U.S.–Mexico border to the Yucatán to visit Pre-Columbian ruins. Several other Danish architects followed: Eva and Nils Koppel in 1959; Poul Erik Skriver in 1965, who later published an account in *Arkitekten*, the journal he edited; and photographer Jesper Høm, who released in 1965 the series Huse uden arkitekter ("Houses Without Architects").

This paper argues that these encounters illuminate a widespread narrative within the postwar Danish architectural profession: that modern architects should turn to both ancient and vernacular dwellings as origins and resources for modern design. In the specific case of Mexico, the urban forms of Pre-Columbian settlements, along with rural dwellings and colonial patio-houses, were not merely studied for their historical significance but actively mobilized to rethink human needs in postwar housing and planning. To a large extent, this instrumental gaze draws on interpretive categories rooted in concepts akin to the vernacular, which—within the Mexican context—raises critical questions about the distinction between pre- and post-colonial periods and the latent framework of a Western-centric narrative.

These narratives further unpack a one-way transfer of architectural references from Mexico to Denmark, as several projects in Denmark eventually display such influences, including Utzon's housing architecture, Koppel's Technical University of Denmark (1961), and Henning Larsen's proposal for Stockholm University (1961). This paper ultimately seeks to enrich perspectives on the complex international circulations of architectural ideas in the postwar period.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

This and That: The "Byzantine" in Tunisia's Colonial Churches

Daniel Coslett

Drexel University, USA

Abstract

Commentators considering the architecture of the Catholic Church built in French-occupied Tunisia often referred to its structures as "pseudo-Byzantine," "Byzantine Mauresque," "Byzantine-Arab," "Romano Byzantine," or some other compound and imprecise term. Such labels were at times applied to buildings the appearance of which bore little resemblance to the supposed models. Used by architects, commentators, and tourists, they betray not only varying levels of familiarity with actual Byzantine architecture, but also the particular suitability of ambiguous references to an early Christian past in the colonized Mediterranean. Although today's Tunisia had been a part of the Byzantine Empire (534–698 ce), those erecting structures there during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries sought to craft narratives that emphasized evolving continuity and colonial legitimacy rather than simply the revival of local traditions. Architects appealing to the past through their innovative compositions and the use of new building methods thus contributed to imperial modernization efforts, despite perpetuating what many deride as merely historicist eclecticism.

Using the several of the Catholic Church's major monuments in the capital region and beyond as illustrative examples, this paper explores the use of the "Byzantine" within the oft-retrospective French colonial project. It introduces the buildings in detail, highlighting the particular elements that might have appeared Byzantine to those critiquing their forms, before considering the varied meanings of such claims. Based on archival and site research conducted in both Tunisia and France, as well as close readings of written commentaries by visitors and designers, the paper seeks to deepen our understanding of not just historicist architectural form, but also the potent language used to describe and legitimate it within the colonial context.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

Soviet Influence in Postwar Japanese Architecture

François Blanciak

National University of Singapore, Singapore

Abstract

In the aftermath of World War II, the recently defeated Japanese nation invested massively in its reconstruction, granting immense powers to a generation of architects hitherto accustomed to implementing a nationalistic style. But instead of taking their cue from Western nations, as they did during the Meiji Restoration, many Japanese architects opted for the formal repertoire of the Soviet avant-garde of the 1920s. Pondering the architectural implications of the oft-overlooked geographic proximity of Japan and Russia, this paper investigates the influence of Soviet design ideology on the architecture of postwar Japan, focusing on the work of members of the Tange Laboratory at the University of Tokyo—namely Arata Isozaki, Kisho Kurokawa, and Kenzō Tange himself—as well as on their political inclinations, delving more specifically into their shared interest in the radical projects of the Constructivist architect Ivan Leonidov (1902-1959). The year 1960 in Japan was marked by both the completion of Tange's *Plan for Tokyo, 1960* and the countrywide upheavals that followed the signature of the US-Japan Security Treaty (or *Anpo*), fueling the development of Marxist artistic movements that aimed to cut ties with the West. In line with this rejection, Tange's plan for Tokyo Bay not only strongly recalled, in both principle and form, Ivan Leonidov's 1930 design for the socialist settlement of an industrial combine at Magnitogorsk, in the Ural Mountains, but the very discourse that accompanied Tange's project also tapped into the Soviet doctrine of *disurbanism*, championed three decades earlier by the urban theorist Mikhail Okhitovich. Considering these fundamental similarities, the paper analyzes the common characteristics between the *Plan for Tokyo, 1960* and Leonidov's Magnitogorsk project, highlighting evidence of the fascination of the Tange Lab members for Soviet Constructivism.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

Notre Dame d'Afrique: Byzantium Between Bishop and Architect

Ralph Ghoche

Barnard College, Columbia University, USA

Abstract

My contribution to the SAH session, "Afterlife of Byzantine Architecture in the Era of Modernity," examines how the divergent visions of architects and the Bishopric of Algiers for the Basilica of Notre Dame d'Afrique ultimately converged on the neo-Byzantine style. For architects in France between the 1830s and 1860s, the Byzantine style was a subject of significant debate, as seen in the works of Verneilh, Vaudoyer, Lenoir, and Viollet-le-Duc. In North Africa, however, it took on even greater significance. While Romantic architects traced the roots of ecclesiastical architecture to Rome, envisioning its evolution as a tree splitting into two main branches—one, the *style byzantin*, spreading eastward and later shaped by Islamic dynasties, and the other, the *style latin*, developing into Romanesque and Gothic in the West—the choice of Byzantine architecture for a North African church was a deliberate attempt to reconnect with these traditions at their source. By adopting this style, architects sought not only to graft onto existing Islamic influences but also to revive what they saw as an original, unifying heritage. The basilica's precise orientation—facing Rome and gazing onto the Mediterranean—visually articulated these ideological underpinnings.

For the Bishopric of Algiers, however, the neo-Byzantine style carried distinct theological and social implications. Embracing its ultramontane resonance, church leaders saw in its rigid iconography and totalizing aesthetic an antidote to modern fragmentation. The basilica's alignment with Rome and the northern Mediterranean shores was not merely symbolic; it reflected a deliberate project to resurrect an Augustinian-era Christianity on the southern coast, one that framed Islamic rule as an interlude rather than a rupture. In this way, the convergence on neo-Byzantine architecture was more than a stylistic compromise—it was a contested reclamation of history, where architectural form became a medium for both spiritual unity and colonial ideology.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

Collaboration in Culture: European Designers and Iranian Museums

Marziyeh Bazyar

Technical University of Munich, Germany

Abstract

During the late 1960s and 1970s, Iran experienced remarkable economic growth, largely fueled by its burgeoning oil industry. This prosperity laid the groundwork for ambitious modernization projects aligned with the Pahlavi ideology to build "a great civilization." Notably, among these endeavors was the establishment of museums as symbols of modernity and progress. Renowned architects and firms from around the world were invited to design these cultural landmarks.

This study delves into the pivotal contributions of figures such as Austrian architect Hans Hollein, Finnish architect Alvar Aalto, and a Czech company led by Jaroslav Frič in shaping Iran's national museums. Methodologically, this research analyzes key museums from this era using primary sources such as archival documents, newspapers, and magazines. By delving into this pivotal period, this study offers a nuanced understanding of the 1960s and 70s as transformative moments in Iran's cultural evolution. The museum projects of this era encapsulate a broader narrative of globalization, where the pursuit of progress and modernity intersected with the complexities of cultural identity and international influence. This research contributes to the discourse on how nations navigate the incorporation of foreign elements into their cultural institutions, shaping their modern identity in the process.

PS60 Open Session - Temporal and Transnational Exchanges

Session Chair: Avigail Sachs, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

Persian by Association: Talavera Tiles and the Orientalist Gaze

U. Sedef Piker

Independent, USA

Abstract

This paper examines how 19th-century travelers and writers described Puebla's Talavera tiles using terms like "Saracenic" and "Persian"—language typically applied to Islamic ornament in European and American accounts. These descriptions reflect how Mexican architectural and decorative traditions were interpreted through Orientalist frameworks that favored generalized associations over historical specificity.

Rather than assessing the accuracy of these comparisons, the paper explores how such references reveal broader ways of seeing within the architectural culture of the period. I trace how Talavera, a ceramic tradition shaped by Spanish, Islamic, and transpacific influences, was visually folded into global narratives of ornament defined by imperial and exoticist taxonomies.

By situating these perceptions within a longer history of intercultural exchange, the paper considers how surface, color, and pattern in Mexican architecture were read through colonial lenses—and what this tells us about the entanglements between material culture, classification, and architectural discourse in the 19th century.

PS61 Ethnoburbia: Built Landscapes of Suburban Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Margaret Crawford, University of California Berkeley, and Erica Allen-Kim, University of Toronto

Little Palestine: The Making and Maintenance of a New Jersey Ethnoburb

Noah Allison

Barnard College, USA

Abstract

Tucked along Main Street in Paterson, New Jersey, is a vibrant collection of Palestinian-owned, businesses, including restaurants, bakeries, hair salons, travel agencies, and more. Over the past few decades, this small stretch of commerce has transformed South Paterson into a significant center of Palestinian culture and identity in the United States. What began with a handful of Muslim immigrants in the late 1800s, has grown into a thriving node with an estimated 10,000 Palestinian descendants residing in this New York City suburb. This emergence mirrors what scholars describe as "ethnoburbs" or "ethnoanchors," where ethnic communities create culturally rich, self-sustaining neighborhoods that reflect both their heritage and contributions to the larger society. This paper adds new perspectives to such scholarship by showing how Paterson's "Little Palestine," characterized by its ordinary cultural vibrancy, and entrepreneurial spirit, exemplifies this phenomenon. It achieves this by exploring the built environment of this Palestinian agglomeration and by showing how resident's social ties to urban hubs in Palestine and New York City are essential for the production and maintenance of this New Jersey ethnoburb.

PS61 Ethnoburbia: Built Landscapes of Suburban Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Margaret Crawford, University of California Berkeley, and Erica Allen-Kim, University of Toronto

From Villas to Villages: Lessons Learned from Ethnoburbs

Lawrence Davis

Syracuse University, USA

Abstract

Ethnoburbs in aging suburban sprawl hold transformative potential that extends far beyond the communities they directly serve. In recent decades, the influx of diverse cultures and their distinct spatial practices has created opportunities to explore more culturally autonomous approaches to design and planning. These include strategies such as hyperlocal zoning, increased residential density, mixed-use development, and shared community spaces.

This design research draws on the work of scholars, writers, and advocates who envision a future for suburban sprawl that leverages cultural diversity to promote inclusivity, strengthen local identities, and enhance economic, ecological, and social well-being. Although much of the existing scholarship focuses on the western United States, this study applies similar strategies to examples from Texas, Ohio, New York State and New Jersey. By expanding the geographic lens, the research suggests that lessons learned from ethnoburbs in the West can inform efforts to revitalize low-density development throughout North America.

PS61 Ethnoburbia: Built Landscapes of Suburban Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Margaret Crawford, University of California Berkeley, and Erica Allen-Kim, University of Toronto

Transnational Quilt: ethnoburbia in the South

Arief Setiawan

Kennesaw State University, USA

Abstract

Atlanta is the cultural mecca and the economic powerhouse of the South. Historically, it was a bi-racial city and its architecture snd urban form reflect the racial divides. The city did not have ethnic enclaves, such as Chinatown and Little Italy, as in many other American cities. However, Atlanta changed. In 1970s, the white flight saw the whites abandoned the city for the suburbs and African Americans moved into historic in-town neighborhoods. Immigrants started to arrive in Atlanta in1980s, many of them were Latino and Asians, especially refugees from Southeast Asia. They transformed empty properties in the suburbs left behind by the white flight. One of these areas is Buford Highway, a seven miles stretch of highway to the northeast of the city lined with a tapestry of multi-ethnic businesses and residential areas. no dominant ethnic group characterizes the line. Buford Highway became the byword for the presence of various ethnicities in the city, even though many ethnoburbs exist across Metro Atlanta.

Atlanta always invents and reinvents itself as a distinct Southern city, from “the capital of the New South” to “a city too busy to hate” to a global city. These imagined states also inform the formation and reformations of architecture and urban form of Atlanta, including its latest transformation into a multi-ethnic city. This study investigates Buford Highway as a site of interethnic dynamics as well as dialogues between different ethnics and the South against the backdrop of typical American suburbs. It will explore the transformations of the area in the last forty years as well as analyzing its formal and spatial characteristics. How does Buford Highway give new meanings for the new South? How do ethnoburbs interact with regional contexts?

PS61 Ethnoburbia: Built Landscapes of Suburban Migration

Session Co-Chairs: Margaret Crawford, University of California Berkeley, and Erica Allen-Kim, University of Toronto

Packaged Ethnoburbia: Financialising the Cultural Format of suburban Chinatown

Zeng Wu

The University of Sydney, Australia

Abstract

Following the rebranding of Sydney's historic CBD Chinatown in the late twentieth century—from a residual ethnic enclave to a nationally recognised multicultural inner-urban residential and entertainment precinct—ethnic theming gained renewed traction among planners, developers, and local councils. In the wake of successful high-density, mixed-use developments across the southern end of Sydney's CBD, particularly those built around the spectacles of Asian night life, the early twenty-first century witnessed the emergence of a new model of ethnic commercial development: investment-led schemes that mobilise multiculturalism as a political leverage to negotiate planning flexibility. Increasingly targeting suburban station precincts, these new wave of projects seek to redefine suburban life by integrating cultural theming, commercial programming, and visual identity into a coherent and exportable urban format.

Burwood Chinatown, a privately led redevelopment completed in 2017 in Sydney's inner west, exemplifies this shift. Situated within a heritage conservation area, the former Murray Arcade was reconfigured into a semi-enclosed laneway precinct shaped by a stylised, pan-Asian aesthetic vocabulary—compressed spatial thresholds, neon glow, ornamental signage, and cinematic atmospherics. This fantasy of "Asian-ness" functions not merely as a reflection of diasporic urban life, but as a proposition calibrated for spatial branding and retail performance. The architectural scheme was conceived alongside tenancy mix, lease structures, and marketing logics, producing a turn-key economic ecosystem: buying the design means acquiring a pre-validated consumer model. This formal and visual coherence also proved instrumental in securing regulatory concessions, including extended trading hours and regular laneway closures, despite the site's planning and heritage constraints. Thus, this paper situates Burwood Chinatown within broader discussions of ethnoburbia, neoliberal governance, and postmodern urbanism, arguing that it marks a shift from ethnic spatial representation to ethnic spatial formatting, where architecture functions simultaneously as a regulatory instrument, cultural signifier, and vehicle for financialisation.

PS62 Secularization and the Persistence of the Sacred

Session Chair: Joseph L. Clarke, University of Toronto

Luis Barragán and the sacralization of the domestic environment

Jose Bernardi

The Design School, USA

Abstract

When accepting the 1980 Pritzker Architecture Prize, Barragán defined his work as a contribution to dignify human life, containing the waves of dehumanization and secularization. Elaborating a personal narrative, he mentions his reverence for the monastic buildings “we inherited from the powerful religious faith,” of the past, recalling the peace he felt in those cloisters, wishing they “may leave their mark on my work.”

Two constant themes reappear and evolve in Barragán. First, his understanding of homes as places for protection and seclusion, the place of resistance to modernity. Second, his interpretation of homes as intimate stages for tranquility and meditation, thansforming mundane activities into a setting for the revelation of the divine. Focusing on the Barragán-Ortega and the Gilardi residence, this paper will explore the links between the sacred and the domestic by relating his reflections in interviews and letters with his design strategies, consciously shedding the outside world, articulating spaces for meditative withdrawal, and interweaving silence, light, water, and gardens to infuse an atmosphere of spiritual significance. These design elements were the antidotes to waves of vulgarization and the aggressiveness brought by modern life. Profoundly spiritual, he searched for earthly paradises, advancing an architectural atmosphere divergent from the main architectural stances of the modern movement.

In the interaction between his successful business operations in a city rapidly expanding and his religious belief, Barragán exposes his own contradictions as well as his irreconcilable ideological differences with Modernity. In the Pritzker Price speech, Barragán interpreted beauty as "the expression of the divine on earth.” Unwilling to accept the larger premises advanced by secularization, Barragán’s response was to construct walled refuges “to banish anxiety and create illusion.” Announcing the “gospel of serenity,” his domestic settings became a place to challenge secular modernity.

PS62 Secularization and the Persistence of the Sacred

Session Chair: Joseph L. Clarke, University of Toronto

Istanbul Hagia Sophia as a Symbol for Secularism in Modern Turkey

Zeynep Aktüre

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Abstract

Reactions especially from the West to the conversion of the Hagia Sophia Museum in Istanbul into the Grand Mosque of Ayasofya in 2020 shared a concern over the maintenance of aspects and elements representing the monument's Eastern Roman origins. This largely overshadowed, in the international media and academia, local reactions based on a perception of (re)mosquification as a decisive action representing Republic of Turkey's desecularisation. Indeed, "Unchaining Ayasofya", the first sultanate mosque of the Ottoman Empire that was converted from the foremost imperial basilica of the conquered Byzantine capital, was long a religious fundamentalist symbol against the Early Republican ideology that materialised through critical reforms including abolition of the sultanate and the caliphate, and change in the Islamic devotion language from Arabic into Turkish. Hagia Sophia was among key venues for implementing these reforms as well as for later initiatives aiming to counter them. This proposal attempts to highlight this key symbolic connection of the monument to secularism in modern Turkey through a selected series of events (including a chanting of Qur'an in the Turkish language during the month of Ramadan in 1932 when deplastering of the now visible figural mosaics had just started, a massively attended salaat on Ayasofya Square upon rumours that Pope Paul VI had privately recited Hail Mary by falling to his knees while visiting the Hagia Sophia Museum in 1967, and a Sultanahmet rally featuring heavy-weight boxing champion and activist Muhammad Ali Clay in 1976) that are argued to surface from conjectural changes which are themselves conditioned by geo-history. Thus adopting Fernand Braudel's formulation of change along three planes of historical time (i.e. events and people, structures and conjuncture, and *longue durée*), the proposal concludes by discussing a religious monument's such conversion into a symbol for the quasi-sacred status of secularism in modern Turkey.

PS62 Secularization and the Persistence of the Sacred

Session Chair: Joseph L. Clarke, University of Toronto

The Spiritualist Foundations of Urbanism

Chantal El Hayek

Pratt Institute, USA

Abstract

This paper examines the spiritualist foundations of urbanism as established by French urban scholar Marcel Poëte (1866–1950), whose theories were shaped by the philosophy of Henri Bergson, renowned author of *Creative Evolution* (1907). Poëte, along with other members of the Société Française des Urbanistes (SFU)—a Parisian think tank founded in 1911—coined the term *urbanisme* and laid the foundations of the field in France. SFU also contributed to the restructuring of over 40 cities worldwide. Poëte was its intellectual leader and prolific theorist. He founded and taught at the Institut d'Urbanisme, France's first urbanism school, and established *La Vie Urbaine* (1919), then the country's leading journal on urbanism.

Analyzing Poëte's writings on the "creative evolution" of Paris, especially its historic core, neighborhoods, and monuments, I show how he challenged the dominant secularism, materialism, and scientific positivism of his time by framing urbanism as an inventive, intellectual practice centered on spiritualism and human agency. Bergson viewed life as driven by an *élan vital*: a creative force resisting material inertia and generating new forms. Building on this, Poëte argued that cities evolve through instinct and intellect, forming complex material and social organisms. He replaced conventional, materialist histories of Paris with a spiritualist one, defying deterministic evolution.

Poëte and Bergson adhered to Spiritualism, a philosophical doctrine that identified the mind, *l'esprit*, with an immortal, free soul possessing faculties and ideas beyond physiology. Poëte asserted that the city is driven by mystical forces. Spiritual insight, whether religious or secular, guided humanity toward higher potential. While Poëte established urbanism as a modern science—emerging only after the Industrial Revolution—he gave it multifaceted meaning, reconciling science and art, and pre- and post-industrial planning. In critiquing modernization and the machine, he redefined urbanism as an "*art urbain*" that harmonized spiritualism with modern technology.

PS62 Secularization and the Persistence of the Sacred

Session Chair: Joseph L. Clarke, University of Toronto

The Fluidity of the Sacred and Profane in Contemporary Mexico

Karla Britton

Diné College, USA

Abstract

The Mexican Revolution left a lasting mark of secularization, yet was overlaid upon a cultural tradition that retained forms of the sacred not only in Catholic faith and practice, but in folklore, the language of indigeneity, and storytelling. As expressions of this cultural complexity, three contemporary sacred spaces speak to this long-established current of fluidity between the sacred and the secular. The first is Christ Church, the Anglican/Episcopal church in the affluent Chapultapec neighborhood of Mexico City. Designed by Carlos Mijares in 1992, the building is a celebration of both the humble brick and the labor which produced it, standing as an ironic product of the politics of patronage. The second project, the Pilgrim's Route "social landscape" (masterplan by Tatiana Bilbao ESTUDIO / Dellekamp Arquitectos, 2008-2010), streches 117 kilometers from Ameca to Talpa de Allende in Jalisco, where millions walk each year to the shrine of the *Virgen de Talpa*. After its completion, the architects stated they were only "foreign agents inserting works on the path that could nonetheless establish a dialogue between the people and the government, the individual and the collective, and a place where history is not only told but manifested." The third project, by Swiss architects Herzog and de Meuron, is El Punto, a multi-purpose "Iglesia project" in Ciudad Juarez, proposed in 2012 for the symbolically laden Parque Chamizal near the Bridge of the Americas, which became the site of Pope Francis's provocative 2016 visit. As imagined by the architects, the project was to represent an important step out of hopelessness towards a new identity for the whole region. Through these three sites, this paper illustrates ways in which contemporary Mexican architecture embraces the flow of allegiances and identities between the sacred and secular, challenging the assumed separation that characterizes their relationship in an atomized society.

PS62 Secularization and the Persistence of the Sacred

Session Chair: Joseph L. Clarke, University of Toronto

"Building Holy, Christian Spaces into the Secularized World"

Alexander Luckmann

University of California, Santa Barbara, USA

Abstract

On August 15, 1948, Cologne celebrated the 700th anniversary of its cathedral with a procession culminating in the first mass in the church since the war. This event symbolized Cologne's reconstruction after wartime bombing. But the day before the mass, Archbishop Josef Frings had taken a stone from the cathedral to lay the cornerstone of the Bruder Klaus Settlement (*Siedlung*) in a suburb across the river. This settlement marked the start of a Catholic construction program that saw the Church and associated developers build around 130,000 units of housing in West Germany, largely in the form of small settlements.

Catholic settlement discourse developed in the 1920s. It called for single-family houses to support large, "child-rich" families; dwelling construction through self-help as both an economic and moral measure; and land reform to reduce rents. In the 1930s, the National Socialist regime coopted settlement discourse and construction, but after the war, the Catholic church finally realized a housing program at scale.

The Bruder Klaus settlement shows how German Catholics conceived of the home itself as a kind of sacred space, and how they attempted to build a postwar Germany of Catholic settlements that would "deproletarize" workers and reestablish the Church as the center of the social order. As Aachen Bishop Joseph van de Velden said in a 1948 settlement conference in Cologne, "We have the responsibility… to build holy, Christian spaces into the secularized world." This paper argues both that the Catholic Church played a largely overlooked role in postwar (West) German housing construction, and that architecture was among the Church's key tools to deal with the challenges of modernity.

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